

AN ADULT EPIC FANTASY NOVEL

THE ARMIES OF THE STOLEN NIGHT



E. R. VEYLAN

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An original adult epic-fantasy novel

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Part I

Chapter 1 — When Evening Failed

Zarha drove the last guest stake herself because the western shade-cloth kept lifting in the hot wind. At the center of Seven Camp, six hundred supper fires smoked beneath a sun that should already have touched the red hills. Children carried cups to the hospitality lane. Orchard workers came in with white dust on their boots. The Night-Bearers knelt by the fungal beds and loosened the black soil with bone forks, making places where evening could enter gently.

“Three more spans toward the cistern,” Zarha told the cloth crew. “Travelers get the first shadow.”

Derrin Kesh, her mother's sister, clicked one tusklet against the other. “Residents have been working since dawn.”

“Guests have been walking since dawn.” Zarha pulled the rope until the cloth's edge covered the stone bench where two human traders waited. “Bring your complaint to the open tent after supper. Bring someone who disagrees with you.”

That requirement usually ended half the complaints before they reached her. Today Derrin only glanced at the sunlight under the cloth and went to find another rope.

A night-reeve did not summon darkness. She made room for everyone who would need it. Seven Camp's covenant had grown across two centuries of graves, root cellars, sleeping animals, shared water, and the names offered voluntarily at every birth or adoption. At dusk its first coolness gathered beneath the oldest tents. Blue fungi opened along the irrigation ditches. The camp's small foxes came out to wait for dropped bread.

None of them came.

Zarha straightened. Light lay white across the eastern terraces and hard gold across the west. The sun had stopped a hand's width above the hills.

The supper bell sounded once. Its keeper hesitated, then struck the second note meant to welcome evening. Voices thinned around the square.

Mera Seln rose from the nearest fungal bed. At sixty-three, the contemplative Bearer moved slowly until there was danger, then seemed to choose which years her body carried. She held up a clod. The pale threads inside had withdrawn into tight curls.

“Cover the beds,” she said. “No lamps. No mirrors.”

Around Seven Camp, people obeyed in the untidy sequence of a practiced community. Bakers dropped shutters. Orchard clans stretched blankets over cisterns. Caravan families opened road chests and pulled out patched dusk-cloth. Nobody waited for Zarha's authority, which gave her a moment to listen.

The Night pressed against her without words. Its presence usually felt like entering a tent where many sleepers trusted one another. Now that shelter tightened, tugged eastward, and recoiled. Beneath the sensation ran thousands of strained relations: names against glass, graves against heat, roots losing the cool they had expected.

Hooves struck the eastern road.

Twenty-four riders appeared between the orchard walls, their horses wrapped in silver flycloth. Each rider carried a narrow white mirror on a hinged frame. Sun disks marked their breastplates. Behind them rolled two wagons, and the thing mounted on the first wagon turned every face in the camp into a sharp little reflection.

Zarha walked into the hospitality lane before fear could turn the crowd into a weapon. Her black-brown eyes watered in the glare. The broken tusklet on her left caught against her lower lip when she called, "You enter Seven Camp under guest law. Cover your mirrors and name your need."

The leading officer had a burned scalp and an imperial census chain looped three times around his wrist. "By road-charter amendment forty-two, all registered shade belongs to the Solar Peace during celestial emergency."

"No court here witnessed that amendment."

"Your reeve's seal witnessed the census."

A soldier on the wagon unlatched a brass case. Inside lay bundled slips of paper, each threaded with a hair, nail clipping, thread of clothing, or pinch of grave soil. Seven Camp had submitted those tokens twelve years earlier when imperial engineers promised access to the White Road. Zarha had been twenty-six and newly elected, fierce enough to suspect every promise except the ones that arrived as culverts and medicine carts.

The officer drew out a slip. "Arko Venn, shade-name given Year Four Hundred Five."

At the far side of the lane, an orchard keeper cried out. His shadow stretched toward the wagon though the sun stood behind him. It ran across the dust like spilled ink, climbed the wheel, and flattened itself against the great mirror.

"Break line of sight," Zarha shouted.

Cloth dropped from roofs. People overturned tables and raised doors from their hinges. A dozen court witnesses rushed the wagons with axes, but the smaller mirrors swung outward. Reflected light struck the ground before their feet. Their shadows tore free in black ribbons.

The Night convulsed.

Every tent rope snapped taut at once. Cool air surged from the fungal beds, carrying the smell of wet bark, nursing dens, and old burial cloth. For a heartbeat dusk filled the camp despite the suspended sun. The foxes appeared under carts.

Moths rose from Selai ink and Khar witness knots alike. Sleeping babies opened their mouths in silent surprise.

Then the wagon mirror drank the coolness.

Zarha seized a canvas awning and dragged it across the hospitality lane. Three people caught the other edge without being told. They ran toward the first wagon, using cloth as a moving wall. Mirror light punched holes through the weave. Heat burned Zarha's palms. Beside her, a boy named Hokk stumbled, and his mother left the canvas to pull him clear. The exposed corner lifted.

A beam struck old Mera across the shoulder. Her shadow peeled halfway loose before she drove both hands into a fungal bed. Black threads climbed her wrists. The local Night held her through root and voluntary name, but that defense cost it strength everywhere else.

"Do not command it," Mera gasped at Zarha. "Make shelter."

Zarha understood the warning. A reeve possessed phrases that could force a covenant to close around chosen bodies. Such command would burn one of her own darkness-linked memories and turn hospitality into selection. Worse, the imperial mirrors had come prepared to catch any concentrated defense.

"Cut the eastern guy-lines," she ordered. "Drop every longcloth between the mirrors and the graves. Move children into the irrigation tunnels. No running alone."

Witnesses carried the order through the camp. Knives flashed at tent corners. Acres of patched shade collapsed, not as panic but as a planned ruin. Walls became blankets; roofs became screens. The moving fabric broke the mirror array into fragments.

The eastern lanes still lay exposed. Zarha ran there with Hokk's mother and four cistern keepers, ducking beneath lengths of cloth handed from one group to the next. People had crowded against the adobe granary because its walls once cast the broadest evening shade. Without the Night, those walls held stored heat. Children pressed their faces against plaster hot enough to blister them.

"Open the grain vault," Zarha said.

Keeper Voska planted herself before the iron latch. "That reserve feeds us until harvest."

"It feeds nobody if they cook against the wall."

"Your court cannot spend winter grain without three orchard witnesses."

Even in disaster, Seven Camp remained itself. Zarha found two orchard workers in the crowd, then dragged the wounded Mera close enough to make a third. All three touched the latch. Voska opened it. Cool air breathed from the half-buried room, faint and dry but sufficient. Families passed children down between sacks. Adults followed only after the burned and elderly had entered.

A crash sounded from the goat market. One of the small imperial mirrors had

fallen from its hinge, yet the white face still pulled at every shadow crossing it. A goat kicked itself bloody trying to escape the draw. Two market women approached from opposite sides with wicker grain shields. Zarha joined them, threw a wool rug over the glass, and heard the trapped darkness strike against its covering like rain.

"Turn it down," said one woman.

"The ground will reflect through the dust," Zarha answered. "Dig beneath the frame."

They cut wheel ruts deeper with mattocks, then rolled the mirror facedown into wet irrigation mud. Its whine sank to a pulse. Zarha wanted to break it, but white glass shattered outward and could bind anyone reflected in its fragments. She posted four witnesses around it instead, each holding an overlapping blanket.

At the southern ditches, runners reported that frightened families had begun fleeing west without water. Zarha sent no guards to stop them. She sent water carriers to meet them and chalked the first assembly point on the orchard wall. Command could make a crowd turn. Shelter gave people a reason to turn together.

The camp's animals needed their own route. Chickens died first, necks stretched in dust. Oxen crowded the narrowing cool around the cistern and threatened to crush the people drawing water. Zarha ordered the north fence pulled apart, driving the herds into the fallow terraces where they could spread. Every animal sent away cost transport. Every animal kept near the square cost water and room. She chose the draft oxen, milk goats, and two seed flocks; the rest were released toward the foothills with wet cloth tied around their horns so no hunter would mistake abandoned livestock for theft.

By then the imperial riders had changed tactics. They no longer tried to hold the lanes. They circled the perimeter, reading census slips wherever fallen cloth exposed a face. The theft had become mobile, and Zarha could not wall off an entire settlement with blankets.

The census officer lifted another handful of names.

He read them quickly. Each spoken name pulled a person's shadow toward the wagons. Some clung to walls or family members. Some tore loose at once. A woman carrying two water jars fell without spilling either one, her eyes open and empty. An infant screamed until its father covered both of them with his coat. In the burial orchard, thin columns of darkness rose from beneath memorial stones.

Zarha reached the lead horse and cut its bridle. The animal bolted west, dragging the officer sideways. She caught his census chain, wrapped it around her forearm, and pulled him down. His helmet struck the road.

"Where are you taking our Night?"

He spat blood. "To safety."

She tightened the chain. "Give me a place."

"The Basilica. The reservoirs. You have fifty-three days to learn gratitude."

A mirror rider drove a spear at her. Zarha turned, felt the point score her coat, and threw the officer beneath the thrust. She did not see who struck the rider from the saddle. Someone pushed a black orchard door between her and the wagon.

Across the camp, a deeper sound began. It resembled wind under canvas, though no cloth still stood high enough to catch wind. Seven Camp's Night pulled itself through roots, beds, cisterns, burrows, and sleeping minds. The imperial array answered with a rising glass whine.

Cracks opened in every blue fungus cap.

Darkness streamed upward. It carried no shape the eye could keep. Zarha glimpsed a canopy of remembered tents, the backs of nocturnal animals, rain over graves, and thousands of sleeping breaths. All of it narrowed into the wagon mirror. White glass blackened from its center outward.

The pressure dropped so suddenly that Zarha fell to one knee.

No shade remained under the orchard door. No darkness rested inside her sleeve. Even the census officer beneath her cast only a faint gray stain.

The imperial captain blew retreat. Twelve riders and both wagons escaped east. Five more riders followed wounded. The rest lay in the road or fled among the trees. Seven Camp did not pursue them. People were already digging neighbors from collapsed cloth and carrying the burned toward the cisterns.

Zarha found Mera beside the dead fungal bed. The old Bearer still breathed, although the keratin ridge along her right cheek had turned ash gray.

"It is gone," Zarha said.

"Taken," Mera corrected. "Gone means it chose to leave."

Work replaced argument. They erected awnings low enough to resist the heat. Orchard families opened underground storage rooms. Human smiths broke wagon boards into splints. Two Selai traders used the last living moths in their ear-fans to find people trapped beneath cloth, then wept when those moths dropped still.

At the counting square, Zarha set seven clerks beneath layered blankets and ordered every household to report living, dead, and missing separately. Numbers came slowly. Heat made ink tacky. Names arrived twice from frightened relatives or not at all from lanes where nobody remained to speak.

By what should have been midnight, the first count stood complete.

"Four thousand one hundred twenty on the morning registry," said clerk Yaro. His voice kept breaking, so he pressed two fingers against his throat. "Two hundred eighty bodies confirmed. Three thousand eight hundred forty living and accounted for."

The symmetry of the loss offended Zarha. It made catastrophe look arranged.

"How many can walk?"

Yaro looked at the second sheet. "Three thousand five hundred sixty. There are 280 who breathe but will not wake."

"Separate number," she said. "Do not fold them into the dead."

"We have no category."

"Write dreamless."

They found the sleepers wherever shade had once held deepest: infants in cellar hammocks, elders beside memorial niches, workers who had lain down between shifts, children hidden in irrigation tunnels. Their eyes moved beneath closed lids. Water slid from their mouths when relatives tried to make them drink. Ren Tal, seventeen and usually impossible to keep from any public argument, lay with one fist still closed around a supper token.

Zarha walked the counting lanes with a wax board divided into four columns. The first held the 4,120 names entered at sunrise. Clerks marked 280 beside the confirmed dead, each body identified by two witnesses whenever possible. A third column tracked the 3,840 survivors. The last separated those who could travel on foot from those needing carts, litters, or constant care. Numbers did not soften grief. They told the living how much rope to cut, how many skins to fill, and which promises could still be kept.

At the school cellar, twenty-six dreamless children lay on arithmetic mats. Their teacher had numbered cups by each child's head so nobody would receive water twice while another received none. Zarha showed the older students how to turn a sleeper without twisting the neck. One girl asked whether dreams could be stolen through the mouth. Zarha said she did not know. She would not turn ignorance into comfort merely because a child had asked.

The burial orchard held the worst count. People who had been tending memorial stones had collapsed when the Night tore through the roots. Some died with soil beneath their nails. Others breathed shallowly and failed to recognize their own kin. Mera examined each survivor without claiming a cure. She placed damp fungus cloth under their tongues, more to keep the mouth from cracking than to call the Night back.

"These forty-seven may wake on the road," Mera said. "Or they may go farther inward."

"Can they hear us?"

"Perhaps relation reaches where speech does not."

Zarha assigned each sleeper three named companions from different households. If one family collapsed under the labor, two others would remain. The choice angered people who wanted sole custody of their kin. It also prevented the poorest lanes from carrying their dreamless on doors while wealthy orchard compounds reserved spring carts for furniture.

At the wagon yard, the transport count failed twice. Seven axles had warped in

the heat. Forty water barrels leaked because their hoops dried too quickly. Smiths soaked leather around the worst gaps and dismantled ceremonial platforms for wheel timber. A marriage canopy became a hospital awning. The open-tent dais became four litter frames. Nobody asked whether those objects remained sacred after the work changed them.

By the time Zarha returned to Ren Tal, his mother had organized six adolescents to carry him in shifts if his cart broke. Ren had taught three of them to cheat at stones. They spoke to him about the debts he would collect on waking, using irritation as a cord tied to ordinary life.

An imperial surgeon captured near the east orchard said the sleepers had followed the Night too far inward. She insisted some would wake if brought near living darkness. When Zarha asked about the eclipse, the surgeon stared at the suspended sun.

"Fifty-three days," she said. "That is what the officers were told. A total alignment. After that, the roads will have regulated shelter."

"Whose shelter?"

The surgeon did not answer.

Mera joined Zarha at the edge of the square, one arm bound to her chest. "The free Night Courts lie west. Akar Seven still hosts its dusk."

"So do the Selai saltwoods." Zarha watched families wrap the dreamless in wet cloth. "The White Road reaches Deren Ford before it divides."

"Imperial road."

"All roads belong first to the feet on them."

Zarha ordered the camp dismantled.

They had too few carts for the dreamless, the wounded, and the water required under an unsetting sun. She assigned orchard barrows to sleepers, put the worst burns on freight wagons, and made every walking household carry one additional water skin. Goats took the lightest shade frames. The burial stones could not travel, so witnesses copied each name onto knots cut from the fallen longcloth.

Some residents refused to leave. Seven Camp held their parents' graves, its old tent circles, and the first houses orchard families had built after choosing to settle. Zarha did not invoke her office. She gave them the count, showed them the dead fungi, and asked each refuser to name who would fetch water after the eastern cistern turned hot.

One by one, they packed.

At departure, nobody could tell morning from night. The sun still hung over the west hills. Heat had whitened the leaves. Behind them, empty tents cast no shadows at all.

Zarha walked at the head only until the road narrowed, then moved back among the carts. A reeve belonged where the column might tear. She checked every

sleeper's wet cloth, every axle pin, every family gap. At Ren Tal's cart, the youth's mother had tied a witness knot around his wrist.

"What do I tell him when he wakes?" she asked.

"The truth in pieces he can bear," Zarha said. "And his own name first."

Seven Camp went west carrying 3,840 living people, 280 of them dreamless, while its stolen Night traveled east inside imperial glass. Fifty-three days remained until an eclipse no one in the column yet understood. Zarha turned her back on the light and ordered the first water halt before anyone asked for it.

Chapter 2 — The Astronomer of Captive Darkness

Ilyen Vaor removed the public eclipse plate from the measuring engine and found eleven minutes missing from the sky.

The brass plate should have matched the noon transit he had watched through smoked crystal. Instead, its final contact notch sat half a finger beyond the mark cut by the engine's true pendulum. He checked the suspension wire, the counterweight, and the temperature of the east pier. Stone, brass, and wire agreed with one another. Only the printed table lied.

Above him, the High Observatory's dome stood open to the unsetting sun. Light flooded down through three floors of instruments and collected in white channels cut into the marble. Assistants worked with veils over their copper ear-fans. The mineral inks across their skin had once hosted blue and silver star-moths. Now most of those delicate creatures clung dead to gauze trays or drifted through the building like ash.

Ilyen placed the public plate beside his private calculation slate.

First contact differed by two minutes. Totality began eleven minutes earlier than the proclamations claimed. Its duration had been shortened on paper by the same interval, hiding the only span when twelve celestial vectors converged over the capital.

No copying error produced symmetry that neat.

"Master Vaor?" His junior, Pell Aven, waited on the lower stair with a ledger hugged to his chest. He belonged to a saltwood trading family rather than an observatory house, which made him useful enough to employ and too peripheral to trust. "Director Ceyn wants the corrected road-light figures."

"Did she say corrected?"

"She said reconciled."

Of course she had. Ilyen slid his calculation slate under a stack of lens invoices. "Tell her the pendulum drifted in the heat. I need a reservoir temperature."

Pell glanced toward the sealed doors beneath the engine. "We do not measure those."

"We measure everything that shifts an arc."

After the junior left, Ilyen leaned over the pendulum shaft. Air rose through it in pulses too cool for the sunlit building. Each pulse made the faded seasonal tattoos along his ear-fans tighten. The sensation belonged to true darkness, or to something held so tightly that it could imitate darkness's pressure.

The observatory's foundations adjoined the Sun Basilica. Official plans showed archive vaults beneath the west wing and empty stone under the measuring piers. Ilyen had approved those plans nineteen years earlier. He had also helped

calculate eclipse paths for imperial road shelters, believing the work would stop local lords from charging desperate travelers for one safe hour after sunset.

A person could build half a prison while measuring only the doorway assigned to him.

He took a maintenance key from the pendulum cabinet and descended.

The first sublevel held brass gears, dust, and six laborers oiling the transit shafts. On the second, white-glass pipes ran through the wall toward the Basilica. Frost silvered their joints. No frost should have survived in the heat. Ilyen set a moth compass against one pipe. Its dead needle moved.

"Who authorized this coupling?" he asked the nearest mechanic.

The woman did not look up from her wrench. "No names below the archive line."

"That is not an answer."

"It keeps us employed." She had human features and an old census burn around one wrist. "If you want a better answer, ask upstairs where answers come with windows."

A warning bell rang once. Not alarm, only pressure change.

The mechanic swore and tightened a valve. Black condensation gathered around its rim. Within each drop Ilyen saw a different dimness: forest shade, cellar dark, rain-heavy dusk, a purple evening full of insects. The drops slid together, fought separation, and vanished into the pipe.

"How many couplings?" he asked.

"You know how to count bells."

Another bell sounded deeper in the foundations, then another farther east. Ilyen listened until twelve distinct tones had passed through the stone.

A service lift stood open beyond the valve gallery. Its platform carried six covered jars, each as tall as Ilyen's knee, and a young warden with burns branching up his neck. The warden checked a paper token against the nearest pipe, then waved two laborers forward. They attached a jar to a brass mouth beneath the valve.

"Pressure draw," he said. "Four breaths only."

The laborers opened the mouth. Darkness entered the jar with no visible flow, but the glaze blackened and the young warden sagged against the wall. His pupils widened until almost no iris remained. One laborer counted breaths. At four, she shut the valve and sealed the jar with white wax.

Ilyen pointed to the warden. "He needs a physician."

"He needs his next shift removed," the mechanic said. "They will give him both."

"What did the draw take?"

The warden touched his neck as if surprised to find skin. "I had a dream about

my daughter's naming feast."

"Had?"

"I know she had one." He looked at the sealed jar. "I cannot see the room anymore."

Nothing in the official eclipse plans mentioned human handling losses. Ilyen read the token before the laborer turned it facedown. It authorized six jars from Reservoir Nine for civic testing, with each four-breath draw assigned to a different ward employee. The line for impairment carried a stamped zero.

"How many draws per day?" Ilyen asked.

The mechanic glanced at the listening pipes. "Enough to teach us not to count aloud."

Along one wall, workers had scratched private tallies behind a tool cabinet. Ilyen counted three hundred seventeen marks for the current month. Some bore tiny circles denoting memory loss. Others ended in crossed lines. He copied the pattern onto his cuff beside the temperature reading, using the shorthand for instrument failures so a search would mistake bodies for broken gears.

A second service platform descended from the Basilica, carrying four census clerks and a shade-name chest. Cold traveled ahead of it. Through the gaps in the chest, paper slips shifted as if breathing. The clerks wore white gloves and avoided looking at one another.

"Observatory personnel above the archive line," their supervisor called. "Clear this floor."

Ilyen remained beside the pipe. "Your draw perturbs the eclipse engine by six arc seconds."

Technical inconvenience achieved what moral objection could not. The supervisor halted. "It falls within tolerance."

"Not if twelve reservoirs enter sympathetic pressure."

For the first time, alarm crossed the woman's face. She recovered quickly and signaled the wardens. That reaction told Ilyen more than any confession. The Office knew the reservoirs would touch, and its confidence depended on the eleven minutes removed from public scrutiny.

Pell came down the stair carrying the temperature rod. His face looked bloodless beneath the veil. "The director says you are to return."

"Take a reading."

"Here?"

"Against the pipe."

The junior obeyed. When the rod touched white glass, its red fluid dropped past the lowest etched number and darkened to violet. Pell jerked his hand away.

Ilyen recorded the impossible reading on his cuff. "There are twelve reservoirs."

"You did not hear me agree."

"No. You heard me count."

They climbed without speaking. At the archive line, two Basilica wardens waited in mirrored half-helms. Their reflections showed Ilyen and Pell slightly younger, with brighter ear-fan inks and living moths circling their heads. The temptation in that false image struck harder than any threat.

Director Ceyn received Ilyen in the meridian room. She had removed her own moth veils, revealing bare ear-fans tattooed in the severe geometry of House Oren. Three imperial officials stood around the central table. They wore no military badges, only the sun-thread cuffs of the Office of Public Continuity.

Ceyn tapped the public eclipse plate. "Your engine disagrees with the approved table."

"My engine agrees with the sky."

"Then adjust its zero point."

An official turned a page. "Road shelters will open according to published time. Premature darkening would cause crowd movement."

"Totality will cause crowd movement whether the notices permit it or not." Ilyen set his cuff beside the plate. "Eleven minutes have been removed. The reservoir harmonics peak inside those minutes."

Pell made a small sound near the door.

Ceyn studied the marks on Ilyen's cuff. "You entered a restricted service level."

"A thermal fault reached my instrument."

"The Basilica's storage arrangements do not concern astronomy."

"They alter local refraction across the capital. Twelve bodies of confined Night sit below our instruments, and someone falsified the only table that shows when they can touch."

Silence moved around the officials, not surprised silence but administrative calculation.

The eldest official folded his hands. "Master Vaor, local darkness has killed more citizens than any imperial campaign. You have read the plague ledgers. You calculated the reduction in predation along regulated roads."

"I also calculated those roads using honest skies."

"Honesty is not a scheduling principle."

Ceyn stepped between them before Ilyen could answer. "The measuring engine will be closed for thermal correction. Master Vaor will surrender his private notes and remain in his rooms until the eclipse audit concludes."

Fifty-two days of confinement. Long enough for every stolen Night to reach the Basilica and every road proclamation to become an order.

Ilyen looked at Pell. The junior kept his eyes down, but his right hand rested against his ledger in the Selai gesture for a witnessed discrepancy. Someone else had seen.

"I will prepare the engine record," Ilyen said.

Two wardens escorted him to the calculation floor. They searched his desk, emptied his sleeves, and collected every slate bearing eclipse figures. Neither noticed the lens invoices under which he had hidden his first calculation. Ilyen destroyed that slate himself by dropping it into the cleaning furnace. One set of true numbers would not survive a room search. He needed a copy the census office could not recognize as writing.

The old moth darkroom lay behind the defunct calendar gallery. Before the Empire standardized light hours, Selai astronomers had bred star-moths there. Their wing dust fixed itself to mineral ink only in voluntary dark. Ilyen had hatched his first colony in that room at age nine, under his mother's supervision and his sister Sava's jealous stare.

He waited until the wardens changed stations, then carried a tray of cracked lenses through the service passage. The darkroom door bore an imperial seal. His maintenance key did not fit, but forty years of paint had made the frame brittle. He slid a lens blade beside the bolt and lifted.

Inside, shallow stone basins lined the walls. Most stood dry. One held a thumb's depth of unlit water under a black cloth. A single star-moth rested on the cloth, wings closed. Its body glimmered blue at the joints.

Ilyen shut the door. Darkness gathered poorly, starved by the white pipes below, yet the room remembered its old relations. Water cooled. Mineral ink prickled across his hands. The moth opened its wings.

He ground a fresh calculation plate with charcoal and salt, then wrote the true contact sequence in a ring around its edge. To conceal the numbers, he needed the moth to carry wing dust over them in the old pattern for seasonal rainfall. An examiner would see a damaged weather calendar. A trained cantor could expose the eclipse table by warming the plate in living shade.

Invitation would take several nights. He possessed less than an hour.

Command could do it now.

Ilyen rested both hands beside the basin. He named the darkroom, the unlit water, the moth, and himself. He acknowledged that the small covenant had not consented to urgency. The proper words tasted shameful before he reached the imperative.

"Carry this measure," he said.

The darkness resisted. Pressure built behind his eyes. Magic sought a memory linked to Night, a price shaped by the act rather than chosen for convenience.

His first star-moth hatching rose within him.

He had been nine. He knew that. The moth had emerged during rain. Sava had complained that he received the first basin. Their mother had laughed and made them hold the warming cloth together. Ilyen remembered every fact.

The memory's living center opened like a door. He felt again the moth's feet on his thumb, the terror of holding something too delicate to grip, his mother's hand steadying his wrist. Blue wings had unfolded in darkness. Wonder had entered him so completely that astronomy became less a study than a lifelong answer.

The darkroom took that wonder.

Wing dust rose in a spiral. It settled across the calculation plate, covering every number with a pattern of false rain. The star-moth dropped onto the cloth. Ilyen caught it before it reached the water.

He knew what had happened at his first hatching. He could list the basin, weather, witnesses, and species. When he reached toward the event, he found information arranged around an absence. His mother's hand carried no warmth. The blue wings gave him nothing.

Grief should have followed. Even grief had lost its path to that hour.

The cost did not prove the command righteous. It only made the damage exact.

Ilyen wrapped the disguised plate in lens paper and slid it into the wooden back of a cracked transit lens. He returned the star-moth to the cloth. Its wings remained still, but its legs caught the weave.

Voices approached in the gallery.

He opened the cleaning flue, smeared soot across his cuffs, and set three worthless weather plates in the furnace. When Director Ceyn entered with the wardens, smoke had filled the room.

"What have you burned?" she demanded.

"My unauthorized calculations." He held out both empty hands. "You asked for reconciliation."

Ceyn looked past him at the covered basin. For one dangerous instant, the old loyalties of their people showed beneath her imperial office. Then she ordered the wardens to search him.

They found soot, a maintenance key, and no figures. The cracked transit lens joined a cart of discarded equipment bound for Deren Ford, where an imperial glass engineer had requested old optical stock for a demonstration.

Ilyen accepted confinement in his observatory rooms. At second watch, Pell brought him food and set the ledger down with its spine pointing west.

"The disposal cart leaves before sunrise," Pell said.

"Who drives it?"

"My uncle's freight partner."

"Does he know what he carries?"

"He knows you paid for a private lens." Pell looked at the faded inks on Ilyen's ear-fans. "What did it cost?"

Ilyen tried once more to touch the first hatching. Facts answered. Feeling did not.

"An honest beginning," he said. "Do not call that payment. Payment settles a debt."

They made no heroic plan. Pell would misfile the confinement meal count. Ilyen would cross the roof during the artificial dawn cleaning, descend with the lens workers, and meet the disposal cart beyond the north archive gate. If either man disappeared too early, the road inspectors would search every wagon.

Before the hour, Ilyen stood at his window and watched the capital shine without relief. White roads divided neighborhoods into bright grids. The Sun Basilica rose at their center, terraces reflecting enough light to erase the stars even if night had come. Beneath those terraces, twelve captive darkneses pressed cold through stone.

The public clocks continued toward a false eclipse.

Ilyen touched the blank place inside his earliest wonder, then packed one veil, two water flasks, and the names of everyone who had helped him lie.

The meal deception bought them thirty-seven minutes. Pell left a second tray outside Ilyen's room and argued loudly with the guard over whether astronomers received wine during disciplinary isolation. While the guard quoted regulations, Ilyen climbed through the instrument hatch wearing a lens cleaner's gray coat.

Outside, the roof tiles burned through his shoes. Observatory domes surrounded him in nested circles, each one feeding a blade of reflected sun toward the Basilica. Cleaners moved along rope paths with buckets of chalk paste. Ilyen joined them, bent his head, and took a scraper from an unattended pail.

At the western dome, an inspector stopped the line. "Ear-fans uncovered."

Selai workers lowered their veils one by one so the inspector could compare ink patterns against employment cards. Ilyen's seasonal tracks would identify him immediately. He stepped off the rope path and knelt beside a mirror seam.

"Crack here," he said.

The cleaner behind him nearly walked into his back. "There is no crack."

"There will be if the south brace keeps expanding." Ilyen pushed his scraper into the seam. "Fetch a cooling hood unless you want the meridian mirror across the Court of Petitions."

The possibility of damaged imperial glass moved everyone faster than an escaped astronomer. The inspector abandoned the identity line to examine the brace. Three cleaners spread a silver hood over the seam. Hidden beneath it, Ilyen crossed to the drainage ladder and descended to the archive yard.

The disposal cart waited among six freight wagons. Its driver had draped

cracked lenses with hemp mats, protecting them less from damage than from scattering dangerous light across the horses. Ilyen crawled beneath the rearmost mat. The disguised eclipse plate rested where he had placed it inside the transit lens backing.

Gate officers searched the first two wagons completely. At the third, a jar of bound shade cracked in the heat. Its escaping darkness snapped every horse shadow toward one wheel. Animals screamed. Clerks ran with white blankets and wax. The inspector waved the remaining freight through to clear the yard before the spill reached it.

Ilyen did not call that luck. Some unknown person's stolen memory had broken containment, and he had used the resulting injury as cover. He recorded the debt in his mind beside Pell's ledger, the mechanic's tally, and the young warden's vanished naming feast.

Beyond the north gate, the driver stopped under an aqueduct where thin shade survived. "Deren Ford in three days," he whispered through the mat. "After that, you are your own bad decision."

"A precise contract."

Ilyen changed into a freight clerk's coat and checked the plate. Wing dust still concealed the true figures. Eleven stolen minutes waited beneath a pattern of rain that no longer fell often enough in the capital. At fifty-two days before totality, the astronomer of captive darkness chose treason and went west with the true sky hidden inside broken glass.

Chapter 3 — The Road Without Shadows

Kessa Dorn had nineteen full water carts and orders to give them to an army that would not arrive until tomorrow.

She stood on the inspection step at White Mile Depot, measuring the western road through her brass field lens. Heat trembled above the paving stones. The road's white-glass chips threw light under wagons, boots, and bellies, erasing every useful patch of shade. At the far marker, a dark line had appeared where no convoy belonged.

"Count the frontage," she told her assistant.

Marn lifted a slotted range card. "At least sixty wagons. More walkers than the road can carry six abreast."

"Military?"

"No formation."

That meant refugees, and the depot had received no refugee order.

Kessa climbed down. Around her, hired crews rolled barrels beneath wet sacking. The nineteen carts each carried eight casks of one hundred twenty gallons, enough to keep an imperial mirror regiment and its horses moving for two hard days. Beside them stood three relief wagons with cracked jars, old grain, fever cloth, and shade poles too short for the canvas issued with them.

"Move the relief wagons to the west gate," she said. "Open the north cistern."

Depot Prefect Arlen heard her from his awning. "North cistern remains sealed for road troops."

"Road troops arrive tomorrow."

"Then it remains sealed until tomorrow."

Kessa looked back through the lens. The dark line resolved into patched cloth carried on poles. People walked beneath it in rotating groups. Carts occupied the center, every one crowded with bodies lying flat.

"Put your seal on the lock," she told Arlen. "I will put my hammer on it."

The prefect had learned that she did not use figures of speech before midday. He found the cistern key.

White Mile Depot had begun as a Dorn Vale toll station before occupation. Kessa's grandfather once collected apple levies there. Imperial engineers widened the road, faced the warehouses in reflective plaster, and gave her the title of refugee and baggage marshal because she knew every feeder track between the vale and Deren Ford. The office let her keep displaced families from being marched in circles. It also required her to count supplies meant for soldiers who had displaced them.

She could live with compromised employment when it kept people watered. The definition of people had become harder to survive.

The first walkers reached the gate carrying four elders on a door. Their eyes reflected gold around dark pupils, and low keratin ridges marked them as Khar. Behind them came human orchard laborers, Selai traders with veiled ear-fans, and children of every local ancestry. Dust had dried white in the creases of their clothes.

A Khar woman with one broken tusket walked beside the lead cart. Her hands had been bandaged but not well. She surveyed the depot's awnings, cistern height, armed watch, and both road exits before looking at Kessa.

"Who counts here?" she asked.

"I do when the number affects water."

"Then count 3,840 living people from Seven Camp."

Marn dropped his range card.

Kessa kept her eyes on the woman. "Name and office."

"Zarha Kesh, night-reeve."

"Kessa Dorn, depot marshal. Cause of displacement?"

"Imperial seizure of our Night."

The answer sounded ceremonial until Kessa looked under the cart's canopy. Eight people lay there with wet cloth over their faces. None reacted when a wheel struck the gate sill.

"Heat collapse?"

"Dreamless. There are 280."

Kessa revised the problem. Three thousand eight hundred forty people under direct sun required at least 3,840 gallons for a minimal first issue, more for children, burns, nursing parents, and the sick. The dreamless could not drink safely without cups, cloth wicks, or trained hands. Nineteen carts held 18,240 gallons. The depot cistern held another 9,000, of which Arlen had authority to release six hundred.

Numbers did not create water. They exposed who had decided where it went.

"Bring your household lists under the freight awning," Kessa said. "Walking groups at the cistern in lots of fifty. Nobody drinks straight from the trough. Dreamless to the east warehouse where the floor stays coolest."

Zarha did not move. "Your soldiers stay away from their names."

"I need no census tokens to pour water."

"They did."

Kessa saw the flinch in people close enough to hear. "Then we use household knots and spoken counts. Your witnesses can stand beside my clerks."

That concession earned neither gratitude nor trust. It did earn movement.

For two hours, the depot became a receiving yard. Kessa cut the road into lanes with flour sacks and rope. One lane led to water, one to shade, one to triage, and one to the wagons where families reported missing companions. She ordered salt added to every fifth cup. She took three depot horses off feed duty and hitched them to ambulance carts. When Arlen complained about horse allocation, she handed him the bucket used for washing burns.

Inside the east warehouse, 280 dreamless lay in rows separated by walking space. Seven Camp companions turned each person on a timed bell. Some sleepers had burns where their shadows had torn away. Others appeared healthy except for eyelids trembling over inaccessible dreams.

A contemplative Khar elder named Mera Seln supervised the room with one arm tied to her body. "Do not call them empty," she told a depot surgeon.

"I called the beds empty."

"You looked at Ren while you said it."

The surgeon flushed. Kessa intervened before the correction became a dispute. "Bed numbers only. People by name or family description. What do they require?"

"Water by wick," the surgeon said. "Half-cup each hour in this heat. Broth if they swallow. We need twice the cloth here."

Kessa wrote the amount on her board. Beside it, she noted six hundred forty-one glare burns, ninety-three serious crush injuries, and forty-seven cases of confusion beyond the nonwaking group. Those categories overlapped. She marked overlap rather than inflating the total.

At the clerk table, Marn had opened the imperial relief code. His finger rested on a paragraph edged in red.

"You should read this before you issue grain," he said quietly.

Kessa read it once, then again because obscenity often hid inside formal grammar.

Persons who failed to wake for two consecutive ration bells after shade seizure entered presumptive civic death. Their household allotment ended. Transporting such persons on imperial roads required a mortuary permit. Water and medicine could not be expended on remains when living road users lacked supply.

"How long between bells?" she asked.

"Six hours."

"Seven Camp lost its Night yesterday."

Marn nodded. "The second bell sounds in forty minutes."

Zarha stood on the other side of the table. Kessa did not know how much common script she read, but the reeve understood Marn's face.

"Say it," Zarha ordered.

Kessa translated the paragraph without softening it.

Nearby witnesses fell silent. A mother filling a cup continued pouring until water covered her hand. Mera came from the warehouse and listened with her head tilted.

"Your code kills by grammar," Zarha said.

"It withdraws relief," Arlen replied from the doorway. Two road wardens stood behind him now. "The medical status comes from Public Continuity, not this depot."

"Thirst does the killing," Kessa said. "Grammar assigns the cup elsewhere."

The prefect held out his hand for her issue board. "Marshal Dorn, return all military stores to seal. You may distribute six hundred gallons and twelve sacks among recognized living claimants. The nonwaking stay outside depot walls until mortuary transport arrives."

Kessa did the arithmetic. Six hundred gallons allowed less than a pint per person. Twelve grain sacks supplied one thin meal. Mortuary transport meant white wagons whose census clerks collected shade-names from bodies. If some dreamless still carried a thread of Seven Camp's Night, those clerks would harvest it.

"No," she said.

Arlen's expression barely changed. "Your commission derives from the road office."

"My commission tells me to prevent obstruction and death among displaced road users."

"Presumptive remains are neither."

Zarha put both palms on the table. Her nails had split under the bandages. "We will leave your road."

"You cannot move 280 sleepers without imperial mortuary seals," Arlen said.

"Watch us."

Kessa looked at the column's wagons. Most had orchard wheels made for soft soil. The White Road would shake them apart before Deren Ford. Leaving by farm tracks required more water because no imperial cisterns served the old route. The sun had not moved since the previous evening.

"How many carts can you repair by the second depot bell?" she asked Zarha.

"Why?"

"Because we need them rolling before the third."

Arlen stepped toward her. "Kessa."

She gave him the issue board. "You wanted military stores returned to seal. Seal them yourself."

In the yard, she found nineteen drivers waiting beside the water train. Ten came from Dorn Vale families. Five were imperial contractors whose wages had gone unpaid for two months. Four belonged to families living in the depot's rear quarter. None had been asked whether they wished to commit theft.

Kessa gathered them under cart fourteen.

"The road office will call these imperial carts," she said. "The casks came from Vale cooperages under unpaid requisition. The water came from a river diverted across Vale farms. Ownership will be argued later by people who are not thirsty. I intend to dispatch all 19 water carts to Deren Ford with Seven Camp."

Driver Hest rubbed his beard. "Dispatch under whose seal?"

"Mine expires as soon as Arlen reaches the signal tower."

"So, nobody's."

"Mine until then."

A younger driver asked whether soldiers would hang them. Kessa did not promise safety. "Road theft carries six years' labor. Aid to uncensused shade rites may carry death after the prefect reports why we took them. You can walk away now. Anyone who stays receives a refugee household knot and a place in the column."

Three drivers left. Two returned before she finished assigning teams.

They could not simply roll through the gate. Arlen had chained the east and west exits and sent a rider toward the signal tower. Kessa divided the work into delays, hitches, and exits. Marn would alter the dispatch slate from Regiment Twelve to Sanitation Column Nineteen. Depot laborers would spill lime across the military yard, forcing road wardens to protect the mirror-wagon covers. Zarha's witnesses would reinforce the western gate with cloth so white-glass fragments could not catch names when the lock broke.

"The south service lane," Hest said. "It reaches the mill track."

"Too narrow for cask axles."

"Cart six can take the post off."

"Cart six loses a wheel if it brushes stone."

A Rill wheelwright from the refugee column heard them. Compact-bodied and scarred across both palms, she crawled under cart six without introduction. "Rear hub has a false join," she said. "Give me two wedges and one door hinge."

Kessa gave her three wedges.

Work spread through the depot. Seven Camp carpenters replaced split pegs with orchard knife handles. Children soaked axle cloth. Depot cooks filled every spare jar while the north cistern remained open. Kessa allotted four water carts to direct drinking, two to dreamless care, three to animals, one to medical use, and nine as marching reserve. The categories could change on the road, but named purposes

prevented the strongest group from claiming the nearest spigot.

At the second bell, road wardens entered the east warehouse carrying mortuary tags.

Mera blocked the first bed. "Ren Tal lives."

"Move aside."

The old Bearer touched her bound shoulder. "I have only one useful arm. Decide how frightened that should make you."

Kessa arrived with the dispatch slate. "These dependents have been assigned to Sanitation Column Nineteen under contagion transfer. Touch them and you break quarantine."

The warden read the forged category. Fear of disease defeated his confidence in legal death. He backed toward the door and demanded a physician's seal.

"The physician rides with the column," Kessa said.

Outside, a tower horn sounded. Arlen had reached the signal line.

Hest cracked his reins. The first water team leaned into its traces. Cart six struck the south gatepost exactly where the Rill wheelwright had chalked it. Timber split outward. The reinforced hub held.

Nineteen water carts rolled into the mill lane.

Wardens ran from the military yard, slipping in lime. One raised a crossbow. Zarha stepped between him and the last driver with no weapon in her hands.

"If you shoot," she said, "name who goes thirsty for your order."

He aimed at her chest.

Kessa threw the depot seal. Brass struck his wrist, and the bolt went into a cask. Water jetted through the puncture. Two children slapped a waxed cloth over it while the cart kept moving.

Arlen appeared on the tower stair. "Close the road barrier!"

Nobody obeyed. The barrier crew came from the rear quarter and had watched Kessa issue water to their families during three previous expulsions. They turned the lifting wheel the wrong direction until its chain jumped.

The refugee column could not depart quickly. That remained the danger no plan erased. Three thousand eight hundred forty people took time to funnel from depot lanes onto a mill track built for grain wagons. Kessa placed able walkers along both sides, dreamless carts in the center, and water teams at intervals instead of one vulnerable train. The worst injured left first. Armed witnesses left last.

Imperial riders appeared on the eastern horizon before half the column had cleared.

"Twenty, maybe more," Marn called from the wall.

Kessa knew the road timings. Riders would reach the depot in eighteen minutes.

A mirror wagon dispatched from Deren Ford could block the main western road within half a day.

She climbed a grain ladder and studied the old tracks. North led into open farms with no surviving wells. West followed the white pavement directly toward enforcement. Southwest, the mill lane crossed two irrigation channels and joined the orchard road to Deren Ford below the imperial toll station.

"Southwest," she ordered. "Break the first two footbridges after the carts cross. Leave the irrigation gates open so walkers behind us can drink."

Zarha came beside her. "You are leaving your post."

"The post has declared 280 living people dead. It can manage without me."

"Seven Camp will not make you reeve of anything."

"Good. I dislike meetings under cloth."

For the first time, Zarha's expression almost softened. "You have not attended one of ours."

Kessa went to the last water cart. Her field ledgers, spare boots, and mother's kitchen knife fit in one grain sack. Everything else remained in her depot room, including seven years of issue records proving how often the Empire had moved food away from those who grew it.

She paused long enough to retrieve those ledgers. Evidence weighed less than regret and traveled better.

At the broken gate, Arlen waited without wardens. "The riders will ask whether you coerced the drivers."

"They will say no."

"They may say what avoids the rope."

"Then believe them."

Arlen looked at the column pouring onto the orchard road. "Deren Ford has a mirror demonstration in two days. Officers everywhere. You are taking them toward a blade."

"Deren has river water, bridge routes, and glass freight headed west. Open farms have heat and no wells." Kessa adjusted the ledger sack. "I choose among harms that exist. Your office chose dead people on paper."

She walked away before he could offer forgiveness or denunciation. Neither would move a cart.

The first irrigation crossing nearly ended the theft. Mud under the western bank swallowed a water cart to its axle, and the team behind it crowded too close to turn. Kessa stopped seven hundred walkers rather than let pressure crush the center ranks. Every halted minute brought the riders nearer.

The Rill wheelwright from cart six crawled into the mud with two Khar orchard workers. They laid shade poles crosswise beneath the buried wheel. Kessa shifted

forty gallons from the trapped cask into family jars, reducing the load without spilling the water into the channel. Zarha sent witnesses down the waiting line with an explanation of the delay. No rumor of attack outran them, so the column remained stretched rather than folding inward.

When the wheel rose, a hub pin split. Marn offered the iron spindle from Kessa's field-lens tripod. It fit after the wheelwright hammered its threads flat.

"You will not measure distances," he said.

"I can count steps."

"You always say other people's estimates are crimes."

"Then walk accurately."

They crossed the second channel with twice the spacing. Able walkers pulled handcarts while draft animals moved the water. At both bridges, crews lifted planks instead of burning them. Farm families might need those crossings after imperial pursuit passed. Kessa left the boards stacked on the far bank, heavy enough to delay horses but recoverable by people arriving on foot.

From the ridge, the pursuing riders divided. Twelve followed the mill lane. The rest turned toward the toll road, likely carrying dispatches to Deren Ford. Kessa marked their choices in her ledger. The column had perhaps one day before the ford closed, less if a mirror message outran the horses.

She moved the dreamless care carts forward by three positions. If troops struck the rear, mortuary law would not receive its victims first.

By the time imperial riders reached White Mile, Seven Camp had left the Road Without Shadows. Nineteen stolen water carts moved among 3,840 refugees, with the 280 dreamless protected in the center. Kessa took the rear count, watched the depot shrink in the glare, and redirected every surviving wheel toward Deren Ford.

Chapter 4 — Blackglass at Deren Ford

Pikk Rill found the false join by listening through his teeth.

He pressed one scarred palm to the siege mirror's bronze frame and bit the handle of a tuning fork. Its vibration traveled through his jaw, wrist, and the twelve blackglass panels suspended above Deren Ford. Eleven panels answered with a clean descending hum. The lower-right panel returned two notes where one belonged.

"Do not charge it," he said.

An imperial lieutenant already had his hand raised toward the signal crew. "We begin at second bell."

"Then begin with eleven panels and a hole." Pikk crawled beneath the frame. "Someone packed river grit behind this brace."

The demonstration platform occupied the eastern bank above the ford. Whitewashed officer tents covered the rise. Below them, the village of Low Deren clustered between willow groves and ferry sheds. Six hundred twelve residents had been ordered onto marked squares in the grazing field, each square positioned within sight of a census mirror. Soldiers called them donors. Pikk called them people whose shade-names appeared on an invoice he had been paid not to read carefully.

He loosened the suspect brace. Black dust fell onto his cheek. Rill workers from three contracted firms watched without speaking. His cousin Vikka's stamp marked the outer frame, while the panel itself came from a labor furnace at Karth Veil. Every component carried ownership marks. None named the lungs that had inhaled its grinding dust.

A compact-bodied apprentice slid beside him. "Brace pin came from Imperial Brass," she whispered. "They filled the socket after our inspection."

"Name?"

"Tovin Pell."

"Your name."

She blinked. "Senn Rill."

Pikk scratched Senn's name inside the frame where heat would darken rather than erase it. "Now the repair has a witness."

He pulled the pin. River grit concealed a silver filament wired toward the command box. Someone had added a bypass so the imperial operator could overload the panel beyond the limit Pikk set. He held the filament up.

The lieutenant crouched. "A calibration lead."

"It bypasses the sink bed."

“The test requires full battlefield force.”

“The sink bed keeps reflected force from entering the ground.”

“Low Deren volunteered its shade.”

Pikk looked toward the grazing field. Soldiers were moving a willow basket maker onto her numbered square because a census clerk said her left foot crossed the painted line. “Did the village choose the load?”

“The provincial office consented.”

Stone, glass, and authority all failed at their joins. The trick lay in discovering which failure could still be repaired.

Pikk removed the grit, reseated the brace, and left the silver bypass exposed where every Rill worker could see it. He could have cut it. Soldiers would replace it and exclude him from the controls. Instead, he altered the tuning weights in the sink bed, giving the overload somewhere to travel for a few breaths.

On the far bank, engineers had built a target wall of quarried basalt forty feet long and twelve feet high. The mirror's purpose involved absorbing the force of a siege strike, turning that force through blackglass, and returning it along a chosen angle. Blackglass created no darkness and no impact. It only persuaded captured relation to break elsewhere.

Imperial planners wanted the device at the head of every white-road army.

Second bell sounded.

Six census mirrors lifted around the grazing field. The 612 donors cast weak shadows beneath the unsetting sun. Clerks opened shade-name chests and fitted paper slips into mirrored wheels.

Pikk climbed to the command box. “Draw at one quarter. Sink bed open. Return angle thirty-two degrees north.”

The lieutenant set the draw lever at half.

“You heard my load.”

“I heard a contractor recommend delay.”

The mirrored wheels began to turn.

Every donor shadow lengthened toward the six white frames. Most villagers remained standing. A few dropped to one knee as their final forceful intentions took shape in the reflected glass: a ferryman bracing a rope, a baker protecting an oven door, a child striking at a dog that had cornered her. Those echoes held no souls or judgment. They repeated pressure given form by stolen shade-names.

The command box filled with a low vibration. Pikk watched the panel seams. Force entered the blackglass as angular stress, visible through pale lines spreading from the outer corners. He adjusted three sink valves. The target wall's reflected image appeared across the panels.

“Release quarter load,” he called.

A Rill operator pulled the return bar. Sound crossed the river without air. The basalt wall buckled inward. Its central stones traveled six feet, then dropped. Officers cheered beneath their awnings.

In the donor field, twelve people collapsed.

Pikk pointed. "End draw."

The lieutenant pushed the lever to full.

Silver filament flashed under the lower brace. The hidden bypass carried census force around the sink bed. Stress lines multiplied across the blackglass. Each donor's shadow stretched thinner, yet the wheels continued turning.

"Full battlefield return," the lieutenant ordered. "Take the wall down."

The tool obeyed its owner command.

Pikk struck the emergency latch. A soldier caught his wrist.

Across Low Deren, darkness began moving. Shade lifted from beneath willow leaves, ferry roofs, beds, cupboards, and grave markers. The river lost the dim green under its banks. Fish thrashed in bright water. On the field, villagers cried out as strips of shadow pulled from their bodies and joined the census mirrors.

The siege panels drank all of it.

Stress entered the false join and forked. One branch aimed toward the basalt wall. Another drove downward into the village's local relations: roots, sleep places, remembered shelter. Pikk felt the doubled note through the command rail.

"If you release now, the return crosses the houses," he said.

The lieutenant kept hold of his wrist. "The target sits north."

"Your bypass changed the ground angle."

"Correct it."

Pikk could not correct force already distributed through twelve panels. He could break its coherence.

He drove his forehead into the lieutenant's mouth. The grip loosened. Pikk dropped under the command box, pulled Senn's wedge from his belt, and hammered it between the seventh and eighth tuning rails.

The hum broke into two competing notes.

Blackglass redirected what entered it. Contradiction counted as a direction if the structure could survive long enough. Half the stored force turned toward the target wall. Half returned into the sink bed. The platform jumped.

Basalt stones exploded across the far bank. Mud erupted under the mirror. The bronze frame twisted above Pikk, dropping bolts hot enough to brand the boards. Senn and two other Rill workers hauled the silver bypass free with insulated hooks.

"Close the census wheels!" Pikk shouted.

Clerks had abandoned their stations. Khar orchard laborers from Low Deren ran

to the nearest wheel. One took a mirror beam across his face and fell blind. Two others wrapped the frame in a horse blanket. Villagers dragged the wheel backward until its axle snapped.

At the second station, soldiers tried to maintain the draw. A human ferryman knocked one down with an oar while his own shadow echo repeated the same blow inside the glass. The echo struck without recognizing friend or sequence. It hit the fallen soldier again, then again, because the donor's last forceful intention had contained no stopping condition.

"Turn the donor away!" Pikk called.

The ferryman's companions rotated him bodily until his reflected shadow lost alignment. The echo flattened against the wheel.

Pikk crawled along the command platform as braces failed around him. He reached the main return bar, which had bent under load. Three operators pulled with him. It did not move.

"Cut the owner line," Senn said.

"We lose every safety latch with it."

"We have already lost them."

She handed him a glass saw.

The owner line ran as a white filament through the center of the command box. Pikk sawed across it. Each stroke threw a reflection of his hands onto the black panels, making the scars look deeper than they were. When the filament parted, stored force ceased receiving imperial direction.

It did not vanish.

The remaining load searched for relation. Without an owner command, the strongest surviving relation ran through the repair names scratched inside the frame, the operators holding the rails, and the workers who had assembled each panel. Blackglass leaned toward its makers.

"Everyone off the platform," Pikk said. "Workers last."

Officers fled first. Rill crews held the sink valves while villagers cleared the bank. Pikk counted panels as their light dimmed. Ten discharged into mud and broken wall. The eleventh cracked along one corner. The lower-right panel kept singing two notes.

Senn stumbled at the stair. Her shadow had torn loose to the knee. Pikk caught her belt and pushed her toward the ground crew.

"Come with me," she said.

"When I remove the wedge, run downstream."

"That releases the contradiction."

"Into a frame with no owner line."

"Or into you."

Pikk showed her his teeth. "Then write my name where heat will not erase it."

He waited until the field cleared, then kicked the wedge free.

The last force struck the river. Water rose in a shining wall and fell over both banks. The lower-right panel split from corner to corner. Pikk rode the collapsing platform into mud.

He woke with his face under warm water and Senn's hand hooked in his collar. The mirror frame lay twisted across the bank. Low Deren's willows cast faint, damaged shadows again, but the deeper green did not return to the river. Whatever local shade covenant had lived there now clung in fragments to roots and wet stone.

The casualty count took four hours.

Of the 612 donors, nine had died from heart failure, head injuries, or force rebound. Fifty-three could not remember dreams from the previous month. One hundred eighty-six suffered partial shade separation, marked by numb limbs, confused sleep, or shadows that lagged behind movement. The remaining donors stayed conscious but reported nausea, grief without known cause, and loss of night vision. Three soldiers died under the repeated oar echo. Twelve workers had burns or broken bones. Pikk kept those categories separate when the lieutenant's clerk tried to record every injury as transient glare distress.

Low Deren's council sent no representative to the imperial inquiry. They sent the broken census wheel and the bloodied oar.

Before officers sealed the field, Pikk walked the donor rows with Senn. He carried a tuning fork and a bowl of lampblack. A healthy shadow returned a faint vibration when he struck the fork near its edge. Torn shadows gave back irregular pulses, while complete separation produced no answer.

The method did not heal anyone. It helped the village surgeons decide who might walk and who needed to stay flat.

At square eighty-four, the willow basket maker stared at her hands. Her shadow copied movements a heartbeat late. When she raised one finger, the dark hand raised two.

"Will it keep doing that?" she asked.

"I do not know."

"You built it."

"I built the black frame. The census wheels supplied the draw."

Her delayed shadow slapped the ground after her living hand had gone still. "Does that distinction help me sleep?"

Pikk marked her wrist for continuous watch. No answer he could give would change the mark.

The ferryman whose echo had killed three soldiers remembered striking the first

man and nothing after. Imperial wardens wanted to arrest him for the repeated blows. Pikk showed them the command trace embedded in a loose glass chip. Each reflected strike carried an identical stress signature, proof that the echo had repeated one intention rather than accepted new decisions.

"He did not issue the later blows," Pikk said.

"He supplied their force," a warden replied.

"Your wheel supplied repetition."

The village council placed forty people between the ferryman and the wardens. Some had supported the imperial road station because regular patrols reduced bandit raids. Others had hidden uncensused shade rites in river caves. Low Deren contained no single response to the Empire, even after imperial glass had injured it.

A ferry owner named Cala offered to keep the damaged census wheel operating under village control. "We could draw only from volunteers and sell reflected force to passing caravans."

The basket maker turned her mismatched shadow toward Cala. "With whose grandchildren repairing mistakes?"

Their argument lasted while medics worked. Pikk listened because tools entered politics before they entered battle. Destroying every mirror would not settle who controlled the next one or who accepted its dust. He promised the council a full stress diagram and told them which sink valves the officers had bypassed. He did not promise that knowledge made the device safe.

Near the river, workers recovered strips of torn shade from wet reeds. Blackglass scraps could hold those fragments for a few hours, but returning them required living local relation and donor consent. Pikk distributed every usable shard to Low Deren's healers. The imperial quartermaster objected that all fragments belonged to the demonstration inventory.

"Then inventory them in the treatment tents," Pikk said.

By the time the inquiry opened, thirty-one partially separated donors had regained sensation in a hand or foot. Seven had worsened. The dead remained nine. Pikk wrote each change beneath the official success figures before the clerk could close the ledger.

The lieutenant, mouth stitched, accused Pikk of sabotage. "Your tuning wedge split the return."

"Your bypass split it first."

"A battlefield mirror must accept command beyond contractor limits."

"Then your battlefield mirror will kill whoever stands behind it."

An Office of Public Continuity examiner arrived before the boards dried. She inspected the exposed silver filament, listened to testimony from officers only, and declared the test strategically successful with preventable donor instability. The

basalt wall had fallen. That mattered more to her report than the village shade.

"You will rebuild at Glass Causeway," she told Pikk. "A mobile frame. Stronger owner line."

He sat on an overturned cask while a medic removed bronze splinters from his palm. "No."

"Your guild contract grants the Empire wartime custody of designs and personnel."

"My contract requires a safe sink ratio."

"Your cousin Vikka Rill has already waived that clause for emergency use."

Vikka's signature appeared beneath the order. Pikk recognized the narrow loop she used when someone stood beside her desk waiting.

Refusal now would remove him from the next mirror and leave the silver bypass inside it. Agreement would put his hands on the structure again.

"Give me the failed panel," he said. "I need its stress map."

The examiner granted custody because broken blackglass looked useless to anyone who did not understand fracture.

At the repair shed, Pikk reconstructed the failure sequence. Owner command had entered through one white filament, crossed the false join, and forced all panels into a single return angle. His wedge introduced a counter-frequency. Cutting the owner line let worker relations pull force away from the intended target.

A stronger frame could reproduce that refusal if struck in the correct sequence: lower right, center left, upper brace, then owner line. Four points formed a fracture key. It would not shatter every panel. It would break the command pathway and force stored shadow to seek other relations.

Senn watched him chalk the sequence. "You plan to give them the repaired design."

"I plan to stand beside it when it matters."

"They will search your notes."

"Then I will not write notes."

A freight cart from the capital arrived carrying discarded observatory lenses for the new assembly. One cracked transit lens had a backing thicker than its optics required. Pikk opened it and found a mineral plate dusted with a false rainfall calendar.

Warm shade from the repair shed exposed numbers beneath the wing dust.

He read the eclipse contacts. Eleven minutes missing from the public table. Twelve harmonic annotations. A name scratched along the plate edge: Ilyen Vaor.

Pikk covered the figures before Senn could see more. "Who came with this cart?"

“Selai freight clerk. Went to the lower ferry.”

He understood neither the full table nor the astronomer's purpose. He did understand concealment. Inside the lens backing, he scratched the four-point fracture key around the plate rim, then sealed both forms of treason under the cracked glass.

The imperial examiner received a clean test record before sunset should have arrived. It blamed river-silt resonance, recommended a reinforced owner line, and certified blackglass return at full battlefield load. Pikk added the donor table as an appendix in ink too permanent to scrape without leaving holes. He signed because an unsigned lie would simply acquire Vikka's name.

Outside the shed, Low Deren buried nine donors under awnings that cast almost no shade. Families named the dead aloud without census clerks present. Pikk stood beyond the gathering. He had designed the frame, accepted imperial money, and trusted limits an owner could bypass. Sabotage at the next battle would not erase those choices.

Senn came to tell him a large refugee column had been sighted on the orchard road. Imperial riders were closing the west approaches. The mobile mirror would depart for Glass Causeway at first bell.

Pikk opened the transit lens one final time. He lifted out Ilyen's mineral plate, leaving the four fracture marks scratched into the wooden inset rim beneath the cracked glass. “Find the Selai freight clerk at the lower ferry,” he told Senn. “Give him this. If he has gone, follow the orchard road and ask for Ilyen Vaor. Do not show it to anyone else.”

“You trust an astronomer you have not met?”

“I trust eleven missing minutes to have an owner.”

Senn wrapped the plate against her ribs and left by the treatment tents. Pikk resealed the lens over the hidden fracture key and placed it in his tool chest. The two refusals now traveled toward the same war by separate roads.

He looked across the ruined river shade and decided his design would fail in war exactly where its owners needed obedience most.

Chapter 5 — The Empress Outlaws Evening

Caldra Ves placed three casualty reports in chronological order and found rebellion growing westward faster than her armies.

Seven Camp had resisted lawful shade collection. White Mile's baggage marshal had stolen 19 water carts and removed 3,840 displaced Khar from imperial custody. At Deren Ford, a blackglass contractor had cut an owner line during a successful siege demonstration, after which Low Deren villagers attacked census personnel.

Each report called itself local. Together they described a road opening away from her.

The Empress sat at the head of the Sun Basilica's dawn chamber while reflected light crossed the ceiling in perfect spokes. Public Continuity ministers occupied one side of the table, military officers the other. Physicians sat between them because Caldra required every campaign meeting to include someone who had touched a wounded body.

"Reservoir status," she said.

Minister Halen turned a page. "Eleven stable. Seven Camp intake arrived with twelve percent relation loss due to field resistance. The twelfth acquisition remains scheduled before eclipse."

"Dream impairment?"

"Two hundred eighty nonwaking after Seven Camp, plus handling losses within expected range."

Caldra looked to the senior physician. "Expected by whom?"

"Public Continuity," Physician-General Serit said. "Medical expectation lacks enough independent data."

Halen's mouth tightened. "The local Night resisted extraction."

"A prisoner can cause its own bruises by struggling," Serit said. "That does not make the bruises self-inflicted."

Caldra allowed the discomfort to remain. She had appointed officials who disagreed because unchallenged agreement had killed more people in her family than any assassin.

General Orr unfolded a road map. "The Seven Camp column moves toward Deren Ford. If it joins the engineer and the escaped astronomer, they may carry technical knowledge west. We can close Glass Causeway and recover all four assets."

"People are not assets."

"The astronomer, engineer, marshal, and reeve."

"You may call them fugitives. You may not turn language into permission to damage what we need to understand."

Orr inclined his head. "Four fugitives."

Caldra studied the map. Fifty days remained until totality, though the campaign clock had begun three days earlier with the Seven Camp seizure. Officials wanted to name it for the eclipse. Military clerks preferred Reservoir Completion. Both titles concealed the reason for urgency.

The One Night project had begun with a promise simple enough to say to a dying child: nobody would ever again be locked outside safe darkness because a lord owned the door.

Caldra rose. "Delay decision until I return."

She crossed the Basilica alone by the lower infirmary route. The white terraces above held ceremonies, petitions, and school visits. Beneath them, basalt corridors connected the medical wards to the reservoir service levels. Cold seeped through the floor. Staff had covered the walls with pale cloth so patients would not glimpse their own shadows moving toward pipes.

The Night Plague memorial occupied a narrow room outside Ward Four. No statues stood there. Shelves held clay cups, each marked with a district and number. Caldra found the cup for South Ves, Year Three Hundred Seventy-One.

Nine thousand four hundred six dead.

She had been thirteen. Her younger brothers, Tal and Oren, had been eight and six. Plague creatures moved through unmanaged darkness, carrying fever between sleep houses. Local lords closed their deep shelters to people without rent tokens. Crowds fought at cellar doors while families with seals slept behind stone.

Caldra remembered every hour.

Tal burning through three wet sheets. Oren asking why morning would not come when dawn had already brightened the shutters. Their mother bargaining with a district lord for two places and receiving one. Caldra had been pushed through the shelter door alone.

The lord later claimed he saved the heir.

Her brothers died outside under an awning too thin to hold safe Night. Hundreds died in the same square. After the plague, free courts praised local sovereignty while widows searched mass trenches for teeth.

Memory kept the square without mercy. A fruit seller had tied blankets between two carts, offering darkness to children until the plague creatures found the warm enclosure. Soldiers burned both carts while people still sheltered beneath them. Across the square, Lord Pael's cellar vents released cool air that smelled of apples. His guards held the doors with spear shafts.

Young Caldra had bitten the hand of the man carrying her inside. She wanted Tal brought with her. The man said the heir must live. At thirteen, she had

understood the sentence as rescue. By morning, she understood its second half: the others could be spent.

Years later she opened every sealed cellar in South Ves and prosecuted Pael's surviving household. The trials proved that his private Night had held room for eight hundred more people. He had admitted one hundred twelve. His defense claimed uncontrolled entry would have broken the covenant and killed everyone. Three surviving Night-Bearers disagreed about whether that claim had been true.

Caldra had learned from the dispute rather than from certainty. Local custody created knowledge outsiders lacked. It also gave custodians power to make self-interest sound like ecology. Imperial records could expose hoarding. Imperial roads could move medicine. Common rules could require a shelter door to open.

She had once believed common rules and central command could remain different things.

Caldra closed both hands around the memorial cup. She had built roads that any traveler could use, funded common shelters, broken hereditary cellar monopolies, and cut night-predator deaths by more than half. Those facts mattered. So did the people whose names her census now pulled into glass.

Serit entered without escort. The physician knew where Caldra went when ministers reduced injury to expected range.

"Seven Camp's dreamless," Caldra said. "Can they wake?"

"Possibly near compatible living Night. Perhaps through time and care. We do not know."

"Public Continuity declared them dead."

"Relief code did. Bodies often fail to obey codes."

Caldra returned the clay cup to its shelf. "If we release the reservoirs now?"

"Some Nights may return toward their origins. Others have changed through confinement. Sudden release beneath the capital could produce predation, dream flooding, ecological shock, or nothing we have language for."

"And if we complete alignment?"

"You ask medicine to predict a commanded covenant no one has created."

"I ask whether one regulated shelter can prevent another plague."

Serit looked at the shelves. "A shelter that cannot be refused can also become a locked cellar."

The words reached the place in Caldra that still smelled fever. She did not dismiss them. She carried them back to the dawn chamber and chose against them.

During her absence, ministers had prepared three orders. General Orr wanted emergency road control and the arrest of named resistance leaders. Halen wanted mandatory registration of every remaining shade rite. Serit proposed a sixty-day

pause on extractions and independent review after eclipse.

"A pause passes through totality," Caldra said.

"Yes."

"It leaves eleven captive Nights separate under pressure they already cannot bear. It leaves unregistered local shelters under lords, courts, guilds, and families with unequal rules."

"It also leaves them local."

Halen pushed his order forward. "Registration lets us distinguish cooperative rites from insurgent stores."

"Seven Camp registered," Caldra said. "We used those names to take it."

Nobody spoke.

She read the three drafts. Orr's order treated the west as a military corridor and would strip civilian administration. Halen's preserved the fiction of voluntary registration while punishing refusal. Serit's accepted immediate disorder to prevent greater coercion, but offered no protection if Night Plague conditions returned during eclipse.

Caldra took a blank sheet.

She wrote the first article herself: no evening, shade rite, sleep covenant, funeral dark, fungal shelter, or hosted local Night could operate without census recognition until the eclipse emergency ended.

The second article ordered uncensused rites opened by district witnesses, then broken with white mirrors if hosts refused inspection.

The third classified obstruction as aid to night predation.

Serit read over her shoulder. "You are outlawing evening."

"I am outlawing unaccountable shelter during a celestial emergency."

"To the person whose family blanket gets cut down, those phrases differ only in who signs the knife."

Caldra continued. Registered rites would receive public rations and supervised hosting. Children, the ill, and the displaced held priority. Mirror teams required medical officers. Every forced breaking needed a named official and an impairment ledger.

Rules did not make coercion harmless. They made a path for later judgment, if later judgment remained possible.

General Orr objected to the medical requirement. Halen objected to publishing impairment. Serit objected to the entire decree.

Caldra listened to all three.

"Will you resign?" she asked the physician.

"No. Someone must write what your mirrors do."

“Then write without permission.”

That concession did not balance the order. Caldra knew the arithmetic of power better than anyone in the room. Her signature would send thousands of patrols into household darkrooms, Khar funeral tents, Selai moth gardens, Rill sleep tunnels, and human village cellars. Some local hosts exploited darkness. Others kept communities alive. Enforcement would not distinguish them cleanly.

She signed anyway.

The title read Evening Prohibition, Emergency Decree Seven.

Beneath it, Caldra authorized the Fifty-Three-Day Campaign, dated from the Seven Camp extraction. Its objectives named the remaining free Night, the eclipse alignment, uninterrupted road supply, and recovery of stolen technical material. No proclamation mentioned that the public table concealed eleven minutes. She ordered that omission maintained to prevent crowds converging during totality.

Halen sanded the decree. “How widely?”

“All provinces.”

“Even districts without reported resistance?”

“Plague does not respect reported resistance.”

Serit left the chamber before copies were made.

The Basilica's dispatch floor turned one signature into movement. Copper stamps struck paper. Mirror clerks reduced articles to light code. Riders took sealed versions to districts lacking relay towers. Quartermasters issued hooks for pulling down shade-cloth and white blankets for containing fragments. Medical offices received new ledger columns they had not requested. Provincial governors received authority to deputize local rivals as inspectors, a clause Caldra had opposed in committee and now accepted for speed. By noon, private resentments across the Empire possessed official uniforms.

Caldra walked among the copy tables and corrected one clerk who had rendered “may be broken” as “shall be destroyed.” The distinction saved some rites, perhaps. It also let her believe precision restrained the machine she had started.

She followed the first enforcement team into Lantern Ward without announcing herself. A plain sun-cloak hid her crown but not her age or bearing. Six mirror constables, a district physician, and two census witnesses stopped at a communal sleep house beneath the dyers' quarter. Forty families had pooled basement rooms there because upper floors never cooled.

The host, a human woman with indigo hands, produced a registration token dated three years earlier. The lead constable rejected it because the sleep house had added two rooms without inspection.

“We added them after your road works displaced the cooper lane,” the host said.

“Unregistered expansion voids covenant coverage.”

Children watched from the stair. Behind them, bowls of unlit water sat beneath shelves of mushroom soil. Caldra felt a weak local darkness gathered among breath, damp brick, and exhausted trust. It posed no plague threat she could detect. She lacked the knowledge to certify that judgment.

The physician recommended temporary registration. The constable wanted the water carried into sunlight and the fungal beds scraped.

Caldra stepped forward. "Article six permits medical supervision pending review."

Recognition passed across the constable's face. He knelt. Everyone else followed more slowly.

"Do not kneel in a sleep house," Caldra said. "Issue a seven-day token."

The host accepted the token without thanks. "And on the eighth day?"

"An inspector decides."

"You decide who inspects."

Caldra had no answer that would make the structure less true. She left the house unbroken and continued to the next address, where constables had already dragged shade-cloth into the street. One spared room could not acquit a province-wide decree.

At a western relay station, her order would reach officers pursuing Seven Camp. At Low Deren, it would legalize the seizure villagers had just survived. In the capital's poor wards, families would hide darkness in water jars and under beds, turning ordinary sleep into an offense.

The knowledge did not stop her. It remained with her as consequence rather than counsel, one more accurate record filed beneath an order already moving. She had always feared rulers who confused pain with wisdom. Fear did not exempt her from becoming one.

She returned to the memorial alone. Tal's and Oren's names did not appear separately on the district cup. Nine thousand four hundred six included them. Empire had begun, in Caldra's mind, with the refusal to let powerful households decide which names deserved shelter.

Now her own name stood above every shelter in Avarra.

Outside, bells announced the Evening Prohibition under a sun that had not set. Fifty days remained in the campaign first counted at fifty-three. Caldra listened until the final bell and ordered Glass Causeway closed before the refugees could cross.

Chapter 6 — Beneath the White Orchard

Zarha cut into the first white-leaf trunk and found cool sap under the dead bark.

She touched one drop to her tongue. Bitter, fungal, alive. Above her, the orchard leaves had bleached to the color of old bone, each leaf fixed on its branch despite the heat. The ground offered no shade, but coolness moved beneath it.

"Stop the lead carts," she called. "No axes below the first branch. Keep wheels between tree rows."

Kessa came forward with her dispatch board. Three days among refugees had left road dust in every seam of her clothes. "We have pursuit behind and a closed ford ahead. Is this where trees give military advice?"

"Trees give axle timber. Advice usually costs more." Zarha showed her the sap. "There may be a Night sliver under the roots."

Kessa crouched and smelled it. "Can it hide 3,840 people?"

"No."

"Can it fill casks?"

"No."

"Then tell me what changes."

"We stop cooking from below."

That changed enough. Kessa rerouted the first five water carts into the orchard and sent runners down the column with strict spacing. Families entered in household groups. Nobody dug fire pits or cut roots. White leaves reflected the fixed sun, yet soil under the oldest trees held a damp chill.

The place had once been an orchard clan settlement. Square house foundations stood among the rows, dismantled long ago. Memorial jars remained in root hollows. Their painted witness marks showed settled Khar families, human grafting crews, and two generations of Selai moth keepers. Empire maps named the land abandoned agricultural reserve.

Roots disagreed.

Seven Camp's oldest orchard families recognized the irrigation marks. White Orchard had belonged to the Keshen and Marrow clans before an imperial land survey moved the river boundary. Their descendants did not tell one history. Keshen witnesses said tax collectors forced the settlement out after three failed harvests. Marrow elders said their own reeves sold the lower grove to pay road debt and concealed the bargain under a migration rite. A human grafting family produced a contract showing both accounts contained truth.

Zarha made the disputed records part of the camp count. A surviving Night did not sanctify every choice made beneath it. The sliver had endured abandonment, sale, and forced boundary change because roots and graves continued relations

that politics refused to settle.

At the western edge, Kessa found an old collection trench holding black water under a lid of woven roots. She tested it for salt and rot before allowing anyone to fill cups. The trench yielded only four hundred gallons before mud rose through the intake, too little for a marching day but enough to replace what had leaked at the irrigation crossing.

"The trees did fill casks," Zarha said.

"The trench did. I remain undecided about the trees."

They assigned the water first to fever patients and draft animals. Kessa posted a clerk beside the trench with one cup size, resisting families who claimed ancestral priority. A Keshen elder objected that her grandparents had dug the channel.

"Then honor them by letting it keep strangers alive," Zarha said.

The elder surrendered her place but stayed to witness the measure. That small choice strengthened the sliver more visibly than any spoken rite. Gray fungus spread along one root and darkened from pearl to charcoal.

Mera Seln knelt with her injured arm strapped close. She scraped soil from a cluster of gray fungi no wider than her hand. When her breath touched them, their gills darkened.

"Small," she said. "Frightened. It has been living under its own dead leaves."

The local sliver pressed against Zarha's senses as a web of narrow relations. Root found fungus. Fungus found memorial clay. Clay found names spoken nearby by descendants passing on the road. No voice emerged. No route appeared. The Night knew injury and shelter, not the empire beyond its trees.

"Ask it about our sleepers," one mother said.

"It does not answer questions." Zarha helped unroll a mat for Ren Tal. "We can introduce them. We cannot make it take responsibility for what Seven Camp lost."

The dreamless carts entered the coolest rows. All 280 survivors still breathed. Their care teams had kept them alive by wick water and broth, though eight now coughed when turned and twenty-one had developed fever. Ren's fist remained closed around his supper token.

From the eastern road came two travelers under a patched lens-cleaner's hood. One walked with a Selai astronomer's long, measured stride. The other, a compact Rill woman, limped whenever her shadow lagged behind her left foot.

Seven Camp witnesses closed around them.

The Selai traveler raised empty hands. Mineral tracks crossed his copper ear-fans, but most of the star-moth ink had faded. "Ilyen Vaor," he said. "Formerly of the High Observatory."

Zarha recognized the name from imperial eclipse notices. "You calculated the tables used to take our Night."

"I calculated road alignments that became part of the apparatus."

Kessa joined them. "If you want the difference to matter, make it useful quickly."

The Rill woman pulled a wrapped plate from beneath her shirt. "Senn Rill. Pikk sent this back to him." She nodded toward Ilyen. "Imperial troops took Pikk and the mobile mirror to Glass Causeway. He carved a way to break owner command into the lens backing he kept."

"Why tell us?" Zarha asked.

"Because I stood inside his first failure." Senn lifted her delayed foot. Its shadow finished moving after the boot stopped. "Because 612 donors stood inside it too."

Ilyen unwrapped the mineral plate. Wing dust showed a false rainfall calendar until Mera held a bowl of root shade above it. Numbers emerged in concentric lines.

"The true eclipse table," he said. "Public proclamations remove eleven minutes from totality. During that hidden interval, twelve captive darkness reservoirs beneath the Sun Basilica can enter sympathetic pressure."

Zarha looked at the rings without pretending to understand their angles. "Seven Camp makes twelve?"

"No. Eleven reservoirs currently hold stolen Nights. Your Night entered one already prepared to receive it. Imperial schedules indicate another free region will supply the twelfth."

"You know this because you built the schedule."

"I know the sky because I measured it. I know the reservoirs because I found their pipes after years of measuring what the Empire assigned me to measure."

Anger climbed Zarha's throat. "Our census names were collected twelve years ago. Were you looking up then?"

"Yes."

The answer left no easy surface to strike.

Ilyen pointed to the outer ring. "The first seizure order opened a span of 53 days. Five have passed. Forty-eight remain before totality."

Kessa took the plate, careful not to touch the wing dust. "What happens during the missing eleven minutes?"

"Captive Nights can touch. The Basilica intends coercive alignment. I do not know the complete command structure."

"Alignment into what?"

"A single regulated darkness able to travel imperial roads."

The words moved through the surrounding witnesses. Someone spat into the dead leaves. A father near the dreamless carts began shouting that the astronomer should be tied beneath the sun until he returned what he took.

Zarha felt the same desire and refused to let it become procedure. "Ilyen Vaor stands under accusation and guest law until this meeting ends. Anyone who strikes him answers to the open tent we no longer possess."

"Convenient," said Derrin Kesh.

"Law becomes most convenient when it protects the person we hate. That does not make it false."

Ilyen removed his veil. The seasonal inks along his ear-fans showed gaps where living moth colonies had died. "To copy this plate, I commanded the last shade in an observatory darkroom. The command spent my memory of my first star-moth hatching."

"You remember enough to tell us," Zarha said.

"I retain the facts. I have no feeling attached to them. My mother steadied my hand, and I can no longer reach the warmth of hers. The absence does not atone for my work."

Mera studied him. "Good. A price becomes dangerous when the payer calls it innocence."

They moved the table beneath a grafting shed while the column settled. Kessa posted three guards, one from Seven Camp, one depot driver, and Senn. Trust arranged by mutual suspicion could still guard a door.

Under the oldest trees, the Night sliver gathered around the dreamless.

Mera organized an invitation rather than a rite of command. Care teams placed unlit water near each sleeper's head. Descendants of White Orchard families came forward from the refugee column and named the memorial jars they recognized. Others offered road dust, funeral knots, mushroom cloth, or one truthful account of where they had slept the previous rest.

Zarha offered Seven Camp's ruined hospitality cloth. "This held strangers before it held wounds."

Coolness rose through the mats.

The sliver moved by relation. It reached people whose care teams touched roots connected to old graves. It leaned away from white-road dust containing mirror grit. Where a sleeper's shade had torn completely, the local darkness could find no path. Where some thread remained through family voice, wet cloth, or remembered shelter, eyelids changed rhythm.

Nobody told it whom to wake.

A child opened her eyes and screamed at the bright leaves. Her father covered her face before lifting her. Three elders woke next, one speaking a language nobody present knew. Across the rows, breaths deepened. Fingers opened.

Ren Tal did not move.

Zarha walked each row while clerks marked names. Thirty-nine people woke

over two hours. None returned whole. A baker recognized her husband but not flour. Two children had lost every memory of Seven Camp houses while remembering songs without words. An orchard worker knew his own name and kept asking where his dead mother waited.

"Do not question them for intelligence," Zarha told the witnesses. "Food, water, names, rest. Their missing pieces belong to them before they belong to our count."

Kessa revised her board. "Two hundred forty-one remain dreamless. Thirty-nine waking require space on medical carts until they can stand. Water demand rises because they can swallow more, but wick labor falls."

"You can make a miracle sound like barrel repair," Derrin said.

"Miracles that ignore barrel repair kill people before supper."

Zarha watched Kessa assign two waking adults to each child, avoiding automatic return to households the child did not recognize. The human marshal distrusted myth, yet her columns gave the Night's change a durable shape.

The White Orchard sliver withdrew after the thirty-ninth waking. Its fungi paled. Mera stopped anyone from requesting more.

"It spent no commander's memory," a witness argued. "Why not continue?"

"Because relation also tires," Mera said. "Consent does not mean endless capacity."

Near the grafting shed, the coalition argument began with water.

Kessa wanted to cross Deren Ford, follow imperial freight routes as long as stolen dispatch marks held, and reach a defensible town before committing to distant allies. Ilyen wanted the true table delivered to Leth Aven, where Selai astronomers could verify it and alert star-moth houses. Zarha wanted Akar Seven and the free Khar Night Courts warned before imperial mirror teams reached them.

"Two destinations, one column, nineteen carts, and forty-eight days," Kessa said. "The Red Salt lies between us and both. Glass Causeway controls the only loaded route west."

Ilyen traced the map. "A foot path follows the southern salt shelves."

"For five hundred walkers, perhaps. Not 3,840, not with 241 unconscious."

Zarha put witness knots at Akar Seven and Leth Aven on the map. "If we reach neither, the Empire collects local Nights one by one. If we split now, one half loses water and both lose the sleepers' care teams."

"Then we need the causeway," Kessa said.

"We need what lies beyond it," Ilyen corrected.

Kessa looked at him. "Bridges object when people treat them as symbolism."

Senn reported what Pikk had built there: a mobile blackglass frame, white census wheels, owner command reinforced after Low Deren. She knew the four-point fracture key only existed in the cracked lens backing in Pikk's chest. She

did not know whether he would use it under guard.

"Pikk intends refusal," she said. "Intent and opportunity have poor marriage prospects."

Zarha understood that well. "Can we send him opportunity?"

Senn drew the causeway deck: mirrored paving above a deep salt gorge, tollhouse at the eastern mouth, maintenance stairs below. Pikk's crews would assemble on the north parapet. Imperial troops expected refugees to approach from the east road.

Kessa began moving household knots across the sketch. "We show them what they expect. Main column on the road. Small teams go under the bridge before engagement, if the maintenance stair remains open. Water carts cross in pairs. Dreamless carts stay central until the first mirror breaks."

They walked the plan through the orchard rather than trusting marks on paper. Two rows of trees represented the causeway parapets. Water drivers practiced entering in pairs and unhitching a lead animal without turning the cart. Care teams learned how to lower dreamless litters beneath axle height if mirror fire crossed the deck. Children carried empty jars along the route so adults could see where panic would create gaps.

Kessa stopped the exercise after the third cart jammed. "We cannot put all nineteen on the bridge. Six cross with the first civilian blocks. Eight wait here until the western mouth clears. Five move below if the service track carries their weight."

"Splitting water invites seizure," Zarha said.

"Concentrating it invites one broken axle to stop everything."

Mera proposed assigning each group rights to draw from any surviving cart, preventing temporary custody from becoming ownership. Kessa wrote that rule onto dispatch tags and tied copies to every spigot. Zarha added two witnesses per group, one from a household with a cart and one without.

Ilyen contributed the mirror angles. White paving would return light upward at midday, but the fixed sun now struck from the west, turning the eastern approach into a glare channel. Wet cloth protected skin but could reflect enough brightness to expose a moving shadow. He showed walkers how to dust the cloth with orchard soil. The refugees practiced without asking whether astronomy counted as treason or repair.

Senn drew the mobile frame in more detail. Its panels could redirect physical force after a census draw. "If Pikk fractures the owner line, stored force may seek the workers who assembled it. Keep his crews away from the return angle. He will care about that before he cares about your column."

"He should," Zarha said. "An ally who sacrifices his own workers for us will sacrifice us later."

Derrin listened from the edge. "You already call him ally."

"I call him a person whose interests may cross ours for one bridge."

That distinction mattered to the witnesses. Seven Camp had suffered from an imperial charter accepted as practical cooperation and later treated as permanent consent. Zarha would not build another road from one convenient agreement to endless obedience.

During the fourth practice, a dreamless litter slipped. Two depot drivers and a Khar child caught it before the sleeper struck ground. Kessa changed every litter knot from a single loop to a paired hitch, then made all care teams retie them. Preparation consumed an hour. It might save a life without ever appearing in a battle song.

"You plan battle before we agree what comes after," Ilyen said.

"After requires living people."

Zarha placed her broken tusklet against her lower lip, thinking. A core alliance could not rest on affection. Ilyen carried knowledge and guilt. Kessa carried water and a refusal to abandon inconvenient bodies. Zarha carried an office whose tent had been left behind. None could command the Night they sought to save without repeating part of the theft.

"We agree on three things," she said. "The dreamless remain living members of the column. The true table belongs before multiple witnesses, not one court. Any Night we reach may refuse our request."

Ilyen nodded first. Kessa took longer.

"If refusal leaves us without shelter?" she asked.

"Then we carry cloth."

"More weight."

"Yes."

Kessa drew a line from Glass Causeway into the Red Salt. "I can govern weight."

They sealed no grand treaty. Zarha tied three cords around the wrapped table: a Seven Camp witness knot, a depot dispatch cord, and one thread from Ilyen's moth veil. Senn retained custody until the causeway because none of the three principals trusted themselves to carry the only evidence.

A scout arrived before they finished. Imperial troops had closed both ends of Glass Causeway. Two companies dug positions at the western mouth. Another held the tollhouse. Mirror crews worked along the north parapet under Pikk Rill. More troops followed the refugees from White Mile.

"Time?" Kessa asked.

"Half a day before the rear patrol reaches the orchard. Less before the causeway finishes its array."

The Night sliver tightened around the roots as if pressure approached from the

road. It offered no instruction. Its fungi simply withdrew from the eastern soil first.

Zarha read relation rather than prophecy. The threat came east. The only westward road crossed imperial glass.

She ordered the waking thirty-nine distributed among care carts, the remaining 241 dreamless moved behind water teams, and every household issued wet cloth for reflected glare. Mera and six volunteers stayed until the last moment to cover the root fungi with clay and leaves.

At forty-eight days before totality, Zarha, Kessa, and Ilyen chose the same road for different reasons. Beyond Glass Causeway waited the Red Salt, free Khar Night Courts, and Selai star-moth houses. Behind them came the Evening Prohibition. Zarha lifted the first white branch from the path, and the coalition moved toward the bridge that had been ordered closed.

Chapter 7 — The Battle of Glass Causeway

Kessa counted four ways off Glass Causeway and rejected three before the first imperial horn.

The bridge crossed a salt-cut gorge west of Deren Ford, eight hundred yards of white paving suspended between black cliffs. Mirror chips lay in every stone. The northern maintenance stair descended to anchor galleries under the deck. A drainage ledge ran along the south parapet, narrow enough for one unburdened person. The gorge itself offered a fifth route only to bodies.

At the western mouth, imperial soldiers had built two barricades around the tollhouse. Crossbow teams held the upper windows. A mobile blackglass frame stood on the north parapet halfway across, twelve dark panels tilted toward the eastern approach. Six census wheels surrounded it. Pikk Rill worked beneath the frame with perhaps eighty Rill crew members and two armed guards close enough to watch his hands.

Behind the refugees, dust marked the White Mile pursuit.

“Three hundred riders,” Kessa said. “Possibly four. They reach the orchard road in two hours.”

Zarha studied the rear through a borrowed lens. “The last households need one hour to reach us.”

“They get forty minutes. We cannot be caught with carts still turning onto the bridge.”

The reeve's black-brown eyes narrowed. “Tell them the reason, not just the number.”

“I intend both.”

Kessa set her field board on a water cask and divided the column. Six water carts would lead under the forged sanitation dispatch. Two hundred walking adults would accompany them, appearing like containment labor. Care carts carrying the 241 dreamless would follow in blocks of twenty, each separated by walkers. Eight reserve water carts waited under white cloth in the orchard. Five descended toward the maintenance track, though nobody yet knew whether its anchor ramps would hold loaded axles.

The thirty-nine newly awakened remained on medical carts among the central blocks. Some could sit. None could walk a battle crossing without risk.

“We preserve water and dependents,” Kessa told the gathered household leaders. “If soldiers attack, do not run toward the nearest cart. Stay with your assigned rope. A stopped line moves aside before it repairs. Anyone separated follows blue cloth west, red cloth east.”

“What if neither cloth remains?” someone called.

"Follow the bridge. It has only two ends."

Dry laughter moved through the crowd and died quickly.

Mera Seln took responsibility for the dreamless blocks. Ilyen wrapped the true eclipse plate beneath his coat after Senn refused to carry the coalition's only proof into the anchor galleries. Zarha assembled three hundred witnesses, orchard hunters, depot workers, and adults willing to hold the rear. Most carried tools rather than military weapons.

Kessa stopped her. "You have no armor."

"Neither do the people behind me."

"That does not improve your skin."

Zarha took a scale vest from a dead imperial rider's recovered gear. It fit badly across her shoulders but covered her center. "Satisfied?"

"No. Less distracted."

A white flag rose over the tollhouse.

The imperial commander rode to the middle of the bridge with twelve guards. He introduced himself as Colonel Sar Avren and read from the Evening Prohibition. The order declared Seven Camp's uncensused rites broken, its shade-names subject to recovery, and all persons obstructing transfer liable to detention.

"Your water train belongs to the road army," Avren called. "Your nonwaking remains require mortuary examination. Surrender Zarha Kesh, Kessa Dorn, Ilyen Vaor, and the stolen table. All other recognized living civilians receive provisional relief."

Kessa walked out under a depot flag. Mirror glare burned through the cloth wrapped around her head.

"How much water?" she asked.

Avren frowned. "What?"

"Provisional relief for 3,840 people. How much water have you allocated?"

"That depends on medical classification."

"Give me the transport count."

"We are discussing surrender."

"You have six cistern wagons behind the tollhouse, four of them half full by spring angle. At half ration, you supply this column for less than a day. Your commander behind us has another three wagons for his horses. You cannot offer relief. You offer a fenced thirst."

Avren's guards shifted. Two glanced toward the cisterns.

"Return to your people," he said. "You have fifteen minutes."

Kessa handed him a copy of her sanitation dispatch. "Six contaminated water carts require passage to Deren quarantine. Your own seal admitted them at White

Mile.”

He read the forged mark. “Prefect Arlen reported theft.”

“After he signed dispatch. Bureaucratic sequence matters.”

Avren tore the paper in half. The gesture told Kessa he feared its procedural ambiguity. An officer certain of authority would have kept it as evidence.

She returned east and said, “We cross now.”

Hest drove the first water team onto the bridge. White paving reflected horses, wheels, and every strip of cloth overhead. Ilyen's orchard soil dulled the wet canopies, but shadows still gathered in wheel ruts. The second cart followed at thirty yards. Kessa walked between them with a sanitation baton and dared the western guards to decide whether orders permitted shooting imperial property.

They passed the first census wheel.

Its operator lowered his gaze. Pikk's crews continued tightening braces. Hammer taps traveled through the bridge in measured groups. Kessa counted four, paused, then three. The Rill engineer did not look at her.

At midspan, Colonel Avren raised one hand.

Crossbows aimed from the tollhouse.

“Stop the carts,” he ordered.

Kessa lifted the dispatch baton. “A stopped contamination train violates road code.”

“You no longer hold commission.”

“Then why are you obeying my spacing?”

Behind her, the third and fourth carts entered. Under their cover, the first dreamless care block reached the paving. Families walked with one hand on litter ropes, eyes lowered against glare.

Avren saw them. “Those are mortuary dependents.”

“They breathe.”

“Remove them from the road.”

“No.”

The colonel dropped his hand.

Crossbows fired.

Kessa pulled a child behind the lead cask. Bolts struck wood and paving. One horse reared, twisting its team bar. Hest cut the trace before the second animal fell. Walkers pushed the cart from both sides while arrows rattled on its wet canopy.

Zarha's rear group answered with hunting bows from the eastern approach. Their shafts fell short of the tollhouse but drove the nearest census operators behind their wheels. Civilians continued onto the bridge because stopping under

aimed mirrors meant dying in a tighter mass.

Kessa blew two notes: spacing and forward movement.

Under the north parapet, Senn reached the maintenance stair. She disappeared below with eight Rill workers who had shed imperial armbands. Pikk heard the second whistle. His hammer pattern changed.

The blackglass panels tilted.

A command officer opened the shade-name chest. Paper slips bearing Seven Camp's old census tokens entered the six mirrored wheels. The first wheel turned.

Shadows pulled eastward under thousands of feet.

Screams moved through the care blocks. A woman fell against a litter, her shadow stretched beneath three other people. Children lost their grip on blue guide cloth. Mirror force gathered across Pikk's frame as pale stress lines.

Kessa reached the first care block. "Cover names. Household groups, speak over the clerks."

Witnesses began reciting voluntary names, not as magic command but as competing relation. "Hara of the north cookfire, under witness by Jekk and Marn." "Seli, daughter by adoption, water carrier, terrible singer." "Ren Tal, stones cheat, ration debtor, sleeping and alive."

The census wheels held registered tokens. Spoken relations did not break glass, but they gave people a way to pull one another upright when shadows dragged.

The mobile mirror hummed.

Pikk stood at its command box. An imperial guard pressed a sword against his shoulder. Colonel Avren shouted, "Return force to the eastern mouth."

That order would strike the densest part of the column.

Pikk pulled a lever.

Blackglass brightened.

Nothing released.

He had opened the sink bed instead of the return rail.

The command officer hit him across the face. Pikk dropped, rolled under the box, and vanished among the braces. Rill crew members stepped between the guards and the controls. One soldier fired into them. Senn emerged from the maintenance hatch and drove a wedge through his boot into the deck.

"Now," Kessa shouted, though she did not know whether Pikk could hear.

The rear pursuit struck the eastern households.

Riders came through the orchard in three ranks, mirror lances held low. Zarha's people overturned two empty freight carts across the approach. The first horses jumped. The second rank crashed into them. Witnesses pulled riders down with tent ropes, avoiding the mirrored lance heads where possible.

Kessa saw the collision from midspan and had to remain facing west. Command divided attention even when the body could not divide. She sent Marn east with her reserve whistle and trusted Zarha to make decisions Kessa would learn only through casualties.

At the tollhouse, Avren ordered infantry onto the deck. Two hundred soldiers advanced behind white shields. Their formation left no lane for civilians exiting west.

Kessa climbed onto the lead water cart. "Drivers, open casks three and four."

Hest stared up at her. "We need that water."

"We need ground they cannot march on."

He pulled both spigots. Water spread across mirrored paving. Refugees threw orchard soil into it. The surface became brown slurry, dulling reflections and taking soldiers' footing. The front rank slowed. Civilian groups pressed through gaps between shields rather than meeting them as a battle line.

A young imperial soldier lowered his spear to let an elder pass. His sergeant struck him. Three others turned on the sergeant. Avren's formation buckled from within.

Kessa pointed to the northern drainage lane. "Anyone refusing the firing order, move there with weapons grounded."

Seventy soldiers broke rank. Some belonged to occupied provinces. Others had relatives among reservoir donors or had watched the dreamless litters enter. Captain Nevi, a human officer with a burn scar across her chin, led them toward the tollhouse winch.

Avren called them traitors and ordered his crossbows to fire.

The first volley killed nine defectors on the open paving.

Nevi kept moving. Her soldiers raised white shields over civilians rather than returning fire. They reached the winch controlling the west barrier and began cutting its chain.

Above them, Pikk struck blackglass.

Lower right panel. One blow.

He crossed beneath the frame while guards fought his workers. Center-left rail. Two blows.

The sound changed from a single imperial hum to competing tones.

Kessa had never met him. She recognized deliberate failure when she heard it.

"Clear the north parapet!" she shouted.

Rill workers dragged wounded companions toward the maintenance hatch. Senn cut the trapped soldier free only after taking his sword. Pikk climbed the outer brace with the cracked transit lens hanging from his belt.

An arrow struck the frame beside his head. He reached the upper brace and

drove his tuning hammer into its join.

Three points.

The owner line remained.

Colonel Avren seized the command lever and forced it toward east return. Stored force gathered into an image across the panels: thousands of stretched shadows, each repeating a last intention to run, protect, strike, or hold. They possessed no minds. Together they formed an army without judgment waiting for direction.

Pikk dropped from the brace onto the command box. Avren drew his sword.

The engineer caught the blade between two blackglass scraps. Force traveled through them and turned the colonel's wrist aside. Pikk kicked open the lens backing, found the four scratches hidden around its wooden rim, and put his hammer against the white filament where the last mark ended.

Avren stabbed him through the coat. The point scraped Pikk's ribs without entering deeply. Pikk hit the owner line.

Four.

White filament broke.

Every panel cracked at once without shattering. Stored shadow force lost imperial direction. It searched through maker marks, repair names, donor relations, and the workers still holding the frame. Pikk shouted a sequence to his crews. They released all north-side clamps and held the south.

The mirror turned west.

Reflected force struck the tollhouse barricade. White shields flew upward. The upper crossbow gallery folded into its own courtyard. The west barrier chain snapped just as Nevi's defectors cut the final link.

An open road appeared beyond the ruin.

"Civilians through!" Kessa blew the long advance.

The bridge did not become safe. It became possible.

Care blocks moved west under defector shields. The first six water carts cleared the tollhouse. Eight reserve carts entered from the east as the rear group gave ground. Beneath the causeway, five more teams struggled along the anchor track, wheels inches from the gorge edge.

A damaged blackglass panel released a second pulse into the deck. Mirror stones bucked like scales. Thirty people went over the south parapet before walkers could stretch rope across the gap. A care cart overturned. Four dreamless slid against its canopy, held by the paired hitches practiced at White Orchard.

Kessa reached them with Mera. They cut the canvas, transferred each sleeper to hand litters, and left the broken cart where it lay. A waking child clung under the axle. Kessa pulled him out by his belt.

"Where is my father?" he asked.

"Name?"

"Sorn Keshen."

She wrote it on her wrist. "West with Mera. We count at the salt markers."

The eastern battle contracted toward the bridge mouth. Zarha's witnesses retreated in alternating lines, dragging wounded behind cloth screens. Imperial riders dismounted when mirror lances became useless among their own people. Close fighting began around the overturned freight carts.

Zarha held the left lane with a pruning hook. A Khar road-charter soldier came at her under a sun disk, his cheek ridges painted in settled-clan blue. Neither ancestry nor office simplified the fight. He called her a raider who would bring free-court revenge onto orchard families.

Kessa could not hear Zarha's answer. She saw the reeve catch his spear on the hook and turn it. A second soldier drove from the side. The spear point entered Zarha's right thigh below the scale vest.

Zarha fell.

Derrin and two depot drivers reached her before the soldiers did. They pulled her behind a wagon while witnesses closed the gap. Zarha tied a strip of longcloth above the wound, stood with help, and ordered the wounded east of her to pass first.

Kessa wanted to run back. Instead, she sent a medical team and kept the west exit moving. Leaving command to perform one rescue would turn hundreds of other bodies into the price of her conscience.

Pikk climbed down from the fractured mirror with blood on his coat. Senn met him at the stair.

"You kept the key," she said.

"You delivered the table?"

"Ilyen has it."

"Then my bad decisions have begun speaking to one another."

Kessa pointed him toward the tollhouse. "Can the frame fire again?"

"Not under one owner."

"Can it kill us without one?"

"Yes."

"Make that answer shorter."

Pikk ordered his crews to cut the cracked panels loose. They lowered each face onto wet mud or wrapped it in layered cloth. The lower-right panel resisted, vibrating toward the donors still on the bridge. Pikk wedged his cracked transit lens into its split and turned. The lens body broke, but the hidden strike marks aligned

the crack. The panel discharged harmlessly into a snapped barricade.

The fracture key no longer had one secret container. Every crew member who had heard Pikk's sequence carried part of it.

At the west winch, Captain Nevi held thirty-eight surviving defectors. Nine had died in the first volley. More lay wounded across the deck. Loyalist troops rallied beyond the collapsed tollhouse, threatening to close the opening before the final refugee blocks crossed.

"We can hold one hour," Nevi told Kessa.

"You have perhaps twenty minutes."

"My estimate offers morale."

"Mine offers a withdrawal time. At eighteen minutes, fall back by squads. At twenty-two, I cut the guide ropes whether you are on them or not."

Nevi smiled without humor. "I see why your depot misses you."

Western scouts found the first Red Salt shelf half a mile beyond the causeway. Kessa sent cleared households there in ordered blocks, forbidding them to stop within arrow range. Water carts established three stations instead of one crowded camp. Ilyen carried the table with the second station. Mera took the dreamless to the farthest hollow.

The last eastern households reached the bridge as fire caught the orchard grass. Imperial riders had gone around the overturned carts and begun shooting into the moving rear. Zarha crossed on a litter she repeatedly tried to leave. Her thigh bandage had soaked dark.

"You stand again after the spear is out," Kessa told her.

"People still fight behind us."

"People fight better when their reeve does not bleed on their hands."

The final 120 witnesses withdrew under arrow fire. Thirty-four fell before reaching midspan. Some rose wounded. Others did not. Kessa counted bodies only when two observers confirmed no movement; anyone reachable came onto a litter regardless of apparent survival.

Pikk's workers had set charges in the mirror frame, ordinary powder placed at structural pins rather than magical destruction. They waited until the last water cart from the anchor track climbed onto the west road. Then Pikk lit three fuses.

The mobile frame collapsed across the northern half of the causeway. It blocked cavalry but left a foot lane. Loyalist soldiers climbed over it. Nevi's defectors held them among broken panels where white shields reflected their own blows unpredictably.

At eighteen minutes, she withdrew the first squad.

At nineteen, a loyalist bolt killed her standard bearer.

At twenty, the remaining defectors carried the wounded through the foot lane.

Kessa did not cut the ropes at twenty-two. Zarha, half conscious on her litter, caught Kessa's wrist before the knife moved.

"You gave a time," Zarha said.

"I gave a threat."

"Then witness your revision."

Kessa waited another forty breaths. Captain Nevi crossed last with three soldiers supporting her. Behind them, Rill crews dropped the final panel into the foot lane. Imperial pursuit stopped against cracked blackglass and its own uncertain reflections.

The battle ended by distance rather than silence.

On the Red Salt shelf, wounded people cried under cloth while the fixed sun heated the rock. Kessa established four counts: Seven Camp civilians, attached non-camp civilians, coalition and defecting fighters, imperial prisoners. Dead remained separate from wounded and missing. Nobody could become a lower number merely because a clerk wanted a clean total.

The first report listed 126 refugee dead. Kessa challenged nine entries. Four people had been counted twice, once at the bridge and again after removal. Three labeled dead still breathed in the surgical row. Two missing had reached the anchor-track water teams.

The corrected number stood at 117 refugees dead.

Among coalition and defecting soldiers, 38 had died. Seventeen belonged to Nevi's road-company defectors, nine in the first volley and eight during the hold. Twelve came from the armed depot and ferry volunteers who had joined before the crossing. Nine were Rill mirror workers killed while breaking owner control. Another sixty-three fighters could not continue due to wounds. Imperial loyalist losses remained an estimate: at least fifty-four dead around the tollhouse, with seventy-one wounded or captured. Kessa kept that estimate out of the coalition total.

Seven Camp had entered the battle with 3,840 survivors. Subtracting 117 left 3,723. All 241 dreamless remained alive, protected by paired hitches, shield lanes, and care teams who had refused to run. Their survival did not make the battle merciful. It showed where thousands of deliberate choices had placed protection.

Two hundred six Seven Camp refugees carried wounds requiring treatment. Fifty-eight could not walk. Thirty-one remained missing at first count; scouts found twenty-seven before the next water issue, and the remaining four were included among the 117 only after witnesses identified bodies at the bridge edge.

Of the nineteen water carts, sixteen reached the salt shelf intact. One had lost its cask to crossbow punctures but retained a usable frame. One care-converted cart broke on the deck. The final cart remained below the causeway with a cracked wheel and half its water; Pikk's crew recovered its casks by rope. The coalition lost

740 gallons to the slurry defense, leaks, and broken vessels. Kessa recorded every gallon because the Red Salt would collect its own casualties if she romanticized the escape.

Zarha's spear wound missed the great artery but cut deep into her right thigh. Serit was not there; a Seven Camp surgeon named Osa removed the head, washed the wound with boiled water, and ordered no weight for three days. Zarha argued until Mera threatened to appoint a temporary reeve by witness vote.

Pikk's rib cut needed six stitches. Senn's delayed shadow had torn farther up her calf but still answered to movement. Ilyen suffered a bolt graze along his left shoulder and spent no memory. Kessa had blood on her clothes from at least seven people and no wound beyond a split lip.

After treatment, Captain Nevi brought a leather dispatch case taken from the tollhouse command room. Inside lay orders naming Project One Night, twelve reservoir requirements, the concealed eleven-minute alignment, and instructions to transfer any captured true table directly to the Sun Basilica. The proof connected Ilyen's calculations to imperial command rather than one astronomer's accusation.

Kessa read the pages beside Zarha's litter and Pikk's repair cloth. "This goes to more than one court."

"All evidence does," Zarha said through fever.

Pikk held up the broken transit lens rim. "My fracture key no longer belongs to this. Sixty workers heard the sequence."

"Can they teach it?" Ilyen asked.

"If owners do not reach them first."

The Rill crews voted under a freight awning. Forty-eight chose to travel west with Pikk. Seventeen stayed with wounded relatives from Low Deren and planned to scatter along river villages. The rest surrendered to Captain Nevi's custody as neutral contractors until they decided; Kessa objected to the word custody, so Nevi changed it to escorted camp.

No group behaved as a single people. Khar road soldiers had fought Zarha. Human troops had defected and remained loyal. Rill workers split three ways. Selai Ilyen carried imperial expertise while other Selai names appeared on observatory orders.

At the bridge, the dead could not yet be recovered safely. Kessa sent two captured officers back under white cloth with the complete casualty list and a demand that bodies receive marker stones rather than census collection. She trusted neither compliance nor refusal. She sent Pikk's stress diagram as proof that disturbing the broken panels would discharge force into the tollhouse.

The coalition rested four hours, no more. Red Salt glare rose from the western flats in pink sheets. Beyond the first shelf, no imperial cisterns waited. Water

discipline began immediately: measured cups, animal priority rotations, wound allotments, and no private reserve larger than one skin without witness.

Kessa walked the three stations before departure. At each, families had written the 117 refugee names on strips of White Orchard bark. The 38 dead fighters received separate strips with affiliations, because merging them into one heroic category would erase how they reached the same side.

Near the dreamless hollow, Ren Tal lay unchanged. His mother had tied a new knot around his wrist containing one strand from the bridge guide rope. "He crossed," she said.

"Yes."

"Will that matter when he wakes?"

"It will matter to what we tell him."

Pikk joined Kessa at the western marker carrying tools salvaged from the mirror. He offered no pledge. "The causeway frame cannot be rebuilt quickly. The Empire has my drawings."

"Do your drawings include refusal?"

"They do now, if Senn's workers reach another furnace."

Kessa assigned him to the third water station, where broken cask hoops needed more immediate engineering than war machines. He accepted the work without joke or protest.

At forty-seven days before totality, the coalition moved into the Red Salt. Behind them, Glass Causeway remained blocked by the mirror that had been built to hold it. Ahead traveled 3,723 Seven Camp survivors, 241 still dreamless, sixteen intact water carts, recovered casks, the true eclipse table, and imperial proof of Project One Night. Kessa took the final count, drew one line through 117 names, and left enough space beside every survivor for the road to change them.

Part II

Chapter 8 — West into the Red Salt

Zarha held the tally board against her raised knee while the last water cart came off the broken causeway.

Its left wheel had lost three spokes. Two Khar adolescents walked beside it with their shoulders under the axle, and a human defector pulled from the front beside a mule whose flanks trembled. On the bed lay seven dreamless sleepers, each tied beneath shade-cloth so the ruts would not pitch them onto the salt. A dead woman's sandals hung from the rear rail. Nobody had found room to bury her before the mirrored road began throwing sunlight back at them.

Kessa reached the final line on her own board. "Three thousand seven hundred twenty-three from Seven Camp. Two hundred forty-one still dreamless. Six of those had woken briefly during the retreat and then slipped back into fever; the one hundred seventeen dead were not part of either count."

"Soldiers?"

"Thirty-eight dead. Twenty-six wounded who can ride if we make room. Eleven who need litters."

Pikk Rill sat beneath the cart with a wrench between his glass-scarred palms. He had used his fracture key on the imperial mirror less than an hour ago, yet he watched the damaged wheel as if timber posed the greater danger. "It will carry half a load. A third if you intend to cross dunes rather than an engineer's drawing of dunes."

Beyond him, the Red Salt began without mercy. Iron-colored grains covered the western flats and rose into long ridges that resembled frozen waves. Permanent noon struck every facet. Far behind, white smoke climbed from the Glass Causeway, where the shattered siege mirror still burned through its own bindings.

Zarha's right thigh pulsed beneath a bandage stiff with blood. The spear cut had missed the artery, according to Kessa's surgeon. It had not missed the muscle that lifted her foot.

"We redistribute," Zarha said. "No sleeper comes off a cart. Strip armor from anyone not guarding the rear. Break the dead cart for spokes and shade poles."

A Seven Camp herder named Oru touched two fingers to the witness knot at his collar. "Night-reeve, the west road has no wells for three days."

"The west road has no imperial mirrors for three days either."

"Water makes a stronger argument."

"It does. Bring that argument to the ration circle."

He went, dissatisfied but witnessed. That mattered. A command could save a

column and still deserve opposition from the people required to survive it.

Ilyen Vaor came down from a low salt rise, copper ear-fans wrapped against the glare. Dead star-moths clung to the mineral ink at his neck like scraps of ash. "Reflections on the eastern ridge," he said. "Four, perhaps six. They vanish whenever I put glass on them."

"Mounted scouts?" Kessa asked.

"Shadows." He looked toward the carts carrying the dreamless. "Or men using shadows to avoid giving us a body to track."

Pikk slid out from beneath the axle. "A shadow scout repeats its donor's last hard intention. Send it to find a column, and it will keep finding even after the column changes direction. It cannot decide what to report."

"Then someone follows to read what it finds," Zarha said.

The fracture key hung inside Pikk's coat. He touched the cloth over it, a craftsman checking that his treason remained where he had put it. "Someone with a mirror slate. Maybe ten leagues behind."

Zarha looked across the glare. Akar Seven lay west by north, beyond the flats and the red dunes. Its open tents hosted five Khar courts, though outsiders often spoke of the place as if one people entered, spoke, and agreed. Her father had once brought road-charter cases there. He had won safe passage for his caravan by naming three dissidents to imperial census men. The court had judged that the travelers under his cloth possessed claims equal to strangers beyond it. He had called the judgment naive until the year he died.

"March in six files," she ordered. "Cloth crews rotate every quarter bell. Rear guard carries blackglass chips, not blades, if a scout comes close. We do not waste water chasing an intention."

They entered the Red Salt with forty-seven days remaining before the eclipse.

By the second quarter bell, the glare had erased every color except rust, white, and the black mouths of water jars. Shade-cloths moved over the column on linked poles. Those beneath them walked in groups of twelve, changing shoulders at Kessa's whistle. The arrangement had come from Seven Camp hospitality practice, where no guest crossed an open court without passing under someone's roof. Here, a roof lasted twelve minutes before its bearers began stumbling.

Zarha walked the eastern edge. Her wounded leg shortened each stride. She resisted the urge to hide it, because hiding pain from people who measured pace against her body amounted to a lie. She also resisted limping theatrically, which would make injury another demand for loyalty.

A child under the nearest cloth began asking for evening. His grandmother gave him a pebble to hold under his tongue. It would not ease thirst, but it stopped him speaking. Farther along, Kessa's stolen water carts creaked between files. Nineteen had left the White Road. Sixteen remained usable after the causeway,

and three now served as parts.

At the midday halt, which the sun refused to mark, Kessa measured half-cups into wooden bowls. "The walking ration stays. Guards get no extra unless they fight. Officers get no extra at all."

Mera Seln, the old Night-Bearer, knelt beside a dreamless girl and wetted the girl's gums with a strip of linen. "They lose more through fever."

"I have allowed for it."

"You have allowed a cup for a body that cannot ask."

"I have allowed one and a quarter."

Mera studied her. "Then I withdraw the complaint and keep the suspicion."

Kessa corked the jar. "Suspicion weighs nothing. Carry as much as you like."

Nearby, Ilyen had planted three pins in the salt and stretched thread between their shadows, each scarcely wider than hair. Zarha crouched beside him.

"What can you read from a sun that will not move?"

"It moves. We are the ones made stupid by exhaustion." He adjusted one pin. "The true eclipse table still gives us direction if my instruments remain honest. Akar Seven lies nine degrees north of our present line."

"And the scouts?"

His mouth tightened. "One has crossed our southern track twice."

Zarha rose before her thigh could lock. "Pikk."

The Rill engineer joined them with a pouch of broken blackglass. Together they walked south of the resting column, stepping where hard crust covered old brine. No footprints marked the scout's passage. Shadows did not press salt, but they altered heat. Pikk scattered glass chips across a shallow crescent. Three smoked. One split with a sound too high for Zarha's ears.

"Here," he said.

She saw it only when it moved: a human-shaped thinning laid across the ground against the angle of the sun. It crawled toward the shade-cloths with one arm extended. No face turned toward them. No breath lifted its ribs.

Pikk dropped a palm-sized shard before it. The shape struck its own reflection and folded around the glass, still reaching west. Zarha drove her spear through the shard rather than the scout. Blackglass cracked. The shape shuddered and ran backward over the salt, compelled to repeat the force that had broken it.

"Will that hurt the donor?" she asked.

"Headache. Lost dream, perhaps. Less than destroying it."

A knot lay where the scout had crossed. Red cord, three turns around bleached camel tendon, closed with a square bronze bead.

Zarha picked it up with the spear point.

She knew the hand that standardized that knot. Besh Kor required every road-charter patrol to mark water, shelter, and disputed passage with the same three-turn claim. He called consistency a kindness to people who could not read imperial script.

Mera had followed them at a slower pace. Her cheek ridges cast narrow shadows beneath her eyes. "His patrol?"

"His charter." Zarha raised the knot for the others. "Besh may command it, or someone wants us to believe he does."

Pikk wiped salt from his shard. "What does a road-charter commander want with refugees?"

"To return stolen imperial property," Zarha said. "You. The eclipse table. The census names they failed to carry away from Seven Camp."

"And you?"

"An example offered under seal."

Mera took the knot. "Besh protected three orchard clans from free-court raiders last year."

"He also delivered their shade rolls to the Empire."

"They agreed after the raiders burned two nurseries."

Pikk looked between them. "You argue as if agreement reached under fire has a clean shape."

"No," Zarha said. "We argue because it does not."

The brine cache appeared near what should have been evening, a line of clay lids set into a shaded cut beneath red shelves. Every lid bore Besh Kor's knot.

Kessa counted the jars without touching them. "Enough to restore two days of full ration."

"Or enough to bind our names when we drink," Mera said.

Imperial white-mirror craft required census names, not mere thirst. Yet road-charter law treated water acceptance as temporary submission to the keeper of a route. Besh understood that Zarha could not bring Seven Camp into Akar Seven under a rival commander's shelter without carrying his claim into every debate.

A bronze plate rested on the central jar.

NIGHT-REEVE KESH: ACCEPT THE RED ROAD. THE DREAMLESS WILL BE CARRIED. THE DEFECTOR WILL STAND IMPERIAL HEARING. YOUR PEOPLE WILL KEEP THEIR TENTS.

No threat named the cost of refusal. The ridges east of them supplied that omission.

Kessa read the plate twice. "Can we use the water and deny the law?"

"In your law, perhaps." Zarha lowered herself onto a rock, keeping her injured leg straight. "At Akar Seven, witnesses would divide. Two courts would say thirst voids consent. One would say drinking creates guest duty but not military obedience. Besh needs only enough doubt to prevent a unified pledge."

"Then we leave it."

"There are children with cracked lips."

Kessa's face hardened, not against Zarha but against a decision that offered no innocent column. "I can cut rations again. We lose pace. The wounded worsen."

Ilyen studied the ridgeline. "A salt storm will reach us before the next full halt."

Zarha saw only a darkening smear against the permanent brightness.

"Storms fill the low road," Mera said. "The high shelves stay passable."

"The high shelves add half a day," Kessa replied.

Zarha looked at the dreamless under their cloth. Besh's offer to carry them exposed the piece of imperial arithmetic he had learned: a body could receive care and still become evidence for the authority providing it. She would not answer that arithmetic by sacrificing the bodies.

"Open six jars," she said. "Pay for them."

"With what?"

"Witness."

She cut Besh's knots from the lids and tied new cords through each handle: Seven Camp blue, Kessa's baggage red, Pikk's black wire, and a strand of Ilyen's moth silk. Mera added undyed host fiber. Zarha dictated while Oru scratched words onto the back of the bronze plate.

WATER TAKEN UNDER MORTAL NEED. DEBT OWED TO THE PEOPLE WHO FILLED THE JARS, NOT TO ANY COMMANDER WHO CLAIMED THEIR THIRST.

They left two fracture-key splinters as payment, useful enough that nobody could call the act theft, incomplete enough that Besh could not turn them against the column.

Before climbing, Zarha ordered a sleep halt beneath the cut. Permanent noon made the word sleep feel dishonest, yet bodies failed without it. The cloth crews doubled three roofs, wetted the outer layers with brine, and packed red salt along the lower edges. Inside, adults lay shoulder to shoulder while assigned watchers held strips of blackglass over their eyes. The dreamless occupied the coolest seam against the rock.

Argument started before the first sleepers settled. Four defectors wanted a separate cloth because Seven Camp families had begun calling them mirror riders. Two Khar herders refused to share a roof with anyone who had served on the causeway. Kessa proposed assigning shelter by cart team, which ignored the quarrel and therefore preserved it.

Zarha sat where both groups could see the blood on her bandage. "Nobody owes forgiveness for one battle's defection," she said. "Nobody may deny mortal shelter to a person currently keeping watch over their children. Those claims can occupy the same tent."

A herder spat into the salt. "Easy from the reeve's place."

"My place has an open side. Sit there and witness whether I favor them."

He did. So did a defector named Lann, whose left hand had lost two fingers to Pikk's broken mirror. For the next quarter bell they recorded who had carried whom off the causeway. The account contained no clean division. One imperial spearman had killed a cloth bearer, then dragged two children clear when the reflected force turned. A Seven Camp youth had stabbed a surrendering rider after seeing his mother fall. Zarha assigned neither innocence nor equal blame. She set hearings for Akar Seven, where time and witnesses might survive the desert.

Sleep came badly. People jerked awake claiming they had heard tents being folded outside, though no wind yet moved. Several could recall the faces of the dead but not the shade under which they had last spoken. Ilyen wrote each failure beside the true eclipse table until Zarha made him lie down.

At the end of the halt, Kessa reported twelve more cases of fever and no newly waking dreamless. The column had consumed less water than a march would have cost, but rest had not restored what stolen Night once gave freely. Zarha ordered the roofs struck before anyone mistook enclosure for safety.

The first wind struck as they climbed toward the high shelves.

Red grains moved across the ground in sheets. Within minutes the eastern ridge disappeared. Shade-cloth snapped above the walkers, poles bending until three broke. Kessa's whistles passed orders down the files: shorten ropes, cover mouths, link carts. Zarha took the rear because her office required her to know who fell outside shelter, not because her leg could bear it.

A mirror flare opened in the storm behind them.

For one heartbeat she saw riders on the lower road. Khar silhouettes leaned low over salt camels, bronze road beads flashing at their throats. Shadows ran ahead of them without mounts. Then dust closed over all of it.

"Besh Kor!" someone shouted.

The name traveled faster than instruction. Walkers surged uphill. A water cart tipped when its right wheels entered soft salt. Two dreamless slid against their straps. A cloth team abandoned a pole to help, exposing thirty people to the storm.

Zarha seized the nearest guide rope. "Stop climbing. Kneel on the lee side of the carts."

"They are behind us," Oru said.

"The storm reaches them too."

A shadow scout came through the dust with both hands raised as if lifting a

gate. It struck a shade pole and kept pushing. The cloth rose, carrying three children off their knees.

Zarha hooked the scout with her spear shaft. Pain tore through her thigh when she planted her foot. She turned the shape toward the tipped cart, using its unthinking force against the axle. Pikk jammed blackglass under one edge. Together, scout and survivors lifted long enough for the trapped wheel to come free.

"Now break the shard," Pikk called.

A teenager stamped it. The scout snapped backward and vanished into red air.

The storm erased command beyond the length of one rope. Zarha moved knot by knot, making each group count twelve before passing her onward. At the fourth cart she found Kessa bleeding from the scalp, still tying sleepers to a replacement rail. At the seventh, Mera had opened her coat over two infants while their father fought a broken buckle. At the ninth, Ilyen lay flat with his true eclipse table sealed beneath his chest.

"Leave the pins," Zarha told him.

"I can recover the line."

"You can recover your life."

He gathered the table and crawled toward the rope.

A tremendous crack rolled from the south. The storm had reached the brine cut. White light spread through the dust, diffuse and sickly, as imperial mirrors tried to hold an image inside moving salt. Pikk laughed once without humor.

"They cannot read us," he said. "Every grain gives them a different road."

Neither could the coalition.

When the wind eased, the Red Salt had remade itself. Dunes covered the lower route. Their own trail ended three paces behind the last cart. No riders appeared, no shadow scouts crawled across the ground, and no marker pointed toward Akar Seven.

The column stood in three pieces.

Kessa began the count before anyone drank. Calls moved from rope leaders to cart captains and back. Zarha waited with Besh Kor's bronze plate tucked inside her coat. Her wound had bled through its wrapping.

"One hundred forty-six missing from the north files," Kessa said at last. "Walkers, not dead. Twelve cloth teams and two guide crews. They had water for a day."

"Who led them?"

"Oru and one of Mera's Bearers."

Mera closed her eyes briefly. "Oru knows the high-shelf signs."

The salt showed none now.

Zarha assigned forty searchers in five groups, each carrying blackglass, two jars, and a cord long enough to retreat by touch. She put Mera in charge of the main body and ordered Kessa to move the carts north at half pace. Every choice divided shelter from search, the living before her from the living beyond sight.

As the first search cord paid out through the red haze, Zarha tied its end around her own waist. The imperial trail had vanished. So had 146 people under her witness, and Akar Seven would not hear her claim until she brought as many of them as the salt allowed home.

Chapter 9 — The Orc Courts of the Open Tent

Oru found Zarha's search cord by stepping on it.

He emerged from the red haze with salt packed in his cheek ridges and a girl asleep across his shoulders. Behind him came the missing walkers in linked groups, all 146 of them, led by a Night-Bearer who had navigated from the taste of mineral fungi under the shelves. Three suffered broken bones. Nine needed carrying. None had died.

Zarha did not call their return a blessing. Blessings concealed labor. Searchers had spent sixteen hours walking circles at the end of ropes; separated families had shared water by rinsing one cloth and passing it from mouth to mouth. She recorded every name before allowing herself to sit.

Two days later, Akar Seven rose from the Red Salt as a country made of roofs without walls.

Five vast tents occupied a ring around a hard clay basin. None had a closed side. Wind crossed carpets, hearing platforms, cook pits, and sleeping tiers without asking permission. Narrower host cloths filled the ground between them, each marked by knots whose colors named duty rather than blood. Goats cropped pale thorn scrub beyond the basin. Orchard wagons stood beside camel trains. Under one awning, scribes pressed route judgments into clay. Under another, contemplatives cultivated dark fungus in covered jars.

Children watched Seven Camp's battered column approach and counted its carts aloud.

Mera Seln came beside Zarha. "Do you remember your first hearing here?"

"I was fourteen. I lied about breaking a cistern lid."

"You confessed before anyone accused you."

"I expected generosity."

"You received repair duty."

"For a month." Zarha adjusted the binding on her thigh. "I remember the court's generosity exactly."

The five hearing tents carried no royal names. Their titles described obligations.

The Tent of Returning Tracks heard disputes involving migrants and those left behind. The Ash Orchard judged settled land, graves, and inherited water. The Uncovered Bowl guarded hospitality law. The Brass Mile governed road charters and trade escorts. The Quiet Hide held Night-Bearers, mourners, and people who believed some decisions required more listening than victory.

Each contained Khar with varied tusklets, cheek ridges, dress, and practice. Humans traded beneath the Brass Mile. Two Selai salt merchants had sleeping niches at Returning Tracks. Rill furnace crews maintained the basin pumps.

Imperial loyalists and free-court raiders sometimes ate from the same public pot while their cases waited.

No horn welcomed Zarha. A basin keeper handed her a cup and pointed toward a plank where petitioners left weapons.

She surrendered her spear.

Admission required more than disarmament. Akar Seven's basin keepers counted needs before affiliations. Every arrival received five clay markers: water, meal, sleeping cloth, animal space, and hearing access. Those who needed less snapped unused markers in half so the fragments could be paired for another person. Nobody could sell a whole marker without presenting the person whose need had created it.

The system slowed beneath Seven Camp's numbers. Kessa occupied a low table with six local clerks and began separating mobile wounded from the 241 dreamless. One clerk tried to stack the sleepers' meal markers aside.

"They cannot eat," he said.

"They require broth, wet cloth, waste cleaning, and attendants who eat while providing all three," Kessa replied. "Assign each group of eight a cooking marker."

"A guest marker belongs to its bearer."

Kessa pointed toward a cart where Ren Tal lay with his eyes open and unseeing beneath a double cloth. "Then ask him to bear it."

The clerk flushed dark along his cheek ridges. Before argument hardened, an Uncovered Bowl keeper split forty markers and placed the halves in the attendants' tray. "The guest's need may travel through another hand. Record the hand."

That small judgment drew more watching than Zarha's arrival. It made the dreamless visible as work, appetite, heat, and obligation rather than a sacred burden people could praise while somebody else cleaned them.

Across the intake ground, Returning Tracks hosts reunited families from the storm-separated group. Oru's sister slapped him, embraced him, then demanded his water record. Ash Orchard merchants inspected the coalition's remaining seed sacks and found three contaminated by mirror dust from the causeway. They burned the affected grain in a covered pit to keep white fragments from entering local Night beds. Brass Mile traders offered replacement millet at twice cost until their own junior factors shouted them down.

Mera guided Quiet Hide contemplatives among the carts. They did not pray over the dreamless. They checked fungal pads under each sleeper's neck, changed the ones gone sour, and listened for the irregular swallowing that preceded glare fever. Their leader refused Zarha's thanks.

"Hospitality performed for a reeve becomes tribute," she said. "Give thanks to the hands when they finish."

Near the animal pens, Pikk found two Rill pump workers arguing over his face. One had seen an imperial broadside naming him saboteur and murderer. The other wanted to hide him before Brass Mile could invoke a contractor warrant. Pikk solved neither argument. He handed them the damaged cart hub and asked whether Akar's forge could true it.

"Work does not settle guilt," the older pump keeper said.

"No," Pikk answered. "It does tell you whether I lie about wheels."

By the time the hearing bell sounded, Seven Camp occupied not one camp but dozens of borrowed obligations distributed through Akar Seven. Zarha could no longer point to a boundary and claim everyone inside it answered to her. The altered witness cord still lay at her throat, but the open tents had already begun the review before any judge spoke.

The first hearing began while Seven Camp still pitched cloth.

Zarha stood in the central basin with Kessa, Ilyen, Pikk, and Mera behind her. Five witness benches faced inward. Each court sent three judges, though Quiet Hide placed two empty cushions beside its living representative for the dead and the absent. Hundreds crowded the open edges.

A clerk read Zarha's petition. It asked for fighters to recover Seven Camp's stolen Night, hosts able to receive damaged darkness, water passage for 3,723 survivors, and recognition that 241 dreamless remained alive under protection.

Judge Haro of Ash Orchard rubbed dust into the grooves of her cheek ridges. "Seven Camp submitted census names under an imperial trade compact eleven years ago."

"We submitted caravan names," Zarha said. "The collectors copied household shade rolls without consent."

"Your reeves accepted white-road protection."

"My predecessor accepted road repair. My father defended the bargain."

A murmur moved around the basin. Zarha let it. Concealing her father's collaboration would give Besh Kor the pleasure of revealing it.

The Brass Mile judge wore a bronze bead at every joint of his collar knot. "Permanent noon has increased safe freight by a third."

"And reduced viable seed in Seven Camp by half."

"Traders can buy seed."

"Not sleep."

From Quiet Hide, Mera's counterpart lifted a covered fungus jar. Its interior held a darkness no larger than a thumbprint. "One village's injury does not establish duty for all Nights."

"It establishes danger to all census names." Ilyen unrolled a copy of the eclipse table. "The Empire has collected eleven regional darknesses beneath the Sun

Basilica. Seven Camp's theft proves their method can move from treaty to seizure within one generation."

A Returning Tracks judge leaned forward. "You served the observatory that built this table."

"I did."

"Then why should your measure become our fear?"

"Because you should test it." Ilyen placed his instruments beside the parchment. "Do not trust my repentance. Recalculate my work."

That answer purchased attention, not belief.

For four hours the courts divided the petition into smaller questions. Returning Tracks accepted refugee passage but opposed a military pledge until separated families testified. Ash Orchard offered grain from settled compounds but refused to risk local Nights as hosts. Uncovered Bowl recognized the dreamless as guests because breath, warmth, and carried names established life. Brass Mile called them legally suspended and warned that feeding them could violate imperial relief statutes. Quiet Hide disputed whether any stolen Night ought to be forced home if captivity had changed it.

Zarha welcomed that last objection. "We will not command its return."

"Then what do you mean by recover?"

"Open the cage. Offer hosts. Accept refusal."

The words cost her support among Seven Camp elders who had come expecting restoration as a right. Oru stared at her from the public edge, his mouth set.

Before he could demand clarification, camel bells sounded on the eastern road.

Besh Kor entered Akar Seven beneath imperial safe-conduct cloth.

He came with thirty mounted Khar soldiers, no humans, and one white-mirror wagon shrouded in red canvas. His armor followed free-court patterns except for the solar disk riveted over his heart. Two shallow cheek ridges ran from his eyes to his jaw. His tusklets had been cut square, a settled orchard custom that made reins and pruning masks easier to wear.

The crowd opened for him without welcoming him.

Besh laid his sword on the petitioner's plank and stepped into the basin. "I challenge the standing of Zarha Kesh as night-reeve."

Zarha felt the old pull to meet accusation with rank. Instead she asked, "Under which court's duty?"

"All five."

"Convenient."

"Necessary. She abandoned lawful road shelter, destroyed an imperial causeway, took water from a marked cache, exposed 3,723 people to a salt storm, and now asks strangers to enlarge her failure."

Kessa whispered, "He practiced that number."

"He had scouts," Zarha said.

Besh faced the benches. "My charter offered carriage for every dreamless person. She refused because accepting would weaken her office."

"Your plate demanded Pikk Rill."

"The engineer killed thirty-eight soldiers through sabotage."

"Imperial reflected force killed them after your allies trapped civilians on glass."

Pikk shifted behind her. Zarha did not turn. The causeway dead would not become pieces moved for his innocence or guilt.

Judge Haro raised one hand. "Commander Kor, does your charter authorize removal of local Night?"

"It authorizes road security."

"That did not answer."

"No road-charter unit under my command took Seven Camp's Night."

"Did your command carry shade rolls to those who did?" Zarha asked.

Besh's eyes reflected the basin as two pale arcs. "We carry censuses. The Empire uses them for grain, rescue, bandit restitution, and disease control."

"And white-mirror binding."

"I did not know that use when the first rolls went east."

"Do you know it now?"

Silence reached even the cook pits.

Besh looked toward the shrouded wagon. "I know free courts attacked Hara Orchard six times in two years. Forty-three children died in a nursery fire because raiders claimed settled Khar had surrendered authentic life. Imperial patrols stopped the seventh attack. The charter keeps six thousand orchard workers under roofs they own."

Nobody could dismiss the dead he named. Zarha had visited Hara after the fire. She had seen melted irrigation pipes beside small grave cloths.

"You bought safety with other people's names," she said.

"I bought it with service. My own name appears first on every roll."

"That makes you liable. It does not make strangers consenting."

Besh turned to the courts. "Review her route. Review her casualties. She treats danger chosen under her voice as freedom, then calls safety chosen under mine conquest."

The accusation found its mark because part of it held.

Zarha had ordered the west route. She had broken the causeway defense rather than surrender. People had died beneath decisions carrying her office. The

difference between her and Besh could not rest on confidence that she possessed the better heart.

"I accept the challenge," she said.

Mera gripped her sleeve. "Choose the terms before he does."

"I submit the office of night-reeve to witness review by all who traveled under it from Seven Camp."

Besh frowned. "That office has no standing here unless its holder does."

"Then we can discover both." Zarha untied the blue witness cord from her collar and set it on the clay. "Until review ends, I issue no order except immediate shelter. Any Seven Camp resident, defector, ally, or person harmed by my choices may testify. The courts may limit, remove, or return my authority. If they remove it, our petition continues under whoever the witnesses appoint."

Uncovered Bowl's senior judge sat back. "You would make a refugee column elect during pursuit?"

"No. Election rewards whoever can campaign during thirst. I ask review of acts, with temporary appointment only if removal occurs."

"And if they return you unchanged?" Besh asked.

"Then they have failed to review."

The hearings lasted through one artificial sleep cycle.

Cloths covered the basin to create darkness enough for tired bodies, but lamps remained over the witness circle. Oru spoke first. He accused Zarha of treating the 146 separated walkers as an argument she needed to win at Akar Seven. Then he testified that she had tied the search cord to herself and sent the main carts onward rather than immobilizing everyone for his group.

Lann, the defector missing two fingers, described Zarha's shelter ruling. A Seven Camp herder answered that the ruling forced bereaved families beside former imperial soldiers. Mera said the ruling had preserved life while postponing justice, then faulted Zarha for deciding the form of postponement alone.

Kessa provided water tables. "The west route cost twenty-one percent more reserve than the marked road would have cost before the storm. Accepting Besh Kor's cache preserved forty fever patients. His legal claim came attached to water people required to live."

"Would his carriage have saved more?" Brass Mile asked.

"Probably, in the next two days. I cannot calculate what surrendering the table and the fracture key would cost over fifty-three."

"Forty-three now," Ilyen corrected quietly.

The deadline changed the room. Eleven captive Nights waited beneath the capital. Seven Camp's stolen darkness had not yet become the twelfth, but the coalition did not know which free region the Empire would take next.

Pikk confessed that the fracture key could break white bindings and that he had designed mirrors for the Empire before defecting. "Zarha did not absolve me. She also did not hand me back to owners who call a contract consent after buying the guild that signed it."

Besh cross-questioned every witness with disciplined care. He caught exaggerations. He made Oru admit that search teams would have found the separated walkers faster if they had taken the lower route. He made Kessa distinguish causeway dead from later wound cases. He never called the dreamless dead.

That restraint troubled Zarha more than cruelty would have. Besh had not become an imperial servant because he hated his own people. He served because he had chosen which Khar deserved protection and built a road over everyone outside the choice.

Near the end, Seli of the Uncovered Bowl asked Zarha, "What limitation do you propose on your returned office?"

Zarha had considered routes, food, military command, and court representation. One answer bound all four.

"Any order affecting people beyond Seven Camp requires a witness from those people with power to halt it for hearing. Any use of a hosted Night requires consent from its hosts, not my office. Casualty counts belong to the public basin each day. No alliance pledge makes me commander outside the march until signatories decide command."

A Seven Camp elder shouted, "You give strangers a hand on our throat."

"We have had an Empire's hand there for forty years. I will not replace it with mine."

The judges withdrew to five different corners. No curtain hid their disputes. Ash Orchard argued that military risk would expose settled compounds. Returning Tracks insisted that no free road survived if the Empire could steal a people's evening. Brass Mile divided between imperial trade and outrage over coerced water law. Quiet Hide demanded host autonomy. Uncovered Bowl refused every clause that could abandon the dreamless.

At dawn by the clocks, though the sky had not changed, three courts pledged.

Returning Tracks committed 4,100 fighters, scouts, cart hosts, and route keepers. Uncovered Bowl committed 2,700 fighters and noncombatant shelter crews, with a binding clause protecting every breathing guest. Quiet Hide committed 1,800 defenders and Night hosts, most of them contemplatives who would carry living darkness but not serve in offensive ranks.

The total reached 8,600 fighters and hosts. The word and mattered. Fewer than six thousand would take weapons. The rest offered transport, shade names, fungus beds, field care, and places where a wounded Night might choose to rest.

Ash Orchard refused troops but sold grain at cost and allowed individual volunteers. Brass Mile refused alliance, citing charter reprisals and trade collapse. Neither refusal spoke for all settled Khar or all road people.

The five courts returned Zarha's cord with three new knots: host consent, outside witness, public count. They also set another cord beside it for a coalition command not yet formed.

Besh retrieved his sword from the plank. "I challenge you still."

"Under what terms?" Zarha asked.

"Whether your open witness survives when my soldiers meet yours on a road too narrow for hearings."

"That is not a challenge. It is a threat."

"It can be both."

He departed under safe-conduct, taking his shrouded mirror wagon east. Some in the basin cursed him. Others touched road beads in respect for the orchards his patrols had saved.

Zarha tied the revised cord at her throat. Eight thousand six hundred had pledged under conditions she could not command away. Two courts had refused. Besh Kor remained protected by a law she honored and armed by an empire she meant to fight.

When she raised the petition for the march toward Leth Aven, three witnesses raised their hands with hers, and one kept a palm open to stop her.

Chapter 10 — The Elf City of Star-Moths

Ilyen caught the first dead moth before it struck the paving.

Its four wings bore the silver commas of the autumn lineage, though autumn had never come. Heat had curled two tips. When he laid the insect across his palm, dust from its scales settled into the mineral tracks inked beneath his skin. No living moth moved to feed there.

Above him, Leth Aven climbed a saltwood escarpment in terraces of pale roots and blue stone. Moth towers opened along the cliff like flutes, each chamber built to release a different seasonal colony into darkness. Permanent noon had turned those openings into ovens. Cloth covered half of them. White imperial mirrors shaded the rest by redirecting sunlight into workers' districts below.

Another moth fell. Then seven.

City sweepers pushed barrows beneath the towers and collected the bodies for pigment, feed, and burial. Their ear-fans showed bare patches where colonies had failed. Selai observatory officials crossed upper bridges beneath polished parasols, skin inks bright with moths bred in contracted darkrooms.

Oth Aven waited beside the entry cistern. The saltwood commune courier had cut his seasonal ink into broken lines, marking the years for which no honest sky record existed.

"You came wearing an imperial astronomer's coat," Oth said.

"It has pockets fitted for the instruments."

"It also has rank braid."

Ilyen took out a knife and cut the braid from both cuffs. "Now it has damaged cuffs."

"That resembles regret from a safe distance."

"Yes."

Oth glanced at the dead moth in his palm. "Your sister has called the observatory assembly. House Oren intends to let you speak."

"That sounds generous."

"They expect generosity to expose you."

Behind them, the coalition filed into the lower caravan ground. Akar's new hosts rigged cloth over Seven Camp's carts. Kessa negotiated cistern access by the jar. Zarha stood beneath three witness knots and refused the ceremonial command platform offered by Leth Aven's gate house. Pikk had already disappeared toward the mirror supports with local maintenance crews.

Ilyen placed the moth in the sweepers' nearest barrow and followed Oth downhill rather than up.

The saltwood communes had built their darkrooms beneath living root terraces. Brine ran through clay pipes in the walls, carrying heat away. In former years, families brought children there to receive first moths on newly inked skin. Now the rooms held emergency colonies in stacked reed drawers. Workers opened each drawer for less than a minute, fed the insects fungus paste, and closed them before imperial glare reached the eggs.

A woman named Teren showed Ilyen a row of empty trays. "Spring line. Gone. High-rain line, nine females left. River-turn survives because traders brought cocoons from the south."

"Any night-flight releases?"

"Under black cloth, twice. They flew in circles and tore their wings on the frame."

Star-moths navigated by relationships among points of darkness, not light alone. A covered room gave them absence without distance. Ilyen had helped advise the imperial ministry that artificial darkrooms could preserve essential colonies after regional evening restrictions. He had not visited the rooms where preservation became confinement.

Teren pushed a contract across the worktable. House Oren's seal overlapped a solar disk.

The public clauses funded mirrors, brine pumps, and observatory grain. A folded insert in finer script transferred all eclipse observations to imperial custody and prohibited release of colony-loss figures that might "disturb confidence in continuous illumination." Another clause required Leth Aven to provide eight thousand shade-names for emergency atmospheric study.

"House Oren says the names merely identify skin hosts," Oth said.

"They identify where darkness touches living tissue." Ilyen read the clause again. "White mirrors could bind from this."

"Could?" Teren asked.

"They can."

Her expression did not change. "Then carry that certainty upstairs."

The ascent passed through districts that occupied different versions of the same city. On the lowest terrace, saltwood cutters worked in wet scarves and stopped every few minutes to brush dead moths from saw teeth. Children ran messages between covered root cellars because mirror glare made the speaking tubes too hot to touch. Vendors sold chilled fungus wrapped in leaves, one portion per household mark.

Higher up, white shade spread from imperial mirror vanes. Observatory apprentices crossed gardens where brine fountains still ran. Their moth colonies had declined, but not died, because contract power kept sealed rooms cool. Notices on the walls praised House Oren for preserving Leth Aven's scientific

inheritance. Smaller print listed a new cooling levy on lower cisterns.

Ilyen paused at a bridge from which he could see both terraces. "We used to say height gave a clearer horizon."

Oth followed his gaze. "Height gives first access to pipes."

At the fourth tower, House Oren guards took the contract copy from Teren and admitted Ilyen alone. Sava waited inside a preparation room with their mother's instrument case open on the bench. The green leather had cracked at every hinge. Ilyen knew which compartments held lunar wires, moth scales, and the bone stylus their mother never permitted either child to touch. Recognition arrived without warmth. The memory he had burned had taken the room's emotional doorway while leaving its inventory intact.

Sava threaded a fresh wire through the transit frame. "You could have sent the table."

"Imperial couriers inspect observatory packets."

"The communes move messages."

"I did not know whom House Oren had bound to the contract."

"You assumed nobody here could decide without your arrival."

The accusation resembled the truth enough to resist easy denial. "I assumed I could not ask another person to carry evidence that might kill them."

"So you brought thousands of refugees to the gate."

"They chose the road before Leth Aven."

"Under facts you controlled." Sava tightened the wire until the frame gave a clear, low note. "Do you remember the winter our mother proved the western almanac wrong?"

"I remember the proof."

"That was not my question."

He searched among facts: cold tiles, three nights of cloud, Sava asleep under the calculation table, their mother laughing when the final plate aligned. The laugh had no interior sound. "I know we were there."

Sava's ear-fans folded closer to her head. "You did not spend that one, did you?"

"No. The loss spreads by association. I cannot choose its boundary after payment."

She set the instrument case between them. "Then every command spends other people at the edges."

"Yes."

"Yet you ask us to prepare more commands."

"I ask us to free what command has caged."

"That sentence hides the instrument."

He wanted to tell her about the White Orchard sliver, how it had offered relation without instruction, how Zarha had promised invitation rather than ownership. Even a true account could sound like a penitent astronomer promoting a result only he had measured. He chose the narrower claim.

"Inspect my figures. If they fail, expose me. If they hold, do not let hatred of my method protect the people who falsified them."

Sava closed the case. "I can do both."

The assembly chamber occupied the highest intact moth tower. Its roof irised shut over a circular floor marked with brass star tracks. Observatory houses sat by professional rank rather than kinship. Oren held the eastern arc. Three caravan houses occupied the west. Commune delegates stood because old rules provided no seats for people who grew food and moth fungus instead of tables.

Sava Vaor waited at the central instrument.

Ilyen had remembered her as she looked six months ago, which meant his mind had preserved facts while expecting kindness no evidence supported. She wore House Oren gray. Mineral ink mapped winter stars across her long ear-fans, and two living moths rested at the pulse behind her jaw. She did not approach him.

"Present your accusation," she said.

"My evidence."

"Your distinction can wait for verification."

He set the true eclipse table beneath the chamber lens. The copy still carried scorch marks from the memory-burn at the High Observatory. He aligned the public table beside it and placed his three measuring pins across both.

"Totality begins eleven minutes earlier than the published calculation," he said. "The public error enters at lunar velocity correction. It repeats across every imperial table distributed in the last two years."

An Oren mathematician adjusted the lens. "Eleven minutes falls within historic uncertainty."

"Not with current parallax observations."

"You signed the uncertainty standard."

"I did."

The chamber stirred.

Ilyen kept his hands on the table. "I also calculated transfer loads for twelve dark reservoirs beneath the Sun Basilica. I accepted the stated purpose: stabilizing refugee shelter during totality. The loads cannot serve temporary shelter. They align captive Nights for command."

Sava's moths lifted their wings. "How many reservoirs have you observed?"

"Eleven filled."

"Directly?"

"Through gravitational shade variance and thermal absence."

"So you infer purpose."

"I copied the internal heading. One Night alignment."

"Where is that copy?"

"I could carry only the table."

The weakness landed where she placed it. A confession without the original order required listeners to trust a man admitting he had lied for years.

Oth unrolled the contract insert from the communes. "Then consider what House Oren carried."

Sava did not look at it. "Stolen correspondence has no chain of custody."

"Workers maintain the archive that owners call theirs," Teren said from the standing ring. "We are the custody."

House voices rose. Sava struck the instrument rail once.

"No declaration until recalculation," she said. "Vaor, surrender your pins."

He did. Six astronomers took positions around the floor, drawn from Oren, two caravan houses, a funerary calendar school, and one commune-trained weather reader whom Oren objected to until the west arc threatened to withdraw. They compared recent observations, corrected for heat distortion, and rebuilt lunar velocity from raw marks.

The work consumed five hours. Ilyen answered questions and touched no instrument. Each correction pulled the result away from the public table. Nine minutes. Ten and a fraction. Finally eleven minutes, within four heartbeats.

Silence settled beneath the closed roof.

A caravan astronomer said, "The published table has been deliberately shifted."

Ilyen forced himself to continue. "Copying the true figures required command through a reservoir margin. I paid with the memory of my first star-moth hatching."

Sava stared at him. "You remember telling me about it."

"I remember that it happened. I remember the room, our mother's green shawl, your hand on my wrist. I cannot reach what the darkness felt like, or why the moth's weight made me cry."

"You spent our memory without asking me."

"The memory lived in me."

"It contained me."

He had prepared for charges of treason, collaboration, and cowardice. This charge entered cleanly because his private cost had never belonged entirely to him.

"Yes," he said. "I did not ask."

Sava stepped away from the instrument. "I denounce Ilyen Vaor before the houses of Leth Aven. Not because the table appears false. It does. I denounce him because he helped build the authority that made one expert's secret judgment more powerful than every person named in it. He concealed the calculations while House Oren signed contracts in ignorance of their full design. Now he arrives with an army and asks us to trust another emergency."

Oth said, "The communes signed nothing."

"You accepted pumps funded by the contracts."

"We accepted water taken from our own escarpment."

Sava faced the standing ring. "House Oren keeps imperial recognition until the shade-name clause receives lawful review. We will not join an armed march based on Ilyen's confession."

Ilyen felt an impulse to expose every private argument she had made against imperial policy. Doing so would turn her uncertainty into his evidence and repeat the violation she had named.

He addressed the room instead. "Do not join because I ask. Copy the table. Publish the calculation. Inspect every contract. Decide what you will host before any Night reaches you."

Teren lifted the tray holding the last nine high-rain females. "The saltwood communes have already decided. We join because permanent noon has made this city feed seasons into drawers while upper houses sell continuity reports. We offer six hundred couriers, two hundred moth keepers, darkroom cloth, saltwood grain, and host ink volunteered name by name."

The funerary school pledged calendar readers and covered wagons. One caravan house offered transport while refusing combat. Another remained neutral to protect eastern trade. House Oren stayed imperial. None spoke for all Selai.

Sava took a copy of the corrected table before leaving. At the door she paused without facing Ilyen.

"You made truth arrive wearing your necessity," she said. "I cannot tell whether that makes it less true or only more dangerous."

"Neither can I."

She left with the two moths still alive against her skin.

The chamber roof opened after the vote. Noon flooded the brass tracks, flattening their careful sky into bright metal. Below, saltwood commune workers carried covered colony drawers toward coalition wagons while House Oren officials sealed their upper bridges.

Ilyen watched another flight of dead star-moths fall across Leth Aven. This time the sweepers did not collect all of them. They laid eleven on the public eclipse table and left the twelfth place empty.

Chapter 11 — Treaty at the Blind Well

Kessa lowered a brass cup into the Blind Well and brought up water without a reflection.

Her hand appeared on the polished rim. The rope appeared. Inside the cup, nothing answered the permanent noon. The water held no sky, face, or darkness, only a dull gray surface that trembled when she breathed.

“Do not drink from the first draw,” said the well keeper beside her. “It belongs to the depth.”

Kessa poured it back. “Does the depth submit ration claims?”

“Only when ignored.”

The keeper wore human road leathers, Khar witness cords, Selai mineral marks on one wrist, and a Rill-made respirator hanging at her belt. Her name was Del Sar. She had inherited none of those objects together. The Blind Well collected customs because no local Night crossed its stone ring. Agreements made here could not rely on darkness to remember relationship or injury. Living witnesses carried every promise.

Kessa drew a second cup. This one reflected her face.

Around the well, the coalition assembled in seven camps that already disagreed about where camp boundaries lay. Seven Camp cloths occupied the north arc. Delegates of Akar’s three pledged courts shared the west but maintained separate kitchens. Saltwood commune wagons kept moth drawers beneath the eastern retaining wall. Pikk’s defectors and Rill engineers claimed a drainage tunnel until Del Sar evicted them from the well’s foundations. White Road refugees parked their carts south. White Orchard hosts tended covered fungus beds beyond the stone ring.

The Blind Well keepers occupied no camp. They moved through all of them, counting lies by the work those lies displaced.

Kessa carried her cup to the tally pavilion. Seven boards waited on trestles.

Her numbers had worsened since Akar Seven. Sixteen usable water carts had become fifteen after an axle split. Forty-seven fever patients needed transport. Three thousand seven hundred twenty-three Seven Camp survivors remained, including 241 dreamless. The broader road column added defectors, White Orchard households, Akar host crews, and Leth Aven volunteers. The 8,600 pledged at Akar described fighters and hosts available across a mobilization network, not bodies already present. Only 2,940 had reached the Blind Well. More would assemble along assigned routes.

Food could support the current column for twelve days at full ration, seventeen at reduced issue, and nine if every promised fighter arrived without local supply.

Kessa wrote those figures in characters large enough to shame anyone pretending alliance began with banners.

The first dispute concerned the road.

Returning Tracks proposed a northwest arc through free caravan ground, adding four days but avoiding imperial mirrors. Saltwood couriers favored the river terraces toward Rusk, where dead moth lines showed the Empire preparing a major extraction. Pikk wanted Karth Veil first because blackglass support could break any mirror orchard. Seven Camp elders demanded the shortest path east toward their captive Night.

"Shortest according to what?" Kessa asked.

A Seven Camp speaker pointed to a map. "Distance."

"Carts do not eat distance. They eat axles, fodder, water, and time. This line crosses two dry cuts and an imperial toll station."

"Every delay gives them time to use our Night."

Ilyen stood over the eclipse table. "The table identifies the deadline, not the order of seizure. We know eleven reservoirs are filled. We do not know whether Seven Camp has reached the capital."

"Then you ask us to gamble."

"I tell you we already are."

Zarha sat among her three outside witnesses rather than at the head. Her revised cord lay visible at her throat. "Akar pledged under host consent. We cannot turn that pledge into a march order from Seven Camp."

Returning Tracks' commander, Jor Kelm, tapped the northwest route. "My scouts can guarantee wells here and here."

"No scout guarantees a well," Del Sar said. "They report its condition on a day."

"Then they report both full."

Oth Aven placed dead moths at three points along the river route. "Rusk still has living Night. These colony failures show white-mirror preparation around its orchard belt. If Rusk becomes another empty noon, your safe northwest wells lose their rain within a season."

Pikk added a blackglass chip at Karth Veil. "And if you reach Rusk without fracture craft, you put hosts against mirrors with skin and good intentions."

The arguments produced three route plans, each with different assumptions hidden beneath the ink. Kessa required every advocate to list daily water, expected stragglers, bridge capacity, and retreat points. Two plans collapsed by themselves. The remaining route went first to Karth Veil, then turned southeast to Rusk, while refugee carts used a sheltered parallel road and rejoined before the orchard belt.

"That splits force from baggage," Jor said.

"It splits targets," Kessa replied. "Each branch remains close enough for one-day support."

Before allowing a vote, she took the delegates outside to test what their lines meant. The Blind Well keepers had built a practice road from discarded paving: steep slabs, a sand trench, a narrow turn between posts, and a bridge deck with three rotten boards painted red. Petitioners seeking route access had to move their actual load across it. Maps gained honesty when an axle met a corner.

Kessa chose the heaviest sleeper cart. Ren Tal and seven others lay secured beneath cloth, attended by two nurses. She added four water jars, fever linen, and the grain allowance the cart would carry on march. Jor's scouts pulled first. Their formation moved quickly on level paving and jammed at the narrow turn because armed escorts crowded both sides.

"You placed fighters on the outer file," Kessa said.

"To protect the cart."

"They prevent its wheel from clearing the post."

"An enemy is not a post."

"An enemy chooses worse places to stand."

Saltwood couriers tried next. They cleared the turn by moving ahead in pairs, then lost control in the sand trench because their light harness lacked rear ropes. Seven Camp herders added drag lines learned on the Red Salt. Rill engineers shifted one water jar over the axle and raised the front bed by a finger's width. No party solved the course alone.

When the cart reached the false bridge, Pikk struck each board with a wrench. "Two hold. One pretends."

Jor pointed to the painted plank. "We can see the bad one."

"Because a keeper marked it. Imperial retreat crews do not offer paint."

He showed them how blackglass dust collected in stressed grain. The method required a craft worker at every uncertain crossing, which removed engineers from siege preparation. Kessa wrote that cost on the route board.

A Seven Camp elder objected to using dreamless people in a demonstration. Kessa looked toward the cart attendants before answering. One, Ren's aunt, gave permission for the course to continue. The other demanded a slower descent and another cloth layer over exposed faces. Those conditions entered the exercise.

By the fourth run, a mixed crew moved the cart through in half the original time: Khar drag ropes, saltwood advance pairs, Rill load balance, human baggage whistles. The result did not prove harmony. Jor and Pikk argued over bridge authority throughout. It proved that each faction's private route plan had omitted work performed by somebody else.

Kessa returned the sleepers to their camp and posted the test times beside the maps. The Karth Veil to Rusk route won because its advocates revised their labor

assumptions, not because anyone surrendered affection for a preferred road.

“Who commands if attacked between?” Jor said.

That opened the second dispute.

Akar’s fighters recognized court-appointed field leaders. Seven Camp guards answered to Zarha only for refugee defense. Saltwood couriers refused military command over host ink. Pikk’s engineers accepted task authority from whoever understood a structure, which generally meant Pikk and therefore irritated everyone. Kessa’s baggage crews followed her whistles because a cart collision did not allow a vote.

Brass plaques went onto the board, one for each authority. Kessa separated march discipline from battle command, refugee movement from host consent, and engineering closure from route choice. No single commander received all plaques. In an attack, the field leader could direct armed units for six hours. Extension required witnesses from three parties. Civilians could not be reassigned as bait, labor, or shield. Local route keepers retained authority to close unsafe ground.

Jor objected. “Six hours ends in the middle of battle.”

“Then your witnesses renew it in the middle of battle.”

“A commander cannot fight while begging signatures.”

“A commander who cannot find three allies after six hours no longer commands an alliance.”

Zarha’s mouth almost formed a smile. Kessa ignored it.

Food took longer.

Ash Orchard grain sold at cost carried no military pledge. Saltwood communes had brought supplies gathered collectively and refused officer privilege. Seven Camp families still owned private goat herds. White Road refugees possessed stolen imperial carts whose legal ownership nobody wished to examine closely. The Rill contingent offered furnace tools but little food.

Kessa proposed a common ration floor: equal grain by body need, supplemental water for fever and glare exposure, additional protein for wound healing, no ancestry or rank preference. Parties could keep food above the floor if they declared it. Undeclared stores discovered during shortage entered common issue, with compensation recorded for later judgment.

A Seven Camp herd owner stood. “You legalize theft from households that planned well.”

“I legalize disclosure. You may keep your goats. You may not watch the common bins empty while selling meat at panic price inside a coalition camp.”

“What compensation?”

“A claim witnessed by two parties not receiving the food.”

“Paid by whom?”

“Whoever still governs after the war.”

Laughter spread under the pavilion. Kessa let it.

“If that answer sounds unreliable,” she said, “then understand the value of the supplies you promise on paper.”

Host rights nearly broke the meeting before the dreamless did.

Mera insisted no living Night could be assigned like a military unit. Every person volunteering a shade-name retained the right to withdraw before contact. Saltwood delegates demanded the same for host ink. Akar fighters wanted assurance that a Night would not abandon a battlefield after receiving shelter. Pikk warned that blackglass could redirect a binding but could not force darkness to remain.

“Then our strongest defense may leave because one frightened host changes her mind,” Jor said.

“Our strongest defense becomes imperial command if she cannot,” Mera replied.

They settled on layered consent. Individual hosts could withdraw their own names. A host circle could not claim the withdrawn name by majority. A Night could leave without breach. Military plans had to survive that possibility. Nobody liked a weapon with freedom, which proved they had not stopped thinking of Night as a weapon.

Kessa added a custody clause for Pikk’s fracture key. He would keep it. Two witnessed copies of its principles would be sealed with Rill labor delegates, not guild owners or field commanders. Using it against a binding required an engineer and a host-right witness when time allowed. Emergency use had to enter the casualty record afterward.

Pikk read the clause. “When time allows means whenever somebody later dislikes what I did.”

“Yes.”

“Good. That resembles engineering review.”

The compact had reached twenty-three clauses when a Brass Mile observer, present without pledge, asked to see the party counts.

He read Kessa’s board and circled the 241 dreamless.

“These cannot sign, witness, withdraw host consent, carry rations, or perform road duty,” he said. “They should fall under dependent carriage, outside the protected-person count.”

Jor nodded slowly. “They retain shelter. This concerns voting weight.”

The observer drew a clean line through the number. “Define party strength by competent adults and children under guardianship. Suspended persons receive mercy without distorting command shares.”

Mercy. Kessa had learned to distrust the word whenever its speaker held the

measuring cup.

A Seven Camp elder said, "If excluding them secures the treaty, their families will understand."

Across the pavilion, attendants continued turning sleepers on reed pallets to prevent sores. One squeezed broth into Ren Tal's mouth a spoonful at a time. Another washed cloth in boiled well water. The labor occupied fifty-eight people per shift.

Kessa took the observer's chalk.

"Remove them," she said.

Nobody expected agreement. The pavilion quieted.

She struck 241 from the population board. Then she struck 116 attendants assigned across two shifts, because without protected standing they could not be ordered to care for excluded persons. She removed four cooking teams, seven cart crews, three fever nurses, and the guards who had family among the dreamless. She deducted nine carts required for bodies and care supplies.

The available march column shrank by 463 living workers and dependents. Daily distance improved briefly because fewer carts remained, then collapsed when Kessa reassigned the displaced sleepers to private family transport and families refused to march without them.

"Your northwest branch loses two water carts," she told Jor. "The Rusk branch loses one surgeon and eighteen armed walkers. Kitchen output falls fourteen percent. Night watch falls eleven percent. Your competent army now cooks, washes waste, and carries bodies, unless you intend to leave the excluded beside this well."

The Brass Mile observer kept his voice calm. "Dependents do not vanish because they lack party standing."

"They vanish from decisions. Their work does not."

"We can assign guardians."

"Guardianship chosen by whom?"

"Families."

"Ren Tal's mother died at the causeway. His father remains dreamless on the next pallet."

"Then the court."

"Which court? Seven Camp lost its ground. Akar recognizes different dependency law. The Empire calls him dead."

Zarha rose. "Seven Camp recognizes him alive."

"Then count him among Seven Camp's political weight," Jor said. "That grants one party influence through people who cannot object."

Oth's ear-fans darkened with blood. "Your fighters appointed you while absent.

They cannot object to every order either.”

The argument spread through the delegations. Some feared fabricated dependent counts. Others feared commanders claiming sleepers as votes. Mera opposed using the dreamless to enlarge any office. Kessa agreed with each fear and refused the proposed remedy.

“Do not assign votes by population,” she said. “Seven parties each sign or refuse. Protected-person status governs food, movement, rescue, and casualty record. It does not create ballots for an office.”

“Then why count anyone?” the observer asked.

“Because grain disappears into mouths, roads fill with bodies, and dead people deserve names rather than a corrected total.”

He pointed toward the well. “A compact cannot receive consent from unconscious persons.”

“No. It can receive consent from us not to exploit their silence.”

Kessa set down the chalk. “White Road refugees do not sign any agreement that defines a breathing person outside rescue priority. If that breaks the alliance, give us our ration share and we leave south.”

It was not a bluff. She had already calculated the cost: eight days of food, perhaps ten with forage, no military protection, and 241 people likely dead before a safe city. Refusing exclusion might kill those she meant to protect. Accepting it would establish the rule used to leave them behind at every later gate.

Pikk moved his blackglass marker beside Kessa’s board. “Rill free engineers withdraw with the baggage column.”

Oth placed a dead moth beside it. “Saltwood communes too.”

Mera carried her fungus jar across the pavilion. Quiet Hide’s hosts followed.

Jor stared at the route map losing half its practical support. “This is coercion.”

“Yes,” Kessa said. “So was requiring their exclusion as the price of your fighters. We are discovering which coercion the compact permits.”

Del Sar spoke for the first time in an hour. “The well takes no reflection on first draw because the depth has not consented to carry your face. Try again.”

The Brass Mile observer left. Jor remained.

Revision took another three hours. Protected persons became every living body traveling under a party’s declared care, regardless of waking, speech, legal status, age, or work capacity. No party gained command weight by dependent count. False population declarations triggered audit by two other parties, never removal of food from the disputed people. Rescue priority followed danger and survival chance, with no automatic exclusion for dreamless status.

Seven parties signed the Blind Well Compact.

Zarha signed for Seven Camp under her revised witness cord. Jor signed for

Returning Tracks. Seli signed for Uncovered Bowl. Quiet Hide gave its mark through Mera and the local representative. Kessa signed for the White Road refugee councils. Oth signed for the saltwood communes. Pikk signed for the free Rill engineers and defectors. The Blind Well keepers did not become an eighth party; they witnessed all seven and kept duplicate boards.

Ash Orchard and Brass Mile remained outside. The funerary school joined under the saltwood signature. White Orchard households entered Quiet Hide's host circle without surrendering their own consent.

Implementation began before the ink dried. Kessa issued new ration boards. Jor named a temporary six-hour field command and three renewal witnesses. Pikk sealed two fracture-principle copies. Mera recorded every volunteered shade-name on cords that could be physically untied. Del Sar assigned the river approach to scouts and marked the parallel refugee road.

Thirty-nine days remained before the eclipse.

Kessa returned to the well and lowered the brass cup twice. On the second draw, her reflection appeared among the faces leaning over the rim: Khar, Selai, Rill, human, waking, carried, doubtful. The Blind Well Compact had not made them one people. It had made abandonment require seven signatures.

Chapter 12 — The Empress Counts Her Nights

Caldra descended into the first well without a crown.

Gold leaf flaked in Noctuary damp, and ceremony interfered with respirator straps. She wore a plain white coat, soft boots, and the brass tally chain carried by reservoir keepers. Eleven counters hung from it. A vacant hook waited at the end.

Marshal Avenn preceded her down the basalt stair. Physician-General Sorai followed with two clerks and a case of nerve instruments. The keeper at the lower door asked each visitor to state a shade-name before entry. Caldra gave the childhood name used by her nurse during storms, not the regnal name printed on census rolls.

The keeper wrote it on dissolving paper and dropped it into a lye bowl. “No durable names beyond this door.”

An empire required records. A prison for living darkness required restraint from records. Caldra had approved both principles and lived with their collision.

The first reservoir held the Night of Hesh Fen.

White mirrors formed a cylinder around the shaft. Within them, black water climbed the walls without wetting stone. Reed shadows moved beneath the surface. Frogs called from no visible bank, repeating the same three notes they had called when imperial surveyors opened Hesh’s burial marsh thirteen years ago. The Night pressed toward Caldra’s left hand, where an old plague scar crossed her palm.

“It remembers fever shelters,” Sorai said.

“It remembers relation,” Caldra corrected. “Do not make testimony from pressure.”

Hesh Fen had lost seventeen children to night predators in the year before annexation and none in the five years after permanent illumination. It had also lost marsh seed, frog spawning, and the funerary water in which families once washed their dead. Every report could become an acquittal if read alone.

At the second well, mountain darkness condensed as frost around empty goat bells. The third carried orchard moths that battered themselves against mirror seams. The fourth smelled of rain on kiln roofs and had begun cracking mortar above its shaft. Each had entered the Noctuary under a different legal instrument: plague emergency, surrendered war levy, debt compact, census enforcement, court purchase, protective custody. Force did not require one name.

Caldra touched a counter after every inspection.

The sixth Night had divided during extraction without host consent. One portion remained in its valley, injured and feral. The captive portion recoiled from every keeper bearing the same family name as the official who authorized removal.

Caldra had ordered those workers reassigned. Ministers praised the decision as compassionate staffing. Nobody proposed returning the darkness.

At the ninth, a maintenance officer reported three mirror technicians dreamless after a binding surge.

"Names?" Caldra asked.

The officer passed her a slate. One technician had repaired Basilica windows for twenty-two years. Another had entered service two months ago to pay a brother's tax debt. The third belonged to a family that supplied Noctuary keepers across four generations.

"Care classifications?"

"Imperial injured for the first and third. Contract dependent for the second."

"Equalize them."

Marshal Avenn shifted beside her. "Contract status affects survivor stipends."

"Then equalize those."

The order would cost less than a cavalry stable and appear in three speeches about imperial mercy. Caldra knew the scale of the gesture. She made it anyway because small justice did not become false merely by failing to cancel large harm.

The eleventh well held darkness taken from the rain coast. It moved like a storm restrained inside glass, illuminating nothing but making every white surface feel exposed. Beyond it, the twelfth shaft remained empty. New mirrors lined its walls. Copper conduits ran upward toward the ritual chamber in unconnected bundles.

"Rusk fits the final harmonics," Avenn said. "Orchard and river relations bridge six incompatible reservoirs. Its census reaches ninety-four percent."

"Population?"

"Thirty-one thousand in the city, another twelve thousand across the orchard belt."

Caldra looked down the empty shaft. "Resistance?"

"Local wardens, orchard militias, civilian host circles. No standing army sufficient against a mirror regiment."

"Coalition distance?"

"Uncertain. Reports place Kesh at Akar Seven. Other reports place her already east of Leth Aven."

The permanent noon above the Noctuary had made time easy to schedule and hard to feel. Thirty-eight days remained before the eclipse. Eleven minutes less than the public table claimed, though only the inner cabinet received the corrected figure.

Caldra climbed to the donor audit chamber.

Rows of ledgers covered three walls. The fourth opened through glass onto a

medical ward where men and women slept beneath dark cloth. Some thrashed against restraints. Others stared without blinking. A child sat beside one bed, turning pages for a mother who no longer dreamed and therefore could not place stories into sequence.

Sorai gave the total without rhetorical preparation. "Eighty-six thousand donors show impairment attributable to Night extraction, reservoir maintenance, or shadow casting."

The number had grown by twelve thousand since the last consolidated audit.

"Categories."

"Twenty-one thousand with sleep fragmentation but stable work capacity. Nineteen thousand with loss of dream recall and associated learning difficulty. Fourteen thousand with emotional flattening. Eleven thousand with waking intrusions. Nine thousand dreamless and dependent. Seven thousand seizure-prone. Five thousand dead across forty years, recorded separately from the 86,000 living impaired."

Caldra kept her eyes on the ward. "Children?"

"Six thousand current minors among the living total, mostly census-name inheritance exposure rather than direct donation."

Avenn said, "The military ledger counts functional personnel, Majesty. Medical categories can imply losses where none affect deployment."

"A soldier who cannot dream may still hold a spear," Sorai said. "He may also fail to consolidate a changed order and repeat the last forceful intention he heard."

"That describes the shadows, not trained donors."

"It describes both at different severity."

Treasury Prefect Halm waited at the audit table with yellow expenditure sheets. "A full pension classification for all 86,000 exceeds provincial grain revenue. We can recognize severe categories and provide clinic vouchers for the remainder."

"Vouchers to clinics already full," Sorai said.

Caldra unhooked her tally chain and laid it across the ledgers. Eleven brass counters looked trivial beside eighty-six thousand entries.

She entered the ward through the clerk's gate. Sorai protested the lack of an escort, then followed carrying her instrument case. Beds stood in groups according to symptom rather than military rank. Dark cloth covered the seizure row. In the waking-intrusion section, patients reached toward objects from dreams that remained visible after their eyes opened.

The child reading beside her mother stopped when Caldra approached. She appeared nine or ten, old enough to recognize the sovereign's face and young enough not to hide dislike.

"What page?" Caldra asked.

“Fourteen. Then page six. She says the river comes before the bridge today.”

The mother wore a census-donor band around one wrist. Her chart identified her as Nemi Ar, municipal lamplighter, exposed during a reservoir pressure release. Caldra pulled a stool close.

“Nemi, where does the bridge belong?”

The woman examined the illustrated book. “After the river if you travel east. Before it if you come home.”

Her answer held logic. The page order did not.

The girl said, “They want to move her to the dependent ward because she cannot pass sequence inspection.”

Sorai opened the chart. “Her body remains independent. Classification concerns legal decisions and work.”

“She still decides,” the girl said. “They ask questions whose answers have one road.”

Caldra had built administrative tests to keep predatory guardians from taking donor pensions. Here, the same tests threatened to erase a woman whose thoughts moved by different routes.

“Repeat assessment with a spatial examiner,” Caldra said. “Keep her pension direct unless fraud appears.”

“Will you do that for everyone?” the child asked.

The question stripped favor from the order. Caldra looked to Sorai.

“How many sequence failures await review?”

“Three thousand two hundred.”

“Train spatial examiners for all.”

“We have forty-one.”

“Then train more.”

“From which clinics?”

Every answer consumed staff already treating another imperial cost. Caldra revised the order: severe pension transfers paused for sixty days, mobile assessment teams drawn from observatory schools, family testimony admitted as evidence but never sole guardianship authority. Halm would complain about fraud. Some fraud would occur. Fewer people would lose their own names through a test designed around undamaged memory.

At the ward exit, three officials waited who had not joined the audit table. Canon Vey carried the Sun Basilica’s white mantle. Provincial Minister Rel Aro wore a farmer’s brown coat despite owning no field. Commander Tesk represented the mirror regiments.

Canon Vey touched two fingers to the eleven counters. “The reservoirs require

consecration before Rusk enters. Their agitation follows mixed custody.”

“Their agitation follows captivity,” Sorai said.

“Captivity under lawful purpose can still require ritual order.”

Caldra asked, “What does consecration change materially?”

“Keeper confidence. Donor alignment. Public acceptance.”

“Nothing in the Nights.”

The canon hesitated. “Sacred relation does not submit to instrument proof.”

“Then do not claim it as maintenance.”

Minister Aro opened a provincial yield chart. “Rusk supplies twelve percent of eastern dried fruit. Extraction during harvest will close orchard sheds. Delay six weeks and seizure costs fall.”

“Totality does not delay.”

“Then exempt outer orchard hosts. The city reservoir may provide enough relation.”

Commander Tesk shook his head. “Partial census creates a tear. We need the belt isolated before mirror contact.”

“Need,” Aro said, “according to a military model that counts fruit trees as host infrastructure and workers as replaceable.”

“They are host infrastructure.”

“They are also people who prune at the only hour heat permits.”

Caldra listened while each institution reduced Rusk differently. The priest saw relation without measurable mechanism. The minister saw yield and labor. The commander saw a binding field. Sorai saw expected injuries. None held the whole city, and Caldra’s power consisted partly of pretending a sovereign view could.

She ordered harvest stores moved west under civilian seal, outer families offered evacuation before the mirror cordon, and no consecration described as changing Night behavior. Tesk received authority to isolate the belt. Every mitigation made the operation more organized. None made Rusk consenting.

When Night Plague entered the lower capital forty-six years earlier, local lords closed their private dark gardens. Caldra’s father had begged access for the palace household and received it. Her younger brothers died anyway because the garden keeper admitted titled adults first and sick children after. Beyond the palace, thousands waited under lamps while safe darkness remained behind walls.

She had learned two lessons at thirteen. Darkness could shelter. Whoever controlled shelter could choose whom to abandon.

The One Night project intended to remove that choice from local lords, court priests, orchard elders, free raiders, and hereditary hosts. One regulated darkness would travel where public need required. Its standards would be measured, inspected, and enforceable.

Yet every well beneath her had turned regulation into custody, and custody into injury distributed among people least able to refuse census collectors.

"Publish the impairment categories after the eclipse," she said.

Halm blinked. "All of them?"

"With compensation schedule."

"Majesty, publication before pacification would aid rebel claims."

"I said after the eclipse."

Sorai's expression remained controlled. "And before?"

"Expand dark wards. Equal care regardless of contract status. Suspend new minor registrations."

"Direct adult casting continues?"

"Yes."

The physician-general looked through the glass at the child reading disordered pages. "Then the total grows."

"It grows if the war continues. It grows faster if every region fights for private custody after imperial collapse."

Avenn placed a sealed military folder over the medical ledger. "The first host stands ready."

Caldra left the ward to witness activation.

The shadow ground lay beneath the eastern Basilica terraces, open to the vertical sun and ringed by white-mirror pylons. Nine thousand four hundred donors stood in marked ranks behind dark screens. They came from imperial legions, road-charter companies, penal auxiliaries, and civil defense wards. Each had supplied one forceful intention under oath. The casting apparatus would repeat that intention as a shadow soldier.

On the bright ground before them, 9,400 empty silhouettes waited.

Caldra walked the donor line. A veteran from the western levy had offered hold this gate. A civil warden had offered carry the children out. A penal auxiliary had offered make them kneel, words accepted by a recruiting officer who should have known better. A road soldier had offered nobody crosses behind me.

"Remove the kneeling cast," Caldra ordered.

Avenn checked the code. "It passed obedience review."

"It cannot distinguish surrender from civilian movement."

"None distinguish. We deploy by compatible intention."

"Then that intention lacks compatibility with imperial service."

The donor had already given it. Removing the cast protected future targets but did not return what the apparatus had taken.

Technicians aligned the pylons. White light narrowed until every donor cast one ordinary shadow and one shape angled against the sun. The second shapes thickened, detached, and stood.

No cheer rose. Nine thousand four hundred soldiers looked at 9,400 repetitions of their hardest chosen purpose.

Avenn issued the demonstration order. "First cohort, advance to the red line and hold."

Human troops marched beside shadows. Khar road-charter soldiers moved with echoes carrying hooked spears. Rill auxiliaries watched compact doubles repeat the stance they had held during recruitment. Selai imperial wardens walked while their copies angled their heads as if listening for orders they could never revise. Alignment followed intention, not ancestry.

At the red line, Avenn changed the command. "Open center. Allow medical carts through."

Living soldiers stepped aside.

Shadows cast from hold this gate did not.

The first medical cart struck a double and stopped. Its driver shouted. A living donor tried to pull his shadow back, but the shape pressed both hands against the cart and held. Three other echoes joined it because their intentions recognized obstruction rather than medicine.

Technicians rotated a pylon to sever the cohort. For half a second, every double pulled taut. Donors screamed behind the screens. Two collapsed with seizures. One woman tore out her own fingernails trying to drag a dream back into reach.

The shadows flattened and reattached.

Sorai entered the ground before Avenn dismissed the ranks. "Thirty-one acute rebounds. Four likely permanent dream-loss cases. Demonstration exposure only."

Halm's clerk wrote training attrition.

Caldra took the slate from him and replaced the words with donor injuries.

Avenn waited until medical crews cleared the red line. "The failure confirms doctrine. Shadow cohorts receive objectives, never maneuver changes."

"It confirms they cannot protect what an order did not imagine."

"No army can."

"Living soldiers can disobey."

The marshal's face tightened. "Majesty, that quality has caused several wars."

"And ended atrocities."

She looked across the donors. The One Night promised shelter obedient to public law. The army before her promised force obedient to prior intention. Both projects treated refusal as a defect. Caldra recognized the resemblance and rejected the conclusion it invited.

Without centralized power, Hesh Fen's strongmen would reclaim burial marshes and private dark gardens would close during the next plague. Free-court raiders would burn settled nurseries. House Oren or another observatory house would monopolize eclipse knowledge. The alternatives already possessed victims.

"Activation proceeds," she said. "No shadow cohort deploys without donor medics. Remove all casts centered on punishment, pursuit of unnamed persons, or denial of retreat. Pair objectives with living units authorized to terminate the cast."

Sorai asked, "Do you accept the projected impairment?"

Caldra did not request a softened word. "I accept responsibility for it."

Responsibility did not reduce the 86,000. It assigned the signature.

Besh Kor arrived after the donors dispersed. Red Salt marked his boots and the seams of his imperial coat. He bowed as a road commander, one fist touching the ground, rather than using court prostration.

"You failed to recover the fracture engineer," Caldra said.

"I chose not to assault Akar Seven under safe-conduct law."

"Your charter answers to imperial law."

"My charter holds because free courts believe I honor road law when imperial advantage points elsewhere."

Caldra valued him for that answer and distrusted him for the same reason. A commander with no law beyond obedience could not hold settled Khar routes. A commander with his own law might one day close them to her.

"Kesh now moves under the Blind Well Compact," Avenn said. "Seven parties, divided command."

Besh read the summary. "That will slow them."

"It may also keep them together," Caldra said. "You will hold the Red Road east of Karth Veil. Deny access to Rusk's orchard belt. Do not enter Akar ground. Offer amnesty to households that leave the Compact."

"And the dreamless?"

"Carriage and treatment. No legal-death exclusions."

Avenn glanced at her, but Besh only nodded.

"What force?" he asked.

"Three road-charter companies, two mirror regiments, and the first shadow cohort after medical review."

His attention sharpened. "My soldiers will not accept copies cast without individual oath."

"Then use only those who consented under your charter."

"Consent under service can carry a narrow road."

"Narrow is sufficient. Hold it."

Caldra signed the Rusk extraction order with the pen used for public-health decrees. Mirror crews would enter from the east while Besh fixed the coalition on the Red Road. Census teams would isolate orchard host names. The twelfth well would receive Rusk before totality.

She returned the tally chain to her coat. Eleven counters struck softly against one another as she climbed toward the unsetting sun. The empty hook made no sound, yet every order issued that day hung from it.

Chapter 13 — The Siegebreakers of Karth Veil

Pikk put his ear against the western gate and heard Karth Veil trying not to breathe.

No hammer struck behind the iron skin. Furnace draft should have pulsed through the hinges, a bass vibration that every child in the city learned before speech. Instead he heard one banked fire somewhere below, three lift chains moving without load, and the thin crystalline whine of blackglass cooling too slowly.

“They have shut the galleries,” he said.

Kessa stood beside him in a dust scarf. “For siege?”

“For punishment. Siege closure keeps the lower drafts open.”

The coalition waited beyond the slag terraces. Armed units had stopped outside bow range under the Blind Well Compact. Rill workers inside had not requested intervention, and Pikk refused to make his return the excuse for an occupation bearing friendly cloth. Behind the fighters, refugee carts continued along the sheltered parallel road toward Rusk.

A notice had been bolted to the gate at Pikk’s eye level.

BY ORDER OF IMPERIAL CONTINUITY AND THE UNITED GUILD TABLE: UNTIL THE SABOTEUR PIKK RILL ENTERS CUSTODY, ALL FURNACE SHARES ARE SUSPENDED. DEPENDENTS OF FRACTURE-SUSPECT CREWS WILL BE REMOVED TO SURFACE CAMPS. FOOD ISSUE RESUMES UPON COMPLIANCE.

The phrase united guild table lied. Karth Veil had never united around anything except the need to keep molten glass from entering its water channels.

Pikk touched the bolt. “This came from Vikka’s number-two press. The left edge bites deeper.”

“Your cousin printed it?” Zarha asked.

“Her firm owns the press. Ownership and action are not identical, though owners enjoy confusing them when profits arrive.”

His right palm scar itched against the metal. The gate contained four false joins, decorative seams designed to lead an attacker away from the load spine. He had drawn two of them at twenty-three while working for the family firm. Vikka had added a third after inheriting. The fourth belonged to a labor crew making certain both owners and invaders misunderstood the door.

Pikk tapped a sequence below the notice: two, five, one, one, three. A furnace maintenance code requesting air, not entry.

Nothing answered.

He repeated it with the butt of his wrench. This time a narrow inspection slot opened near the ground. One dark eye appeared behind a dust lens.

"Name your shift," said the person inside.

"Third Deep, before Guild Rill sold its labor charter."

"That shift dissolved eighteen years ago."

"Work lasts in the wrist." Pikk placed both hands against the gate so the glass scars could be seen. "I request entry alone under maintenance shelter."

A woman behind him whispered that the city might keep him. She had reason. Pikk's fracture key had broken the imperial causeway mirror and brought collective punishment to everyone whose employment record shared his old furnace codes.

The eye vanished. Bolts moved in the wrong order, proving workers rather than gate officers controlled them.

A gap opened wide enough for Pikk's compact body. Zarha caught his sleeve.

"Your outside witness comes with you."

"They admitted one."

"The Compact requires one for decisions affecting parties beyond your own."

"I am going home to be shouted at."

"That has already affected us."

He considered arguing, then selected Kessa because she understood that food ledgers could become weapons. The eye at the slot rejected her. Pikk put his foot in the gap and waited until the hidden crew admitted both.

Inside, Karth Veil descended around them.

The city filled an extinct glass quarry, its galleries cut in concentric rings down a blue-black pit. Bridges crossed the open center at seven levels. Chimneys rose through housing terraces. Ordinarily every surface carried motion: ore baskets, sand lifts, hot carts, vendors, children running messages between shifts. Now imperial guards occupied the bridges while families crowded shuttered doorways. Surface light fell to the lowest water in a hard white column.

A maintenance worker led them through an air duct and down two levels. Her name was Olli Tern, chair of the Fourth Draft crew council. She kept a knife at Pikk's back.

"How many dependents removed?" Kessa asked.

"Eight hundred sixty-two to the slag camps. More scheduled at second bell."

"Food?"

"Two days if the lockout holds. Half a day in the camps."

"Prisoners?" Pikk asked.

"Three hundred eleven workers. Forty children held with them because the governor calls family records evidence."

The numbers struck more precisely than blame. "Deaths?"

“Six during arrests. One lift fall, two shot, three crushed at East Sluice.”

They passed a furnace hall whose doors had been chained. Inside, banked heat pressed against refractory brick. Too little draft allowed fuel gas to collect; too much oxygen would bring the fire back through cracks. Punishment had turned every idle furnace into a delayed explosion.

Olli saw him listening. “Can you stabilize them?”

“Which banks?”

“All nine.”

“With crews, yes.”

“The crews are prisoners or outside.”

“Then the governor has placed his own garrison over nine bombs.”

“He sleeps on the surface.”

Of course he did.

The old labor chamber occupied a tunnel where dripping water carried away glass dust. Forty people waited around a scarred table. They did not form one Rill interest. Family-firm owners wore brass thumb caps. Labor-republic delegates carried shift seals. Imperial contractors kept white badges visible. Furnace tenders came in work aprons. Tunnel households sent grandmothers because their employed adults sat in cells. Two guild guards attended without weapons.

Vikka Rill stood at the far end.

She resembled Pikk around the eyes and nowhere else. Her coat used heat-resistant silk. Pale scars crossed her fingers, earned before ownership moved her above the furnace floor. She had printed the punishment order. She had also left the western gate’s labor code active.

“You look badly employed,” she said.

“You look expensive.”

Kessa placed her tally board on the table. “Save family affection for after the food count.”

Nobody laughed.

Vikka pointed to a chair. “The governor demands Pikk before second bell. In exchange he returns dependents, opens grain, and commutes collective charges to contract fines.”

Olli said, “Fines equal twelve years of worker shares.”

“Less than artillery through the galleries.”

Pikk remained standing. “Will he open the furnace drafts?”

“He says after surrender.”

“Then he does not understand the plant.”

“He has imperial engineers.”

“He has mirror polishers trained to call a crack cosmetic until it enters somebody else’s lungs.”

Vikka’s gaze moved to his coat, where the fracture key rested. “You broke an imperial siege mirror using work developed in this city. Every guild contract now faces seizure.”

“Imperial contracts already seized the work.”

“They paid.”

“They purchased firms. Workers signed continuation terms after owners sold the air systems that kept them alive.”

An elderly contractor struck the table. “Do not turn your grievance into our starvation. Some of us chose imperial orders because they kept furnaces open.”

Olli answered, “And some of us chose them because closing meant eviction.”

Pikk took out the fracture key.

The object looked unimpressive: three blackglass vanes pinned through a copper hinge. Each vane held a stress note. Sounded together, they could show white binding where to break itself. Pikk had hidden it, used it, and treated possession as proof that the design belonged to him.

He set it in the table’s center.

“I offer the method to any crew that joins a public fracture register,” he said. “No guild ownership. No personal ownership. Every use lists the workers, target, host witnesses, injuries, and payment. Crews may refuse military work. The design council can remove me.”

Vikka leaned forward. “You offer what your family furnace financed.”

“Our workers’ lungs financed it.”

“You drew the key under a guild salary.”

“And imperial officers ordered the mirror that tore shade from 612 donors at Deren Ford. Shall we invite them to divide royalties?”

The room broke into arguments. Owners demanded compensation for kilns. Labor councils demanded custody. Contractors feared imperial reprisals. A tunnel delegate wanted every mirror furnace destroyed. Olli refused because water pumps, surgical glass, and darkroom plates used the same heat.

Kessa began writing objectives on the wall.

“People before symbols,” she said. “What must change by second bell?”

Prison cells opened. Children removed. Slag camps supplied. Furnace drafts stabilized. Grain store unlocked. Mirror yard disabled. Lift controls held. Records preserved. Surface gates opened only after the city decided who entered.

“Governor?” asked a guild guard.

"Alive for judgment if possible," Olli said.

"Imperial garrison?"

"Offer withdrawal without mirrors."

The tunnel delegate objected. "They killed six."

"Then record six murder charges. We do not solve records by making more bodies unavailable."

Pikk studied the city diagram. The objectives competed for the same shafts. Prisoners occupied level five. Draft controls sat level six. Grain rested level two. Imperial troops could lock the lifts from the mirror yard on level three.

"We need three fracture choirs," he said.

Nobody used the term yet. It came to him from the structure. A single key broke one binding at one stress point. Large mirror arrays distributed strain across several plates. Three crews, sounding related keys at calculated intervals, could make the array choose incompatible supports.

Vikka understood first. "You have never tested linked fracture."

"The Empire has helpfully assembled a yard."

"You could break every window in the west galleries."

"Yes."

"Those galleries house four thousand people."

"Then we evacuate the lines of return before sounding."

Olli stared at the diagram. "Can three crews learn it before second bell?"

"If furnace workers lead. They already hear load."

Vikka picked up the key. "If this fails, your public register records who?"

"Me first. Every chooser after."

She put it down. "My firm does not join a revolt."

"Will it join the governor?"

"My firm keeps contracts until law changes."

Olli asked, "Will you block us?"

Vikka looked toward the dark ventilation slit. "I will close my workshops for safety inspection and order guild guards to protect firm property. What they interpret as property remains a matter for their supervisors."

Neutrality shaped to preserve an owner's future. Pikk did not call it courage. He also did not refuse the opening.

The chamber voted by work crews. Eleven joined the action. Four refused but promised no report. Two contractor groups left to warn the governor. One family firm pledged its private guards to imperial order.

Second bell lay ninety minutes away.

Pikk divided the fracture key principles among three crews. First Choir took the low note at the mirror yard's foundation. Second held the crossing frequency along lift rails. Third carried the high break into the white control plates. They practiced on discarded glass no larger than dinner trays. Wrong timing produced powder. Correct timing opened a branching crack that stopped at the blackglass boundary.

"You do not sing," Pikk told them. "You listen, answer, and leave room for the next stress."

A young furnace tuner named Venn tapped his ear protection. "Then why choir?"

"Because engineers enjoy naming ordinary cooperation after the plan begins."

Kessa left for the surface camps with a maintenance escort. Her task involved food, not glory: get water to 862 dependents and position coalition carts beyond any reflected-force line. Zarha kept armed allies outside. Under the Compact, local workers had to signal before intervention.

Pikk and Olli went down to level six.

The first sabotage required no explosion. Furnace crews opened inspection drains and released cooled blackglass beads into ore chutes. The beads jammed sorting teeth without harming the fireboxes. Lift workers replaced imperial destination tags, sending mirror blanks to abandoned galleries. Water crews increased flow through worker housing and reduced it at the governor's ornamental cascade.

Across Karth Veil, machines began refusing owners through the accumulated decisions of people who knew their joints.

Imperial whistles sounded.

Troops entered the furnace hall in heat armor, shields polished white. Their captain ordered crews to restore production. Olli presented a safety closure stamped by Vikka's firm.

"This stamp lacks governor approval."

"Fire does not require his signature."

He arrested her.

Pikk struck the emergency draft lever.

Nine furnace doors opened one hand's width. Stored gas rolled into the hall as a bitter shimmer. Every Rill worker dropped flat and covered respirator valves. Imperial troops stayed upright half a breath too long. They began coughing, shields lowering.

Nobody lit a spark. Pikk crawled to Olli, cut her wrist cord against his palm scar, and led workers through the lower duct. The troops recovered without burning. Sabotage preserved the possibility of surrender.

At level five, prison crews attacked locks with thermal wedges smuggled inside

food tins. The first opened. The second expanded in its frame and jammed. Children screamed behind it as guards approached from the north bridge.

Pikk reached the cell with a fracture tuner. "Heat the hinge, not the bar."

"The hinge backs onto bedding."

"Wet the bedding. Move people to the south wall."

Gun bolts struck the corridor. A labor guard returned fire from behind an ore cart. White mirror shields caught the force and threw dark replicas of the impacts across the ceiling. One reflected bolt entered the cell through a vent and hit a prisoner in the shoulder.

"Stop shooting," Pikk shouted.

Neither side listened until Olli opened a steam line between them. Scalding fog filled the corridor, forcing both groups back. Pikk felt along the hot door, set blackglass at the hinge pins, and tapped three descending notes. Metal separated from the imperial white seal. Workers dragged forty children out beneath wet blankets.

The governor's voice entered speaking tubes across the city.

PIKK RILL HAS INITIATED INDUSTRIAL TERROR. ALL DEPENDENT TRANSFERS COMMENCE. RESISTANCE VOIDS FOOD GUARANTEES.

At the surface camps, Kessa answered by raising three red cloths. Water delivered. Dependents under local protection. Coalition entry requested only for evacuation corridors.

Zarha sent unarmed host crews first.

The decision confused imperial gunners prepared for an assault. Akar cloth bearers crossed the slag terraces carrying stretchers instead of shields. Saltwood couriers brought darkroom fabric to cover families from mirror sight. Seven Camp guards remained beyond range until workers opened the western gate.

On level three, the mirror yard activated.

Twenty-four white plates rose on geared frames around the pit. They had been manufactured for Rusk's orchard extraction. Each plate bore thousands of census-name grooves. As they turned, shadows tore from people standing on bridges and leaned toward the central light.

Pikk felt his own shadow pull.

The yard had his childhood name. Guild Rill had entered it on an apprentice census thirty-eight years earlier. The mirror did not care that he had defected or changed allegiance. It recognized where shade had once touched him.

He drove a blackglass pin through the pale scar on his left palm and into the rail. Pain gave the binding a nearer path. His shadow snapped back against his boots.

"Choirs to stations," he said into the maintenance tube.

First Choir answered with three low taps. Second returned two. Third remained

silent.

The high station occupied a crane above the yard. Imperial guards had reached it first.

Without Third Choir, breaking the foundation would send strain through housing windows. Waiting let the array strip names from everyone in the galleries.

Olli came beside him, blood running from a cut over one eye. "We can rotate the high plate from here."

"Manual gear requires someone on the service arm."

"That someone can be small."

"Everyone in this city can be small."

"You designed the sequence."

There it stood: expertise becoming command because time had narrowed. The public register would not make refusal practical for a person already climbing.

Pikk handed the central key to Olli. "You call the break. If my plate misses alignment, stop both lower choirs."

"And leave you?"

"Yes."

He climbed onto the service arm.

The crane extended over the pit, a lattice of black iron above white mirrors. Heat rose from banked furnaces. Below, fighting spread across level-three bridges. Workers pushed ore carts as barricades. Guild guards protected workshops, some firing at imperial soldiers, others firing at anyone approaching owner vaults. One labor group tried to destroy a medical-glass kiln until its own neighbors dragged them away.

Karth Veil had not become one city through revolt. It had become every conflict at once.

Pikk reached the manual gear. Third Choir's tuners crouched behind the crane housing, pinned by mirror fire. Their leader Venn had a bolt through his calf.

"Can you sound?" Pikk called.

"Can you count?" Venn replied.

The young tuner passed him the high vane.

Pikk locked his feet around the service rail and turned the gear. The control plate resisted. White binding pulled through its axle, powered by names cut across the yard. Each turn dragged at memories of shade: his mother under a furnace awning, Olli asleep after a double shift, Vikka teaching him to hear a cooling seam. The mirror sought not to burn those memories but to use their relations as handles.

He thought of the 612 donors at Deren Ford and turned harder.

The plate reached alignment.

First Choir sounded below hearing, a vibration Pikk felt in his teeth. Second Choir entered through the lift rails. Their note crossed the first and divided around the pit.

Pikk struck the high vane.

The plate screamed.

Sound drove into his right ear like a heated needle. He missed the next interval. Venn caught his wrist and struck the vane with Pikk's wrench. The high note met the lower two.

Cracks opened across all twenty-four white mirrors.

They did not explode. Each split along census grooves, freeing narrow shadows that rushed outward in search of bodies. Reflected force traveled into the blackglass foundation, found incompatible supports, and curled upward through the empty light column. The crane bucked.

Pikk saw Venn fall toward the pit. He caught the tuner's coat with one hand. His right ear filled with a roar, then silence. The left still heard iron tearing.

Olli called the release below. Workers pulled foundation pins. The array folded inward one plate at a time, white faces striking one another until the central light vanished beneath a heap of cracked glass.

Every shadow in the galleries returned.

The service arm broke at its base.

Pikk and Venn swung against the crane housing. Pikk's shoulder struck iron. Venn's wounded leg hit the rail and he screamed. A safety chain held them above the pit until workers hauled them onto the platform.

Through his left ear, Pikk heard the western gate open.

Coalition evacuation crews entered. Armed units followed only to marked bridge lines. Jor Kelm's fighters secured the grain level but stopped when local signals lowered. Seven Camp guards escorted prisoners out. Saltwood cloth covered the mirror yard, preventing residual fragments from catching names.

Imperial resistance lasted another hour.

At the governor's lift, guild guards loyal to the contract fought labor crews seeking the control room. Seven people died before Vikka arrived with her firm seal and ordered the lift braked for property protection. The governor found himself stranded between levels with twelve officers. He surrendered to the Blind Well witnesses rather than to workers he had scheduled for removal.

Other garrison units accepted withdrawal through the north tunnel after leaving mirror weapons. Two squads refused and barricaded a payroll vault. Nobody assaulted it. Water crews shut off their cooling, and the squads emerged twenty minutes later carrying coin they had no safe route to spend.

Pikk sat on a furnace step while Sorai-trained medics examined his ear. Blood had dried along his neck. When the physician clicked metal beside the right side of his head, he heard pressure and no sound.

"Membrane torn," she said. "Deeper damage likely. It may recover partly."

"Do not promise a structure you cannot inspect."

"I promise swelling."

"That I believe."

Vikka found him there. Soot marked her expensive coat. "My west warehouse burned."

"Was anyone inside?"

"No."

"Then the ledger can mourn it."

She sat one step above him. "The governor claims you brought a foreign army into a guild dispute."

"The workers opened the gate under Compact signals."

"You supplied the crisis."

"The punishment order supplied itself?"

Her mouth tightened. "My firm remains under imperial contract until a lawful table releases it."

"The imperial governor no longer controls the table."

"Then a city court will review. I will not convert because you won."

Pikk looked at the workers carrying shattered mirror plates into a guarded evidence bay. "Good. Sudden virtue has poor tolerances."

The count took the rest of the day.

Forty-six people had died during lockout and uprising: twenty-nine workers and civilians, ten imperial soldiers, and seven guild guards. The earlier six arrest deaths were included among the twenty-nine, not added again. One hundred twelve people carried wounds requiring treatment; thirty-one would likely remain unable to return to furnace work. No dependent died in the slag camps. All 311 prisoners and forty confined children came out alive, though one prisoner's reflected-bolt wound remained critical.

Nine furnace banks survived. Two required week-long repair. The medical-glass kiln remained intact. Grain loss came to four percent, mostly from water used against the west warehouse fire. The mirror yard could never operate again.

In the labor chamber, fracture crews entered names into the first public register. Pikk's appeared first, followed by Olli, Venn, and every tuner who accepted. Families of the dead received speaking priority before military recruiters.

Karth Veil did not pledge as one people. Vikka's firm stayed under contested

contract. Three family guilds declared neutrality. Two contractor circles left with the disarmed imperial column. Eight labor councils joined the Compact, while four remained to govern furnaces and defend households.

Exactly 1,700 Rill sappers chose the march to Rusk. Their number included bridge crews, tunnelers, glass tuners, pump engineers, and 190 noncombatant furnace and medical workers. Three fracture choirs traveled with them. Each choir elected its caller and carried a copy of the method sealed to a labor register.

The count excluded 640 workers who had signed defense rosters for Karth Veil and excluded every household member who would travel only as family. Kessa entered those groups on separate boards. A sapper could leave the march at any Compact review without making a spouse or child forfeit food, and no recruiter could inflate military strength by folding furnace medics into the armed total. Pikk approved the separation. Structures failed when labels carried more load than their joints.

Pikk stood before them with cotton packed in his right ear. He heard their pledge unevenly, full on the left and as bone vibration on the damaged side.

"I do not own your work," he said. "The Compact does not own it. Refuse any target whose structure you have not inspected. Record every name a mirror touches. If I order a break without showing you where force returns, remove me."

Olli raised the registered fracture key. "And if there is no time?"

"Then choose, act, and submit to people who paid for the choice."

No cheer followed. Workers checked tool crates, reassigned furnace shifts, marked the dead, and packed three sets of tuned blackglass. The labor that made revolt possible continued after victory, less visible and more necessary.

When Pikk left Karth Veil, the city's surviving furnaces had begun breathing again. He heard their joined draft through one ear, and for the first time the fracture key sounded back from hands beyond his own.

Chapter 14 — Night Returns to Rusk

Ilyen measured the orchard by the moths dying above it.

They fell in three curved bands, each tracing heat lifted from a buried mirror line. The western arc lay beneath irrigation stones. A second followed the old pear terraces. The third closed against the river, where white pylons stood among willow roots. At the center, Rusk's observatory had been stripped of its bronze roof and fitted with a lens broad enough to cover the dome.

Beneath that geometry lived thirty-one thousand people who had not evacuated.

"Show me where to put the choirs," Pikk said.

He held his head slightly turned, keeping his left ear toward Ilyen. Cotton and wax sealed the damaged right ear. Behind him, fracture crews crouched in a dry drainage channel with tuned blackglass wrapped in wool. Their arrival from Karth Veil had cost the coalition a day the shortest-route faction still resented.

Ilyen set three blue pins on the field map. "Not at the hottest points. Those are reflections meant to draw force. Here, here, and under the river pylon."

Olli Tern studied the distances. "Third Choir cannot cross open ground before the other two begin."

"If First sounds early, the orchard mirrors turn west and expose a corridor."

"If First sounds early, First receives the return."

"Yes."

She waited for him to improve the answer. He could not.

Thirty-four days remained before total eclipse. Imperial extraction crews had begun cutting host names from Rusk's census into the central lens. At their present rate, the orchard Night would enter the empty Noctuary well before the next artificial sleep cycle. Once the binding closed, fracture here might injure every named host without reaching the captive darkness.

The coalition had one assault.

From the ridge, Ilyen could distinguish five forces and no unified army. Returning Tracks fighters held the west. Seven Camp guards protected refugee and medical corridors. Saltwood couriers carried covered moth boxes between command posts. Rill sappers prepared the anchor breaks. Rusk wardens and orchard families occupied hidden pruning trenches inside the city belt. Kessa ran supply boards from a river warehouse. Zarha held temporary field command for six hours, with Oth, Jor, and a Rusk councilor empowered to renew or stop it.

Besh Kor's road-charter companies waited on the Red Road east of the city. Kessa had sent empty grain carts north to suggest the main coalition approach. Besh had not taken the bait entirely, but two mirror regiments shifted away from

the western orchard.

A saltwood courier opened a small moth box. Five river-turn moths clung to dark bark. When Ilyen rotated the box, four moved toward Rusk. One folded its wings and remained still.

“Host corridor remains open,” he said. “Narrower than an hour ago.”

The courier, Senn, touched the mineral ink at her throat. “If we open the cloth, they die.”

“If we keep it closed, we learn nothing more.”

She looked toward the city. “Then we know enough.”

Ilyen closed the box. Expertise did not entitle him to spend her colony.

Zarha’s signal rose from the ridge: one blue cloth, one black. Advance with host protection.

First Choir entered the western arc.

Returning Tracks fighters moved ahead beneath layered shade cloth, not to hide from sunlight but to prevent mirrors from finding clean body outlines. Imperial bolts struck the cloth and returned as dark force along the ground. One replica impact broke a fighter’s ankle without tearing fabric. Another threw three bearers into a drainage cut.

The choir crawled between irrigation stones. Each worker carried one tuned vane and no weapon. Seven Camp guards formed a moving wall around them, blackglass chips fixed to wicker shields. When reflected force struck, the chips drank part of it and heated until shield rims smoked.

Ilyen descended from the ridge with Pikk. His role lay at the central observatory, where the astronomical error entered the binding. He wore no armor beyond a glass scale vest. Armor changed the body’s shadow, and today a familiar outline offered more danger than steel.

At the first orchard row, pear trees stood under permanent noon with leaves curled inward. Fruit had ripened on one side and remained green on the other. Families hid in root cellars beneath the rows. Chalk marks on trunks identified occupied shelters so coalition fighters would not use them as cover.

A woman lifted a hatch as Ilyen passed. “Will darkness come back?”

“We can open what holds it,” he said.

“That is not what I asked.”

“No. I do not know what it will choose.”

She closed the hatch without thanking him.

First Choir sounded.

The note traveled through irrigation water. White mirrors rotated beneath the soil, pulling west toward the apparent stress. Reflected bolts shifted with them. For twelve heartbeats the center lane cleared.

Third Choir ran for the river pylon.

Imperial troops emerged from pruning sheds. Their mirror shields caught coalition movement and cast shadow charges ahead of living bodies. The doubles carried a single intention: drive them from the orchard. They rushed cloth bearers, passed through spear gaps, and struck anyone moving east.

Pikk threw a blackglass bead across their path. Two doubles turned toward its false reflection. The others continued.

"They cannot revise," Ilyen said.

"They also cannot hear lectures," Pikk replied.

A double hit him before Ilyen could pull him aside. Pikk rolled against a tree, protecting his damaged ear. Ilyen drove his shoulder into the shadow's flank. Contact numbed his arm and filled his mouth with the taste of sleepless metal. The shape turned back toward the east as soon as his body ceased moving that way.

"Go north," he told Pikk.

They stepped sideways between rows. The double ignored them and continued west, faithful to an objective whose battlefield had changed.

Living imperial soldiers adjusted. A captain sent two squads north to close the host corridor. Rusk wardens rose from pruning trenches and caught them between low stone walls. Fighting compressed into spaces built for ladders and fruit carts. Spears had no room. People used pruning hooks, shield edges, and handfuls of mirror dust thrown into lenses.

Ilyen saw a warden cut an imperial throat, then drop her weapon to drag a wounded enemy away from a burning tree. No people owned the roles of invader or protector. Rusk itself included census clerks who had prepared the binding and orchard hosts who had hidden names. One family cellar sheltered two imperial deserters beside three children.

Second Choir reached the pear terraces late.

A reflected-force burst had overturned their blackglass sled. Four tuners lay wounded. One had lost both feet below the ankle. Olli tried to redistribute vanes, but the choir needed thirteen intervals and had nine people able to strike.

Ilyen knelt beside the wounded tuner. "Can you call your interval?"

The man's face had gone gray. "My hands work."

"Your blood does not."

"Then move the vanes close."

A field medic packed tourniquets above the injuries. They set three vanes across his chest. He sounded them with both hands while Olli carried the rest along the terrace. The sequence bent around one person who could no longer stand.

At the river, Third Choir's signal did not come.

The central lens began to brighten.

Every tree cast its shadow toward the observatory regardless of sun angle. Names cut into the glass took hold: birth names, field nicknames, terms spoken by lovers in dark rooms, nursery syllables, work calls. White-mirror census had grown beyond official records by harvesting relations from shade contact.

Rusk's Night rose unwillingly through the roots.

Ilyen felt it as pressure behind his eyes. Fungal beds emptied. Cellars warmed. Nocturnal beetles crawled into daylight and died. The river's dark under stones thinned until fish exposed themselves in clear water.

"Extraction has started," he said.

Pikk wiped blood from his mouth. "Third Choir must break the river anchor."

A red flare lifted beside the pylon: blocked.

Zarha's six-hour command reached its review point. Three witness flags rose. Oth renewed. Jor renewed. The Rusk councilor held his flag down while civilians remained trapped along the river.

Without renewal, field command could not send fighters into that district.

Pikk cursed softly. "We can reach it through the culvert."

"Not before transfer completes."

"Then we sound two anchors."

"The unbroken third sends return through the river hosts."

"How many?"

Ilyen looked at the census overlays. "Nine thousand, perhaps more."

Pikk lowered his wrench. He would not purchase success with a hidden load.

The Rusk councilor climbed onto the signal wall and shouted conditions to Zarha. Open civilian withdrawal along South Bank. No mirror attack until cellars emptied. Place Rusk wardens, not Akar fighters, at the pylon approach. Zarha accepted all three. Kessa shifted medical carts into the south lane. Seven Camp guards formed cloth corridors while imperial bolts cut holes through the upper layers.

People came out carrying children, old orchard ledgers, fungus cradles, cages of heat-sick bats, and jars of river mud. Host relation had a weight. It filled hands.

The councilor raised his flag.

Field command renewed.

Rusk wardens attacked the river pylon from below. Third Choir followed through the culvert, waist-deep in water that no longer held shade. Ilyen and Pikk crossed toward the observatory under the last intact cloth.

The central dome stood inside a circular plaza cleared of trees. Imperial extraction crews occupied the lens platform. Copper conduits ran from its rim to three orchard anchors and eastward into a mirror wagon pointed toward the

capital. The wagon did not carry Night. It carried alignment, a path along census relations to the empty well.

Pikk examined the foundation. "Fracture can break the lens."

"What returns?"

"Everything it currently holds."

Thirty-one thousand names pulled against the glass. A blind break could drive those relations into the bodies that carried them, burning dream and memory across the city.

Ilyen saw the astronomical correction engraved around the lens rim. Imperial designers had used the false public timing for civilian systems and the true timing for extraction. Eleven minutes of hidden sky had become a key.

"If we shift the lens to the public angle," he said, "the alignment loses the Noctuary path."

"Can gears move it?"

"Not against active binding."

Pikk understood. "Command."

A Night would resist direct command and take the operator's darkness-linked memory. Ilyen did not intend to order Rusk home. He needed to command the narrow darkness inside the lens, the captive interval between true and falsified eclipse positions. That interval belonged partly to the imprisoned Night, partly to astronomical error, partly to every shadow-name under strain.

The cost would choose from him according to relation, not preference. He thought of the first moth hatching already emptied of feeling. He thought of his last childhood comfort, which he had guarded without admitting the decision.

Between those memories lay his mother's night stories.

She had told them beside an unlit window in Leth Aven. He remembered factual pieces: a rain coast child who traded a lamp for directions from moths; a boastful census clerk fooled by people who exchanged names; a river that carried stars beneath a sealed city. He remembered Sava complaining when the endings changed. Warmth lived there still.

If the command took those stories, knowledge might remain. His mother's voice would cease to open their emotional door.

Imperial troops fired from the platform.

Pikk shoved Ilyen behind the dome base. A bolt struck his vest and broke three glass scales. Olli's Second Choir entered the plaza from the west, carrying the wounded tuner on a door. First Choir continued sounding beneath irrigation channels. A blue flare at the river announced Third in position.

Three anchors waited.

"I can give you eleven minutes," Ilyen said.

Pikk turned his good ear toward him. "What does that mean?"

"Sound on my mark. Whatever happens after belongs to Rusk."

"It already does."

Ilyen climbed the platform.

The extraction chief recognized his observatory coat and hesitated. "Master Vaor?"

"I signed the correction you are using."

"Then you understand we preserve regional darkness from rebel damage."

"I understand the subtraction in line forty-seven."

He reached the lens before the chief ordered fire. His palm struck hot glass.

Darkness opened beneath it, thinner than thread and crowded with names. He spoke no grand phrase. Command needed relation and intention, not theater.

"Move to the angle they were told."

The lens resisted. Every gear screamed. A place inside Ilyen reached for payment.

His mother sat beside the unlit window. Sava leaned against his shoulder. Rain touched the saltwood leaves outside. The story concerned a river. Or a clerk. Or moths.

Ilyen knew those facts after the warmth vanished.

He could still see his mother's mouth shaping words. He could not remember why he had once wanted the story to continue.

The lens moved eleven minutes across its ring.

"Now," he said.

Three fracture choirs sounded.

Blackglass notes crossed beneath orchard, terrace, and river. White anchor plates split along census grooves. The central lens released its eastward pull. Shadows flew outward from the observatory, not as soldiers but as ordinary absence returning to bodies, roots, stones, and water.

Imperial extraction crews fell. Some seized. Others crawled away. The chief tried to realign the lens by hand until a Rusk warden dragged him clear of a breaking gear.

For several breaths, nothing became dark.

The permanent sun remained overhead. Fires burned. White mirrors cracked. Ilyen kept his palm on cooling glass and felt no answer that could be translated into promise.

Then the river went black beneath its stones.

Shade entered the deepest roots first. Fungi along cellar walls opened silver

caps. Heat lifted from animal burrows. Orchard shadows stopped pointing toward the dome and settled beneath branches at honest angles. Every covered jar of river mud darkened from within.

Rusk's living Night gathered through relations extraction had failed to erase.

It did not obey Ilyen. It passed around him.

Darkness rose over the western orchard, dense with moth flight and wet-leaf smell. It crossed the pear terraces through host circles who opened their cloths one by one. Some names withdrew. Gaps remained around those households, and the Night did not force entry. At the river it divided around wounded soldiers, sheltering Rusk and imperial bodies alike where people offered water.

The noon sky above Rusk dimmed.

Not across the continent. Not even beyond the orchard belt. Local darkness formed beneath the sun as a covenant returning to the ground that knew it. Stars appeared inside it, first three, then hundreds, the sky Rusk's dead and living relations remembered.

Across the city, 31,000 citizens saw stars.

People shouted. Others hid. A boy screamed because he had never experienced dark and believed the world had closed. Orchard workers opened seed bins and wept when husks split. Nocturnal birds struck the air clumsily after years in covered aviaries. In the medical corridor, dreamless sleepers did not rise in miraculous unison. Some breathed more evenly. Most remained still.

Ren Tal woke while an attendant changed the fungal pad beneath his neck.

He did not announce a vision. He vomited broth, struck at the hands holding him, and asked why his mother had not come. Kessa knelt beside the pallet and told him about the causeway in plain sentences. Ren remembered Seven Camp's cistern, the shape of his father's coat, and how to add ration columns. He could not remember his mother's face or the last day evening arrived.

"How long?" he asked.

Kessa gave him the number of days asleep. He demanded a slate, then failed to write his own surname. The attendant marked him awake with partial memory loss and kept him on the dependent list. Around them, four other sleepers opened their eyes; two spoke, one screamed without recognition, and one stared at the stars until fever took him back into sleep. The remaining dreamless received the same care as before. Rusk Night offered conditions for rest, not a cure or message.

Ilyen looked upward and knew the constellations. Their names, coordinates, and seasonal errors remained exact. He remembered his mother teaching him the rain-coast star by story. The fact felt like a label on somebody else's instrument.

Pikk found him beside the broken lens. "What did it take?"

"My mother's night stories."

"All of them?"

"I know the plots." Ilyen watched moths cross the stars. "I cannot hear why her voice mattered."

No answer could repair that sentence.

Casualty boards filled under the returned dark. The coalition recorded 642 casualties from the assault: 184 dead and 458 wounded or otherwise removed from action. The dead included 71 Akar fighters, 39 Rusk wardens, 28 Rill sappers, 17 Seven Camp guards, 12 saltwood couriers and hosts, and 17 from other Compact crews. Wounded counts stayed separate from dead even when commanders wanted one loss figure.

Rusk civilians lost 63 dead and 190 treated wounded, outside the coalition 642. Imperial forces counted 211 dead, 376 wounded, and 804 captured or surrendered. Those numbers remained provisional until orchard cellars and river positions could be searched.

Third Choir lost four tuners at the pylon. First Choir had taken the strongest reflected return. Pikk ordered every cracked vane sealed for review rather than reused under celebration. Kessa opened grain stores under Rusk council custody. Zarha ended field authority instead of extending victory into rule.

Thirty-four days remained before the eclipse.

Night covered only Rusk, bounded by relation and consent. Beyond the orchard, permanent noon still burned the roads. Yet the proof stood around Ilyen in wet leaves, opened seed, frightened children, and stars no imperial table could distribute.

He remembered that his mother had loved one of those stars. He could no longer remember loving it with her.

Part III

Chapter 15 — The Moonless Road Through Veyran

Kessa drove a red stake beside the last casualty awning and told the cartmaster to stop calling everyone beneath it dead.

“Red means they cannot march,” she said. “It does not tell us why.”

The cartmaster, a broad Khar orchard hand with one cheek ridge split by an old pruning hook, looked toward the rows outside Rusk. White cloth covered the dead. Striped cloth shaded those whose wounds allowed transport. Beneath reed mats lay soldiers too fevered to move before noon. Farther down the riverbank, search parties returned with empty litters and lists of the missing.

Three days had passed since Night returned to Rusk. The coalition still had not agreed how many of its 642 casualties belonged in each column. Kessa had counted 217 dead, 301 wounded or burned badly enough to leave the advance, sixty-four missing, and sixty who could return to duty if given carts for two days. Every number carried a ration consequence. Every careless total stole food from someone breathing.

“Change the marker,” she said.

He pulled the red stake, painted four colors across its head, and drove it back into the hard bank.

Behind them, Rusk slept under darkness.

The sight had not become ordinary. Noon pressed white fire across the western road, yet the orchard city held a deep blue dusk beneath its boughs. People moved there by lamps. Children who had never seen stars refused to enter houses. Ilyen stood among them with both hands against an apple trunk, receiving thanks he could no longer connect to his mother’s stories. Kessa knew the fact of his payment. His face had taught her not to ask for its shape.

Rusk’s Night reached as far as the old boundary stones and stopped. It belonged to river silt, burial roots, moth nests, sleeping families, and hosts who had invited it home. It would not follow an army merely because the army had freed it.

Kessa approved of that refusal. It ruined her march calculations.

At the western boundary, wagons left cool shade and entered the unsettling glare one axle at a time. Wet cloth went over the dreamless. Saltwood screens covered the water carts. Mera Seln’s nonmilitary hosts tied witness knots at the road marker and promised Rusk’s people that no commander would claim their returned darkness as campaign property.

Kessa mounted her dun mare after the last medical cart crossed. The capital lay east, but the imperial road bent north through Veyran before turning toward Mirrorgate. Thirty-one days remained before the eclipse. Her grain ledger allowed

nine days at full issue, twelve at siege issue, or sixteen if civilians accepted the hunger ration that imperial quartermasters called efficient.

She had stopped using that word.

The first wagon failed before the road left Rusk's outer orchards. Its rear axle split beneath three wounded sappers, a shade loom, and two crates of blackglass forks. The driver shouted for everyone to stand clear as the wheel leaned. Six people ignored him and put their shoulders under the bed before it could roll into the drainage cut.

Kessa ordered the cargo divided. The wounded went into an empty grain cart. The forks moved to a mule litter with felt packed between every tooth. No officer volunteered to abandon the shade loom, though it weighed as much as a water barrel and could not win a battle. Mera's hosts had used it to weave the layered cloth that kept dreamless sleepers alive through noon. Kessa marked the loom essential and struck one commander's spare pavilion from the load instead.

"You cannot hold route council in the rain without it," he said.

"If rain comes, hold council wet."

The discarded pavilion became awnings for two medical carts. By the time the repaired wagon moved again, thirty companies had compressed behind it. Riders cursed the lost hour. Children woke under the awnings and asked whether the darkness at Rusk had vanished. Their parents turned them to look back.

A blue line still lay among the trees.

Kessa kept the column in four lanes where the ground allowed: mounted scouts, foot companies, supply wagons, and civilians with medical priority. Every road narrowed eventually. At bridges all four lanes became one argument. She assigned mixed crossing crews so no people could advance all its own fighters before another people's wounded. The rule angered everyone evenly, which did not prove justice but often prevented knives.

Water discipline demanded harsher choices. Adults on foot received three cups between watch changes. Wounded travelers received four. Dreamless sleepers received measured cloth-wetting in addition to mouth care, entered separately so no quartermaster could accuse them of drinking more than the living. Animals drank by load class. A court rider who watered his spare mount from a civilian barrel lost the mount to the medical train for seven days.

Ren wrote that penalty with visible satisfaction.

"You enjoy government too much," Kessa told him.

"I enjoy columns that add."

A cluster of Seven Camp elders had begun bringing him mistakes to correct. They did not ask whether he remembered their tents. They asked whether nine sacks divided among eleven cookfires could leave every fire with a morning portion. Arithmetic gave them a way to trust him without demanding the boy they

had lost.

At the final Rusk milestone, Kessa changed the deadline board herself. She wiped away the old count and wrote: ECLIPSE IN 31 days. The mixed lettering offended Ilyen's eye when he rode past.

"You have used an imperial numeral and a Veyran word," he said.

"Then everyone can dislike half of it."

He almost smiled. The expression faded when the cool orchard boundary left them and the glare found his empty moth inks.

Veyran began with a field of unopened flax.

The stalks stood gray and shoulder-high, each seed husk locked by years without a true cooling cycle. A farmer had cut pathways through them so his goats could graze the lower leaves. He waited across one path with six women, two old men, and pruning knives held like tools they had not yet decided to turn into weapons.

Kessa halted the first supply company forty paces away. Behind her came Khar court fighters under different tent colors, Selai couriers with dead moth cages tied at their shoulders, Rill sappers pushing blackglass wagons, and the long civilian tail from Seven Camp. An army could call such a line an alliance. A farmer watching it approach saw mouths.

"We need fodder," Kessa called. "We pay in salt, metal, or labor."

"You paid Rusk with a battle," the farmer answered. "Did the dead eat well?"

His common tongue carried the clipped vowels of northern Veyran. Imperial tax officers had taught many conquered provinces the same trade language, then mistaken comprehension for consent.

"Some of them were mine," Kessa said. "That does not make your grain mine."

He studied her plain baggage coat. "The white-road men said that before they measured our barns."

A boy beside him lifted an empty census basket. Its slats had been branded with the sunburst seal. Kessa dismounted, handed her reins to Ren Tal, and approached alone with her palms visible.

Ren had woken on the second night after Rusk's restoration. He remembered his name, the arithmetic his aunt taught him, and how to hitch a water mule. He did not remember his aunt's face or why Seven Camp songs made him sick. At seventeen, he had become Kessa's quickest ration clerk because figures asked nothing of his missing past.

"Show them the payment chest," she told him.

Ren opened it thirty paces from the farmers. Iron needles, lamp wicks, three bars of salt, hinge pins, and stamped coalition chits lay in divided trays. The chits promised repayment by any of the seven parties to the Blind Well Compact. Kessa

trusted the needles more.

The farmer approached far enough to see the contents. "Metal for food we cannot grow again."

"Then sell us none. Tell me what you need repaired."

His knife lowered by the width of one finger. Beyond the flax field, a stone channel ran dry toward three hamlets. Imperial mirror wagons had broken its shade sluices so no local dusk rite could collect beneath the running water. Without shade, algae choked the upper gates. Without water, the farmers had slaughtered breeding goats. The army had already emptied two district granaries while retreating to Mirrorgate.

Kessa looked down the road. Speed offered the coalition a chance to reach the fortress before its upper garrison closed every approach. Speed also left Veyran behind them without food, guides, or a reason not to sell their route to Besh Kor.

"How many people below the broken gate?" she asked.

"Eleven hundred and nine on the last tax count. Fewer now."

"Children?"

"Three hundred, if the fever did not take more."

She returned to the column and called the seven quarter representatives. None liked her proposal. The Akar Seven riders wanted to press forward while Rusk's victory still frightened the imperial line. A saltwood delegate warned that each hour in open glare killed more star-moth eggs. Pikk's sappers had carried glass through a labor revolt and a battle; their wheel teams needed rest. Mera asked only whether repair work would invite local shade rather than command it.

Zarha listened from the saddle, her injured right leg held a little too straight. "How long?"

"One day if we strip two cart braces for sluice pins. Two if the lower channel has cracked."

"We lose the road race."

"We have already lost it. The retreating garrison took the grain and knew where it was going."

Kessa spread the district map across a shield. Three imperial marks showed official depots. Ren placed stones over each, then crossed them out as Veyran farmers named the emptied sites. A narrow blue line followed the canal south and rejoined the capital road below Mirrorgate.

"The canal path can carry foot companies," Kessa said. "Not mirror wagons. These people know its crossings. Feed them now, repair the water, and we gain a route the fortress cannot watch from its road towers."

One court captain objected that civilians offered unreliable testimony under occupation. The farmer heard him.

“So do armies under flags,” he said.

Zarha’s broken tusklet showed when her mouth tightened. “He may witness that sentence at my review.”

The vote took twelve minutes. Five parties accepted the delay. Two recorded objections and supplied workers anyway, because the Compact required losing parties to honor a lawful route decision.

By afternoon, the coalition had become a repair crew.

Rill sappers lifted the cracked sluice housing with screw jacks. Veyran masons showed them where the old builders had set reed fiber between stones to survive winter contraction. Khar hosts stretched layered tent cloth above the first hundred paces of channel. Selai couriers climbed the dead pollard trees and tied pale screens between branches. Human baggage teams moved grain from army reserve into village ovens under double witness.

Kessa walked the issue line with Ren. They released eighteen sacks, four jars of rendered fat, and medicine for glare fever. Each hamlet appointed two counters. Nobody counted soldiers and civilians in the same column.

At the second oven, a woman refused a coalition chit and asked for the iron hinge from Kessa’s payment chest.

“My house still has a door,” she said. “A promise will not hang it.”

Ren traded the hinge and amended the ledger without being told. His hand stalled over the family-name space.

“I knew her,” he murmured, looking at the woman. “Before.”

The woman waited.

“No,” Ren said after a while. “I knew someone who tied her hair that way.”

Kessa did not offer comfort he had not requested. “Write what you know. Leave the rest open.”

He drew a line through the blank rather than filling it with a guess.

Near midnight by the coalition clocks, though the sky gave no sign of it, water entered the repaired channel. It carried mud first, then torn algae, then a clean brown rush that slapped against the new gate. The people of the lower hamlets placed clay bowls under the shaded banks. No Night came. Kessa had not expected one. Still, cooler air gathered under the layered cloth, and children lay down where water sounds softened the glare.

The farmers sold fodder after that. Not enough for the whole host, but enough to keep the medical teams moving. They also supplied fourteen guides who knew the canal path and the abandoned vineyard terraces below Mirrorgate.

At dawn by the brass watches, an Oth Aven courier landed hard beside Kessa’s command cart. Dead star-moths dusted his shoulder ink. He had ridden the northern road through two relay horses.

“Mirrorgate sealed its lower road doors yesterday,” he said. “White mirrors cover the outer walls. Besh Kor’s field army has passed east of the Veyran ridge. He may turn on us before we reach the fortress.”

Kessa took his report and changed the map. She moved the fortress marker across the capital road, set Besh’s token behind their left flank, then drew the canal route in charcoal.

Thirty-one days remained. Mirrorgate had closed the road to the capital, and the coalition would have to reach its walls by walking beside the water it had chosen to free.

Chapter 16 — The Army That Fought Twice

Zarha saw the second army before she saw the first.

Across the Veyran canal, shadows advanced over sun-whitened barley in disciplined ranks. No bodies stood above them. They slid around stones, climbed dry terrace walls without breaking formation, and carried long spear-shapes that darkened wherever their absent donors had once thrust in anger.

The living soldiers waited below the eastern ridge.

“Down,” Zarha ordered.

Her outriders flattened behind the canal bank. A shadow spear crossed the water without a splash and punched through the empty saddle of a scout who had dismounted quickly enough. Leather tore. The horse screamed and dragged its reins toward the fields.

Zarha counted six shadow cohorts on the terraces, perhaps twenty-four hundred shapes. Some had lost arms or heads in earlier fights and continued to march because a repeated intention did not require a whole body. Behind them, white mirror wagons came over the ridge. Khar soldiers walked chained in pairs beside each axle. Their reflections stretched through the mirror faces and joined the advancing darkness.

Besh Kor had brought donors into battle.

The canal path held the coalition’s left wing: Veyran guides, two Khar court companies, Rill fracture crews, and forty-seven supply wagons still moving south from the repaired sluice. Families from the nearest hamlet had sheltered under the canal cloth instead of evacuating. The children there could not outrun cavalry. Zarha had one bank, four bridges, and less than a minute before the shadows reached spear range.

“Red knots on every bridge,” she said. “Civilians and wagons south. Foot companies hold west bank. Riders do not cross.”

Akar Seven captains repeated the order in three Khar route dialects. Selai couriers lifted red streamers. The coalition line bent toward the water while the shadow ranks continued straight ahead, faithful to an intention given before Besh saw the defense change.

That gave Zarha eleven heartbeats.

She sent Pikk’s first fracture choir to the north bridge and ordered the other two to remain masked behind grain carts. Kessa’s wagon crews cut traces, turned teams, and pushed loads into the canal path. Mera Seln led unarmed hosts beneath the shade cloth, carrying bowls of dark water past terrified families. A local Night did not live there, but the forms of hospitality still made people move together.

The leading shadows reached the bank. They did not slow for water. Their feet entered the canal, thinned across its bright surface, and gathered again on the stones below.

“Now,” Zarha said.

Forty Khar spears struck downward. The points met no flesh, yet each impact carried resistance like wet hide over bone. A shadow climbed Zarha’s shaft, cold enough to numb both hands. Its shape showed a thick cheek ridge and an imperial route seal branded across one forearm. Somewhere behind the ridge, a living donor repeated the need to take this bank.

Zarha twisted, trapped the dark spear against the canal lip, and broke its point with her boot. Pain flashed through the donor’s shadow. The figure doubled over, then rose because the intention remained.

Across the field, someone screamed.

The donor had felt it.

“Do not waste strength killing shapes,” Zarha called. “Turn their purpose. Make them miss.”

Her fighters yielded three paces and opened gaps beside stone piles. Shadows charged through those gaps at the positions where defenders had stood. Some struck empty air until their spear motions completed. Others collided with the canal wall and folded against it, then resumed. They could repeat force. They could not understand retreat.

The living army crested the ridge once the doubles had fixed the coalition line. Besh’s road-charter banners rose among white sun disks. Khar orchard clans marched beside imperial human archers. Two contemplative Bearers carried no weapons; census collars linked them to the largest mirror wagon. Settled Khar families had sent these soldiers because imperial service guarded their irrigation roads from raiding courts. Zarha knew the argument. Her father had signed its smaller version and called survival clean because the betrayal happened elsewhere.

Besh rode ahead in lamellar armor lacquered pale gold. One side of his face carried witness scars from Akar Seven, where Zarha had defeated his challenge without erasing it. He raised a hooked staff.

The living archers released.

“Cloth!” Zarha shouted.

Layered shade screens lifted along the bank. Arrows punched through the first sheets and lost force in the folds. Others fell among the supply teams. A mule dropped. A Veyran guide spun down with a shaft through his upper arm, alive and furious. Kessa’s crews dragged him behind a cart without stopping the southward movement.

Besh signaled again. His soldiers advanced to reinforce their own doubles.

Changing orders broke the attack's neatness. The shadows continued driving at the old line while donors angled north toward the bridge. Doubles crossed through living ranks, causing bound soldiers to stagger whenever cold edges passed their bodies. A shadow officer cut left. His donor went right. Both tried to occupy the same narrow terrace and fouled the cohort behind them.

Zarha pointed with her spear. "First choir, expose the join."

Rill workers pulled black felt from a waist-high glass frame. The blackglass held no reflection, only depth. Six sappers struck tuning bars against its rim in a rhythm Pikk had taught them after Karth Veil. The frame drank the nearest white gleam. Thin lines appeared between eleven shadows and the mirror wagon above the ridge.

Imperial archers turned toward the choir.

Zarha crossed the north bridge with thirty riders on foot. She had forbidden a mounted charge because horses could not distinguish shadow ground from solid bodies. Her fighters climbed the terrace behind shields and hit the archer flank before the second volley.

A living Khar soldier met her at the top. His cheek ridges had been polished with orchard oil. A small copper plate at his throat named the Kor Lower Groves, a settled district whose delegates had refused Akar Seven's alliance.

"You brought raiders to our road," he said.

"You brought our stolen sleep."

Their spears met. He drove low, not at her chest but at the right thigh injured on Glass Causeway. Besh had briefed his soldiers well. Zarha turned enough to save the artery. The point split scar tissue and traveled along the old wound.

Heat filled her leg. She hooked his shaft under her broken tusklet's side, shoved it wide, and struck his helmet with the butt of her spear. He dropped to one knee. Killing him would have been easy.

Instead she kicked his weapon into the canal and moved past.

Blood ran into her boot. Every step loosened the scar further. She tied a witness cord above the cut while walking and told the nearest captain to record that she remained mobile, not uninjured.

The first fracture choir sounded its key.

Blackglass gave a low crack. Eleven binding lines snapped at once. The shadows collapsed into stains that rushed back across the field. Donors fell where they stood. Several began convulsing. One clawed at his eyes and cried that he could no longer see his daughter in sleep.

The coalition fighters heard him.

A court captain named Orra Venn came to Zarha with blood on both tusklets. "The donors anchor the force. We can end this by killing them before the mirrors turn."

"How many?"

"Nine cohorts below the ridge. Bound in files. They cannot defend themselves while the doubles hold intention."

"They are soldiers."

"They came to kill us."

"Yes." Zarha looked at the chained Bearers beside the master wagon, then at orchard troops fighting to protect its wheels. Some donors had volunteered. Some had accepted service for road safety or wages. Others wore census collars too tight to permit consent. Killing the files would collapse the doubles and teach every Khar polity that the free courts answered collaboration with extermination.

Orra followed her gaze. "If we wait, their shadows kill our children."

"Then we sever faster."

"That spends sappers."

"It spends fighters who entered the field with tools in their hands. We do not purchase speed with chained throats."

Orra's eyes flashed silver in the glare. "Your office cannot shelter both sides of a spear."

"No. It can judge which point we break first." Zarha pulled the red witness cord from her thigh knot and gave half to Orra. "Record your objection. If this command fails, bring it against me before the open tents."

The captain tied the cord to her wrist. "I intend to."

That answer steadied Zarha more than obedience would have.

She ordered all three fracture choirs forward.

Pikk's workers needed the white wagons within two hundred paces. Reaching that range required opening the west bank while shadows still crowded the canal. Zarha changed the route markers from red to black. Kessa's last supply carts cleared south. Mera moved the civilians into a drainage tunnel beneath the fields. Coalition foot companies withdrew from the central bridge and left it apparently open.

The shadows took the invitation. They surged across in a dense column, following the last command to seize the bank. Zarha's defenders retreated along two marked lanes. When the doubles reached the abandoned grain carts, Rill sappers released the wheel blocks.

Eight loaded carts rolled downhill.

The shadows could not be crushed, but they could be displaced. Wheels passed through their upper bodies while iron-rimmed hubs dragged their spear intentions sideways. The column twisted. Some figures struck the carts forever. Others spilled into the dry flax ditch and continued attacking the road beneath them.

"Choirs advance," Zarha ordered.

Blackglass teams ran between the trapped ranks carrying frames on shoulder poles. Imperial archers shot three workers before coalition shields covered them. One frame fell and cracked at its lower corner. Its crew lifted it anyway. A fracture key did not require perfect glass. It required a controlled flaw and workers willing to sound it together.

Besh recognized the maneuver. He left the ridge with his household riders and drove toward the second choir.

Zarha intercepted him beside a broken terrace wall. Her injured leg nearly failed when she planted it. She shifted weight to the other side and caught his hooked staff against her spear.

"You would save soldiers who sold us," he said.

"I would free donors you made into ammunition."

"They asked for service. The free courts burned their storehouses three winters running."

"Some asked. The collars did not."

Besh shoved her shaft down and struck her shoulder with the hook. "You will leave when the capital calls you onward. We remain beside the roads you taught everyone to raid."

His grievance carried names Zarha did not know. That did not cleanse what moved across the canal.

She let his next blow slide past, stepped inside its arc, and drove her forehead into his mouth. One of his tuskets broke. He reeled. Zarha struck his sword hand. The blade fell, but his household closed around him before she could take him for witness.

Besh mounted behind another rider. Blood covered his chin and right hand. He looked once toward the donor files, where imperial handlers had begun cutting collar chains to hurry retreat.

"Your mercy kills slowly," he called.

"Your protection learned to march without judgment."

His riders carried him east.

The three choirs reached their positions.

Each blackglass frame faced a different wagon. Workers sounded the first note low enough that Zarha felt it through her wounded leg. White mirrors brightened in answer. Every shadow on the canal field turned toward its donor, stretching thin between command and body.

The second note opened the flaws Pikk's guild had hidden in imperial geometry. Jagged dark veins spread across the frames. Sappers coughed glass dust into their masks. One collapsed and kept striking his bar from the ground.

At the third note, the bindings severed.

All 2,300 doubles lost their imposed shape.

Darkness did not vanish. It crossed the battlefield in a low rush, passed through armor and cloth, and returned to the people whose intentions had fed it. Some donors woke from standing trances and screamed. Others simply sat down. Many stared at the glare with no expression, unable to find the dream in which they had first chosen service.

Four hundred eighteen donors died during severance. The dead included volunteers, conscripts, orchard guards, two imperial handlers, and nine coalition prisoners whose names had remained in captured census rolls. Zarha would not learn those distinctions until the field count. In the moment she saw bodies fall in chained rows and understood what her refusal had cost.

It had cost less than killing them all. That truth offered no comfort.

Without doubles, Besh's living companies retreated toward Mirrorgate. Coalition riders pursued only to the eastern ridge. Zarha stopped them there. A broken army on a known road could still turn and fight; a reckless pursuit would abandon the donors and the Veyran civilians they had just defended.

By the next watch, casualty clerks had laid five ledgers across an upturned cart. They counted coalition dead separately from wounded. They counted imperial dead in battle separately from the 418 donor deaths. Surviving donors formed three groups: conscious and mobile, conscious but unable to walk, and unresponsive. Prisoners who had fought under road-charter received different marks from collared conscripts. Nobody wrote freed shadow doubles under dead, because the doubles had never lived as separate souls.

The arguments began before the ink dried. An Akar rider demanded that every conscious road-charter soldier surrender his route seal. An orchard lieutenant refused, saying the seal protected his family from imperial requisition even if he became a prisoner. A human archer claimed conscription while a census clerk produced a wage roll bearing his mark. Two collared Khar insisted they had volunteered before officers closed the collars and wanted that choice recorded alongside the coercion that followed.

Zarha made the clerks add columns instead of forcing one answer. Initial consent. Present restraint. Pay received. Family threatened. Combat witnessed. Dream injury reported. The new ledger angered those who wanted collaborators placed in one clean category. It also angered officers who preferred every bound soldier called a victim. Zarha accepted both angers. Judgment without distinctions merely changed which authority got to lie.

One surviving donor asked to speak with her. His name, Leth Korren, came from the Lower Groves. He had lost three fingers to a free-court raid seven years earlier and joined Besh's force after the imperial road patrols stopped a second raid. The severance had left him unable to remember any dream containing his dead husband. He knew the man's name, the orchard they had leased, and the winter they married. Sleep now gave him rooms with a person-shaped absence.

"Will your court return that?" he asked.

"No."

"Then what did you free?"

Zarha looked toward the field where his double had fought after he could no longer alter its purpose. "Your next intention."

Leth spat beside her boot. "I intended to keep my road safe."

"You may still intend it. You will have to choose how without a mirror choosing the method for you."

His laugh hurt more than an insult. "That sounds clean from the winning bank."

She gave him the red cord that marked her contested command. "Bring that sentence to Akar Seven if you survive the prison road. Or give it to someone who will."

Leth took the cord. He did not thank her.

At the medical line, Mera's hosts built separate shade bays for dream injury and bodily wounds. A donor with an unbroken body could still wake biting through his tongue. Another might walk, speak, and never dream again. The healers used no single color for them. They tied gray for uncertain memory, blue for fever, green for voluntary testimony, and white only when breath had ended.

Coalition fighters watched that work from across the canal. Some had lost friends to shadow spears and resented water spent on donors. Others had kin among Besh's orchard companies. Zarha ordered every company to provide one guard and one water carrier to the donor bays, pairing nobody with prisoners from the same district. Shared labor could not settle the dispute, but it stopped resentment from becoming an unattended knife.

Kessa arrived with the civilian damage account. Twenty-three Veyran people had suffered wounds during the attack; four had died, including the guide shot at the first volley. Seven Camp's supply line had lost nine animals, two medicine carts, and one week of lamp oil when a jar wagon overturned. The canal itself remained open. Farmers wanted compensation in iron, not coalition promises.

"Give them the spare cavalry shoes and six tool chests," Zarha said.

"The cavalry will object."

"Record it."

"I already did."

Orra Venn stood beside Zarha while a healer stitched the reopened thigh. "The choirs lost nineteen workers dead and forty-one wounded."

"I will carry that count."

"You will answer for it."

"Yes."

Orra tied the other half of the red cord around the casualty ledger. "Then my company accepts your road authority through Mirrorgate."

Not loyalty. Not forgiveness. Authority with a destination and a review attached.

Around them, Khar soldiers from opposing courts carried bound orchard troops to the same treatment awnings. Rill workers covered fractured frames. Veyran families came out of the drainage tunnel and found spear holes in their shade cloth, trampled flax, and water still running through the repaired canal.

Zarha rose when the stitches ended. Her right leg shook, but it held. She ordered payment for field damage, burial shade for every named dead, and witness space for surviving donors who chose to speak against either army.

Then she turned the coalition toward Mirrorgate under a command strengthened by the right of others to challenge it.

Chapter 17 — The Siege of Mirrorgate

Pikk measured the returning bolt by the hole it punched behind him.

The coalition ballista had fired uphill at Mirrorgate's lower wall. Its iron shaft struck a white panel between two towers, vanished into brightness, and returned as a black force along a different angle. No iron came back. The impact still tore through three layers of earth-filled wicker and buried itself in the trench floor where Pikk's left foot had stood.

"Four degrees south," he said.

His assistant Rell cupped one hand around his good ear. Since Karth Veil, voices on Pikk's right reached him as pressure without words. He turned his left side toward the trench.

"South from the panel normal?" Rell asked.

"South from us. The wall distributes force through the upper conduit before it returns. Mark the delay."

Rell checked the water clock. "Two beats."

Above them, Mirrorgate covered the pass from cliff to cliff. The lower fortress had three road doors faced in bronze, six white-mirror towers, and a sloped killing field stripped of every tree. Beyond it rose the upper city, where tiled houses climbed around cisterns and military courts. A second wall separated those houses from the lower works. Laundry hung between the roofs. Civilians had not been evacuated.

That fact changed every useful equation.

Pikk crawled to the observation slit and watched defenders reset the struck panel. Laborers in gray imperial tunics turned capstans behind the parapet. Each rotation shifted buried silver conduits beneath the city. Mirrorgate did not merely reflect a missile at its source. It stored the act of impact, routed that force through its walls, and released a shadow of the blow wherever its white geometry found an exposed line.

A siege engine attacking one tower might kill a family in a cellar two streets away if the conduit cracked beneath them.

"Tell the batteries to stop," he said.

A Khar captain crouched nearby. "They have fired once."

"That taught the wall enough about our range."

"We need the lower doors open before Besh regroups."

"Then find me a method that does not return our own attack through the civilians."

The captain's cheek ridges lowered. "You are the method."

Pikk disliked accurate insults.

He left the forward trench through a tunnel roofed with wagon doors. Coalition sappers had advanced seventy paces during the first night by the clocks, though permanent noon denied the work any darkness. Shade cloth covered the spoil heaps. Water carriers wet the tunnel skins every half hour. Even so, glass dust from the walls coated tongues and made workers cough black into their masks.

At the rear gallery, Pikk found Vikka Rill waiting beside a drainage map.

The gallery had begun as an irrigation culvert. Two hundred workers had widened it by shifts, bracing the roof with orchard trunks hauled from Rusk. Every brace bore three chalk marks: the crew that cut it, the crew that set it, and the inspector who accepted the load. Imperial tunnels named only the master engineer. Karth Veil workers had stopped building anonymous obedience.

Pikk checked the shift slate before he looked at Vikka's map. Nine workers had exceeded the glass-dust exposure limit during the approach. Their foreman wanted to keep four on duty because they alone knew the conduit drill. Pikk struck their names from the active list and assigned them to teach replacements aboveground through clay models.

"We lose half a watch," the foreman said.

"We keep four lungs."

"You are sending your own lung toward the wall."

"That does not make yours available."

The foreman accepted the ruling badly, which meant the safety council still functioned. Pikk signed the slate with his strike name and added his expected exposure beside it. Public risk did not make a bad choice safe. It kept a clever engineer from pretending only other bodies had paid for his design.

His cousin still wore the blue cuff of a guild owner. She had not joined the 1,700 workers who left Karth Veil after the uprising. She had come to Mirrorgate under a neutrality writ, officially to inspect imperial worker safety. Two hired guards stood behind her with their hands away from their knives.

"You broke a load panel with a ballista," she said.

"I asked whether it returned force."

"Your father used to ask whether furnaces were hot by touching them."

"He had fewer instruments."

Vikka placed one finger on the map. "The upper conduit carries drinking water beside the reflection channel. Break it at the west tower and you flood three cellar streets with boiling silver wash."

"Why tell me?"

"Because guild glass lies under those streets. If civilians die from it, every surviving worker in my contracts gets called butcher."

"You could join the siege and choose where the glass breaks."

"I could also decline to make your revolt respectable."

Her neutrality had begun to sound less comfortable. Pikk accepted that as movement, not allegiance.

He studied the map. Three main conduits joined below the lower gate. Imperial designers had buried white channels around a central blackglass regulator. The regulator absorbed excess return force so the wall would not fracture itself. Pikk had built smaller versions at Deren Ford. This one lacked the hidden fracture key his later designs carried.

"Can the lower regulator be removed whole?" he asked.

Vikka stared at him. "If you reach it without breaking the west conduit."

"I asked can."

"Eight bolts hold the cradle. Two will have fused. The piece weighs four hundredweight."

"Portable with a sled."

"For a generous meaning of portable."

Pikk marked the regulator in charcoal. Blackglass that size could expose how the Noctuary indexed larger bindings. Breaking it now might open Mirrorgate faster. Carrying it onward could save thousands at the capital. A tool could refuse one owner only once if the refusal destroyed it.

He drew circles around the east and center mirror towers instead.

Before approving those targets, he called in the three people who knew the upper city without military maps. Lera Veyn had cleaned officers' houses until her son vanished into a census crew. Old Tamm kept the storm drains and could name which grates children used to cross districts. A Mirrorgate midwife named Jes had come out in a laundry cart carrying thirty-seven household addresses sewn into her sleeve.

Pikk laid transparent glass sheets over the drainage plan. "We break here and here. Which cellars receive the first force?"

Tamm moved his finger away from the official conduit line. "The city map lies. West channel cracked twelve years ago. Guild repaired it through Candle Lane because the commandant would not close the road."

Vikka's jaw tightened. Her firm had signed the old repair.

Jes marked three courtyards where civilians could gather beyond the altered return angles. Lera chose a warning phrase that soldiers would mistake for laundry instructions: blue sheets for leave now, yellow for remain below, bare rope for a route already blocked. Selai couriers memorized the addresses. Khar smugglers carried the colors through drains. Nobody promised complete evacuation. A warning could reduce harm without pretending control over every household.

Pikk added Candle Lane to the forbidden break zone. The available geometry narrowed to two panels and one release path through the sap line.

The first assault began beneath six hundred shields.

Sappers pushed mantlets uphill while archers fired smoke pots over them. The pots did not strike the white panels. They burst against stone, spreading thick flax smoke across the defenders' sight lines. Mirrorgate returned the impacts anyway. Black bursts hit the approach behind the mantlets and flung earth over the reserve companies.

Pikk walked in the second sap line carrying a tuning fork longer than his arm. His hearing loss made the instrument safer in one way and more dangerous in another. He felt stress through his palms, knees, and teeth, but he could not hear the high warning note from a crack approaching on his right.

Rell stayed at that shoulder.

"Pitch rising," she said.

"How far?"

"Three fingers above test note."

"Good. The east tower carries more load."

A returned arrow force struck the mantlet ahead. Wood remained whole while the two workers behind it fell, ribs crushed by an impact with no visible shaft. Their crew dragged them into a side cut. One breathed. The other did not.

Pikk marked one dead and one wounded on the slate tied to his belt. Engineers who counted only breaches eventually built with bodies because bodies looked free.

At sixty paces, the sappers dropped their mantlets and drove hollow iron rods into the slope. Each rod carried a blackglass tooth. They were not explosives. They offered the wall small, harmless places to discharge stored force.

White light flashed above. The rods jumped. Shadow blows hammered the empty ground between them.

"Again," Pikk ordered.

Workers reset the teeth at new angles. Every false target taught Pikk which buried conduit answered which panel. The east tower fed center. The center tower fed the lower road. The west tower fed the civilian cistern line Vikka had warned him about.

Imperial soldiers rolled stones from the parapet. No reflection craft improved gravity. Coalition shields locked. Three stones bounced aside; a fourth broke a worker's leg. The line kept moving.

At the base of the east tower, Pikk's crew dug into the joint between foundation courses. Mortar there contained powdered whiteglass and census ash. It tightened whenever named attackers pressed against it. The empire had entered captured

labor rolls into the wall.

Rell's chisel stuck as the joint narrowed around it.

"Whose name?" Pikk asked.

She pulled her mask down. "Rell Venn Rill, furnace register eight."

"Use your strike name."

"My what?"

"The name you took at Karth Veil when the guild register burned."

Rell understood. She placed both hands on the chisel. "Rell Without Owner."

The mortar loosened.

Workers around her spoke names chosen on the strike floor, family names the guild had refused to record, and nicknames earned in tunnels. The wall's census binding reached for ownership records and found people who had changed relation to them. Stone did not open willingly, but it stopped tightening fast enough to let the chisels work.

Pikk smiled into his mask. A tool could learn refusal from labor.

They inserted the first fracture fork below the east panel. Across the field, the center team reached its joint. Two colored flags rose from the rear trench: civilian warning complete. Veyran guides and upper-city smugglers had carried messages through drainage culverts. Families below the target conduits had moved into marked courtyards. Not everyone trusted the warning. Not everyone could move. The chosen break still carried risk.

A Khar officer signaled immediate fracture.

Pikk signaled wait.

The upper garrison had begun driving civilians back toward the lower cellars to discourage attack. From the observation lane he saw gray-clad people pressed down a stair by spear hafts. Vikka saw them too. Her neutrality guards looked away.

"If they enter the east cellars, we lose the target," Rell said.

"We change the return path."

"The forks sit already."

"Then we teach them another note."

Pikk crawled between the east and center teams under arrow cover. He rotated six blackglass teeth by hand and reversed two tuning bars. The new geometry would send the first fracture upward through the empty parapet rather than down through cellar foundations. It also placed the sap line inside the release cone.

"Clear every worker after the second note," he ordered. "I stay to sound the third."

Rell refused. "Your right ear cannot hear the split warning."

"You can shout it from the trench."

"You cannot hear me from your right."

"Stand left."

She called him three furnace names that would have violated any guild safety report. Then she withdrew with the others.

The east and center forks sounded together.

Their first note entered stone as a tremor. White panels brightened across both towers. Imperial soldiers stopped pushing civilians and ran from the parapets.

A second strike opened black seams around the mirror frames. Stored force poured into the altered teeth. The sap line bucked. Pikk's damaged hearing disappeared beneath pressure, leaving only his pulse and the vibration of the long bar in his hands.

Rell waved from his left. The split warning had begun.

Pikk struck the third note.

Two mirrors broke.

The east panel folded inward without shattering, its white surface turned suddenly dull. The center panel burst outward in plates. Their stored shadow force took the path Pikk had made and climbed through the parapets. Stone battlements lifted, twisted, and fell into the empty killing ground behind the towers.

The release cone struck the sap line too.

Pikk felt a hot fist under his ribs. He landed against the foundation. His mask tore. Fine glass crossed the air like shining flour, beautiful for one stupid instant before he breathed it.

Rell dragged him behind a shield. "Do not cough."

He coughed.

Blood speckled the inside of his mask. Each breath made a wet ticking low on the left side of his chest. A healer pressed waxed cloth over his mouth and told him to breathe shallowly.

"Left lung," Pikk managed.

"I know where lungs are."

"The splinters move if you carry me flat."

The healer swore and propped him sitting against a gabion.

She cut his coat from collar to waist and listened against his back. Pikk could tell from her pauses which sounds troubled her. One splinter had entered between ribs. Smaller glass sat deeper, moving with every shortened breath. Removing it in the trench would open the lung. Leaving it risked bleeding when he climbed or shouted.

"You stop work now," she said.

Pikk wrote on his slate because speech made him cough: CAN ADVISE SITTING.

"You stop deciding what your body permits."

Rell knelt on his good side. "Safety council rule seventeen. An injured designer loses sole authority over continuation when blood enters the airway."

He had written that rule after a furnace master hid a cough for three days. He considered arguing that a siege differed from a furnace. The excuse sounded exactly like ownership.

Pikk surrendered the tuning bar. Rell took field authority. The healer allowed him chalk, the map, and six words per instruction. Every seventh word cost him a tap on the wrist. It felt absurd. It kept his breathing shallow enough to remain conscious.

News of his injury moved through the crews without becoming an order to hurry. They slowed the cradle lift, doubled the sling inspection, and assigned replacement counters. A heroic rush would have honored him by producing more patients. Their refusal pleased him more than he could say within six words.

Through the broken east tower, coalition soldiers entered the lower works. They did not have an open gate yet. Imperial defenders dropped portcullises and fought room by room along the winch corridors. Khar shields took the front while Rill crews followed to lock every return conduit they crossed. Selai couriers carried evacuation flags into the cellars.

The first winch room changed hands three times. Imperial soldiers held its stairs while coalition sappers tried to reach the brake drum. Each sword strike against the iron rail fed a small wall panel, which returned the force at ankle height from the opposite side. Fighters fell with uncut legs and shattered bones. Zarha's captain ordered weapons sheathed in the lower corridor. Shields pushed. Hands grappled. Rill workers poured sand over the panel until it could no longer see clean movement to copy.

At the second portcullis, defenders opened a cistern valve. Water rushed down the steps, silvered by whiteglass dust. It burned skin wherever light struck it. Kessa's medical teams pulled back while Pikk, watching through the breach, scratched a drainage instruction on his slate. Rell relayed it to workers who broke a waste grate rather than damming the flood. The burning water turned into an empty stable channel and spared the cellar court below.

Blue sheets appeared from two upper windows. Yellow cloth followed across Candle Lane. A bare rope hung near the west stair, confirming soldiers had blocked that route. Coalition officers wanted to press through before defenders reorganized. Pikk made them wait until Jes's address list accounted for the east-cellar families. Seven households remained missing. Their uncertainty entered the assault record rather than disappearing under the word cleared.

Pikk refused the sleep draught. He watched the lower-gate regulator on Vikka's map and directed the cradle crew with chalk signs when speech shortened his

breath.

Four bolts turned. Two snapped. One fused bolt required a hand saw. The eighth had been installed backward by a worker who either made a mistake or left a future act of sabotage. The cradle opened.

Blackglass emerged on a timber sled, a dark slab taller than Pikk and veined by forty years of absorbed force. He laid one scarred palm against it. The regulator held indexing marks cut too small for ordinary wall maintenance. Twelve families of lines crossed its back, each leading inward toward a common blank center.

Noctuary work.

“Keep this one,” he said.

Vikka stood above him in the breached tower. Dust covered her guild cuff. One of her neutrality guards carried a child from the east cellars; the other had disappeared.

“The upper city garrison has sealed the second wall,” she said. “They are distributing water by military household.”

“Neutral report?”

“For now.” She looked at the dead sapper beside the foundation and at civilians filing through the marked courtyard. “My crews will shut the west conduit. No banner.”

Pikk nodded. Neutrality had developed hands.

At the road doors, coalition workers cut the final chain. The bronze leaves opened toward them a span wide, jammed on bodies and fallen gears, then yielded when thirty people pushed together. Kessa’s medical teams entered before cavalry. Zarha’s officers marked civilian corridors in blue. The coalition held the lower gate and two towers.

Above, Mirrorgate’s upper city remained behind white walls.

Pikk sat on the blackglass sled because walking cost too much air. Two mirrors lay broken. The third rested beneath him, saved not from destruction but for a more difficult refusal below the capital. When the sled began to move through the lower gate, every breath clicked around glass in his left lung, measuring the price of the road still closed above them.

Chapter 18 — Caldra Ves and the Clean War

Caldra placed the victory report beside the hospital rail manifest and asked which document had learned to lie.

The war secretary did not answer. He stood at the end of the long solar table with three generals and the Minister of Civic Continuance, all wearing white court coats without dust. Behind them, noon burned through mirrored shutters and laid narrow bars across the map of Mirrorgate.

The report claimed Besh Kor had completed an orderly withdrawal after destroying the coalition's forward strength. It described donor losses as negligible. The rail manifest requested transport for 1,086 dream-impaired soldiers, 312 surgical casualties, and 418 bodies requiring sealed burial because their shade bindings had ruptured.

"Perhaps the hospital multiplied them," Caldra said.

General Ared looked down. "The field summary preceded the medical reconciliation."

"Bodies arrived before your reconciliation."

"Majesty, Commander Kor preserved the road army. His maneuver delayed the enemy long enough for Mirrorgate to secure its upper defenses."

Caldra moved a black stone from the Veyran canal to the fortress. "The lower gate?"

"Contested."

The rail manifest called it lost.

She turned to the page reporting the shadow host. Of the first 9,400 activated soldiers, 2,300 doubles had been severed in one engagement. The sentence written for public release said enemy sabotage briefly interrupted auxiliary support. The language displayed remarkable calm for an institution watching nearly a quarter of its new army collapse.

"Who approved 'briefly'?" she asked.

The minister raised one hand. "The interruption need not affect the eclipse force. Replacement donors remain available."

"How many replacements can survive severance?"

Silence answered with greater accuracy than the report.

Caldra closed the folder. "Take me to Ward Nine."

The war secretary began explaining that the wards had not been prepared for an imperial visit. She walked past him before he finished. Preparation improved carpets and corrupted testimony.

Ward Nine occupied the old mint beneath the eastern palace hill. During the

Night Plague, coins had carried spores between provinces and the mint furnaces had become sterilization pits. Caldra remembered smoke over that roof from when she was thirteen. Her brothers had coughed in adjacent rooms while local lords kept private darkrooms sealed for their own households. Safe darkness had existed. Authority had failed to distribute it.

Now iron cots covered the coin floor in rows of fifty. Dreamless veterans lay beneath thin shade sheets. Some stared upward without blinking. Others slept in violent intervals and woke calling commands their doubles had carried. Nurses wore padded mouth guards on their wrists so they could keep convulsing patients from biting through their tongues.

The ward superintendent bowed too deeply. Caldra stopped her.

"Give me the count before the courtesy."

"Eight hundred seventy-four admitted here, Majesty. Two hundred twelve transferred to family houses. Forty-one died after arrival. We have one hundred nine without names because collar numbers burned away during severance."

"Separate the dead from transfers in every report."

"We do. The ministry combines them as resolved beds."

Caldra looked back at the Minister of Civic Continuance. "It will stop."

"Yes, Majesty."

A patient in the nearest row began striking his fist against his chest. His body showed no battlefield wound. The nurse caught his wrist and counted slowly until the motion eased.

"What repeats?" Caldra asked.

"His double received an order to hold a canal bank," the nurse said. "He wakes when he feels himself retreating. We have moved his cot against the wall so sleep gives him one secured side."

The man's collar record identified him as Pel Tarn, a human road conscript from the western grain districts. He had signed for six years of pay to clear his family's tax debt. Caldra knew the system's defense: no citizen had been forced to sign. She also knew what happened to a family whose arrears blocked water allotments.

"Can he dream?"

"Only the canal attack. If that qualifies."

It did not. A repeated intention lacked the relation, surprise, and disobedience of a dream. Shadow force had carried the last command out of him until sleep could no longer make another shape.

Farther down the ward, a Khar veteran sat upright weaving witness cord from torn bedding. Her cheek ridges bore the shallow cuts of an imperial orchard clan. She did not bow when Caldra approached.

"Name?" Caldra asked.

"Esh Var, Lower Groves. I had one yesterday."

"You have one now."

"I meant a shadow name. The census took it into the mirror. The blackglass sent back an empty place."

Esh held up the cord. Every knot ended unfinished.

"Did you volunteer for binding?" Caldra asked.

"For road service. The officer said the shadow kept fighting if I tired."

"Did he explain rebound?"

"He said dreams grow back."

Caldra turned to the ward superintendent. "Do they?"

"No, Majesty."

The answer struck an old place. During the Plague, physicians had promised her mother that darkness fever left no lasting marks after the skin cleared. Caldra still woke some nights with her brothers' final coughing erased by a white roar. She had built ministries because promises without institutions had killed them. Yet institutions had learned to lie in complete sentences.

Esh watched her. "Will you stop making them?"

The truthful answer required more than compassion beside a cot. Without shadow troops, the capital faced a coalition that had broken imperial roads, freed a captive Night, and armed regional courts against central law. Local darkness could shelter children. It could also be hoarded. Caldra had seen both.

"I will stop officers from hiding the cost," she said.

"That is not what I asked."

"No."

Esh pulled the unfinished knot tight until cloth cut her fingers.

In the south aisle, veterans with no violent symptoms sorted buttons by color. One had arranged black buttons into a perfect circle and refused to let anyone enter it. Another had forgotten every face seen under moonlight while preserving names and dates. A Selai artillery observer remembered star charts but could no longer host moths on his ear-fans; they fled his sleep-damaged ink.

Caldra spent an hour speaking with nurses. The wards lacked cooling cloth, sedatives, trained memory attendants, and family transport. They did not lack classification forms. Seven ministries had produced overlapping categories for dream impairment, none of which guaranteed food after discharge.

"Convert the old audience halls into wards," she ordered. "Move court petitions to the west archive. Release palace shade stores to medical use."

The war secretary shifted. "Those stores support eclipse alignment staff."

"Keep three days' reserve. The rest comes here."

She ordered lifetime stipends for severed donors and forbade their families' tax debt from consuming the payment. Each order would meet resistance in offices that had perfected compassionate theft. She named responsible clerks and deadlines.

None of it returned Esh Var's dreams.

The superintendent brought Caldra to the ward records room before she left. Bundles of family letters filled pigeonholes once used for coin dies. Some begged for veterans to come home regardless of impairment. Others asked the hospital to keep them because one wage had supported six people and a returned donor without sleep could not work. A few disowned patients who had attacked relatives during repeated command dreams.

Caldra opened a letter from the Lower Groves. Esh Var's orchard council wanted proof that her service injury qualified under the road-charter covenant. The charter compensated a severed limb, blindness, or death. It said nothing about losing a shadow name. An imperial drafter had treated dreams as inexhaustible because no treasury counted them.

"How many claims denied?" Caldra asked.

"Six hundred three in this ward," the clerk said. "More await classification."

"Reopen them."

The clerk hesitated over the labor. "Under which injury schedule?"

"Create one. Put nurses and donors on the drafting panel. Not only actuaries."

She signed an interim order recognizing dream severance as service injury. It would cost the treasury. The war secretary began calculating aloud until she told him that unpaid damage did not become free merely because accounts omitted it.

Recruitment forms occupied another shelf. The newest version disclosed rebound in a paragraph of legal script smaller than a fingernail. Caldra tore one form through the seal. "Print the risk above the signature. State that dreams may not return."

"Enrollment will fall," General Ared said.

"Then the enrollment measured ignorance."

Honest consent would not cure the coercion of tax debt, occupied roads, or family hunger. Caldra knew that. She nevertheless corrected the piece her authority could reach in that room, then refused herself the comfort of calling it enough.

Outside Ward Nine, the security council waited in a former counting room. A map of the capital covered its wall. Red ink marked districts where labor stoppages, ration theft, or illegal evening rites had occurred. The marks clustered near the southern granaries and along the workers' canal.

Minister Seln Va proposed the solution in a voice trained to make murder sound sanitary.

"The enemy relies on unrest inside our defenses. We remove the infected elements before they coordinate. Seven hundred and forty names. Quiet arrests, immediate tribunals, closed sentences."

"Execution," Caldra said.

"Where treason warrants."

"How many warrants have evidence beyond district residence?"

"Evidence becomes harder once cells activate."

"That means none."

Seln Va opened a second folder. "The dreamless veterans create another vulnerability. Several have attacked staff. Families spread accounts that weaken donor recruitment. We recommend transferring the most impaired to the north quarantine works until after totality."

Caldra knew those works. Windowless sheds stood beside lime pits left from the plague years.

"You recommend disappearing witnesses and calling it infection control."

"We recommend a clean war. Short, contained, conclusive."

The phrase traveled around the table without resistance. Clean war. Clean roads. Clean darkness. Each promised that disciplined administration could remove grief from force.

"My brothers died because lords sealed safe rooms and left infected districts outside," Caldra said. "I will not preserve the capital by repeating their method in a different uniform."

Nobody mistook her anger for mercy toward the coalition.

She rejected the execution list. She ordered accused citizens charged publicly under named statutes, with family notification and appeal. She forbade transfer of dreamless veterans to the north works. The minister recorded each refusal with a face composed for future blame.

Then General Ared placed the eclipse projections before her.

Without full alignment, he said, war would continue across twelve regions. Free courts would raid charter roads. Observatory houses would build private reservoirs. Saltwood communes would deny darkness to imperial towns. Predation would return wherever local hosts refused regulation. The coalition called its diversity consent; the empire's records called it uneven survival.

The evidence contained truth. Night attacks had declined by sixty-three percent along seized roads. Grain movement had increased. Childhood deaths from dusk predators had fallen. The same reports omitted locked seeds, memory illness, dead moths, and conquered hosts. A policy could save lives and still build its safety from stolen parts.

Caldra requested the original Night Plague cabinet from the locked archive. An

attendant rolled in a narrow iron box bearing her mother's seal. Inside lay provincial dispatches from forty-six years earlier: requests for darkroom access, lists of infected households, offers of grain in exchange for protected sleep. Local lords had answered according to kinship, debt, and fear. One opened his Night house to tenants and lost half his own family when the crowd overwhelmed its fungal beds. Another kept three hundred safe places empty while children died outside his wall.

Her youngest brother, Cal, appeared in a physician's note as Patient V-18. No title. Fever at dusk, aversion to sunlight, pulmonary shadowing. Her other brother had become V-19 the following day. Their mother had written across the margin: They have names.

Caldra knew their names. She could still say them. What she no longer trusted came after: the private recollection of which boy hated pears and which hid beetles in her shoes. Grief had polished both into the same lost innocence. She had spent no magic to blur them. Time and rule had done enough.

Minister Seln Va used the cabinet to argue for stronger central power. General Ared pointed to the lord who opened his darkroom and called generosity without capacity another form of killing. A civil jurist noted that imperial seizure had ended private exclusion along many roads. Each claim held evidence. None granted a right to turn local Nights into obedient stores.

"We built standards because whim killed," Caldra said. "Then we treated every refusal as whim."

The jurist asked whether she intended to restore regional veto over imperial safety measures.

"I intend to complete the emergency for which we have already paid too much."

Even to her own ear, the sentence resembled every ruler's reason for continuing harm. She set the plague cabinet aside but did not close it.

Caldra stood before the capital map. Under the Sun Basilica, eleven captive Nights pressed against basalt wells. Rusk should have completed the design. Its loss forced engineers to divide existing reservoirs and accept instability. During totality, those darknesses could touch. A living commander could align them into one regulated shelter that moved with law rather than local favor.

She had never trusted purity. She trusted standards, inspection, appeals, supply obligations, and force constrained by record. Her failure lay in believing local custodians would accept those constraints before more children died.

The coalition's victories argued that compulsion had reached its limit. Ward Nine argued that her instruments had become what they claimed to prevent.

Neither argument answered who received safe sleep next winter.

"Suspend new shadow activation until rebound disclosure reaches every donor," she said.

General Ared stared. "That leaves the capital short."

"Use living troops."

"And the alignment?"

"Continues."

Seln Va permitted himself a small exhale. He had expected horror to make her abandon the entire design. Horror had made the need for an end more urgent.

"One Night remains the only mechanism that can place every province under the same enforceable duty of shelter," Caldra said. "We complete it without mass executions, hidden wards, or false casualty categories. If your offices cannot obey those limits, I will find offices that can."

She heard the contradiction. Coercion with better records still coerced. Yet abandoning central shelter now would return authority to the same kinds of lords who had watched her brothers die behind barred doors. She could not make that gamble with other families.

A Basilica engineer entered carrying a ritual alignment diagram. Coalition pressure on Mirrorgate had accelerated the evacuation schedule. Three capital districts lay along reflection corridors required to feed the command chamber during totality. Residents had been ordered to leave, but food gates opened only four hours per day and carts blocked the south route.

"How many remain?" Caldra asked.

"Twenty-six thousand registered. Perhaps eight thousand uncensused."

"Open additional exits."

"We cannot. Unshielded movement across the corridors changes the civic reflection load. If districts empty unevenly, alignment may drift."

The minister suggested moving registered households first and sweeping the rest after. Caldra looked at the map. The southern districts contained glass workers, canal families, migrant tents, and people who had reason to distrust any imperial relocation order. Keeping the gates open risked uncontrolled movement at the hour when the city's geometry needed stable counts.

She thought of plague lords sealing doors. She thought of Esh Var asking a question Caldra had not answered.

"Food moves inward before any closure," she said. "Medical teams remain. Water cannot be cut. Post the order in six languages and name me on it."

The engineer tried to convert those conditions into quantities. District Three needed forty grain wagons daily. District Five held the largest uncensused population and only two public wells. District Seven housed glassworkers whose furnaces could not cool quickly without destroying nearby walls. If the gates closed at once, carts would trap people in the reflection corridors. If closure waited for orderly movement, the corridors might never stabilize.

Caldra called the southern prefect through the speaking tube. He reported crowds already forming at South Granary. Rumor claimed the palace meant to starve the sealed wards and harvest their shade-names. His watch commanders requested cavalry.

"Send clerks with ration tallies first," Caldra said.

"They threw stones at the last clerks."

"Did the last carts carry grain?"

The prefect paused. "No, Majesty."

"Then send both."

She prohibited mounted weapons inside the closure districts and ordered gate guards rotated from neighborhoods without local kin. Family ties could corrupt enforcement, the minister argued. Caldra answered that strangers with no stake corrupted it differently. Each gate would pair one local watch officer with one outside officer, and both would sign closure counts.

Medical exemptions required another page. Birthing patients, fever cases, and people needing surgery could leave under escort. Workers essential to water and furnaces could pass on marked shifts. Caldra refused an exemption for noble households, despite Seln Va's warning that several council families lived inside District Three. Law that began with a private escape would not survive its first hour.

"And uncensused residents?" the engineer asked.

"They receive food and medicine."

"Their movement alters the count."

"Count bodies present. Do not punish them for absent papers."

The requirement would produce delays and probably fraud. It also prevented the closure order from turning legal nonexistence into starvation. Caldra initialed every condition. The stack grew thick enough to resemble care. She knew paper could not hold a gate open against frightened soldiers.

General Ared waited. "The gates, Majesty?"

Caldra placed her seal on the district plan.

"Once provision enters, the evacuation districts are sealed until ritual alignment is complete."

Wax spread beneath the sunburst. Beyond the counting-room wall, hospital carts carried dreamless veterans into palace halls cleared by her command. Farther south, other citizens would soon find imperial gates closed for their protection. Caldra watched the red seal cool and called the contradiction necessity.

Chapter 19 — The Council Under No Stars

Ilyen pinned the true eclipse table to Mirrorgate's inner wall while dust still fell from the ceiling.

The council chamber had once served as a customs court. Its roof contained a circular lens meant to display the noon sun above every tariff judgment. Pikk's fracture had clouded the glass. Light entered as a white blur without position, hour, or season.

No stars could be seen from the lower city. Ilyen had spent most of his life turning absence into numbers. That skill had helped build the prison they now argued how to open.

Representatives of the seven Blind Well parties sat around a table made from two gate leaves laid across grain barrels. Khar court captains kept witness cords at their wrists. Saltwood Selai brought empty moth cages. Rill delegates carried respirator masks around their necks. Kessa had placed civilian and dreamless observers between military chairs so nobody could define urgency without meeting those expected to pay for it.

Three clay bowls stood before Zarha.

The first held a broken mirror chip. Destroy every captive Night before the eclipse could join them.

The second held river water darkened with soot. Free them as soon as the coalition reached any reservoir, regardless of destination or available hosts.

The third held twelve different pieces of shade cloth. Carry willing hosts to the capital and disperse each freed darkness through more than one civic relation.

Ilyen disliked the neatness of the choices. Reality would mix their costs.

Akar captain Orra Venn spoke for destruction. Her company had buried friends killed by shadow doubles two days earlier. "The empire turned Nights into weapons. House Oren built the tables that made it possible. Any captive released near the capital can be seized again. Break the reservoirs, break every mirror, salt the wells, and end the weapon."

Mera Seln touched the broken chip but did not lift it. "A Night is relation, not stored force. Destroying its prison may kill the relations held inside."

"Then you prefer to gamble our living people on the captives' gratitude."

"I said nothing about gratitude." Mera's old cheek ridges caught the clouded light. "Seven Camp's Night knew injury. Rusk Night knew roots, water, hosts, and invitations. Neither offered us obedience after rescue."

A Rill safety delegate asked whether destruction could even succeed. Blackglass cracked bindings. It did not erase darkness. Blasting basalt wells might release pressure through whatever path survived, including the bodies of donors, fungal

beds, or city drains.

Orra answered that uncertain destruction still denied the empress a controlled ritual.

“Uncertain for whom?” Kessa asked. “Soldiers outside the wall, or households sleeping over a well?”

The first bowl drew support from commanders who wanted a military objective they could complete. Ilyen understood the appeal. Break a thing, count the pieces, declare danger ended. His observatory had practiced the same simplification with tables.

Pikk could not attend, but Rell brought a palm-sized model from his sickroom. A whiteglass shell surrounded soot, damp moss, and three threads tied to volunteer names. Blackglass ribs crossed the shell. The model held no Night. It reproduced only the binding stresses measured at Rusk and Mirrorgate.

Rell struck the destruction point Orra proposed. The shell cracked. Soot escaped through every opening, including the seam facing the council. Moss burned where whiteglass fragments touched it. One named thread tightened until it cut through the damp bed. Another pulled free. The third remained trapped under an unbroken piece.

“Which result represents a captive Night?” Orra asked.

“Any of them,” Rell said. “Or none. Our model lacks relation.”

She repeated the test using a fracture key. This time the shell split along one chosen seam, but a blackglass rib absorbed enough force to snap. Controlled opening reduced uncertainty. It did not make the contents obey.

Ilyen placed both broken models beside the first bowl. “We can deny imperial command geometry. We cannot certify that violence against a reservoir harms only its cage.”

Orra did not withdraw her position. She changed its wording: destroy command structures first, and destroy captive darkness only if capture became otherwise certain. The amendment mattered. So did the fact that she kept the final option.

Oth Aven spoke for immediate release. “Every hour of captivity extends the theft. We have no right to make freedom wait for our preferred arrangement.”

Several saltwood communes agreed. They had watched star-moths die while House Oren negotiated imperial contracts. Delay sounded like another expert asking damaged lives to remain patient.

Ilyen turned a brass pointer between his fingers. “If a reservoir opens under unsettling noon without hosts, water, fungus, or sheltered sleepers, where does the Night go?”

“Where it chooses,” Oth said.

“Choice requires available relations. A prison door opening onto a furnace offers direction without refuge.”

"You built the furnace."

"Yes."

The admission gave him no special authority. It merely kept denial from taking a chair.

Oth leaned forward. Dead moth wings flaked from the ink below his ear-fans. "At Leth Aven, you told us experts used uncertainty to keep power. Now you say uncertainty requires delay."

"I say we must prepare places capable of receiving refusal."

"That sentence can postpone freedom forever."

Kessa intervened before the exchange hardened into lineage. "Name the preparation. How many people, how much cloth, how much water, how long?"

Specifics changed the argument. Mera estimated that each released Night required at least three distinct host relations to avoid collapsing into the strongest nearby claim: named sleepers, a bed of living fungus or root, and unlit water. More relations improved resilience. No host could be compelled. A host who withdrew consent needed a route out. If one army carried every host, military command could become ownership by circumstance.

Ren Tal, seated with the dreamless observers, asked whether people who no longer dreamed could host.

Nobody answered quickly.

Ilyen remembered Ren asleep under white glare before Rusk, one of hundreds the empire had classified as already dead. "Not as primary dream hosts," he said. "Perhaps as witnesses, keepers, or people whose relation changes what the Night becomes. We do not know."

"Then write that we do not know," Ren said. "Do not write us out."

Kessa added the sentence to the draft conditions.

The council worked for two hours by water clock. Every proposal revealed another ownership hidden inside good intentions. Immediate release favored communities closest to the reservoirs. Carried hosts favored people healthy enough to travel. Destruction favored armies willing to call ecological death a denied weapon. Returning each Night to its named region sounded just until they considered settlements transformed by forty years of displacement, new graves, dead species, and hosts born elsewhere.

Ilyen mapped potential receiving relations on the customs wall. Rusk's restoration offered their only tested case. Its Night had recognized orchard roots, river silt, dead names, star-moth flight, and the living hosts who invited it. Command had required his memory of his mother's night stories. The Night returned locally because enough of its relations remained.

The captive reservoirs held regions with less surviving continuity. One coastal Night came from a town drowned by an imperial harbor. Another belonged to

migrating shepherd communities split across four provinces. A third had lost every registered fungal sanctuary to white-road construction.

"Home cannot mean a pin on an old map," Zarha said.

Nor could dispersal mean cutting each Night into useful shares. Division required consent from hosts and changed both descendants. Ilyen wrote that constraint at the top of the cloth proposal.

A commotion rose beyond the chamber doors.

Selai guards entered first, carrying House Oren mirror rods wrapped in black cloth. Sava Vaor walked between them under her own power. Dust striped her travel coat. The seasonal inks across her copper ear-fans had been scraped raw where someone removed an imperial listening thread.

Ilyen forgot the next eclipse figure.

His sister had denounced him before Leth Aven's observatory houses. She had called his treason an attempt to wash complicity through public confession. She had been right about the washing and wrong about the treason.

Sava set a sealed cylinder on the gate-leaf table. "House Oren has completed a replacement alignment."

Oth drew a knife. Saltwood guards did not stop him.

"If I carried their alignment, you would already be asleep," Sava said. "Put the knife where you can still choose it."

He left it on the table.

The cylinder contained copied observatory minutes, moth-route charts, and contracts bearing six Oren seals. After Rusk escaped imperial capture, House Oren had offered Caldra an alternative: Selai-run alignment through private star-moth conduits. The house would stabilize the captive darkness and retain permanent authority over celestial timing. If the empire fell, Oren planned to activate the design independently and bargain safe Night access to successor states.

"A rival One Night," Ilyen said.

"A more elegantly administered monopoly," Sava replied. "Our cousins consider that moral progress."

Oth read the seals twice. "Why bring this now?"

"Because they ordered the saltwood darkrooms seized for moth breeding. They call your communes incapable of continental stewardship."

"That offended you more than imperial theft?"

"It made the theft impossible to describe as temporary."

Sava did not ask forgiveness. Her evidence did not make House Oren represent all Selai, nor did her defection make her innocent of its contracts. She placed her observer ring beside the cylinder and gave the council names of seven house astronomers, four willing to testify and three still committed to the design.

The contracts divided future access by contribution. Oren observatories would receive first claim on stable darkness for moth breeding. Imperial grain districts came second. Charter roads followed. Saltwood settlements appeared under discretionary ecological repair, with no guaranteed allotment. Seven Camp did not appear because its stolen Night had already entered the imperial reservoir accounts under an obsolete regional name.

Oth read that clause aloud. His anger lost volume and gained precision. "They planned to return pieces of our own skies as grants."

Sava nodded. "Administered by astronomers with the correct calibration."

"Your calibration."

"Mine among others." She showed him three corrections written in her hand. The corrections reduced moth mortality during transfer. They also made transfer more feasible. "I improved a mechanism before I accepted what its success meant."

Ilyen knew that shape of guilt. Technical care could reduce suffering inside an unjust design and make the design harder to stop. Condemning every improvement would ask workers to let victims suffer more. Praising improvement could excuse the structure. No clean position waited between.

Zarha asked whether House Oren could activate its plan without Caldra. Sava said not before totality and not without access to at least seven captive reservoirs. Three loyalist teams had already moved toward the capital. Four observatories remained divided. The saltwood seizures aimed to force enough moth stock for signaling, not host consent.

"Then your evidence gives us opponents and possible defectors," Kessa said. "List both. Do not label a whole house fixed."

Sava separated names by current action rather than family. Ilyen watched her do it and recognized the first practical breach in House Oren's claim to speak as one body.

Ilyen wanted to embrace her. He also wanted to ask when she had known. Childhood habits reached for an answer he no longer possessed. He remembered sleeping beside Sava during star-moth hatching season. He knew his mother had told stories in darkness. The warmth attached to those facts had burned away at Rusk.

"You spent her stories," Sava said quietly.

"Yes."

"Did you know which ones you would lose?"

"I knew the category. Not the edges."

Her face closed. "You always trusted categories."

The rebuke found its place.

House Oren's plan ended the argument for simple seizure of the imperial mechanism. Even if Caldra fell, another centralized custodian stood ready. Destruction might prevent Oren's design but could slaughter relations inside the reservoirs. Immediate release might allow the strongest nearby observatory to recapture them.

Zarha lifted the bowl of varied cloth. "We require hosts who remain politically separate after they cooperate."

The phrase changed the room. Not one host corps. Many delegations, each able to refuse command and each witnessed by the others. Khar Bearers could carry fungal beds and funeral names. Saltwood communes could bring moth colonies and darkroom water. Rill workers could build blackglass shelters controlled by labor councils rather than owners. Human refugee wards could provide sleepers and civic kitchens. Dreamless people could audit rations, names, and withdrawals without being used as symbolic hosts.

Kessa turned principle into loads. "How many host groups can we supply to the capital?"

She cleared the bowls aside and opened a transport ledger. Fungal beds needed shallow carts, damp cloth, and water that had never crossed a white-mirror purification gate. Moth colonies required cooled cages and two keepers per watch. Funeral-name hosts traveled with family witnesses who could detect an altered name. Sleeping hosts needed enough guards to prevent forced waking without turning the sleep tent into military property.

Food created the first reduction. The coalition could not sustain every volunteer at full ration. Kessa refused to hide that limit under spiritual language. Host groups would receive the same march ration as medical workers, not officers. Communities offering wealthy specialists without replacement keepers lost priority to poorer groups able to rotate care.

Mera asked each delegation who could say no after departure. Several discovered they had named volunteers but no withdrawal process. An Akar court assumed its elected speaker could consent for all Bearers. Mera rejected that. A Selai commune proposed deciding by moth behavior. Oth rejected that because hungry moths followed light, not policy. Rill workers required a shift vote before any blackglass shelter changed destination.

Ren drafted withdrawal cards with symbols readable by people without a shared language. Open hand meant pause. Closed fist meant leave. Two fingers across the mouth meant the host could not safely speak and required a private witness. Each card carried space for a host name, a keeper, and one independent observer.

"What if a commander ignores it during battle?" Ren asked.

Zarha answered, "Then every other host shelters in place until the person is released."

"That lets one frightened person stop the plan," an officer said.

“Yes,” Mera replied. “Consent that cannot inconvenience power carries no force.”

Water presented a different danger. If all groups drew from one cistern, whoever guarded that cistern controlled the hosts. Kessa assigned separate barrels to each group and placed two days of reserve under civilian ration councils. Rill crews offered collapsible shade frames. Khar courts supplied funeral cloth. Saltwood delegates divided surviving moth eggs among four cages so one attack could not erase them.

By the end of the exercise, the proposal had become slower, heavier, and less efficient. Ilyen trusted it more for every inconvenience. Imperial alignment sought to remove friction until command moved instantly through one will. The host design preserved friction as evidence that many wills still existed.

Seven parties offered twenty-nine groups between them. Mera cut that to eighteen after asking who had replacement keepers, protected sleep shifts, and water transport. Oth reduced the number again by refusing to count moth colonies too weak to survive the road. Twelve viable groups remained, but Ilyen refused to treat that coincidence as instructions. They did not yet know how many reservoir openings could be reached or what mechanism joined them.

“Each group needs independent custody,” Sava said. “No shared command rod.”

“Shared timing may still be necessary,” Ilyen replied.

“Timing without authority.”

“A signal can become an order if only one person controls it.”

They drafted three redundant signals: moth release, struck glass, and spoken witness relayed by runners. Any two could initiate movement. No single expert could stop all three. If signals disagreed, hosts sheltered in place rather than forcing entry.

The resulting plan earned an ugly administrative name: many-host dispersal. Kessa liked it because nobody could mistake it for prophecy. Mera disliked dispersal, which suggested grain thrown by one hand, but accepted the term after the custody clauses gave every host group power to withdraw.

The council voted by party, then recorded internal minorities. Six parties adopted the plan. One Khar court abstained because its captain still favored destroying the wells. Saltwood delegates split three to two. Rill guild owners opposed labor custody while their worker delegation supported it. No ancestry spoke with one voice.

Ilyen received responsibility for timing and error margins under two witnesses, one chosen by Sava and one by Ren. He could not command a host. He could not alter the eclipse table alone. Every calculation would be copied by three hands.

After the others left to prepare, Sava remained beneath the clouded sun lens.

"You have another memory to spend," she said.

"More than one."

"The table does not require childhood."

"Command reaches for darkness-linked memory. I cannot promise which remaining part it takes."

He still held one memory that mattered beyond fact: lying awake during a storm while someone, perhaps his mother, perhaps Sava, kept a hand over his eyes until thunder became bearable. He could not separate the face from the safety. The memory formed the last private dark place he knew how to enter.

Sava touched the copied eclipse table. "If your plan demands that, the plan has failed you."

"No. A plan fails when it hides the payment or assigns it to someone without consent."

"That sounds like the astronomer who built the first tables."

"It should. I cannot become innocent by changing sides."

He wrote the risk beside his name: remaining childhood-dark memory, extent unknown. Then he signed beneath witnesses instead of sealing the note in an expert archive.

Outside, Mirrorgate's upper wall still cut the capital road. Inside the customs chamber, twelve host groups began packing different forms of shelter. Ilyen looked up through a lens that showed no stars and accepted that opening a road for many Nights might spend the last childhood darkness he could feel.

Chapter 20 — The Battle at Three Evenings

Kessa set three clocks on the map and watched them disagree.

The canal clock lost nine minutes each hour beneath a ribbon of blue shade that had gathered over the repaired water. The cellar clock gained four minutes whenever Mirrorgate's buried cisterns cooled. The ridge clock ran true until flights of dusk gnats crossed its brass face, then stopped as if the insects carried evening in their wings.

None measured sorcery directly. They measured wax flow, water drop, and pendulum swing under three local Nights returning after the lower mirrors broke.

Veyran families called the first Canal Evening. It lived along shaded water, reed roots, drowned names, and the workers who had reopened the sluices. Mirrorgate households invited Cellar Evening through unlit wells and generations of sleeping below fortress walls. Ridge Evening descended from vineyard caves, fox dens, caravan graves, and wind cooled by the pass. Each had survived imperial noon in fragments. None recognized coalition command.

Where their boundaries touched, soldiers could stand with one boot in blue dusk and the other under white glare.

Kessa did not need them obedient. She needed fourteen thousand civilians moved through that confusion while an upper garrison fired down the only road.

Her command board held three objectives. Blue cord marked the civilian corridor from Candle Lane through the lower gate. Black cord ran to the conduit towers that still returned force. Red cord climbed to the upper road doors. If the army seized red before securing blue, trapped households would become shields. If it secured blue without black, reflected missiles would sweep the evacuees. Every cord depended on the others.

Zarha's Khar courts held the eastern stairs. Rell commanded Rill sappers at the conduit towers while Pikk directed from a litter below. Oth's saltwood couriers carried signal lamps. Kessa kept mixed reserve companies at the lower market, where all three evenings overlapped.

"Use events, not hours," she told the assembled runners. "First advance begins when the canal screens drop. Second begins after the center conduit goes dark. Retreat signal uses three red cloths, never bells."

Three local witnesses stood beside the runners. Canal Evening sent no priest; its people chose a sluice keeper named Dara Veyn who carried mud under every fingernail. Cellar Evening's witness, Old Tamm, knew storm drains and household wells. Ridge Evening came with Nara Sorn, a vineyard keeper whose family had buried caravan dead without asking their flags.

Kessa asked each what their Night would do during battle.

"Nothing for battle," Dara said. "Water cools where we shade it. Reflections fail

if the surface stays broken. Stop the canal and evening thins.”

Tamm warned that Cellar Evening followed inhabited rooms, not streets. Evacuating a block could move its deepest darkness toward the families who remained. Locked cellars with no sleepers would brighten. Cisterns holding funeral water might deepen without warning.

Nara refused even that much prediction. “Ridge Evening keeps relation with graves, animals, wind, and our vines. Soldiers enter as strangers. If they shelter what belongs there, it may shelter near them. If they burn caves, it leaves or bites. I cannot promise which.”

The human officer called those statements useless for command.

Kessa copied them onto the board. “They tell us what not to build a schedule around.”

She gave each witness authority to halt work affecting their local relation. Military staff protested that three civilians could interrupt an assault. Zarha supported the condition. Pikk, speaking through Rell, added a fourth halt authority for conduit overload. The resulting command structure looked slow and vulnerable. It also meant no single frightened general could burn a Night’s roots to recover an hour.

Kessa then walked the civilian corridor before approving it. Candle Lane narrowed around an abandoned dye market. The lower road crossed two exposed reflection lines. One basement stair could hold only nine litters per quarter hour. She ordered doorframes removed, paving sanded for cart wheels, and every well marked with a cloth code. The route gained two hundred paces and enough width to keep a fallen cart from stopping thousands.

A human officer objected. “Our watches are synchronized.”

“With which evening?”

He looked at the three clocks and stopped arguing.

The garrison began the battle before Kessa completed her briefing.

White panels opened along the upper wall. A sheet of reflected noon crossed Cellar Evening and entered the lower streets. Darkness folded around it, not resisting but changing relation. The beam struck a cistern mouth, passed through black water, and emerged from six basement windows at different angles.

One cut through the market awnings.

Kessa threw herself behind a stone trough. The glare passed above her and set stacked flour sacks smoking. Runners scattered. A horse broke its lead and charged into Canal Evening, where the sudden cool made it stumble as though it had crossed into night.

“Drop screens!” Kessa shouted.

Veyran crews released the blue cloth above the canal. The first advance started under attack instead of formation.

Khar shield companies climbed east. Their front rank entered Ridge Evening and vanished from the garrison's sight, then emerged twenty paces higher when wind shifted the boundary. Imperial archers shot at where they had been. Shadow arrows struck empty stone. The second rank followed too slowly, trusting the apparent distance, and opened a gap between companies.

Zarha's runners tried to close it. One crossed into Cellar Evening, where every lamp dimmed. He delivered the order to the wrong court captain.

On the west side, Rell's sappers moved toward the conduit towers behind sand carts. Canal Evening erased clean reflections from water and wet stone, protecting them from some return panels. Ridge Evening sharpened every edge of exposed glass. A white fragment on the ground cut through boot leather before a worker felt it.

Kessa climbed onto the trough and made herself visible. "Reserve Three to the east gap. Reserve Five pulls flour from the awnings. Civilian doors open now."

"Red objective has not started," the human officer shouted.

"Blue has."

He sent Reserve Five but held Three, unwilling to violate the sequence. Kessa seized his signal flags and gave them to Ren Tal.

"East stairs. Tell them Zarha needs bodies, not permission."

Ren ran. Since waking at Rusk, he avoided sleep when he could. Under Cellar Evening, memory absence pulled at him; he slowed near a doorway where an old woman called him by another boy's name. Then he looked at the flags, found the task, and kept moving.

The upper garrison rolled mirror shields down the road. Each shield stored impacts from arrows and stones. Imperial troops pushed behind them in narrow files, releasing shadow blows whenever coalition fighters approached. The road itself became a weapon fed by resistance.

Kessa ordered archers to stop firing. "Ropes and hooks. Pull, do not strike."

Mixed teams cast hemp loops over the first shield. Twenty people hauled from side streets. The shield turned sideways. Its stored force discharged into an empty wall and broke a balcony instead of bodies. Civilians screamed above as the floor tilted.

A saltwood courier climbed the cracked facade, braced his ear-fans beneath a scarf, and lowered two children in laundry baskets. Their grandmother refused to leave until he returned for a clay urn of household dead. He carried that too. Evacuation moved at the speed of what people would not abandon.

At Candle Lane, blue sheets appeared from twelve windows. Yellow cloth remained at seven. Bare ropes marked four blocked routes. Jes the midwife stood on a cistern cover counting households from the address list sewn inside her sleeve.

"Three hundred fourteen ready," she told Kessa. "Sixty-eight sheltering. North lane blocked."

"Move the ready in groups of fifty. One local guide, one shield team, two water carriers."

"Families stay together."

"Then groups vary."

The first civilians entered the corridor as Rell reached the center conduit.

A blackglass tooth struck stone. The tower answered with a force pulse that traveled under the road. Cellar doors flew open. People waiting below mistook it for the evacuation signal and surged into Candle Lane ahead of their guides.

Kessa saw the collision forming. Three hundred prepared evacuees moved south. Uncounted cellar households pushed west. A Khar reserve company advanced north through the same intersection. Above them, the garrison uncovered another noon panel.

She ran into the crossing.

"Shields to roofs. Civilians against the water wall. Soldiers kneel."

Nobody heard all of it. Canal Evening softened voices near the channel. Kessa used her whole body, pointing groups into lanes. Jes caught the method and repeated it from the cistern. Zarha's reserve captain dropped to one knee without understanding why; his company followed. Families passed over the open line between shields.

The noon panel fired.

Light hit the canal and divided across every ripple. A thousand thin beams filled the crossing. Blue shade turned them violet, weak enough to spare skin but bright enough to blind.

Kessa covered her face too late.

Her left eye filled with white. Pain entered behind it like a heated nail. She kept the right eye open and saw only half the street.

A medic grabbed her arm. "You need dark cover."

"So do fourteen thousand people."

"Your eye is burned."

"Mark it wounded, mobile."

She tied a folded black cloth over the left side and returned to the crossing before depth became impossible. Steps looked flatter. Faces on her blind side vanished. She assigned a runner there and made him call distances.

The center conduit sounded.

Rell's first fracture note reached the market through the stones. Pikk answered from below with a handbell because his damaged right ear and left lung no longer

tolerated the long tuning bars. Three strikes meant the conduit had not gone dark. Two meant fracture complete. The bell rang once, stopped for a wet cough, then rang again.

Two.

Kessa released the black objective. Sappers struck locking wedges into the center tower. Returned force ceased along Candle Lane. The corridor widened to include the lower market.

Zarha's eastern assault did not advance. Ridge Evening had shifted downhill, exposing her companies under full noon while hiding the defenders above. Imperial archers shot from darkness into light. Khar shields that had looked black became mirrored targets.

Orra Venn sent a runner asking permission to burn the vineyard caves feeding Ridge Evening. Smoke would drive out animals and break the local darkness long enough to reveal the upper stairs.

Kessa stared at the message. A commander could win clear terrain by destroying the relation they claimed to defend. The same reasoning had built white roads.

"No burning," she said. "Ask the vineyard families where the evening opens next."

The runner doubted he had heard correctly. "Ask civilians during assault?"

"They know their Night. Go."

Vineyard elders identified three grave terraces where Ridge Evening returned whenever wind crossed the pass. Zarha shifted her companies not toward the hidden defenders but toward those terraces. Her unarmed hosts set water bowls beside the graves. The Night deepened around invited shelter. Its boundary moved uphill along the old caravan route, covering the Khar advance without obeying an order.

Imperial archers lost their angle.

The east companies reached the first stair tower. Fighting compressed into a space two shields wide. Shadow doubles from surviving wagons repeated thrusts down the steps while living defenders tried to change positions behind them. Zarha's fighters used hooked poles to pull doubles off line. Others crawled beneath the repeated thrust and cut mirror feeds instead of donor throats.

Kessa could not see the detail from the market. She saw casualty litters multiply.

By the third hour on the canal clock, 4,800 civilians had crossed the lower gate. By the cellar clock, nearly four hours had passed. Ridge couriers claimed only two. Food teams worked by completed groups rather than time: one cup of water after the address check, one barley cake at the gate, medical inspection beyond the force-return range.

The medical inspection became a battlefield of its own. Reflected blows produced internal injuries without cuts, so walkers collapsed after clearing the gate. Glare burns appeared slowly under skin. Cellar families arrived cold and shivering while Canal evacuees came wet to the knees. Healers could not sort by visible blood.

Ren reorganized the intake board into breath, walking, vision, and memory. Anyone who could answer name and address entered the household queue. Anyone repeating an order entered dream-injury shade regardless of uniform. Children without adults received clay tokens shaped by exit route rather than numbers they might forget.

A mirror pulse struck the lower gate while Kessa inspected the line. The bronze leaf rang. Six people fell from pressure. A woman carrying a funeral jar dropped it; ash spread across wet paving. Her family stopped in the corridor to gather it by hand while thousands pressed behind them.

The officer at the gate ordered the ash swept aside. Kessa countermanded him. She put ten reserve soldiers around the family and sent workers to lift the wet paving sand into a cloth. The delay cost five minutes by the canal clock. It prevented a household from crossing into safety without its dead, a loss Cellar Evening might have understood better than any commander.

When movement resumed, the woman gave Kessa half the recovered ash for the local cistern. "So evening knows where we went," she said.

Kessa had no measure for whether that worked. She recorded the jar among escorted household property and moved the next group.

Elsewhere, command messages collided. A runner emerging from Ridge Evening reported the eastern stair clear, but his report described a condition eleven minutes old by the canal clock. Reserve Three advanced and found imperial shields back in place. Twenty soldiers fell before they withdrew. Kessa banned every message lacking a visible condition marker. Couriers now carried a chip from the stair, wet cloth from the canal, or chalk from the conduit they described. Evidence traveled with words.

An imperial horn sounded from the upper city. The garrison opened its western postern and drove civilians onto the conduit terrace.

They came under guard in a packed mass, perhaps two thousand at first sight. White paint marked their hands so imperial panels would read them as authorized movement. Soldiers behind them carried mirror pikes. If coalition forces attacked, the wall would return force through the civilians. If the corridor remained still, the garrison could push the mass down onto Kessa's command position.

The human officer beside her said, "We close the market barricade."

"That traps them."

"It protects the corridor already moving."

Both claims held lives. Kessa counted width, pace, and distance with one working eye. The market could absorb eight people across. Candle Lane already carried six across southward. Opening the western turn would create a crossing conflict every thirty paces.

She cut the blue cord from her command board.

“Reverse Canal route. Existing column moves along the water north for two blocks, then enters the lower road. Western civilians take Candle Lane south. Separate flows.”

“That adds half a mile.”

“It prevents two masses meeting here.”

The officer looked toward the red stair objective. “We divert Reserve Seven to guide them, we lose the upper gate assault.”

“Yes.”

“Mirrorgate may hold.”

“Yes.”

He waited for a justification grand enough to make the choice painless. Kessa gave him arithmetic. “Two thousand in front of mirror pikes. Move.”

Reserve Seven turned away from the stairs.

The garrison commander saw the corridor change and ordered the civilian mass forward faster. People fell. Mirror pikes released stored blows above their heads to induce panic. Kessa sent laundry-code runners onto balconies: blue for move, yellow for shelter, bare rope for blocked. Jes and local guides shouted household routes in Mirrorgate dialect.

Canal Evening spread over the north turn when evacuees carried bowls of canal water into the lane. Reflections dulled on the imperial pikes. The devices could still strike, but they lost coordinated return angles.

Kessa led forty shield bearers against the guards, advancing backward so her covered left eye faced the civilian mass and her clear right eye held the threat. They did not charge. They opened a moving wall, admitted families through gaps, then closed before pikes reached them.

A reflected strike hit Kessa’s shield and numbed her arm. Another broke the knee of the bearer beside her. She pulled him through the gap and replaced him with a city watchwoman who had thrown away an imperial badge.

“Do I count as surrendered?” the watchwoman asked.

“Later. Hold left.”

They took the postern approach one body-width at a time.

Above the eastern stairs, Zarha’s witness cords appeared on the first tower. Rell’s west team signaled that Candle Lane’s concealed conduit had been isolated with Vikka’s crews. The three objectives finally approached each other, not by

synchronized clocks but by visible changes in streets.

Kessa ordered the red assault.

Ballista crews did not fire at the upper doors. Rill sappers rolled the captured blackglass regulator into the lower road and faced its absorbing side uphill. Imperial panels released stored force. The slab drank part of it, shuddered, and passed the remainder into sand beds along the road. Workers shoveled heated sand away between pulses.

Pikk sat strapped upright on the regulator sled, chalking load limits on a board. Each breath shortened his figures. Rell had sole authority to stop the operation. When a black vein reached the slab's third index mark, she raised one fist.

Every crew stopped.

A Khar commander screamed that the gate stood within reach. Rell ignored him. Workers rotated the slab, replaced one sand bed, and checked the timber sled. Only then did she lower her fist.

The delay let imperial infantry descend from the upper doors. They struck the coalition front before the regulator regained position. Fighting spread across the red road. Human defectors met former units. Selai House Oren guards fought saltwood couriers beneath dead moth banners. Khar orchard soldiers lowered weapons when they recognized severed donors among coalition medical teams; others attacked harder, calling them traitors.

No people moved as one.

Kessa committed her final reserve to the road, keeping only stretcher crews at the corridor. The upper doors could open or the coalition could retreat. There were no untouched troops left for a third choice.

Then Cellar Evening changed.

Evacuated households had carried funeral urns, water bowls, bedding, and sleeping children through the lower gate. The local Night did not follow them beyond its relations. Their departure thinned it inside Mirrorgate. Basement darkness rose through empty stairs and gathered around the upper cisterns where families still sheltered.

The garrison's noon panels lost their lower routes.

Pikk saw it first. He marked a new force line across the board. Rell turned the blackglass regulator toward the unsupported center.

"Strike the doors now?" Kessa asked.

Pikk shook his head and wrote: STRIKE ROAD UNDER HINGES.

Coalition sappers drove three hammers into the paving stones. The blow entered the road, met the regulator's dark face, and redirected upward beneath the gate pivots. No missile touched the white panels. Bronze hinges lifted from their sockets.

The upper doors fell inward.

Imperial defenders behind them broke in two directions. General staff and mirror technicians fled east toward the capital. Three infantry cohorts withdrew to the northern barracks and raised white cloth. Other soldiers continued fighting in disconnected rooms, unaware that the gate had fallen because every clock and signal told a different battle.

Zarha sent witnesses to receive surrender. Rell's workers locked the remaining panels. Kessa kept Reserve Seven on evacuation duty rather than turning it toward pursuit.

By the time the last organized resistance ended, Canal Evening covered the water road, Cellar Evening held the inhabited upper blocks, and Ridge Evening cooled the grave terraces. Their edges overlapped without blending. A person walking from gate to pass crossed three distinct dusks and emerged under noon between them.

The casualty count took another full cycle of the canal clock.

Coalition clerks recorded 1,206 dead or wounded badly enough to leave action. They refused to announce the number as deaths. The first reconciliation listed 487 dead, 681 wounded removed, and 38 missing; missing names would change those columns later. Imperial records gave 1,880 dead, wounded, captured, or surrendered out of the defense. Kessa ordered separate marks for prisoners needing care and soldiers released after local witness review.

Civilian teams counted 14,700 people evacuated through the lower gate and canal routes. That number did not represent Mirrorgate's full population. Several thousand remained in upper districts under Cellar Evening. Two hundred eleven evacuees needed surgical care. Fifty-three had died during the battle. Others remained separated from households, a loss not permitted to disappear merely because breath continued.

The 14,700 count required three reconciliations. Gate clerks had counted crossings, ration councils had counted food issues, and address teams had counted named people. Children carried twice through the gate during family searches appeared as duplicate crossings. Wounded defenders who surrendered inside the corridor appeared in imperial and civilian ledgers. Forty-three people had crossed north along the canal, returned for relatives, then crossed again.

Kessa did not choose the largest count to magnify success. She locked the three teams in the customs court with water, bread, and the instruction to reconcile names before totals. Ren led the duplicate review. Jes identified household nicknames the imperial census treated as different people. Tamm marked seven cellar families never registered at all. The final figure represented distinct evacuees confirmed by name, household relation, or two witnesses.

Missing-person boards filled the lower market. One side listed those last seen in upper districts. Another listed unidentified patients. A third recorded people who

had chosen to remain. Kessa refused to merge chosen stayers with missing. Choice mattered even when commanders disliked it.

Imperial casualty reconciliation brought harsher disputes. Coalition fighters wanted every surrendered soldier counted as captured victory. Local watch members argued they had deserted before the gate fell. Kessa separated 612 formal prisoners, 493 surrendered units under local witness, 517 dead or surgically removed, and 258 missing or retreated. Together they formed the reported 1,880, but their futures differed.

The coalition's 1,206 also concealed political weight. Khar courts had taken the heaviest stair losses. Rill crews lost fewer people but a high share of trained conduit workers. Human reserves carried most civilian-corridor wounds. Selai couriers suffered glare injuries and dead moth colonies that no body count captured. Kessa attached those distinctions to the total so later councils could not use one number to erase unequal payment.

Jes read the address ledger aloud in the lower market. Families answered from both sides of the gate. Bare ropes came down as blocked routes reopened. Yellow sheets stayed over homes whose occupants chose not to evacuate.

A medic examined Kessa's left eye under three layers of cloth. The burn had spared the center of vision narrowly, but glare damage ringed it. In future darkness, lights would carry halos. For now she could distinguish motion and little else.

"You should rest it," the medic said.

"I plan to use the other one."

"You have two because bodies expect loss poorly."

Kessa accepted the bandage and delegated the final ration count to Ren. Compassion as organization included letting another clerk finish a column.

At the upper road, coalition workers pulled down the imperial sun disk without replacing it with one alliance banner. Seven party markers went over the gatehouse beside three local witness cords. Surrender terms forbade seizure of civilian wells and recognized each local Evening's hosts as independent from military command.

Scouts rode east through the pass. The white road descended toward the capital with no fortress across it. Besh Kor's remnants had retreated beyond sight. Far away, noon shone above the Sun Basilica.

Kessa changed the deadline board with her clear eye. Eclipse in 12 days.

Mirrorgate had fallen. The capital road stood open, and behind the army 14,700 civilians learned which of three evenings knew their homes.

Chapter 21 — Down into the Noctuary

Zarha entered the basalt shaft with her spear tied across her back and Besh Kor's blood drying on the lift chain.

The blood led downward in handprints.

An imperial outer station stood nine miles east of Mirrorgate, where the white road crossed a dry ravine. Aboveground it resembled a tollhouse built around a sun mirror. Below, according to Pikk's captured regulator, a service conduit joined the Noctuary wells beneath the capital. Besh's retreating officers had reached the station two days earlier. They had left twenty-three dead defenders, six shattered donor collars, and no commander.

Then Rell found blood on the lift.

Taking the station had cost less than its defenders expected because they aimed every weapon west, toward an army on the road. Veyran drain keepers brought Zarha's group through the ravine culvert. Rill workers packed the sun mirror's rotation gears with wet clay. When imperial soldiers tried to turn reflected force on the culvert, the panel jammed halfway and sent noon into an empty cliff.

The twenty-three defenders died in three different circumstances. Nine fell fighting in the mirror court. Seven died at a locked inner door after their commander withdrew its key. Five suffocated when station attendants sealed the donor room rather than let bound personnel surrender. Two wore medical bands and had been struck while treating the rest. Zarha ordered those distinctions entered before anyone called the station a clean victory.

Six captured attendants gave incompatible accounts of Besh. One said he arrived under guard. Another claimed he walked willingly. A third saw officers beat him after he refused the lift chair. Zarha recorded all three. Witness did not become truth merely because it helped her dislike him.

The surface force found route orders burned in a brazier. Rell recovered a ceramic dispatch seal from the ash. It authorized "continuation of Commander Kor's useful intent under correction protocol." The wording gave ownership to his purpose while discarding the person who held it.

Zarha could have waited for the full army and medical teams. Patrol markers showed an imperial relay due before the next watch. Delay risked losing the underground controls and whoever had left the blood. She limited the descent, assigned two independent surface commanders, and wrote an extraction condition: if no signal returned within one water-clock cycle, the upper force would disable the mirror, hold the ravine, and not send more bodies blindly below.

Zarha took eight people below: herself, Orra Venn, two Rill workers, one Selai eclipse reader, a Veyran drain keeper, Mera Seln, and Pikk. The engineer sat in a narrow sling chair fixed to the rear of the platform. He could walk a short distance,

but climbing stole breath around the splinters in his left lung. Every cough sounded wet.

"You should remain above," Zarha said as workers released the brake.

"You should remain off your thigh," Pikk replied.

The reopened spear wound pulled under Zarha's bandage. They had both heard the medical answer and chosen a narrower disobedience. Orra carried authority to end Zarha's participation. Rell carried the same power over Pikk. Neither injured person commanded the condition of remaining injured.

The platform descended.

White stone gave way to black basalt after thirty feet. The air cooled without becoming dark. Thin reflection veins ran through the shaft walls, carrying noon from the station mirror into the earth. Between them, fungus grew pale and dry, denied enough darkness to open its caps.

Mera touched no wall. "Something below knows the difference between us and the light."

"Can it guide?" Orra asked.

"No."

The Night-Bearer offered no apology for useless mystery. Zarha trusted her more for that.

At the first landing, they found the lift operator alive. He lay strapped into a copper chair facing a black slit in the wall. His eyes moved. His mouth did not. A collar at his throat carried twelve small hooks, only three connected.

Pikk examined the chair from his sling. "Relay donor. Each hook carries one category of instruction."

The Selai reader leaned near the etched labels. "Open. Close. Equalize."

"What do the other nine carry?" Zarha asked.

"No wires here."

The operator's fingers twitched when they spoke the labels. His shadow on the floor performed a different motion: reaching for a lever no longer present.

Mera cut the chair straps but left the collar untouched until Pikk placed a blackglass tooth between skin and copper. Removing a live binding without somewhere for its force to go could tear dream memory through the body. Rell struck the tooth once. The shadow hand opened. The operator inhaled and began repeating the word close.

He did not stop.

They sent him upward with two guards from the station. The strike group continued with six fighters and specialists, too small now for comfort and still large enough to kill each other in a narrow passage.

The conduit sloped toward the capital. Bronze doors divided it every hundred

paces. Each door carried a census name rather than a number: Harrow Coast, Neral Fen, Old Senn, Tammar Deep. Regions reduced to labels on plumbing.

Behind the doors, pressure changed. Harrow Coast smelled of salt and drowned timber. Neral Fen brought insects beating against stone where no insects lived. At Old Senn, Zarha heard tent ropes in wind and almost turned because the sound resembled Seven Camp before its Night was stolen.

"Pressure memory," Mera said. "Not speech."

Zarha kept walking.

Pikk's portable blackglass regulator moved on a low rail cart. When Rell rolled it past each door, indexing lines glimmered on its back. Twelve families of marks, first noticed at Mirrorgate, answered the bronze nameplates. The blank center darkened a little more with each response.

The empire had used local names to build a machine that denied local custody.

Halfway down, they reached a donor gallery.

Copper chairs lined both sides, sixty in total. Forty-one held bodies. Some breathed. Several had died long enough ago for attendants to tie white cloth over their faces. Tubes delivered water to the living. Waste channels ran beneath the chairs. No attendants remained.

Orra looked for weapons. Zarha looked for witness cords and found none.

The donors belonged to many peoples. Khar orchard seals appeared beside human levy brands. Two Selai wore House Oren ear caps that prevented moth contact. Rill labor numbers had been etched directly into four collars. Each body cast several partial shadows toward different wall slits.

"They divide intention," Pikk said. "One donor may open more than one line."

"By consent?" Zarha asked.

Rell showed her a collar ratchet locked from behind the chair.

Consent might have existed at recruitment. It did not exist here.

They could not free forty-one people quickly without triggering the conduit alarms. Leaving them preserved the station. Orra argued for taking the index and returning with medical crews. Mera said some donors would not survive another hour if pressure increased. Zarha chose six with failing breath for immediate severance and marked every remaining chair on the route map.

Choosing the six required judgments nobody wanted. A pulse meter identified bodies closest to failure, but one donor's collar fed the corridor doors. Severing her could trap the group below. Another carried a name that matched Orra's maternal court. Orra disclosed the relation and stepped away from that choice. Mera selected by breath and skin temperature while Rell assessed which lines could accept blackglass grounding.

Beneath each chair, attendants had placed a small tray for personal effects.

Most stood empty. One held three seed husks that had never opened. Another held a child's counting cord. A Selai donor's tray contained dead star-moth scales wrapped in observatory paper. The empire had preserved tokens of identity while using the bodies as mechanisms, perhaps believing the courtesy reduced the theft.

Zarha found an operations ledger at the gallery end. Its categories read available, degraded, silent, and expended. Dead donors entered the last column beside recoverable collar components. Nobody had left space for wounded, unwilling, or missing memory. She tore out no page. The whole book would travel upward as evidence.

Mera wrote the six selected names on strips of burial cloth before severance began. "For the living too?" an attendant asked from the doorway.

"Especially the living. A rescue can erase a person by remembering only who died."

The first donor woke speaking a dock language none of them knew. The Veyran keeper held water to his mouth anyway. The second woke laughing and could not stop. The third remained unconscious but breathed more evenly after his partial shadows returned. Results varied because bindings and people varied; one successful release did not establish a universal cure.

Pikk refused to design the six operations as one mass break. "Different lines. Different rebound. We do each."

Time narrowed. Ten days remained before eclipse, and imperial patrols would discover the captured station. Zarha accepted the delay.

The fourth donor died during severance. His body had worn a human grain levy mark. The shadow lines collapsed into his chest, and no breath followed. The other five lived, though two woke without language and one could no longer close her eyes.

Zarha recorded dead, living impaired, and left bound in separate columns. There would be no clean word for rescue.

Beyond the gallery, blood appeared again.

It marked one wall at shoulder height, then crossed the floor where someone had crawled. A broken tusklet lay beside a drainage grate. Zarha recognized the angle of the break from their fight at the canal.

Besh had not escaped toward the capital as a trusted commander. Someone had brought him here.

The trail ended at a round chamber built over a vertical well. White rods descended into darkness too deep for the station light. A binding frame hung above it. Besh Kor occupied the frame with his arms spread and his feet off the floor.

His armor had been removed. Census script covered his chest in fresh burns. A mirror crown held his head upright. His shadow below did not resemble his body. It

stood at the head of an army, raising a hooked staff again and again.

Besh's living right hand hung swollen from Zarha's earlier strike. His shadow hand moved perfectly.

"He failed withdrawal," Orra said. "They made him a donor."

"Or he volunteered for another weapon," Zarha answered.

Besh opened one eye. "They said I had already given the intention."

His voice scarcely carried.

Pikk studied the frame. The well beneath answered every breath with a pressure pulse. This mechanism did not cast one double. It tested whether a commander's last forceful intention could coordinate thousands of bindings. Besh had wanted to preserve charter roads. The machine had stripped context until only hold remained.

"Can you free him?" Zarha asked.

"Can. Cost uncertain."

Orra drew her knife. "He ordered the canal attack. Four hundred eighteen donors died."

"I remember," Zarha said.

"He can answer in a court if he lives. The frame threatens everyone if it succeeds now." Mera placed a bowl of dark water beside the well lip. Its surface bent away from the white rods. "Freeing him denies the test. Killing him may complete his last intention."

Besh laughed once and turned it into a cough. "Even my execution requires hospitality law."

"No," Zarha said. "It requires care about the weapon behind you."

They used the portable regulator as an alternate ground. Rell aligned its twelve line families with the frame. Pikk gave instructions in groups short enough to preserve breath. Orra kept her knife under Besh's ribs in case the shadow army moved toward the group.

The first fracture note made the mirror crown brighten. Besh screamed. His shadow below continued raising the staff.

At the second note, images entered the regulator: orchard gates, raiders under dusk cloth, imperial patrols arriving after smoke, Besh signing a road-charter while families watched. Not memories told as narrative. Relations pressed into glass. Fear of raids. Pride in paved wells. Disgust toward free courts that visited settled Khar only to demand fighters. The machine had compressed all of it into hold.

Zarha saw enough truth to understand him and enough choice to keep judging him.

"Third note," Pikk said.

Rell struck.

The frame opened. Besh fell into Orra's arms. His shadow army broke into a dark stain and rushed through the regulator rather than his body. Black veins spread across the slab. One indexing family remained bright after the others dimmed.

Besh lay on the floor, conscious. "You should have left me."

"You do not choose the easiest judgment," Zarha said.

"You think this purchases testimony."

"It purchases nothing. You witnessed what they did. Decide whether you speak."

He looked at the well. "Caldra's officers called it correction. They said my road intention belonged to the empire after my charter failed."

"Will you testify to that?"

"I will testify that they own service past consent. I will also testify that free courts raided the Lower Groves and called it levy."

"Both belong in the record."

Orra objected. "He does not become an ally because he can accuse two sides."

Besh pushed himself upright against the wall. "I have no wish to become yours."

That settled the false redemption before anyone could offer it.

The bright index line on the regulator led to a narrow service door. Behind it waited a room filled with brass plates arranged in a circle. Each plate carried a well name, a reservoir pressure, a donor count, and a column labeled civic aperture.

"well index," Rell read from the header.

The plates showed eleven captive Nights divided among twelve wells after Rusk's escape. Some reservoirs fed one well. Others had been split under command, damaging both descendant relations. Every well line continued upward to a district reflection point inside the capital.

Pressure numbers changed while they watched. Harrow Coast rose whenever the station mirror brightened. Neral Fen fell when Mera placed dark water near its service door. The plates measured imposed response, not health. Imperial annotations treated stable pressure as success even when donor demand doubled.

Each civic aperture served an ordinary city function aboveground. One occupied a bathhouse skylight. Another formed the mirrored roof of a grain exchange. Two belonged to observatory courts. A northern aperture sat inside a hospital laundry tower. The southernmost line passed through a public ration square near South Granary. Imperial engineers had hidden ritual infrastructure inside places where thousands worked, ate, washed, or waited for food.

That design protected the mechanism from a single military strike. It also gave city residents access if they understood what their buildings carried. Darkening an aperture required no command memory. Cloth, soot, shuttered mirrors, or a dense enough invited Night could interrupt reflection. Holding the darkness through totality demanded people at every site while the empire defended them.

The Selai reader calculated the timing margin. "All latches must register within eleven minutes."

Ilyen had found the public eclipse table falsified by that same interval. The empire's lie concealed not only totality but the civic opening period. A population following official time would darken too late or uncover too early.

Rell copied current pressure beside every rubbing. Pikk added load limits from the regulator. Zarha asked Mera to mark which well responses resembled relation and which merely showed injury. Mera refused certainty but annotated scent, sound, and changes in the dark-water bowl. Their copy kept engineering and witness observations separate.

Besh recognized the military designations attached to four apertures. One district had been renamed after a suppressed canal strike. Another official name covered two neighborhoods divided by a wall. He warned that orders using military labels would send couriers to guarded entrances rather than community routes.

"Write both names," Zarha said. "Local first."

The resulting map could not fit under one title block. It carried imperial, current, and household names side by side. Complexity slowed reading. Simplicity here would send people to the wrong doors.

The Selai eclipse reader copied angles while Ilyen's tables lay open beside her. "These apertures cannot open from below."

"Why?" Zarha asked.

"Pressure interlock. A well gate responds only when its city reflection darkens during totality. The command chamber cannot initiate it. It receives what the city sends."

Pikk traced the civic aperture marks through the portable slab. Twelve lines. Twelve districts. The empire had described those points as passive windows, but their geometry contained latches.

"Name them plainly," Zarha said.

Rell pointed around the circle. "Twelve civic windows. Each must be darkened from its own district while the eclipse touches the well. Then a latch opens. Miss one, and that well remains bound."

The many-host plan had acquired a mechanism.

No single strike team could open all twelve. No commander in the Basilica could substitute for citizens at the windows. Caldra's system had centralized darkness while depending on distributed city infrastructure it treated as obedient.

They copied every plate by rubbing, angle, and hand transcription. Three forms prevented one error from becoming law. Besh identified two district names changed after annexation and supplied their current military designations. His help remained evidence, not allegiance.

An alarm sounded above.

Imperial patrols had reached the station. Orra wanted to collapse the conduit behind them. Pikk refused because forty-one donor chairs and their service routes remained inside. Zarha ordered a slower withdrawal using the bronze doors as barriers. They carried the six severed donors, the dead man, the index copies, and Besh. The remaining bound donors received water and marked release positions for the returning medical force.

The first patrol reached Harrow Coast's door before the carriers passed Old Senn. Imperial bolts traveled down the corridor and struck bronze. Shadow force returned from the nameplate behind the shooters, throwing two into the wall. Even the station defended its current routing, indifferent to uniform.

Orra held the rear with four fighters. She did not kill fallen patrol members when stepping over them. Rell wedged each door with blackglass teeth tuned to release after a short delay. The barriers bought distance without sealing the donor gallery permanently.

Besh tried to take a weapon from a dead station guard. Zarha stopped him.

"Prisoner," she said.

"I know their approach calls."

"Then speak them."

He called a false inspection order around the next bend. Three patrol soldiers lowered crossbows long enough for Orra to disarm them. Besh received no blade. Witness knowledge changed the escape without changing his custody.

At Old Senn's door, Besh stumbled. Zarha caught him despite her thigh. He recoiled from her hand.

"Witnesses may still be prisoners," she said.

"And reeves may still be enemies."

"Yes."

They reached the lift while fighting began in the tollhouse above. Coalition guards held the mirror court long enough for two platform trips. Pikk and the impaired donors went first with the regulator. Zarha stayed for the second with Orra and Besh.

As the lift rose, pressure from the captive Nights followed them through basalt. It carried salt, insects, old tent ropes, drowned wood, and injuries without convenient instruction. Zarha did not ask it to bless their plan.

At the surface, she gave the well index copies to three separate couriers. One rode for Ilyen. One rode for Kessa. One stayed with Mera's hosts. Besh entered contested witness custody under both an Akar court and a Lower Groves prisoner advocate.

Ten days before eclipse, the coalition finally knew the practical lock beneath the empire's stolen darkness: the wells could open only when twelve civic windows went dark from twelve parts of the capital at once.

Part IV

Chapter 22 — The Refugees Before the Capital

Kessa climbed the lead flour wagon while its wheels still turned and struck the brake lever with her heel.

The team stopped three paces short of the ditch. Behind her, the road from Mirrorgate shuddered under carts, litters, handbarrows, marching companies, and people carrying everything left of a house in one sheet. Ahead, Avarra Ves rose in white walls around the Sun Basilica. Its towers caught the afternoon glare and threw it back in hard fans. No gate opened.

“Blue cloth to the east field,” Kessa called. “Red tags beside the aqueduct. Walking wounded stay off the stone. If you can lift, you do not thereby become a soldier.”

The order passed by flags, drums, and people who knew how to make a sentence travel without changing its number. Seventy-two thousand refugees and expelled ward residents had reached the imperial outer wards. Of those, fifty-eight thousand could walk under their own power. Four thousand nine hundred needed litters or carts. Seven hundred eighty carried wounds likely to kill them without surgery. The remainder included children, elders, the fevered, the dreamless, and people whose bodies worked but whose attention had gone ragged beneath weeks of unsetting sun.

Her left eye made a bright ring around every polished surface. Since Three Evenings, darkness also carried a pale rim, as if Night had acquired a wound to match hers. She covered that eye with one hand and read the capital gate through the other.

White shutters had closed across the food arches. Above them, clerks in yellow tabards unrolled an imperial proclamation. They did not shout it. Mirror plates on the wall multiplied the clerk’s voice over the fields.

“By order of Empress Caldra Ves, the outer relief wards have exceeded safe capacity. Grain, cistern, and infirmary access remain sealed pending restoration of civic order. Armed bodies approaching within five hundred paces will be treated as siege forces.”

A groan moved through the crowd. It had weight but no single throat. Kessa watched its effect: three mothers turned toward the ditch as if water might be hiding there; a Khar cart team began cutting the lashings from a reserve barrel; two soldiers reached for spear shafts when the people around them needed hands.

“Put those down,” she told them.

One obeyed. The other stared at the walls.

“Marshal, they have food.”

"So do we, for thirty-one hours at half ration. If you start a panic, we have it for nine."

That reached him. Hunger understood arithmetic even when anger did not.

Kessa jumped from the wagon. Her right knee buckled after ten days of marching, but the ground held. Ren Tal waited with the column boards tucked beneath one arm. At seventeen he had the long wrists of someone whose body had grown while he slept. He had awakened after Rusk with holes in his memory large enough to lose familiar faces. Numbers stayed with him if someone wrote their purpose beside them.

"Mark outer field one," Kessa said. "Seventeen thousand three hundred people. Six wells promised on the survey, three actually drawing. Put a broken cup beside the missing ones."

Ren chalked the board. "People will think it means no cups."

"Then draw a dry well."

"I'm poor at wells."

"You're excellent at disagreeing with bad symbols. Find someone who can draw."

His mouth moved toward a smile, then stopped before memory could demand the rest of it. He carried the board east.

On the Basilica terraces, twelve white towers stood around a central dome. Kessa knew what waited below them only through Zarha's report from the Noctuary station: twelve captive Nights, twelve indexed wells, twelve civic windows required during the eclipse. Three days remained. That fact did not make the next hour less hungry.

A runner came from coalition command. "They want you at the map shelter."

"They know where I am."

"They said now."

"Then they can learn what now costs." Kessa pointed to the clogged ditch. "Get forty spades and a sanitation crew here before sunset. If the command tent asks again, tell them I'm preventing a fever army from forming on their flank."

The runner looked delighted to carry that sentence.

By the time Kessa reached the shelter, six commanders had already moved carved blocks across the capital map. Zarha stood rather than sat, favoring the old wound in her right thigh. Mera Selin watched from a stool among the nonmilitary hosts. Three Selai couriers had spread moth-route silks over the southern wards. Pikk sat close to the entrance where air moved, each breath kept shallow by the glass in his left lung.

A Khar spear captain tapped the South Gate. "We have perhaps eight hours before their reserve columns arrive from the eastern road. Strip the baggage carts.

Put every able carrier behind the assault. We can reach the Basilica terraces before dawn."

"Which dawn?" Kessa asked.

The captain's cheek ridges tightened. "The one we make by taking the city."

"Give me your water count."

"We are discussing the breach."

"Then discuss how thirty thousand assault troops drink while seventy-two thousand displaced people watch their carts being taken."

A human colonel from Dorn Vale pushed a marker toward the wall. "The refugees came because the Basilica must fall. They understand necessity."

Kessa took his marker and placed it back in the tray. "They came because their farms burned, Mirrorgate closed behind them, and your rear companies promised food outside the capital. Understanding necessity does not turn a person into a wheel."

"We cannot feed them if we lose."

"We lose before the first ladder rises if we steal their transport."

Zarha asked, "What can you do with thirty-one hours?"

"Make it forty-eight. More if the city feeds itself."

"The gates are sealed," the colonel said.

"Walls don't mill flour. People do. The inner labor wards have families outside with us, and Caldra sealed them in to preserve her ritual alignment. You want the Basilica. I want the kitchens, granaries, drain crews, wagon yards, and ward councils between here and it."

Mera Seln folded both hands over her witness staff. "What would you offer them?"

"A seat before obedience. Their grain under joint seal. No requisition without a ration council vote. Civilian corridors protected ahead of military routes."

The spear captain gave a short, angry laugh. "You mean to conduct municipal law beneath siege engines."

"I mean to keep people alive beneath siege engines. Law may have to keep up."

Silence gathered around the map. Kessa distrusted silences in command shelters; they often meant someone had found a noble way to ignore labor. Zarha broke this one by removing the assault blocks from the South Gate.

"Eight hours," the night-reeve said. "Then we review."

Kessa nodded. "Give me every interpreter, three printing presses, the saltwood courier line, and authority to arrest any officer who takes a civilian cart."

"Two presses," Pikk said. "The third cracked an axle at Mirrorgate."

"Then give me the axle crew too."

Outside, she built the first ration council on four overturned grain boxes.

No ancestry received a block by default. Kessa divided representation by the work that could fail: water, food, shelter, waste, medical care, children, transport, and night hosting. Seven Camp elected a weaver for shelter and sent Ren to the food board. The Rill sappers chose a kiln nurse who knew glass-lung from dust fever. Imperial ward expellees selected a baker named Toma Ver, whose wife and two sons remained sealed inside South Labor. Mera's Bearers requested one voice for sleepers and the dead, then accepted a nonvoting witness place when the council refused to let unseen dead outvote hungry living people.

They argued for forty minutes about counting soldiers.

"Soldiers eat," the Dorn colonel said.

"So do prisoners," Toma Ver replied. "Eating does not establish command."

Kessa assigned military companies rations by head and labor, while their officers received one advisory seat with no veto. She expected the colonel to object. Instead, he took off his rank sash and tied it around a water barrel to mark army allocation.

Three presses began producing ration slips on old imperial surrender notices. One side still demanded Mirrorgate's submission. The other promised a cup of grain per five people, subject to revision when South Granary opened or the column's supplies failed. Kessa insisted on both possibilities in print.

Ren developed the symbols. A full cup meant grain issued. A cup crossed once meant delayed. Two crossed strokes meant disputed count. Dreamless recipients received a dark thumbprint beside the household mark so no clerk could declare their share unused.

"You made that one look like a closed eye," Kessa said.

"It is an eye," Ren answered.

"Some people will call it death."

"Then they can look at me while I collect the ration."

She left it.

Water came first. The outer aqueduct carried enough for the capital gardens but imperial sluices had diverted most of it behind the walls. Pikk's apprentices found a maintenance culvert beneath the third buttress. They could have cracked it in minutes. Kessa stopped them until two ward plumbers crawled out through the same drain with blue dye on their palms.

"We close it, your pressure rises," said the older plumber, a woman named Jes Caro. "Rises enough to burst the ceramic mains under South Labor. Open it without closing the north branch, you flood the dye works and drown anyone sheltering in the settling pits."

"Can you send a message back?" Kessa asked.

Jes held up the dye. "That is how they sent us."

The color on her left palm formed three bars and a circle. Toma Ver recognized a shift tally: three workhouses prepared to stop, South Granary watch undecided.

Kessa crouched beside the culvert. Hot air breathed from it, carrying flour dust, sewage, and the mineral bite of whitewash. "What does the granary watch need?"

"To know you won't empty the bins for your army."

"Tell them joint seal. Two ward keepers, two refugee clerks, one army quartermaster. Daily count painted where the queues can see."

Jes looked at the armed field behind Kessa. "And if command changes its mind?"

Kessa called the colonel over. "Give her your sash."

He glanced at the sash tied around the water barrel. "That is my sash."

"Exactly."

The colonel untied it and passed it to Jes. She wound the cloth around one blue hand.

"If we break the South Granary," she said, "the district rises. Not for you. For its own food and because Caldra sealed our children outside."

"Good," Kessa said. "People who rise for me can be ordered back down by someone else."

Jes crawled into the drain.

The ration councils spread faster than orders. Each field elected voices and posted its count. People surrendered private flour when the tally promised them standing in the next distribution. Akar Seven hosts raised shade cloth over the medical lanes. Selai commune workers stitched dead star-moth silk into signal panels because ordinary white flags vanished against the walls. Rill crews repaired cart rims without claiming the carts. None of it erased fear. It gave fear jobs.

Keeping 72,000 people fed meant little if the camp poisoned its own water. Kessa sent the waste council downslope with lime from three abandoned imperial tollhouses. They marked six trench fields beyond the sleeping rows and hired children as flag carriers, not diggers. A dispute followed when a Khar orchard clan refused burial dust near a latrine cut. Mera Seln listened, then moved the trench rather than treating custom as a luxury hunger had canceled. In return, the clan lent eighty shovel crews through the hottest hour. The medical council counted vinegar, clean linen, fever bark, glass-dust masks, and hands trained to stitch. It posted the figures where anyone could challenge them. Two purported surgeons disappeared when asked to name their teachers; a midwife from the imperial potters' ward took their place and reorganized the burn tables.

At the transport council, cart owners tied witness cords to their axles. A green knot allowed food hauling. A blue knot allowed medical use. An unmarked axle required the owner's spoken consent before any officer touched it. The spear captain watched a lieutenant surrender a seized mule and did not intervene. That

mattered more than another proclamation. By late afternoon, people had begun bringing disputes to the boxes before reaching for knives. The councils had acquired no sacred authority. They worked because every ruling ended in water moved, cloth raised, a name restored to a list, or an officer forced to give back what he had taken.

At the sixth hour, a white bolt struck the east field.

The imperial mirror tower had aimed at an approaching coalition wagon. Reflection bent in the polished road and cut through a shelter line instead. Eleven people fell. Four died before the glare faded from their clothes. Seven went to the surgery tarps with burns across the face and shoulders.

The spear captain demanded immediate assault.

Kessa walked him to the bodies. "Name what changes if you charge now."

"They stop firing."

"Or they fire faster. The labor districts have not moved."

"You spend civilian lives to protect your plan."

"I count the lives the plan failed to protect. Do you?"

He looked at each covered body. By the fourth, his anger had lost the ease of abstraction.

A work whistle sounded inside South Labor.

One long note, two short. Across the fields, Toma Ver stood so quickly he knocked over the food ledger.

"That calls the night shift," he said. "There has been no night shift in forty years."

Another whistle answered farther north. Then the dye works sounded its cracked brass horn. Laundry lines rose between tenements inside the wall, dark blankets drawn over windows in deliberate violation of the Evening Prohibition.

Every mirror tower turned toward the labor wards.

Kessa raised both signal panels. "Medical teams to the south lane. No troops through the gate until ward witnesses cross. Archers cover windows, not streets. Anyone loots grain loses their ration place and their weapon."

The South Granary doors did not open at first. They bulged.

Workers had jammed a flour cart against the inner bar while the watch tried to hold it. Through the drain, Jes's people sent counts in blue-dyed scraps: fourteen watchmen refusing, nine wavering, two already beaten by their own captain. The outer field heard none of the words, only the impact of wood, the brass whistles, and mirror fire skidding over rooftops.

Pikk's fracture choir carried blackglass shields to the ditch. Each shield swallowed one white flash and heated until its bearers had to lay it in mud. Kessa rotated crews after every strike. She kept soldiers behind the refugee line where

their presence could not be mistaken for a charge.

The gate beside the granary opened a hand's breadth.

A young man squeezed through and fell into the ditch. Blood covered one sleeve. Toma dragged him clear.

"Ward vote," the young man gasped. "Six houses for opening. Two abstained. Granary watch accepts joint seal if the army remains outside until the first five hundred sacks pass."

Kessa looked toward Zarha. The night-reeve had arrived with a hundred Khar fighters and no court banner.

"My people can hold the mirror crews from here," Zarha said.

"Then the army waits."

A boom rolled through South Labor. The granary doors split around the flour cart. Workers poured out carrying hooks, mill paddles, and ledger boards. Some fought the remaining watch. Others formed two lines from the bins to the gate, protecting sacks from hands that reached too soon.

The first ward witnesses crossed into the field: Jes Caro, three millers, a teenage chimney sweeper, and an old imperial grain clerk who carried every key on a chain around his waist. Kessa met them at the ditch. She placed Ren's ledger in front of them, then laid the colonel's sash across it.

"Two ward keepers," she said. "Two refugee clerks. One quartermaster. Counts displayed at both doors. First issue to medical lanes and children under eight. Soldiers draw after civilian half ration unless currently holding the granary corridor."

The old clerk peered at the crossed-cup symbol. "What does this mean?"

"Disputed."

"It looks unfinished."

"It is."

He considered that, then took one end of the sash.

By the time the sun leaned toward an evening it had denied the capital for four decades, five hundred sacks stood outside the walls. Four laborers and three granary watchmen had died inside. Twenty-six people carried wounds. No coalition soldier had entered South Labor. The second ward vote admitted medical crews and blackglass defenders. The third invited a hundred unarmed grain porters.

The military map shelter sent no further demand for carts.

Kessa climbed the flour wagon again. Her left eye ringed every raised window in pale fire, but behind that false brightness she saw dark cloth spreading from building to building. The labor districts had not joined an army. They had opened a city to its own hungry people and required the army to stand witness.

At South Granary, the imperial sunburst came down. The workers did not

replace it with Zarha's knots, Selai moth silk, or a coalition standard. They hung the ration ledger above the broken doors.

Then they opened the second grain hall from within.

Chapter 23 — Every Window Darkened

Ilyen held the blackglass upright while six millers turned South Granary into night.

They worked without ceremony. One shutter dropped over the west loft. Two apprentices packed flour sacking around its edges. A granary watchman extinguished the weighing lamps, and a refugee child crawled beneath the bins to cover the rat holes with clay. Light narrowed to white threads, then vanished.

The portable mirror in Ilyen's hands cooled.

Pikk Rill knelt beside the frame, listening through his good ear to a sound Ilyen could feel only as pressure in his fingertips. The goblin engineer had braced the mirror with three ashwood legs because his left lung no longer allowed him to hold weight against his chest. Blackglass carried no image. In the dark loft it looked deeper than a surface and more exact than a hole.

"Third well," Pikk said. "South-by-southwest pull. It recognizes the index cut."

Ilyen turned the basalt token Zarha had brought from the outer Noctuary station. Twelve grooves crossed its face. Each carried a name stolen from a local Night and reduced to a well number. He had copied those grooves onto separate slivers of mica. No cell would carry the complete index.

Behind him, the millers began to breathe at different speeds. Their shared darkness acquired relation: grain dust, rat warmth, old flour, sweat, names spoken over communal ovens, and the memory of workers who had died in machinery. Something under the city pressed upward in reply.

Not speech. Never speech. A captive Night knew injury and the shape of offered shelter. It could not tell them how to free it.

Ilyen whispered, "Release the east shutter."

A miller pulled the cord. Sunlight knifed across the loft. Pressure vanished, and the blackglass warmed again.

Pikk marked the result on his slate. "South Granary can host an opening. It cannot hold the line to the Basilica without the other eleven."

"Nor should it." Ilyen flexed cramped fingers. "If one window could carry all wells, we would have built Caldra another throne."

A woman from the ward council relit one lamp. "We covered a room. Why call it a window?"

"Because the Noctuary uses civic reflections," Ilyen said. "The Basilica's white mirrors look outward through twelve district towers. During the eclipse, each tower can return a local darkness down one indexed well. We do not need the imperial mirror itself. We need a site inside its reflected path, hosts who consent, and enough blackglass contact to interrupt command."

She glanced at Pikk's single mirror. "One piece for twelve sites."

“Temporarily one network,” Pikk said. “My sappers laid dusted thread in drain mortar and roof seams. When the master reflection breaks, every thread breaks with it. Until then, a stress pulse from here reaches the other cuts.”

“If your thread fails?”

“Then your darkness belongs to this granary and no one else. Failure stays local. That is part of the design.”

The council woman nodded. Consent became easier to trust when refusal remained possible.

Outside, the capital had begun to manufacture evening by hand. Dark laundry covered tenement windows. Kiln crews banked furnaces. Funeral houses opened underground washing rooms to living hosts. In the salt merchants’ ward, Selai traders released the few star-moths that had survived permanent noon inside clay jars. Across twelve districts, a cell prepared to stand between one civic reflection window and one captive well.

Ilyen climbed to the granary roof. He knew the route map without looking, yet he unfolded it because memory deserved witnesses now.

South Granary held the third well. The potters’ settling chambers held the first, with unlit water and names fired into cracked bowls. Seven Camp’s mobile hosts took the western caravan yard beneath woven tent cloth. Saltwood commune families occupied a dead conservatory whose surviving moth eggs waited in cooled bark. Rill kiln workers held a blackglass polishing cellar. Imperial veterans gathered in a shuttered bathhouse, including dreamless donors whose shadows had fought under orders they never chose. Other cells occupied a laundry court, a funeral kitchen, a dye vault, a condemned prison chapel, the old rain cistern, and the North Observatory.

No two shelters made darkness the same way. That difference carried the plan.

Matching those shelters to the index had taken most of the previous night. Imperial well numbers described angles, not communities, and the old surveyors had assumed every district reflection remained fixed. Four decades of demolition had shifted the city. A textile tower now leaned into the path once assigned to a tax court. The western caravan yard occupied ground where an imperial cavalry hall had burned. Ilyen walked each line with a sighting frame while ward residents corrected maps that still showed their homes as warehouses or vacant lots.

At the veterans’ bathhouse, disagreement nearly ended the sixth cell. An imperial surgeon argued that former donors already possessed registered shade-names, making further consent redundant. A woman named Pela Av, whose shadow double had killed at Three Evenings, asked him to leave. Her last forceful intention had been to protect her ward. The Empire had copied that intention into a soldier and then treated her resulting dream loss as evidence that she could no longer decide. Ilyen removed the surgeon’s name from the witness slate. The cell reopened its vote, this time by touch for donors who could not read. Thirty-one

agreed to host. Nine refused and received safe passage out. Their refusal weakened nothing. It made the thirty-one choices legible.

The prison chapel presented the opposite problem. Its registered hosts had died under Evening Prohibition, while the living cooks and sweepers carried no census standing. Ilyen accepted household grave lists, kitchen duty rolls, and spoken kinship witnessed by three prisoners' families. The well responded to relations rather than imperial paperwork. A woman serving a sentence for grain theft placed her hand against the chapel wall and felt pressure from below before any observatory instrument moved. Ilyen entered that result in the table with her name, not his.

Oth Aven landed on the roof from a rope bridge, copper ear-fans flattened by the hot wind. A shallow cut ran beneath his jaw.

"They took the blue courier," he said.

Ilyen looked toward the observatory towers. "Alive?"

"The moths burned. Teren fell into Lantern Street. House Oren hunters reached him first."

"How much did he carry?"

"One mica groove. First well, potters' cell. He broke it before they searched him."

The facts aligned cleanly. Ilyen hated that his mind still did this work while grief had to wait outside the calculation.

"Move the potters to drain route four," he said. "No moth signal until moonrise."

"There is no moonrise."

"Tomorrow there will be an eclipse."

Oth gripped the roof rail. "That answer would be clever if Teren were less dead."

Ilyen closed the map. "You are right."

A second courier came over the roofs before he could say more. She carried a jar against her ribs. Inside, three star-moths battered themselves against darkness cloth, their wing points tracing the same angle.

"Hunters above Salt Market," she said. "They have observatory lenses tuned to moth ink. Every flight shows like a flare."

House Oren had once used those lenses to count migrations without trapping them. Ilyen had approved the military adaptation during his imperial service, reasoning that smuggler routes also carried night predators. His signature might still sit on the calibration table.

"Ground every moth," he said.

Oth stared at him. "The cells synchronize by flight."

"They synchronize by consent. Flight only tells us when they are ready."

“At totality, eleven minutes matters.”

“I know exactly what eleven minutes can do.”

The true eclipse table had cost him the memory of his first star-moth hatching. He knew where it had happened, which teacher had stood beside him, how old he had been. When he reached toward the wonder, nothing reached back. Later, at Rusk, he had paid with his mother’s night stories. Their words remained in fragments, stripped of her voice and the safety with which she had told them.

He would not burn another memory to save a signaling method.

Ilyen spread the map on the roof tiles and drew new routes. Laundry crews would hang twelve combinations of dark and pale cloth. Drain workers would send dye pulses into public fountains. Kilns would bank smoke by number. Workhouses would sound ordinary shift whistles at irregular intervals known only to their own paired cell. No central observer could read every method. South Granary would confirm readiness through ration marks carried openly on grain carts.

“What if one cell lies?” the second courier asked.

“Then its paired Night does not open through that site.”

“What if the lie ruins all twelve?”

Pikk had followed them onto the roof slowly. “My connections carry fracture, not command. A missing line leaves a closed well. It does not force the others shut.”

Ilyen looked at the Basilica. “We are not building perfection. We are building refusal into the mechanism.”

Below, a bell rang twice. People on the grain line ducked before learning it came from their own tally station. Fear traveled faster than explanation. It also tired sooner when work continued.

By midday, observatory hunters had closed three roof routes. Teren’s body remained in Lantern Street. Two more couriers disappeared near the white-road archive. One returned without his moth jar and with burns across both palms. Ilyen reassigned nothing until each cell’s witnesses approved the new messenger.

The delay enraged military command.

Before command arrived, Ilyen followed the failed white-road route to its last safe crossing. Lantern Street had become a strip of shuttered shops between observatory balconies. Teren still lay where he had fallen because House Oren hunters watched the body through mirrored scopes. A bakery family had drawn him beneath an awning with a dough hook, but reaching him would expose anyone who crossed the remaining pavement.

Oth wanted to go. Ilyen stopped him and asked the laundry court for three sheets. Workers soaked the cloth in blue dye and stretched it across the street on pulley lines, producing a moving wall that ruined the hunters’ reflections. Under that cover, two bakers carried Teren inside. His broken mica groove lay beneath his tongue. He had destroyed the readable number but preserved enough of the

cut for the potters' cell to recognize its own line.

They did not turn him into a courier saint. The bakery washed his body while Oth recorded the route error that had exposed him: Ilyen's map showed a covered arcade where imperial demolition had left open stone. A resident had warned the first routing meeting, but an observatory-trained planner had trusted the survey. Ilyen wrote the resident's warning beside his own mistake. Every later route required a street witness to walk it before another courier carried glass.

A captain arrived with written authority from the siege council to take the portable mirror north. "The Basilica assault begins before totality. The sappers need it on the terraces."

"They will have it tomorrow," Pikk said.

"They need to test the master reflection."

"Testing tells the master reflection what we built."

The captain turned to Ilyen. "Astronomer, you understand the deadline."

"Better than the person who wrote that order."

"This signature belongs to Zarha Kesh."

"Then Zarha expects us to tell her when she is wrong."

Pikk coughed into a folded cloth. When he drew it away, black flecks marked the linen. "The mirror stays until every cell reports. You can carry me to the siege council if you want the explanation delivered faster."

The captain left the mirror.

Sava arrived at dusk wearing House Oren white.

Workers at the granary door barred her with flour hooks. Her observatory coat bore the twelve-point collar of an imperial senior reader, though she had cut the sunburst buttons away. Two saltwood couriers followed at a distance with hands on their knives.

Ilyen met her under the ration ledger.

"You chose a dangerous coat," he said.

"It still opens dangerous doors." Sava's copper ear-fans carried no moths. Her seasonal ink had been scrubbed pale at the edges where House Oren removed the marks of defectors. "North Observatory remains sealed. The cell cannot reach its reflection chamber."

"Use the old rain cistern."

"Already assigned to the ninth well. Its angle misses north by seven degrees."

"The prison chapel has roof access."

"And no living witness with a shade-name recorded in North Ward."

He disliked the accuracy because it left only one answer.

Sava said, "I will take the northern window."

"No."

The word came with a brother's speed, before an astronomer could calculate.

Her face changed very little. "You have discovered family at an inconvenient hour."

"House Oren hunters control the tower."

"I trained half of them."

"They know you defected."

"They know I submitted evidence against the House plan. They do not know the tribunal accepted it, because the tribunal no longer meets."

Ilyen drew her aside from the doorway. Around them, grain sacks moved hand to hand. "You denounced me in Leth Aven."

"You had concealed eleven minutes that would kill thousands."

"I know."

"You want me to say I regret it."

"I want to know whether you came because you trust the dispersal or because it injures Oren."

Sava looked up at the white towers. "Both. Our motives have never waited to become pure before doing harm. I see no reason to demand purity before repair."

The sentence found a place inside him where his mother's voice should have answered. Only the fact remained: she had often forgiven Sava first. He could recall the unfairness. He could not recover its warmth.

"I gave the Empire the first moth-lens targeting tables," he said.

"I know. I found your approval seal."

"Teren died under them."

"Yes."

He waited for mercy. She offered accountability instead.

"At the North Observatory," Sava continued, "the keepers still believe singular custody protects knowledge. Some serve Caldra. Others intend to seize a freed Night for House Oren. I can reach them because they think I might agree."

"Do you?"

"No. But I understand why they will ask."

That marked the nearest they had come to reconciliation: no pardon, no denial, a truth placed where both could see it.

Ilyen gave her the mica groove for the twelfth well. "Break it if they take you."

"They taught us that together."

"I remember the lesson."

"Do you remember learning it?"

He searched. A darkroom, their shoulders touching, a teacher's hands. The image possessed no interior light.

"Not enough," he said.

Sava closed her fingers around the mica. "Then let me carry this part."

She entered South Labor through the grain gate and disappeared north in the uniform of the House that had erased her ink.

Night did not fall. The city darkened itself district by district.

A black sheet covered the laundry court. Potters submerged their lamps in settling water. Seven Camp hosts stretched patched tent cloth across the western yard and spoke the names of travelers buried far from home. Rill polishers banked their furnaces until heat remained without glare. At the veterans' bathhouse, donors entered the unlit steam room voluntarily, including six people whose dream loss made their own children strangers.

Readiness arrived through ordinary systems. A grain cart bore one uncrossed cup. Dye turned the south fountain blue, then clear. Four kiln smoke plumes stopped in sequence. The funeral kitchen sent out empty bread boards. Every signal required a witness at its origin and another at South Granary.

Ten cells confirmed.

The prison chapel remained silent. North Observatory showed full white light.

Ilyen stood beside the blackglass until his hands shook. Pikk adjusted the ashwood legs by fractions. No one proposed that Ilyen command the missing responses. They had learned what his command cost, and the entire design existed to prevent one expert from becoming necessary enough to rule.

A child from the prison ward arrived carrying a slate under his shirt. On it, a jail cook had drawn an open door beside the tenth well groove. The chapel cell had broken through its sealed crypt and admitted its ward witnesses.

Eleven.

Sun glare reddened over the western roofs. One day remained before the eclipse.

At North Observatory, a white lamp went out.

Another followed below it. Then the upper reflection chamber darkened, not all at once, but window by window as people inside chose and acted. A jar opened on the roof. Three surviving star-moths rose into the manufactured dusk, beyond the reach of the hunting lenses now that no imperial lamp remained to mark them.

Their flight bent south.

Pikk touched the blackglass frame. "Twelve lines carrying."

Ilyen did not mistake readiness for victory. The wells remained bound. Sava remained inside a hostile tower. The Basilica still held its master reflection, and totality would give Caldra the same opening it gave them.

He placed both palms against the cool glass. Across Avarra Ves, twelve shelters held twelve separate kinds of darkness without asking any of them to become one. In South Granary, the millers posted a final duty list for shutter ropes, fire buckets, injured replacements, and witnesses empowered to stop the opening. The list included three apprentices and one former imperial watchman. No astronomer ranked above them inside their own shelter. Ilyen signed beneath their names as a technical servant, then gave the chalk back to the council woman.

Every window stood ready to refuse.

Chapter 24 — The Siege of the Sun Basilica

Pikk drove a glass pin into the mortar and felt the Sun Basilica turn its attention toward him.

The pin shivered beneath his hammer. A black line no thicker than hair ran from it down the terrace stair, across South Labor roofs, and into the city's twelve prepared darkenings. White mirrors along the upper balustrade tilted by a fraction. Imperial engineers had detected stress in their master reflection.

"Pin seated," he told Vesh Rill.

His cousin's daughter repeated the signal by hand because noise crowded Pikk's damaged right ear. Two hundred sappers lay along the lower avenue behind overturned grain wagons. Above them, city rebels held the first terrace colonnade. Coalition shield crews waited in three lanes marked with flour, charcoal, and blue dye. None of those lanes pointed directly toward the great doors.

Direct approaches pleased mirrors. A straight charge gave reflection one intention to copy.

Pikk's left lung caught on his next breath. Glass splinters from Mirrorgate still lived in the tissue, too deep for knives. He waited through the tightening and studied the terraces.

The Basilica climbed in seven white levels. Each balustrade carried mirror plates angled to throw force downward or sideways. Their master reflection hung behind the central dome, where a framework of polished silver combined every plate into one obedient surface. Break a terrace mirror carelessly and the stored force struck the nearest moving body. Break the master without supporting twelve fracture lines and the recoil closed every civic window.

Three jobs, then. Blind the terrace fire. Keep a civilian route open through the eastern hospice. Reach the master reflection before imperial cutters severed Pikk's blackglass threads.

He had one portable mirror left, braced on a grain cart under twelve wet blankets. Its surface joined the fracture lines laid through drains and roof seams. Pikk could feel each district as a distinct tension: South Granary's steady pull, the potters' irregular water weight, the western caravan yard fluttering like cloth, North Observatory narrow and hard.

All twelve carried.

The siege map had no single commander's line. Zarha controlled the western fighter screen, Kessa protected the hospice and granary routes, and ward captains decided when civilians could cross their streets. Pikk controlled only fractures. That limit had already stopped one colonel from ordering a mirror dropped onto a residential roof. It also meant Pikk had to explain every change in terms that could survive translation through hand signs and work whistles.

He sent Vesh along the sapper line with three contingencies. A fist meant absorb force and hold. Two fingers meant redirect into empty stone. An open palm authorized a local break only after the nearest ward witness cleared it. Imperial armies could move faster because one order treated every terrace as property. The coalition's delay carried its own tactical cost, but people beneath those terraces retained the power to say where liberation could not fall.

At the eastern hospice, nurses hung patient lists from the grilles. Kessa's runners copied the counts onto slate and assigned litter teams before the breach opened. Pikk marked load-bearing walls with charcoal visible to the workers inside. The preparation consumed forty minutes while mirror fire struck the lower avenue. It also ensured that nobody had to choose between carrying a stranger and guessing whether the roof above them would hold.

A work whistle sounded from the dye ward. Rebel slingers rose behind the first colonnade and cast clay balls against the western plates. Blue pigment burst across polished surfaces. The mirrors turned toward the impact.

"Flour lane forward," Pikk said.

Khar shield crews advanced beneath pale cloth, not in ranks but in pairs separated by empty ground. White force struck one shield and returned its bearer's last hard shove. The blackglass absorbed part of it. The rest drove the pair backward into catch nets held by unarmed porters.

Rill sappers ran between impacts. They fixed fracture keys into the blue-stained mirrors, then twisted at different tempos. A single rhythm could feed the master. Disorder made each plate answer locally.

The first mirror cracked with a sound like lake ice under a heavy cart.

Force burst upward. Tiles lifted from the terrace and shattered against the dome. Coalition fighters surged into the gap. City rebels threw ropes from laundry balconies and dragged a second plate out of alignment.

Pikk marked one blind angle on his slate.

Imperial troops appeared along the third terrace. Their shields carried census names etched in white. Shadow doubles rose behind them, thinner beneath the unsetting sun yet strong enough to repeat each spear thrust. Pikk watched the donors rather than the echoes. Many wore infirmary gray beneath armor, bodies already impaired by years of shade extraction.

"Choir two," he ordered. "Sever echoes. Do not break the donor plates."

Vesh signed the command down the line.

The second fracture choir laid three blackglass rods across the avenue. When imperial spears struck, the rods bent the reflected intention into the paving stones. Shadow points stabbed downward. Cobblestones erupted. Donors stumbled with blood at their noses, alive and dreaming no worse than before.

A rebel captain shouted for the central stair.

Pikk caught her sash. "No straight lines."

"The doors are there."

"So are six mirrors waiting for one brave decision."

She jerked free. "People are dying while your sappers make angles."

"Angles decide which people."

A white flash erased the end of the sentence.

The flour lane vanished under reflected force. One catch net tore loose. Bodies struck the retaining wall. Pikk counted thirteen unmoving before dust covered them.

An upper plate had fired without taking an impact. The master reflection now copied commands sent from inside the dome.

Pikk tasted iron. "Change. Charcoal lane to hospice buttress. Blue lane holds. Choir one follows me."

The rebel captain pointed east. "There are civilians under that buttress."

He looked again.

White cloth moved behind the hospice grilles. The imperial evacuation seal had trapped patients and nurses between the terrace wall and an infirmary door barred from outside. Pikk's planned fracture would drop the buttress into their shelter.

"How many?"

"Two hundred, perhaps."

"Perhaps doesn't brace stone."

He crawled along the grain cart and put his good ear to a drainage pipe. Voices carried through it. A hospice worker counted one hundred eighty-six patients, forty-three staff, sixteen children visiting parents when the district sealed. Two patients had died during the morning bombardment. Thirty-seven could not walk.

The direct breach ended there.

Pikk changed his drawing on the slate. "Tunnel beneath the outer stair. Shore it toward the hospice. We drop the stair inward, not the wall."

"That costs two hours," Vesh said.

"We have less than one day."

"We may have less than two hours before they cut a window line."

Pikk handed her the slate. "Then dig like someone knows your name."

Rill crews opened the paving with quiet tools. Rebel porters carried spoil away in bread baskets. Above them, Khar hosts and human infantry kept imperial attention on the stained mirrors. Selai couriers moved between roof signals with moth jars sealed beneath their coats. No people supplied a single virtue. Everyone supplied work, fear, argument, and bodies that could fail.

Pikk went into the tunnel because the shoring angle belonged to him.

Glass dust found his damaged lung before the wet masks caught it. He coughed on hands and knees while Vesh set braces. The passage crawled beneath old foundations poured around bones. Basilica builders had mixed grave fragments into the white mortar, claiming ancestral shade as imperial material. Pikk refused to name that discovery aloud until the roof stopped moving.

At the stair footing, he cut three wedges and assigned each to a different choir. "On my fingers. Not the horn."

His right ear translated horns into pain and false echoes. Since Karth Veil, he heard some high tones twice, one arriving after the other. In blackglass work, that defect had sometimes warned him of stress. It had also made sleep a room where metal never stopped ringing.

Pikk raised one finger, then two.

At three, the wedges turned.

The outer stair folded inward. Stone dropped away from the hospice buttress and opened a sloped breach to the second terrace. Dust filled the avenue, but the wall above the patients held. Rebel crews cut the infirmary bar. Nurses brought out the thirty-seven who could not walk first.

The evacuation crossed under three kinds of protection. Khar shield pairs caught reflected blows in wet hide. Rill sappers rolled blackglass screens only after each impact cooled enough to touch. South Labor porters carried patients through the gaps without weapons, making it harder for shadow doubles to find a forceful intention worth repeating. One old man refused his litter until his daughter appeared from the refugee field. A nurse slapped his hand away from the frame and ordered the porters onward. Family reunion had no authority to block two hundred people behind him.

Imperial archers shifted to the upper windows. A bolt killed a porter beside Pikk and pinned a litter blanket to the paving. The patient beneath it lived. Pikk cut the cloth free with a fracture chisel while Vesh covered his back. He recorded the porter under civilian dead because the man wore no coalition mark, then added service during evacuation so later clerks would not erase what he had chosen to do.

Once the hospice emptied, ward crews did not abandon it. They turned the infirmary into a forward treatment room, keeping the western half below the undamaged buttress and marking the cracked rooms with red flour. Surgeons received casualties from both armies. Two imperial donors woke after their shadow doubles were severed and tried to crawl away, certain the coalition would kill them. A Seven Camp host gave them water under the same ration rule as everyone else. Neither gratitude nor allegiance followed. Their breathing steadied, which met the immediate purpose.

An imperial cutter found the laundry-court thread.

Pikk felt its tension snap through the portable mirror. Not break. Tighten. The cutter had clamped white metal around the blackglass dust line and begun pulling the cell's local darkness toward the master reflection.

"Laundry line under seizure," he said.

Vesh sent two sappers into the drain route. Pikk could not spare the portable mirror to follow. He pressed two fingers against its frame and read the other eleven tensions while battle moved around him.

South Granary held. Potters held. Western yard held. Conservatory wavered under mirror fire. Kiln cellar held. Veterans' bathhouse carried more strongly than before. Funeral kitchen, dye vault, prison chapel, rain cistern, and North Observatory remained distinct.

The laundry court pulled harder.

A centralized engineer would cut the threatened branch to save the system. Pikk had built no branch command into the glass. The laundry witnesses owned their line.

A dark sheet rose above the district roofs. It bore three pale squares: refusal, local cut, reroute.

"They're cutting themselves free," Vesh said.

The blackglass tension vanished, then returned through a drainage line the ward had prepared without Pikk's knowledge. Shorter, rougher, independent.

He laughed once and paid for it with a coughing fit.

The blackglass network had learned nothing. People had.

Coalition fighters reached the fourth terrace. Imperial defenders retreated toward the dome, taking donors with them. Mirror plates fired sideways through rebel-held colonnades. One bolt struck the hospice route after most patients had crossed. Nine staff and six patients died. Twenty-two more suffered burns or crushed limbs.

Pikk made himself write the count.

At the fifth terrace, master force held every door shut. The silver framework inside the dome had aligned its plates into a single reflective command: repel entry. Battering rams returned their own impacts. Shadow doubles repeated each charge. Even falling stones leaped outward.

Pikk led three fracture choirs through an ash chute beneath the ceremonial kitchens.

The passage ended behind a wall of white mirror backing. Heat from the optical chamber baked its plaster. He set his palms against it and found the master's rhythm.

Not one tone. Twelve well harmonics forced into one interval, with a thirteenth carrier tone for the throne.

His damaged right ear heard the carrier twice.

Pikk opened the wall one brick at a time. Beyond it, silver ribs curved through a chamber taller than Karth Veil's largest kiln. The master reflection hung vertical above a round shaft. Its surface showed no room. It showed twelve captive darknesses pressed into one outline, each moving against the others beneath white restraints.

Imperial mirrorwrights worked on three galleries. Some wore guild marks from Pikk's own labor city. Their foreman saw him and reached for the alignment lever.

"Vikka said you would come," she called. "She said you would mistake destruction for freedom."

Pikk crouched behind the brick opening as reflected force tore through it. "Vikka says many profitable things."

"She remained neutral. You made her city bleed for your revolt."

"Workers made choices your contracts denied them."

Another force strike broke the ash chute behind him. Retreat narrowed to a hole no stretcher could pass.

Vesh unpacked the choir forks. Three fracture choirs had crossed the terraces. Each consisted of six workers, not singers, who tuned glass by touch, breath, and struck metal. To break the master, they had to send a counter-pulse through twelve restraints at the instant the portable mirror completed its circuit.

Pikk's right ear could track the doubled carrier tone. No instrument could separate it under battle vibration.

Vesh pressed wax into his palm. "Protect the ear. We read your hand."

"If I block it, I lose the second arrival."

"You lose the ear if you don't."

"I have mostly lost it."

"Mostly still contains something."

The chamber shook. One civic tension faded, then returned. Totality had not begun, but the moon's first dark edge touched the sun. Imperial engineers drove the master harder.

Pikk looked at the workers around him. No owner commanded their hands. They had followed plans they could revise, through a breach changed for civilians, into a chamber built from their guilds' labor. He would not turn that consent into a speech about his own sacrifice.

"Wet cloth over the left," he said. "Leave the right open."

Vesh tied protection over his good ear.

The world narrowed into pain.

Pikk struck the first tuning bar. Choir one answered from the lower gallery. Choir

two drove rods into the western ribs. Choir three set fracture keys along the throne carrier. Imperial mirrorwrights pulled alignment levers; city rebels burst through a side door and fought them among silver braces.

The doubled tone climbed.

Pikk indicated corrections with both hands. Lower. Hold. Split. His right ear filled with a white shriek that became pressure, then heat. Blood ran down his neck. He kept listening because the second arrival told him how far the master reflection lagged behind its outer plates.

A gallery collapsed. Two choir workers fell into the shaft. Their line continued through replacements already waiting at the brace.

The portable mirror reached full tension.

Pikk cut his hand downward.

Eighteen workers struck at once.

Black fractures crossed the master reflection from twelve directions. For one heartbeat, every captive Night appeared separately in the surface: orchard dusk, salt dark, fungus shade, storm evening, moth-filled air, a camp shelter carried by roads. None stayed long enough to become an image Pikk could own.

The carrier tone tore through his right ear.

Sound stopped on that side.

The master reflection broke inward. White force collapsed into the shaft instead of returning across the city. Pikk's portable mirror shattered under its blankets. Blackglass threads burned out through drains and roof seams, leaving each civic darkness locally held and no longer connected to a central tool.

Sun Basilica mirrors went blind.

Blindness changed the battle unevenly. Lower plates dulled at once, releasing stored impacts as harmless warmth. Three upper mirrors cracked outward and showered the terraces with white splinters. Sappers shouted warnings by sight because Pikk could no longer judge direction through sound. On the western stair, imperial troops continued fighting after their shadow doubles collapsed, while one entire company lowered weapons when officers could no longer promise reflected protection.

The city rebels did not wait for a formal surrender. Mill workers jammed the western lift with iron hooks so defenders could not send donors down into the Noctuary. Potters carried wet clay onto hot mirror frames, preventing engineers from realigning loose plates. Former Basilica cleaners opened service passages whose doors had disappeared from military surveys. Their knowledge shortened the breach and also produced arguments at every junction, since some passages ran beneath sealed civilian dormitories. Kessa's corridor guards closed those routes despite the advantage.

Coalition rams struck the great doors. This time force did not return. The hinges

failed. City rebels entered through the ceremonial kitchens while Khar fighters held the hospice lane and Selai couriers marked routes away from the well shafts.

Pikk remained on his knees. His left ear heard shouting, glass fall, and his own uneven breath. The right offered nothing, not even the old false echo.

Vesh touched his shoulder from that side. He turned only when he saw her hand.

“Permanent,” she said.

He read the word on her mouth.

“Good,” Pikk answered, though grief moved through him with the relief. “Write it as cost, not cure.”

They counted before advancing. One hundred eighty-three coalition fighters and city rebels had died on the terraces. Ninety-six imperial defenders lay dead. Fifty-four civilians had been killed in sealed wards, mirror strikes, and the hospice crossing. Six hundred twelve wounded required treatment, divided among forces and residents rather than folded into the dead.

The numbers would change after searches. Pikk wrote provisional beside each.

Beyond the broken dome, a basalt door still sealed the ritual chamber. Imperial guards withdrew behind it with surviving mirrorwrights and throne attendants. The captive Nights pressed upward through the shaft, close enough now to cool the blood on Pikk’s neck.

The Basilica had been breached. Its heart remained held.

Chapter 25 — What Ilyen's Last Memory Bought

Ilyen climbed the North Observatory by its outer calibration ladder because bodies blocked the stairs.

House Oren keepers lay beside ward laborers on the landings, white coats and flour-marked sleeves mixed without agreement. Some breathed. Some did not. A young astronomer pressed both hands against a wound in an imperial guard's thigh while cursing him for firing on the window cell. No ancestry, uniform, or profession simplified the tower now.

Above Ilyen, the sun narrowed behind the moon. Its remaining light sharpened every roof edge in Avarra Ves. Eleven civic darkenings tugged at his inked skin through the approaching eclipse. The northern line answered weakly, then disappeared.

He climbed faster.

His knees struck iron rungs. One copper ear-fan caught on a bracket and tore along the rim. Blood ran warm into his collar. He retained enough training to know the injury looked worse than it felt. That judgment came from remembered instruction, not from the vanished wonder of learning it.

At the upper platform, Oth Aven hauled him over the rail.

"Reflection chamber sealed," Oth said. "Sava is inside with eight hosts. Oren loyalists hold the lens gallery."

"How many defectors?"

"Six alive. Two can stand."

"Other cells?"

"Ready. South Granary sent the opening mark. They are waiting for north."

The portable blackglass network had burned out when Pikk destroyed the master reflection. Local cells now held their own paths. That protected them from a single seizure, but synchronized opening depended on timing and twelve living civic alignments. Without North Observatory, the twelfth well remained closed. Caldra could still force the well through the throne when totality arrived, turning the missing local host into a point of imperial control.

Ilyen entered the calibration hall.

Broken star lenses covered the floor. Every step crushed glass that had once measured moth flight without harming it. At the far doors, two ward workers braced a telescope rail against white-coated loyalists pushing from the other side. One defender had wrapped House Oren seasonal ink around her wrists as a mourning band. Another wore saltwood bark plates over an imperial uniform.

"Vaor," the first woman said. "Your sister said you would know a second angle."

"There is no second civic angle within seven degrees."

“Then invent one.”

He almost rebuked her. Experts used impossibility as a shield after spending years teaching everyone else to depend on them. Ilyen looked instead.

The North Observatory’s reflection path ran from the roof lens through the upper chamber, down a hollow meridian column, and into the twelfth Noctuary well. House Oren had built its authority around controlling that line. Sava had entered with their credentials, admitted ward witnesses, and darkened the chamber one lamp at a time. When loyalists discovered the local host vote, they locked the lower column and attacked upward.

No alternate structure shared the angle. No blackglass remained to bend it. The moon would reach totality in minutes.

Ilyen tested the possibilities anyway. He sighted along a broken roof lens toward the rain cistern and found the same seven-degree error Sava had named. He asked the weather clerk whether the meridian column could be rotated. Its foundation reached four stories into the tower and had not moved since the Observatory’s founding. A surviving Rill sapper offered two blackglass splinters recovered from a burned thread, but together they could redirect no more than a handspan at the well depth. House Oren’s emergency mirror could carry the angle, though using it would place the northern opening under the senior keeper’s census seal.

That last method would open the well by granting Oren what Sava had come to prevent. Ilyen placed the mirror face down. Technical necessity often arrived wearing the preferences of whoever had designed the instrument. He had hidden behind such necessity through half his career. Now ward witnesses stood close enough to reject it.

The lamplighter gathered the eight local hosts before anyone touched the chamber doors. Each named a relation to North Ward: roofs cleaned, weather copied, dead washed, families removed by Observatory expansion, moth jars kept through the glare years. Two observatory keepers named their employment and also the evictions their institution had justified. No testimony canceled another. Their circle established that the window belonged neither to House Oren nor to Ilyen’s expertise.

“Open the doors,” Ilyen said.

The defenders stared at him.

“Oren expects us to keep pushing. Release the rail, move left, and let their force carry them through.”

They obeyed after the ward woman repeated the order in her own words. The telescope rail dropped. Doors burst inward. Three loyalists fell across the floor. Oth threw a moth-dark cloth over their white mirror shield. Ward fighters struck hands and knees rather than throats. Ilyen stepped around the struggle and reached the upper chamber.

Sava stood at the northern window with one palm pressed to the meridian

column.

All imperial lamps had gone out. A roof aperture cast the crescent sun across her face. Eight hosts formed a broken ring around her: observatory cleaners, two keepers, a ward lamplighter, a weather clerk, and three residents whose houses had been demolished to expand the tower. Each touched the column or someone who did.

The twelfth well pressed upward. Ilyen felt cold gather beneath the floor.

Sava saw the blood on his collar. "You took the ladder."

"The stairs looked occupied."

"They objected to my interpretation of House policy."

"Your interpretations often have that effect."

Their humor arrived dry and insufficient. It did not erase Leth Aven, Teren, the House plot, or forty years of service. It gave them one breath in which they remained brother and sister without demanding innocence.

Ilyen touched the meridian column. "The other eleven are waiting."

"The lower shutter is jammed."

"Can the weather counterweight move it?"

"Cut. The loyalists planned to hold north for Oren after the Basilica fell."

He examined the column seam. Someone below had driven a white-metal wedge into the alignment channel. Removing it required access from the lens gallery.

A bolt struck the chamber wall.

The loyalists had recovered. One fired through the open doors while others dragged the covered mirror shield clear. Oth and the ward fighters closed around the host ring.

"Hold contact," Sava said.

She moved before Ilyen could stop her. Her House coat let her cross the lens gallery threshold while its census lock still read her as authorized. She reached the maintenance wheel and drove both hands into its spokes.

A senior Oren keeper stepped from behind the roof lens. "Sava. We can preserve the well. Let the coalition open eleven."

"Preserve for whom?"

"For Leth Aven. For those who understand what a Night costs."

"The people under this tower understand cost."

"They are not trained."

"They voted."

The keeper drew a narrow mirror pistol.

Ilyen shouted her name.

Sava turned the maintenance wheel. The lower wedge shrieked along the channel. White force from the pistol crossed the gallery and struck beneath her ribs. It did not throw her back. Reflected intent repeated the keeper's desire to remove her, pinning her against the wheel while she forced it another quarter turn.

The wedge fell.

North's alignment opened.

Sava slid to the floor.

Oth's knife struck the pistol aside. Ward workers overwhelmed the keeper without killing him. Ilyen crossed the gallery on his knees because his legs failed before he reached his sister.

Blood spread across the white coat she had used to open dangerous doors. He pressed both hands to the wound. The force had passed through her liver and torn the vessels behind it. He knew the anatomy. Facts had never promised power.

"Sava."

Her eyes found him. "Is it open?"

"Yes."

"Do not give it to Oren."

"We won't."

She gripped his wrist once, more correction than farewell. "You don't know that."

"No." He made himself answer honestly. "We built refusal into it."

Sava breathed out. Her copper ear-fans relaxed against the floor.

Ilyen kept pressure on the wound until the weather clerk touched his shoulder and said there was no pulse. Then he kept his hands there longer. He expected a childhood feeling to rise, some stored darkness in which they had belonged to each other before work and guilt divided them.

The expected feeling did not come. He had already burned too much of the way back.

Oth closed Sava's coat over the wound. He did not remove the House collar, though a saltwood courier reached for it. "Evidence," he said. The ward lamplighter wrote the senior keeper's name, the weapon, the angle of fire, and every witness who had seen Sava turn the maintenance wheel. Ilyen supplied no title for her. Sister, defector, House observer, northern host, and astronomer would all enter later accounts, each incomplete. For the present record, the clerk wrote killed while opening a ward-controlled reflection path.

They moved Sava three paces from the meridian column because the living still needed the space. Ilyen helped lift her shoulders. Her weight surprised him, as the weight of any loved body might have done. He noticed that surprise without

finding the old family tenderness beneath it. Oth covered her face with moth-dark cloth and left one hand visible so the ward witnesses could identify her after the chamber changed.

Below, fighting continued in the calibration hall. The host ring had lost two members to wounds and one to panic. Replacements could not simply step in. Each new person had to state relation, receive the others' consent, and understand that opening the well might attract a captive Night injured by imperial custody. A roof cleaner joined for the wounded weather observer. An Oren apprentice asked to replace Sava and received refusal because she still claimed the House should own the released darkness. The refusal cost them time. It also kept the opening from becoming the seizure they opposed.

Cold vanished from the column.

One of the eight hosts had broken contact to help Oth. Another had been wounded. Sava's death removed the living alignment that held House authorization and ward consent together. The lower wedge lay open, but the twelfth well no longer recognized a complete relation.

Across the city, eleven windows began their opening. The pressure arrived through stone as separate pulses. North gave nothing.

"Put me in the ring," Ilyen said.

The ward lamplighter shook her head. "You do not live in North Ward."

"I served this observatory for nineteen years."

"Under the Empire."

"Yes."

"You approved the lenses that killed couriers."

"Yes."

No clock allowed him to soften the answers.

The woman looked at Sava, then at the surviving hosts. "We can witness his relation as injury and labor. We do not grant him custody."

Each host consented aloud. One refused to touch Ilyen and linked through the weather clerk instead. The shape remained theirs.

Ilyen took Sava's place at the meridian column.

The captive Night below did not welcome him. Pressure gathered around every harm his tables, lenses, and secrecy had enabled. He offered no argument. He needed to command one action only: align the open northern path with the local host ring for the length of totality.

Command required a darkness-linked memory.

He had one left from childhood that still carried feeling, his last memory of being comforted in darkness.

At nine, during a summer storm, he had hidden beneath a table while thunder

shook the shutters. Their mother sat on the floor beside him. Sava crawled under from the other side, furious that he had taken the safest place. Their mother put one hand on each child's neck and extinguished the lamp. In darkness, no one had to pretend the thunder was small. Ilyen remembered the cool underside of the table, Sava's foot against his ankle, his mother's thumb moving slowly below his ear. Comfort had possessed weight, temperature, and a boundary the storm could not cross.

He knew what the memory contained. Once spent, he would continue to know the facts.

Ilyen placed his bleeding palm against the column.

"Open through us," he said.

The memory burned without flame.

The table remained. A storm had happened. His mother and Sava had sat beside him. Those statements survived with perfect clarity. Their comfort disappeared. He could not reach the safety, could not recall why a hand below his ear had made darkness bearable, could not feel Sava's foot as anything beyond contact recorded long ago.

Grief did not vanish. It lost its oldest shelter.

The twelfth well answered.

Cold rushed up the meridian column and passed through the host ring. It carried no single image. North Ward's dead, demolished houses, weather records, trapped moths, roof fungi, and willing sleepers pressed into relation without surrendering their differences. Ilyen held alignment and nothing more.

A shadow crossed the crescent sun.

Signals rose from the city: whistles, dark cloth, dye in fountains, hands on columns, shutters closed by people who had chosen their own rooms. One by one, then together without becoming identical, the twelve windows opened.

Totality began.

Chapter 26 — The Eclipse Battle

Darkness struck the Basilica roofs, and Zarha Kesh heard forty years of soldiers forget their orders.

The last rim of sun vanished behind the moon. White terraces lost their glare. Imperial mirror plates became dull squares set among broken columns. Across Avarra Ves, people cried out from astonishment, fear, and remembered ritual. Some fell to their knees. Others lifted weapons toward a sky that had done nothing but keep its appointed distance.

Zarha stayed standing because three hundred people waited for her hand.

“Eleven minutes,” she called. “Hold the windows. Keep the east hospice clear. No one follows darkness without a living guide.”

Her reflective eyes opened to totality. What humans called blackness contained roads: the warm gray of bodies, the blue damp of stone, the faint green life in roof moss, the silver outline around Khar eyes. After months beneath an unsetting sun, seeing without pain felt dangerous enough to resemble grace.

She did not trust grace during a siege.

Below the central dome, the twelve civic openings answered the eclipse. Cold pushed through the broken optical shaft. It came in separate pulses that refused one rhythm. Orchard Night smelled of wet bark and opened seed husks. Salt Night scraped dry grains across tile. A darkness thick with moth wings touched the upper gallery and sent surviving star-moths out of clay jars across the city. Seven Camp’s captive Night arrived as shelter cloth lifting over a road, its absence from home made present as injury.

None spoke.

The Nights recognized relations offered through the windows. They also recognized the white restraints still buried in the wells. Their pressure cracked mortar around the ritual chamber and filled every hollow in the Basilica with moving dark.

Imperial horns recovered first.

Three notes called reserves from the eastern barracks. A fourth ordered shadow companies to protect the throne path. Donors on the lower terraces stiffened as their doubles rose beside them. Every shadow repeated the last forceful intention pressed into its donor: bar the gate, hold the stair, kill whoever crossed the white line, keep a child from entering a burning room. Imperial officers had built formations from those intentions without caring where they began.

A gray-haired donor shouted her daughter’s name while her double drove a spear through a South Labor defender.

“Sever, don’t crush,” Zarha ordered.

Blackglass shields had shattered with Pikk's master reflection, but fracture keys remained among the choirs. Rill workers drove the keys into paving seams while Khar fighters caught shadow thrusts on wet hide. The echoes tore loose in strips. Each severance dropped a donor, stunned but alive.

One imperial cohort charged before the sappers could prepare. Zarha met them on the fifth terrace.

Her right thigh pulled at the old spear cut. It had opened again against Besh's doubles weeks earlier and never healed beyond what marching allowed. She shortened her stride and used the terrace rail. The first soldier swung low, expecting the limp. Zarha trapped his blade between rail spindles and struck his throat with the heel of her hand. The second carried an orchard-clan witness knot beside an imperial sunburst. She cut the sword belt rather than the wearer and shoved her into two advancing troops.

"West screen fold!" Zarha called. "Leave them a retreat."

Akar Seven fighters yielded three paces. The imperial cohort entered the gap, then found no enemy at its center. Coalition pairs struck from both sides, taking knees and weapon hands. Forty-three soldiers surrendered. Nineteen fought until wounds stopped them. Seven died.

Zarha ordered their census shields broken and their water flasks left.

The surrendered cohort could not remain on an active terrace without guards. Zarha assigned twelve fighters to disarm them, then changed the arrangement when a former imperial nurse pointed out that six prisoners carried donor-collapse symptoms. Mera's hosts moved those six beneath a cloth awning, away from the white plates still embedded in the paving. Three refused treatment from Khar hands. A human medic stayed with them while the remaining prisoners carried their own wounded down one level.

Along the western edge, totality disrupted both commands and bodies. Human infantry trained to read mirror flashes lost their signals. Khar road scouts saw well in darkness but did not know the Basilica stairs. Selai couriers could follow star-moths across open roofs, though enclosed galleries deprived them of flight cues. Rill sappers navigated structure by touch and then stopped at every unsupported span. Zarha paired units by missing skill rather than people, making Khar scouts follow Basilica cleaners, Selai couriers carry Rill stress marks, and human infantry guard moth jars from wind.

An officer accused her of breaking companies during attack. She answered by pointing to the third terrace, where an intact company had followed its captain into a mirror pit. Twenty-seven soldiers remained trapped there under reflected versions of their own charge. Mixed rescue pairs approached from angles no single training doctrine would have chosen and brought nineteen out alive. The others entered the dead count before the fighting moved on.

A runner climbed from Kessa's corridor with blood on both sleeves. "East

hospice blocked. Throne guard dropped the saint bridge. Four hundred civilians trapped between the Basilica dormitory and the dye stairs."

"Can the lower lane take them?"

"Mirror debris closed it."

"Where is Kessa?"

"Under the bridge."

Of course she was.

Zarha gave the western terrace to Mera Seln. The old Bearer accepted command only after stating its bounds: protect hosts, donors, wounded, and anyone who laid down arms; do not pursue into the ritual chamber. Two free-court captains objected to a nonmilitary host taking the line. Zarha made them repeat the order from Mera's mouth. Authority needed more than a familiar weapon to become real.

She took eighty fighters east.

The saint bridge had once carried imperial processions between the hospice and the Basilica dormitory. Its central span now lay across the evacuation stair, stone saints face down among the injured. Kessa stood on the wreckage directing litters through a gap beneath one carved shoulder. Her left eye had swollen shut. The open right eye tracked every body.

"Four hundred?" Zarha asked.

"Three hundred eighty-six at first count. Thirty-two cannot walk. Eleven died when the bridge fell. There are imperial families mixed with ward rebels, so both sides keep trying to sort them before moving them."

"Stop the sorting."

"I have. It keeps starting again."

An imperial lieutenant held twenty dormitory residents at sword point on the upper landing. "They go north. Rebels go east."

Kessa shouted back, "North stair is burning."

"My orders name the route."

"Your route kills them."

"My orders remain."

The lieutenant's shadow double stood beside him, formed from a donor's rigid intention to keep a door closed. It could not adapt to a fallen bridge.

Zarha climbed onto the saint's back. "Lieutenant, send one soldier north without civilians. If that soldier returns, take your route."

"You have no command here."

"No. The fire does."

A young imperial soldier looked north, smelled smoke, and lowered his spear.

The shadow double struck him across the face for crossing its assigned line.

That broke the lieutenant's certainty. Kessa's litter crews surged through the pause. Zarha's fighters raised wet cloth against shadow blows while Rill sappers reached the donor plate. The echo collapsed. The young soldier carried the first ward child through the gap.

Command friction did not end. Coalition archers demanded the east stair for a line of fire. Kessa refused because litters still crossed. A free-court captain tried to move the wounded aside. Zarha removed his witness knot and gave his company to the oldest litter bearer until the last thirty-two immobile civilians passed.

The delay cost the sixth terrace. Imperial reserves took it and drove city rebels down two levels. Their shadow doubles poured over the blind mirrors like spilled ink.

A horn from North Observatory sounded once, broke, then sounded again.

Sava's signal should have carried three notes. Ilyen's signal used two.

Zarha understood the absence without knowing its shape. North remained open, but someone had paid.

Totality entered its third minute.

The Nights rose higher.

Basalt doors around the ritual chamber cracked from within. Darkness flowed through the seams and changed the roof terrain. Fungus spread over white mortar where an eastern marsh Night touched it. A storm Night condensed water in open air, turning stairs slick. Seven Camp's Night drew every loose cloth upward, making tents of banners, bandages, coats, and surrender flags. Beneath those shelters, shadow doubles weakened because their donors' last intentions encountered relations the imperial orders had stripped away.

They did not awaken into souls. One echo continued thrusting at an empty stair until cloth covered its census plate. Another repeated a mother's protective shove and moved a wounded stranger out of falling stone. No choice guided either action. Circumstance changed the result.

The distinction grew harder to hold when darkness altered what an intention touched. A shadow cast from a miller's determination to keep a wheel turning seized a broken capstan and opened a sealed dormitory vent. An echo formed from an executioner's last ordered strike chopped at a fungal mat until its donor collapsed screaming. Coalition fighters wanted to praise the first and punish the second. Zarha ordered both severed when fracture workers reached them. Useful outcome did not create a soul, and horrific outcome did not make the donor the echo's willing author.

Local hosts entered the roof battle carrying no weapons. Potters brought bowls of unlit water to keep the first well's relation open. Seven Camp families repaired shelter cloth each time arrows tore it. Funeral cooks passed names through a line

of hands so the eighth window did not lose contact when one witness died. Imperial archers recognized the hosts as targets and shifted fire away from soldiers. Coalition shields followed, reducing strength on the inner stairs.

At the saltwood conservatory line, a white bolt shattered three clay moth jars. The surviving insects scattered into storm-dark air, ruining the signal pattern. Oth Aven stopped trying to restore the original flight. He asked the conservatory families to witness the change, then opened the bark beds so moths could choose shelter among local roots. The well pressure returned unevenly but strong. A fixed signal had failed; a relation adapted without command.

Zarha crossed the sixth terrace under moth-dark air.

Her objective had narrowed. Twelve window paths had to remain locally held until the well restraints released. Kessa could keep the east route open. Mera held the west hosts. Pikk's sappers attacked the last physical clamps. Zarha needed to reach the ritual chamber and prevent the throne guard from giving Caldra an unopposed command path.

An imperial road-charter banner appeared at the inner stair.

Besh Kor carried it.

He wore no imperial armor. Noctuary burns ringed his throat where a failed shadow-binding had nearly turned him into a donor and echo at once. Zarha's strike group had freed him at the outer station. Since then he had provided well-index testimony under guard, refused coalition rank, and spoken only when a witness question required it.

Now two thousand road-chartered Khar stood behind him on the inner terraces.

Some had fought for the Empire at Three Evenings. Others had deserted after seeing donors collapse. Settled orchard clans among them feared the free courts as much as imperial punishment. They had allowed Besh to carry their banner because no coalition commander owned their oath.

Zarha stopped beyond spear reach. "Whose stair are you holding?"

"The road-charters'," Besh said.

"Caldra is above it."

"So are the throne and the well release."

"We agreed on many-host dispersal."

"You agreed. Free courts, communes, labor wards, and a council built while seventy-two thousand hungry people watched your grain. My settlements were not there."

"You were invited to witness."

"As a prisoner."

"As a commander who sent shadow doubles against us."

Besh's broken tusklet showed when he bared his teeth. "There. That is the truth

under your tent. You need my testimony and despise the mouth carrying it.”

Zarha did despise him in parts. He had hunted Seven Camp across the Red Salt. His road-charter troops had killed donors and refugees. Yet his service had protected settled Khar orchards from raids the open courts preferred to call regrettable custom. He carried crimes and evidence in the same body.

“What do you demand?” she asked.

“Witness combat. Your office against my charter. The winner binds our response until totality ends. If you win, my troops hold the wells against imperial seizure and accept local window custody. If I win, we close the Khar-indexed wells until our settlements consent.”

“Closing them now leaves Caldra the throne path.”

“Then prove your urgency without claiming my people.”

Behind Zarha, a captain hissed that they should rush him. Two thousand spears lowered in reply. A battle there would spend the remaining minutes and hand Caldra every advantage.

Khar witness combat did not decide truth. It decided who carried liability for an immediate act when deliberation could not finish. The loser survived when possible, because a dead witness could not testify later. Imperial road-charters had corrupted the form into officer duels. Free courts had sometimes romanticized it into spectacle. Zarha’s office required her to name both distortions before accepting.

“This combat does not absolve prior acts,” she called so both lines heard. “It does not grant permanent command. It binds one response through totality. The loser remains witness and may challenge the account afterward.”

Besh planted the charter banner in a crack. “Agreed.”

Mera’s voice came from the western rise. “Witnessed.”

The circle formed among broken mirror plates while war continued around it.

Besh chose a short spear. Zarha carried her shelter knife and a hooked staff taken from a fallen standard. Neither wore shields. The road-charter fighters stamped once, then fell silent.

He attacked her right thigh.

No feint disguised it. Besh knew the wound and believed truth in combat included every weakness history had made. Zarha caught his shaft with the staff hook, but the spearhead scored her scar. Pain folded the leg. She dropped to one knee.

Besh reversed and drove the butt toward her temple. Zarha rolled under it, caught a handful of his coat, and cut the road-charter seals from his shoulder. He struck her mouth with an elbow. Blood filled her lower lip.

“Your courts abandoned orchard roads,” he said.

Zarha swept the staff at his ankle. "Your charters sold census names."

He jumped the sweep and kicked her injured thigh.

The circle tilted. Totality had reached its sixth minute. Beyond Besh, Caldra's throne guard moved along the upper gallery. Zarha could not watch both.

She stopped trying.

Besh expected anger to shorten her decisions. Zarha gave him retreat instead. She yielded two steps toward a cracked mirror, presenting an open line to her ribs. He drove the spear.

Her staff hook caught the shaft below its head. Rather than resist, she turned with the thrust and directed it into the mirror crack. Blackglass residue from Pikk's fracture choir gripped the metal. Besh pulled. Zarha stamped the shaft sideways.

Wood broke.

He kept the jagged half and came inside her staff. The broken spear cut across her forearm. Zarha struck his burned throat with the staff end, not hard enough to crush it, only enough to steal breath. He answered with his forehead against her cheek ridge. White light burst through her vision although the sun remained covered.

They fell together.

Besh reached her shelter knife first. He put its edge beneath her jaw.

Zarha held the broken spear against the Noctuary burns at his throat. Pressure from either weapon could kill. Around them, road-charter fighters waited. A free-court archer drew despite the terms.

"Lower it," Zarha told the archer.

Besh laughed once, painfully. "Still chairing the tent."

"Still trying to survive it."

He pressed the knife. A thin line opened under her jaw.

Zarha could shove the spear fragment through his burned tissue before he cut. The fastest victory required a dead witness. It would also tell his troops that coalition consent lasted until urgency found it inconvenient.

She released the fragment.

Besh's surprise loosened the knife by a fraction.

Zarha trapped his wrist, rolled her body across his elbow, and drove her knee onto his weapon hand. The old thigh wound tore wider. She kept turning until his fingers opened. Then she kicked the knife beyond the circle and pinned him facedown with the staff across both shoulders.

"Yield the response," she said.

He breathed against the tiles. Darkness from Seven Camp moved over them like shelter cloth testing unfamiliar stakes.

"I yield through totality," Besh said. "Nothing beyond."

"Witnessed," Mera called.

Zarha rose without killing him.

The road-charter fighters changed their spear angle. Half faced the throne guard. Half turned toward the well shafts to protect donors and local hosts. None raised Zarha's banner. Their own remained planted beside Besh, exactly as the terms required.

Their change carried immediate cost. An imperial cavalry remnant struck the eastern well before the new line settled. Road-charter orchard troops locked shields around potter hosts they had never met, while free-court riders covered their exposed flank. Neither formation trusted the other enough to merge. They exchanged route calls through two witnesses stationed between them. When a cavalry horse fell into the fungal dark, settled Khar pulled its human rider free and then bound her hands. Mercy did not cancel captivity. Cooperation did not dissolve the dispute that had required combat.

A road-charter sergeant brought Zarha three census plates taken from fallen throne guards. He refused to hand them to her directly and placed them under Mera's witness staff instead. "For severance only," he said. "No free-court archive." Mera accepted the condition. Rill workers cracked the plates at the well edge, releasing fourteen donors from shadow commands. Four woke. Ten remained unconscious and were carried behind the road-charter banner, not into coalition custody.

"Take him to the witness stair," Zarha ordered.

Besh pushed away the hands offered to help him. "I can walk."

"You can testify. Walking is optional."

His glare carried no gratitude.

Totality entered its eighth minute.

Zarha ran for the ritual chamber.

The basalt doors had opened inward. Twelve Nights flooded the round space around the command throne, each tethered by a white restraint descending into its well. The throne stood on a narrow bridge above them, built from census mirrors and bone-white metal. Its seat faced no audience. A circlet of blackened silver waited above its back, connected to twelve levers.

Coalition sappers held the lower bridge against throne attendants. Imperial donors crowded side galleries, some conscious, others moving only through commands embedded in their shadows. Kessa's corridor entered from the east and carried civilians out through a service arch. She had tied a blue strip over her injured eye.

"Three hundred still below," Kessa shouted. "Attendants sealed the dormitory stairs."

“Can you reach the throne?”

“Not while I’m moving them.”

A coalition colonel ordered her litter crews onto the bridge.

Zarha removed him from command with one sentence. “You answer to Kessa until the last civilian crosses.”

He objected. Mera, arriving behind them, cut his rank sash. The colonel went to the litters.

Pikk sat against the optical shaft with blood dried below his right ear. He could not hear Zarha approach from that side. Vesh signed to him, and he pointed toward a narrow service gallery above the throne.

Before Zarha could follow his hand, the eastern well restraint tore loose from its wall. A band of captive marsh darkness swept across the lower bridge. It cooled fevered donors, drowned two open braziers, and covered a stair in ankle-deep water filled with pale fungal threads. Imperial soldiers slipped. Coalition troops behind them slipped too. Kessa’s litter crews abandoned wheeled frames and made hand chains across the current.

One throne attendant tried to close the eastern lever. Pikk threw a fracture chisel left-handed. It struck the mechanism rather than the person, jamming the lever halfway. Vesh and two choir workers crawled onto the bridge to wedge it open. An imperial donor seized Vesh’s ankle. The man had no shadow remaining and acted from his own fear. She kicked free, then came back with another sapper and pulled him above the water before he drowned.

Zarha saw the command throne through moving layers of Night. Its twelve levers gathered restraints from separate wells, but the bridge approaching it admitted only one body at a time. The architecture expressed the Empire’s argument more clearly than any proclamation: many places might supply power, yet one sovereign received the seat. Breaking the bridge would deny Caldra access and also trap hundreds in the galleries. Zarha could not destroy it while Kessa’s evacuation crossed below.

Caldra Ves had entered through it.

The Empress wore no crown and carried no weapon. Four throne attendants surrounded her with white shields. Zarha saw a woman of fifty-nine moving carefully through a building that had killed for her policy. She also saw the route impossible to reach before Caldra crossed the bridge.

“Stop her!” someone shouted.

Every side acted at once.

Coalition archers fired. White shields returned the arrows as shadow force. Two attendants fell. Imperial reserves charged the lower bridge. Road-charter Khar intercepted them under Besh’s yielded response. Civic hosts at the windows pulled against well restraints. The Nights surged, turning stairs into orchard root, salt

crust, storm water, moth-dark air, fungal mats, and shelter cloth.

Zarha reached the bridge entrance.

A shadow soldier met her with her own intention.

It carried the force of her command to protect the hosts, taken from blood dropped on a census mirror during the Noctuary descent. The echo shoved her away from the throne and toward a falling window keeper. Its action saved the keeper while blocking Zarha.

She could not argue with intent. She stepped where it pushed, caught the keeper, and lost the remaining distance.

Caldra reached the command throne.

The Empress placed both hands on its arms. Twelve white restraints tightened. Darkness convulsed through the chamber. Local Nights pressed back through their windows, still distinct, but the throne carrier drew their captive portions toward one shape.

Above, the first edge of sun prepared to return.

Caldra lowered the blackened circlet over her head.

The battle count arrived by runners while the chamber fought around them, provisional and already unbearable: 914 coalition fighters and city defenders dead; 1,327 imperial troops and donors dead; 499 civic hosts and civilians dead, including Sava Vaor at the northern window. The total reached 2,740. Wounded exceeded the space available to lay them down. Those numbers covered the eclipse battle and its window actions, not the dead of Mirrorgate or the pre-totality Basilica siege.

Kessa kept the east route open.

Besh remained alive on the witness stair.

Pikk's deaf side faced the throne while his good ear followed the cracking wells.

Zarha dragged herself upright as the old wound filled her boot.

Caldra spoke the first command into the circlet.

Twelve captive darknesses began to move toward one imperial Night.

Chapter 27 — When One Night Refused One Throne

Caldra closed both hands around the command throne and ordered twelve darknesses to breathe together.

The circlet tightened across her temples. White restraints dropped from its rim into the wells. Each one carried a district, a captive Night, and tens of thousands of shade-names collected under imperial census law. For forty years, clerks had written those names into safety tables. For forty years, armies had carried the tables outward beneath an unsetting sun.

Now the names pulled back.

Darkness climbed the throne bridge. Orchard rain touched Caldra's left hand. Salt scored the right. Moth wings filled her mouth without entering it. A storm gathered behind her eyes. Other Nights arrived as root pressure, burial cloth, warm animal breath, fungus opening wood, a road sheltered by many tents.

She gave them the imperial pulse used in every reservoir test: gather, equalize, hold.

The first command took a memory.

Alsen Ves at nine years old sat on the nursery floor, teaching his younger brother Jori to stack copper census tiles. Caldra remembered the room, the boys' ages, and the nurse who scolded them for scratching the sunburst. Affection disappeared from the scene. Her brothers became two children whose deaths later changed imperial succession.

Pain followed after the loss, too late to save what had gone.

"Equalize," she said again.

The twelfth Night pushed north. The seventh remained beneath funeral-kitchen cloth. The third spread through South Granary flour dust. Instead of gathering, each captive darkness leaned toward the civic window that had opened it.

Throne attendants fought around the bridge. Two held white shields against coalition arrows. One lay beside the eastern lever with a fracture chisel through his hand. Caldra heard the battle as a series of quantities: bridge width, guard strength, minutes of totality, well pressure, dead accumulating beyond the chamber. Compressing suffering into count had let her govern it. Count also prevented any one scream from becoming policy.

She pulled the second and fifth levers.

"Align by common injury."

Another memory burned. Jori coughing beneath plague cloth while Caldra held a cup against his lips. The cup remained blue ceramic. He had been six. The room smelled of boiled fennel and human waste. She no longer felt the desperation with which she had tried to make him swallow.

The Nights touched one another.

For an instant, Caldra sensed what she had promised the Empire: one mobile shelter crossing every road, wide enough for trade caravans, plague wards, armies, seed vaults, children who feared predators beyond a village lamp. A regulated darkness that no local lord could close against a stranger. Her evidence remained sound. Night-beasts had killed fewer people where imperial roads replaced feudal shade tolls. Grain moved farther. Midwives crossed borders after dark without paying burial silver.

Then the contact separated into twelve relations.

At the potters' window, hosts offered unlit water and cracked bowls bearing household names. Seven Camp offered cloth carried across roads and graves named far from home. North Observatory offered weather ledgers, demolished houses, moth jars, guilt, and Sava Vaor's blood. These acts did not define darkness alike. They prevented sameness from becoming a condition of shelter.

Caldra increased force.

The circlet drove white heat into her scalp. A third memory left: her mother standing at the palace infirmary door, barred from the boys because a physician feared contagion. Caldra retained the physician's name and the legal order. The sensation of her mother's hand crushing hers vanished.

"Common custody," Caldra commanded.

Salt Night stripped polish from one throne arm. Orchard Night sent roots through the bridge joints. Moth-dark air covered the census mirrors until they could no longer return a single image.

The throne answered resistance with more memory channels.

Caldra had designed that response. A commander who hesitated could not hold One Night. The circlet would offer another person, another darkness-linked recollection, another chance to prove the promised peace mattered more than private feeling.

She accepted.

Captain Orra Fen closing the east palace gate during the Night Plague. A road engineer named Vek standing beneath the first permanent noon mirror while caravans cheered. A village mother whose child survived a night-beast attack in an imperial shelter. A donor from the western wards who thanked Caldra after his shadow entered service, before dream loss made gratitude inaccessible. Each person remained in the record of her mind. Their faces lost emotional weight.

She spent a palace gardener who had shown her moths sleeping under leaves. She spent a field surgeon washing black fever from his hands in darkness. She spent the old tutor who taught her that a sovereign must remember a number represents bodies.

The command strengthened.

Reservoir measures climbed across the throne arms. Caldra read them by habit: host resistance, shade-name compliance, donor stability, road projection. Imperial designers had given no measure to voluntary refusal. A host who withdrew appeared as loss. A local Night that changed through relation registered as contamination. When different darknesses touched without merging, the throne classified the result as noise.

She had approved every category. Advisers had warned that consent would make the system unreliable because communities could interrupt trade guarantees or deny military shelter. Caldra had answered that public safety could not depend on local mood. Now the instruments translated living difference into technical defect exactly as she had required.

On a side gallery, surviving ministers argued over succession protocols while the battle continued. One urged her to bind only the six most compliant wells and declare partial victory. Another proposed draining resistant hosts until their windows collapsed. A third asked whether House Oren could be promised the northern reservoir in exchange for alignment. Their divisions proved the Empire contained no single appetite, yet every offered solution preserved a deciding center. Caldra rejected each without relinquishing the premise beneath them.

"All twelve," she ordered. "No provincial monopolies."

The command carrier opened reserve channels beneath the city. Registered prisoners, hospice patients, palace servants, and Night donors appeared as available subordinate operators. The throne could not issue through them without her authorization and physical command bands. Every order would burn one darkness-linked memory from the person forced to carry it. The display showed how many people remained to conscript. Caldra had once called the authorization requirement humane.

Twelve captive portions rose above the wells and pressed into a towering outline. It had no face. Shadow soldiers across the terraces turned toward it, awaiting a shared intention. Imperial troops cried out in triumph. Coalition hosts pulled at their local windows.

"Hold," Caldra said.

The outline bent toward the throne.

From the northern restraint came a memory not hers: a child under a table during thunder, a mother's hand, a sister's foot. Its feeling had been burned away. Only relation remained, offered through a wounded astronomer and a ward that denied him custody.

From the west came graves Seven Camp had carried in spoken routes because settled stone could not follow refugees. From the veterans' bathhouse came donors who had refused renewed census ownership. The prison chapel sent relations from people imperial law declared unable to host anything. South Granary carried a ration council's posted counts and the authority to stop its own opening.

Caldra tried to reduce them to functions.

North: astronomical alignment. West: mobile shade. Bathhouse: donor reservoir. Chapel: unregistered host mass. Granary: supply darkening.

The throne accepted those categories. The Nights did not.

Their outline broke at the shoulders. Storm entered salt and became neither storm nor salt. Moth darkness crossed orchard shade, then returned altered without surrendering its source. Funeral-kitchen Night touched the road shelter and carried names farther than either had held alone. Contact multiplied relation.

Caldra pulled all twelve levers.

The circlet offered her the deepest remaining memory of the Night Plague.

At thirteen she had stood outside a lord's private darkhouse while city children died in the lit street. The lord kept his household inside with water, fungus beds, and licensed healers. Caldra struck the locked door until her palms bled. He opened only after the palace guard promised him land and immunity. By then Alsen no longer breathed. Jori died before dawn.

That night had governed every law she later wrote.

She paid it.

The street remained in memory. She knew the number of bodies, the lord's title, the bargain, her brothers' times of death. Rage left. Grief left. The locked door no longer felt like a wound. It became an administrative failure in Year 371.

Caldra sat within the purpose emptied of its source.

The One Night almost formed.

Every shadow soldier in the Basilica rose. Beyond the walls, darkness drew itself along imperial roads. For a breath, one shelter reached from the capital toward provinces that had not consented. It promised equal access because no local hand could close it.

It also required every local hand to let go.

At twelve windows, people refused.

Not with one word. The potters opened an overflow channel, changing their host relation. Seven Camp loosened its cloth so the road wind entered. Veterans admitted nine people who had refused the first vote, because consent could change. Prison cooks spoke the dead by household rather than census number. North Observatory removed House Oren's emergency mirror from the chamber. Each difference pulled one living Night away from singular identity.

South Granary altered its host list when two millers left to carry wounded. Their council replaced them through a posted vote instead of demanding they remain. The laundry court cut a reflection line after imperial troops entered one house and resumed through another roof only when residents agreed. At the old rain cistern, hosts admitted water carriers from an enemy cohort who had surrendered minutes

earlier. The darkness there changed pressure around the newcomers but did not reject them by uniform.

Each revision weakened the throne because its census expected stable categories. Caldra tried freezing host lists at the instant totality began. Civic windows continued changing outside the command. She ordered the wells to ignore late consent; Nights followed the living relations instead. She commanded them to honor registered names only; the prison chapel answered through people the Empire had declared legally absent.

No window defeated her alone. Together, their differences denied the assumption that one definition could preserve every shelter. The many-host plan carried no superior force. It carried more places where a command could fail.

Caldra commanded harder.

No memory rose.

The circlet searched and found records without feeling. Alsen. Jori. Her mother. Orra Fen. Vek. The gardener. The surgeon. The donor. Thousands she had visited, decorated, counted, displaced, or promised to protect. Their facts remained organized. She could no longer feel why any one of them had mattered beyond policy.

One Night stood at the edge of obedience, fed by a woman who had spent the people from her own purpose.

Below the throne, a Khar night-reeve dragged herself across the bridge with blood soaking one boot. Caldra knew Zarha Kesh's age, office, injury history, population, military strength, and likely negotiating position. None of those entries explained why the woman had spared Besh Kor when killing him would have shortened the battle.

Caldra asked, "Why keep the witness alive?"

Zarha stopped beyond the last white restraint. "Because urgency does not make my office innocent."

"You would risk the settlement for one enemy's testimony?"

"He is not one enemy. He carries people your census taught us to treat as a single column."

Caldra looked into the rising imperial darkness. "Local lords closed Night against plague children. I ended that power."

"You moved the door." Zarha's voice shook from blood loss. "Then you put your throne behind it."

The words found no rage to strike. Caldra had spent that memory. Logic remained.

During the Night Plague, a lord had claimed the right to decide whose need counted, centralized safety inside his house, and called exclusion necessary to preserve shelter. Caldra had built a larger house. Its door crossed a continent. Its

lock used census names. Its promise reached more people, and its command permitted no refusal.

Scale had changed the beneficiaries. It had not changed the claim.

Many Nights pulled against the throne.

Caldra could still force them. The system had reserve channels that could turn living palace attendants and prisoners registered below the Basilica into operators, while her own remaining darkness-linked memories from adulthood could fund further commands. She could conscript people she no longer loved and make each surrender a memory, which made the mechanism easier now.

That ease convicted the design more clearly than pain had.

She released the levers.

The throne tightened them again automatically. Its safety interlock interpreted hesitation as operator weakness.

Of course it did. Caldra had ordered the mirrorwrights to prevent one frightened sovereign from abandoning generations of public work.

She reached beneath the left armrest and opened the maintenance seal.

A throne attendant shouted, "Majesty, reserve alignment remains viable."

"Whose memory pays it?"

"Registered vessels are available."

"People."

The attendant stared.

Caldra saw how thoroughly her own language had trained him.

Inside the seal, twelve fine white rods connected the levers to the command carrier. Breaking them under load would send force through the operator's hands. It might kill her. Death would be convenient. Martyrdom could turn a failed conquest into sacred necessity.

She did not deserve that exit.

Caldra pulled the circlet free first. Skin tore at both temples. Command pressure fell but did not stop. She wrapped her imperial sash around the rods, braced one foot against the throne base, and pulled sideways.

Three rods snapped. White force broke two fingers on her left hand.

Six more bent. Orchard roots tightened around the throne legs. Salt entered the maintenance gears. Moth wings covered her bleeding face.

She pulled again.

The remaining rods broke.

The command throne split along its carrier channel. Census mirrors fell from the bridge and shattered in the well dark. The towering outline opened. Twelve captive portions poured apart, not back into prisons, but outward toward the civic relations

that had held through battle.

Caldra fell beside the ruined seat.

Zarha reached her first. A shelter knife remained in the night-reeve's hand. Behind her came Kessa Dorn with a blue strip over one eye, Pikk Rill turning his good ear toward the collapse, Mera Seln, road-charter witnesses, ward laborers, imperial defectors, and soldiers from both sides.

"Kill me," Caldra said.

Zarha crouched with difficulty. "No."

"A living claimant divides surrender."

"You are not being preserved as claimant."

"Then as what?"

"Evidence. Defendant. Witness if you can manage truth."

Caldra looked for fear and found its record without its heat.

"I ordered the wells," she said. "The censuses. The sealed districts. I knew donor impairment had reached eighty-six thousand. I continued."

Kessa answered, "Say it where the families can hear."

"Here?"

"In public judgment. Repeatedly."

No one thanked Caldra for breaking the throne. Pikk's workers bound her wrists without touching the broken fingers. An imperial physician asked permission from a ward medic before setting them. Zarha ordered the command circlet sealed as evidence under five custodians, none imperial and none solely coalition.

The five named themselves in her hearing: a South Labor miller, a road-charter witness, a saltwood courier, a Rill fracture worker, and an imperial archive clerk who had defected only after the sealed wards. Zarha refused to chair their custody. Caldra understood the gesture and also its limit. Distributed evidence could still be lost, falsified, or turned into factional property. The custodians answered by making five rubbings of every circlet mark and sending each copy by a different route.

An imperial general approached under guard and offered surrender if Caldra retained ceremonial rank. Kessa rejected the bargain before Zarha could answer. Ward councils demanded the sealed-district orders, donor tables, well lists, and names of officers who had fired on civic hosts. Free-court fighters demanded immediate execution. Road-charter troops demanded guarantees against retaliatory raids once imperial roads lost command. None accepted throne destruction as settlement.

Caldra issued one final sovereign order: all imperial forces were to cease defense of the One Night apparatus and open sealed medical stores. Zarha had the order copied, witnessed, and sent, then declared that compliance would reduce

further harm without reducing culpability. Caldra's authority could stop some killing. It could not determine the terms under which she answered for starting it.

Above the Basilica, sunlight returned around the moon.

People screamed again. This time the light did not harden into permanent noon. The sun crossed westward by ordinary degrees. Mirrors no longer held it above the horizon.

The Nights dispersed through twelve windows. Some returned at once toward stolen regions along roads of fungal shade, funeral names, animal paths, and sleeping hosts. Others remained in capital wards that had offered shelter, changed by captivity and contact. Seven Camp's Night divided only where its hosts consented, sending one portion west and leaving a small dusk with the rebuilt caravan yard until refugees could travel.

No commander assigned their routes.

By late afternoon, ceasefires held unevenly. Two imperial cohorts continued fighting until their officers saw the broken circlet. A free-court company tried to seize a white-mirror archive and met resistance from South Labor councils. Road-charter fighters kept custody of their unconscious donors. The war's central command had ended. Disputes survived it.

Caldra sat under guard on the sixth terrace while the sun descended.

She knew this sight had once comforted her before the Night Plague. That comfort did not return. Around her, people who had lived without evening for forty years stopped carrying stretchers, ledgers, bodies, and water long enough to watch color enter the western sky.

The first ordinary shadow lengthened from the broken throne.

Then the sun set without asking an empire to permit it.

Chapter 28 — The Nights Return by Many Roads

Three years later, Kessa Dorn stopped a Night at a washed-out bridge and asked everyone carrying it to vote.

The host caravan had reached the Veyran fork at evening. Behind twelve shade wagons, merchants waited with salt, seed tools, blackglass splints, and two hundred jars of star-moth eggs. Ahead, spring flood had taken the bridge's middle arch. The local Night traveled among the wagons in damp canvas, sleeping bodies, mushroom beds, two funeral chests, and the shadows beneath mule harness.

It wanted across. Kessa felt that much in the way darkness gathered toward the broken road. Want did not establish consent, engineering, or liability.

"East ford adds two days," said the merchant captain. "The moth eggs hatch tomorrow."

"Then cool them here," Kessa said.

"The host agreement names Seven Camp by the nineteenth."

"It also forbids ordering a Night over untested blackglass."

A bridge crew had laid three temporary glass beams across the gap. Each came from a different workshop, and one carried an ownership seam polished too smooth to read. Under imperial practice, a master plate would have forced the local darkness into the structure and tested it by command. No one carried such a plate now.

Kessa covered her left eye. Dusk put pale rings around every wet rope. The glare injury from Three Evenings had not healed. In darkness, halos sometimes doubled a bridge edge or turned a lantern into a false doorway. She relied on the crew's chalk marks and asked someone else to confirm distances.

The hosts gathered beside the first wagon. They included Veyran farmers, two Khar Bearers, a Selai moth keeper, a Rill road apprentice, three people from the funeral families, and six sleepers chosen by their households. Merchants received a voice on cargo risk. The bridge settlement received a voice on future repair. Kessa held no vote.

A farmer proposed sending an empty shade wagon first. The funeral families refused to detach their dead from the living host line. The Rill apprentice suggested testing one beam under unlit water. Merchants objected to losing another hour. Rain began before argument finished.

The Night moved into the shelter raised over all of them, including people who wanted opposite things.

They chose the east ford.

Star-moth keepers built cooling pits in the riverbank. Merchants recorded two days' compensation against the bridge guild, subject to proof that the unreadable

seam belonged to its workshop. Funeral chests stayed with the caravan. No darkness crossed the broken span.

The detour followed farms relearning night. Beans whose husks had stayed sealed for decades now opened after dusk, but so did beetle nests that permanent noon had suppressed. Farmers gained seed and lost leaves. Night-blooming orchard trees fruited again while migrating reed hounds followed pollinators into goat pens. Circuit agreements carried predator corridors, crop watches, fungus exchanges, and compensation schedules beside trade tolls. Restoring a Night restored appetites as well as shelter.

At the first ford village, residents refused the visiting darkness access to their graveyard because an earlier caravan had brought burial fungus that displaced a local strain. The hosts camped outside and offered soil samples rather than invoking the larger compact. By morning, village growers approved one wagon near an unlit irrigation pond. The Night rested there without entering the graves. Kessa recorded a partial welcome, neither failure nor full admission.

On the second day, a child developed sleep fever inside the host line. Under imperial road rules, officials would have isolated the household and continued moving the reservoir. The caravan stopped. Two hundred merchants waited while a village healer distinguished ordinary fever from shade injury. The delay spoiled twelve moth eggs. It also kept the child with her family and prevented rumor from turning sickness into a reason to expel every traveler.

Kessa entered the decision in the circuit ledger and wrote the reason in ordinary language: route refused because hosts could not identify who owned the third beam's fracture risk.

At dawn, Pikk Rill arrived to inspect it.

He traveled with eleven apprentices from Karth Veil, none wearing an imperial guild mark. His right ear heard nothing. He positioned people on his left or asked them to sign. The old glass scars along his palms had thickened, and a cough still interrupted steep climbs. He treated both facts as working conditions rather than sources of authority.

Pikk scraped the polished seam with a copper pick. A family-firm stamp appeared beneath the shine.

"Vikka's old yard," he signed.

The apprentices answered in the silent glass language developed after the war: stress direction, heat, owner, refusal, safe to touch, leave in place. Kessa knew only enough signs to avoid embarrassing guesses. Pikk taught without speaking when sound added nothing. Students learned to read vibration through fingertips, making the craft available to deaf workers and safer in tunnels where noise hid cracks.

One apprentice signed that the beam should be destroyed.

Pikk shook his head. He indicated the flood, the settlement, and the workshop

seal, then made the sign for witness.

“Vikka remains neutral?” Kessa asked.

“Her firm dissolved,” he said aloud, turning his left ear toward her. “Workers bought two yards. She owns the third with six families. Neutrality now has payroll records.”

He summoned the bridge clerk and two workers who had installed the span. One admitted polishing away the mark because host caravans distrusted former imperial contractors. The beam itself had passed load tests. Concealing ownership made the test unusable.

Pikk did not seize it. The bridge council ordered the beam removed, reinspected under its true mark, and returned only after a public fracture test. His apprentices set a temporary timber span for foot traffic. The host caravan still took the ford because its vote could not be retroactively improved by better information.

That afternoon, Pikk opened his lesson to the waiting merchants. He placed a blackglass splint on a cracked wagon tongue and showed how the tool supported strain without binding shade. No device commanded the Night. Every repair bore the maker’s name and a line where later workers could break it safely.

“Silent glass?” the merchant captain said. “You’re talking through half the lesson.”

Pikk signed something Kessa did not know. His apprentices laughed with their hands against their chests, without sound.

“He says silence means ownership stops shouting,” the road apprentice translated.

Pikk frowned and corrected the sign. The apprentice amended, “Ownership must remain readable even when the owner cannot shout.”

The distinction pleased him.

Kessa left the caravan at the east ford and rode ahead with the circuit records. Her route took her through Avarra Ves, no longer the undisputed capital. White-road mile posts had been painted with distances to local councils rather than distances from the Sun Basilica. Some provinces had removed the posts entirely. Trade slowed where jurisdictions multiplied. So did imperial requisition.

The broken Basilica remained roofless above the city. Fungi grew in the Noctuary shafts. Four of the former wells served as evidence vaults, three as memorial chambers chosen by donor families, two remained sealed because their Nights had not released the stone, and three held water for the ward districts. No council had forced all twelve into one use.

Kessa carried her ledger to the Confederal Record House, a converted supply court beside South Granary. Families crowded its steps with petitions concerning dead donors, missing prisoners, seized farms, road-charter crimes, free-court reprisals, House Oren property, and imperial officials who claimed late defection.

Caldra Ves waited in the prison wing across the courtyard.

Kessa saw her during transfer hour. The former Empress wore a plain dark coat and a brace on two left fingers that had healed crooked. Guards came from five jurisdictions and changed every month. No imperial officer served alone. No coalition faction controlled both keys.

The confederal tribunal had not yet opened its final proceeding. Three years of preliminary hearings had established evidence standards, translated census archives, located mass donor records, and argued which communities possessed standing. Delay had protected some defendants and exhausted families. Speed would have buried smaller claims beneath the war leaders' cases. The compromise satisfied nobody.

Caldra recognized Kessa through the courtyard grille. "Have the northern well lists arrived?"

"They arrived six months ago."

"My counsel says House Oren challenged custody."

"They did. North Ward filed its own copy."

"Good."

Kessa did not reward the answer. "Your clean-war orders killed people whose names are in this book."

"I know."

"Knowing while imprisoned costs less than knowing while you signed them."

Caldra gripped the grille with her healed hand. "Yes."

She had given depositions for two years. Some proved useful. Some compressed decisions into sovereign grammar that hid clerks, generals, contractors, and local collaborators. The Record House required her to answer the same event under separate community questions. No single confession controlled the history.

A guard called transfer. Caldra went inside.

Besh Kor waited in the witness hall with no guard inside arm's reach. The Noctuary burns around his throat had healed white. His road-charter coalition had negotiated collective counsel and refused to let free-court prosecutors describe all charter settlements as imperial auxiliaries. At the same time, donor families had filed three hundred twelve claims naming troops under his command.

He had spent twenty-one hearing days describing census recruitment, shadow orders, the Noctuary binding attempt, and his combat yield to Zarha. Each answer could implicate him. The tribunal agreement protected truthful testimony from being used to invent charges, but not from charges already supported by other evidence.

"Your circuit reaches Kor Orchard?" he asked Kessa.

"Next winter."

"Free-court riders took two Night wagons last month."

"I have the claims."

"Zarha's people call it return."

"Zarha chairs no claims court."

Besh looked toward the prison wing. "Good. Put that in writing."

Kessa did. His testimony would help convict imperial officers, perhaps Caldra, and possibly himself. Witness status granted no easy redemption. It required him to remain available while every faction preferred either a hero or a monster simple enough to finish.

Kessa filed the circuit ledger as evidence of what replaced imperial Night roads, including failures, toll disputes, predator deaths, host withdrawals, and bridges refused. A record showing only restoration would become another proclamation.

West of the city, she joined Ilyen Vaor at a moth station built inside an abandoned tollhouse.

He sat beneath a roof hung with maps. Lines crossed the continent in charcoal, fungal stain, copper ink, thread, and witness knots. No color meant one kind of Night. Each marked who had described the route and what they could no longer verify.

Ilyen's ear-fan tear had healed into a notch. His seasonal ink supported a small colony of dusk moths, though he never claimed their hatching as a recovery of what command had burned from him. On the table lay testimonies from people who remembered evenings he had mapped.

"Seven Camp route changed," Kessa said. "Veyran hosts refused the bridge and took east ford."

Ilyen reached for charcoal. "Weather or structure?"

"Unreadable ownership seam."

"Who proposed refusal?"

"No one. It emerged after four proposals failed."

He wrote four names beside the fork, then left space for the funeral families and bridge settlement to add theirs.

A young Selai assistant brought him a childhood account from Leth Aven. Ilyen read it once and wrote witness memory: Sere Aven, age seventy-two, west moth garden, first postwar evening. He did not write remembered by Ilyen.

"Do you recall the garden?" the assistant asked.

"I know its plan and the hatching tables."

"That isn't what I asked."

"No."

The answer did not change with kindness. His first hatching, his mother's

stories, and the comfort of childhood darkness remained facts without emotional access. He mapped by other people's memories because pretending to own them would turn service into another theft.

Kessa gave him Sava's northern-window record from the capital archive. He read his sister's name without visible collapse, then asked who had witnessed the maintenance wheel. She listed the ward lamplighter, Oth Aven, two observatory cleaners, and the weather clerk.

"Put them before me," he said.

"It's your map."

"It's their memory."

He wrote their names first.

The host caravan reached Seven Camp on the twenty-first, two days after its agreement. Nobody punished the Night for lateness.

Seven Camp had rebuilt beside its former basin without choosing between settlement and road. Stone houses stood around workshops and sleep clinics. Tents occupied broad witness grounds among them. Some families moved walls each season. Others planted orchards. The returned Night held both habits uneasily, gathering deepest where funeral paths crossed fungal beds.

Kessa arrived during a dispute over reed hounds.

With local darkness restored, the long-legged predators had returned to the basin and killed forty-three goats in one month. Farmers demanded fixed night fences and hunters wanted bounties. Bearers argued that reed hounds opened seed husks by disturbing marsh fungus. A trade house proposed concentrating Seven Camp's Night around livestock compounds, which would leave road tents exposed.

Zarha Kesh listened from a low chair because her stiff right thigh no longer tolerated standing through court. She used a cane on cold days. No permanent high court had replaced her war office. Seven Camp rotated chairs among orchard clans, mobile hosts, sleepers' families, labor houses, and road witnesses. Zarha could speak, question, and accept assignments. She could not bind the camp alone.

Ren Tal kept the population ledger.

At twenty, he still lost faces after long separation. He recognized Kessa by the crossed-cup ration mark she wore on a cord, not by features. His current registry accounted for the original 280 dreamless: 206 remained asleep and received full care; 28 had awakened but needed daily memory support; 46 lived independently with varied losses. Ren belonged to the last category while still using names, marks, and written routines.

No category declared anyone restored.

The memory-care compact funded sleep clinics through road tolls, granary

shares, and payments from the former imperial donor estates. Families could not lose rations when a sleeper failed to wake. Awakened people retained decision rights even when memory tests fell below imperial legal standards. Care workers received scheduled relief because devotion did not prevent exhaustion.

Kessa added a circuit clause: host caravans using Seven Camp's Night would carry medicine or trained relief workers on one journey in six. Traders objected until Ren showed what local shade reduced in moth-egg loss and heat spoilage. Benefit entered the same ledger as duty.

For the reed hounds, the court rejected both extermination and unrestricted return. Hunters received a seasonal quota around livestock paths. Farmers raised fungus gaps that discouraged dens without pushing the Night away. Bearers marked two marsh corridors where predators could move. The agreement would be reviewed after six months of goat loss, seed opening, and hound counts.

"Who enforces it?" a farmer asked.

Zarha leaned on her cane. "You do, with the hunters and Bearers."

"We need a court above the three groups."

"You need a review date and records each group can challenge."

"You chaired armies."

"And learned not to make that habit permanent."

The court assigned Zarha to witness the first count, not to rule the next dispute.

After the hearing, Seven Camp offered Kessa a permanent marshal's chair over the western host circuit. The office came with authority to set tolls, suspend dangerous routes, and appoint local recorders. Three years earlier she might have accepted because carts still needed someone to count them when councils argued. Now she read the appointment twice and crossed out permanent.

She proposed a six-season term divided among three circuit regions, with emergency powers expiring after seven days unless two host councils renewed them. Her own decisions would travel with the ledger and could be reopened at the next stop. Seven Camp objected that rotating marshals would produce inconsistent routes.

"Yes," Kessa said. "So do rivers, harvests, and Nights."

Ren added a requirement that one memory-care clerk review every route suspension affecting sleepers or dream-impaired travelers. A merchant delegate demanded equal review for cargo. The court granted cargo a separate appeal without equating spoiled goods with people. By sunset, the office had become less efficient, harder to seize, and possible for Kessa to accept.

Toward evening, the delayed host caravan came down the west road. Its shade wagons carried the Veyran Night portion, funeral families, cooled moth eggs, and the record of the bridge refusal. Seven Camp opened its outer shelter without absorbing the visiting darkness into its own. Hosts met at the basin and decided

where the travelers would sleep, where the dead would rest, and which fungus beds could receive foreign spores.

Kessa stood beside Ren as moth keepers opened the first jar. Dusk wings rose over stone roofs and tent ropes. Pikk's apprentices checked wagon splints by touch. Ilyen's map copy hung at the court shelter with witness names crowded around every route. Zarha sat among other chairs, her cane laid across her knees rather than raised as a staff.

No peace removed predators, grief, borders, tolls, ambition, or the labor of care. Evening asked work of everyone who wanted shelter inside it.

The sun touched the basin rim.

People paused, then continued what they were doing. A nurse carried water into the sleepers' house. Merchants covered moth jars. Children pulled goats inside the fungus gaps. Funeral hosts spoke road names beneath the opening cloth.

Seven Camp received night through houses, tents, graves, animals, spores, visitors, and those who still slept.

Darkness arrived by many roads, and no one road closed behind it.